BREAKING THE DEADLY DANCE OF RACISM

PERPETRATORS, TARGETS, BYSTANDERS, AND ALLIES

DERALD WING SUE • LISA BETH SPANIERMAN

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BREAKING THE DEADLY DANCE OF RACISM

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DERALD WING SUE

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Preface

Throughout US history, periods of racial progress have often been met with swift and aggressive backlash. We are once again living through such a moment. The Make America Great Again (MAGA) movement has actively dismantled hard-won anti-discrimination laws and policies, creating a chilling effect across federal agencies, education, law, healthcare, and civil society. These rollbacks not only stifle discourse but also carry profound consequences for People of Color (POC) and other marginalized communities, who face escalating threats to their rights, safety, and dignity. With Trump's re-election, these threats have intensified through executive orders aimed at ending birthright citizenship, promoting mass deportations of immigrants, suppressing DEI programs, restricting research funds, and banning terms such as “bias,” “discrimination,” and “racism” in public documents. Federal agencies have purged references to key civil rights concepts and removed public commemorations of Black military history, such as memorials and photographs of the Tuskegee Airmen. These 21st-century developments do not signal a return to the past but instead affirm the persistence of racial domination through tactics of erasure, censorship, and authoritarian control.

These policy changes have not only reshaped institutions but have also emboldened a cultural climate of grievance, entitlement, and racial resentment. Across the country, individuals have adopted a rebranded posture of white victimhood, embracing a zero-sum view of equity that treats demands for justice as threats to their status. Hate crimes and identity-based violence have surged alongside a rise in dehumanizing rhetoric and normalized bias by political leaders, media figures, and everyday citizens. These dynamics reflect not only the persistence of racial and gendered oppression but also the widespread passivity of those who choose silence over action. Indifference to injustice, as history reminds us, is a form of complicity.

Moral leaders have long warned of the dangers of neutrality in the face of injustice. Nobel Peace Prize laureates Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. and Archbishop Desmond Tutu both challenged the myth that decency alone is

enough and called on individuals to act with conviction. As Dr. King warned, “We will have to repent in this generation not merely for the hateful words and actions of the bad people but for the appalling silence of the good people.” Similarly, Tutu reminded us that “To be neutral is to take the side of the oppressor.” When racist incidents occur—whether overt or covert, intentional or unintentional—they are far too often allowed to unfold without being challenged. Silence allows racial injustice to persist, signals passive approval, and erodes the promise of equity in a multiracial democracy.

Even in the face of escalating violence and political persecution, we are not without strength. The current wave of racial retrenchment is not new. Our ancestors and elders have endured similar threats and refused to capitulate. We draw inspiration from a long tradition of resistance—from Ida B. Wells's fearless crusade against racial terror to Gerald Vizenor's concept of survivance, which affirms Indigenous presence and resistance in the face of colonization, to Dolores Huerta's organizing for the dignity and rights of farmworkers. These figures refused silence, bore witness, and modeled what it means to act with moral clarity in the face of systemic injustice. Their legacies offer a roadmap for our own actions. Today, we must draw on that lineage and challenge racism at all levels. Interrupting racism means naming it, resisting it, and disrupting the institutional and relational conditions that allow it to flourish. This is the moral imperative of our time.

In this spirit, we offer this book as one contribution to the long and unfinished struggle for racial justice. *Breaking the Deadly Dance of Racism* emerges amid a resurgence of white grievance, growing authoritarianism, and widespread efforts to silence those who challenge injustice. We wrote it not only to name the patterns that uphold racism, but also to help readers recognize their place within those patterns, reflect on their roles, and take informed action. The framework we offer is grounded in decades of scholarship, practice, and lived experience and shaped by our shared commitment to speak with clarity, resist complicity, and build on the legacies of those who came before us. Our aim is to support those who are ready to step into this legacy of resistance with courage, clarity, and a commitment to collective action.

At the heart of this framework is our guiding metaphor that racism operates like a dance. It is not simply a matter of individual bias or intent, but a

patterned set of roles, rhythms, and responses that are repeated, learned, and reinforced across relationships and systems. In this choreography, perpetrators, targets, bystanders, and white allies each move in ways that either sustain or disrupt racial injustice. These roles are interactive and shaped by institutional scripts and cultural ground rules that elevate whiteness while diminishing other ways of knowing and being. We chose this metaphor because it illuminates how racism is relational and systemic, and because it gives us language to explore how people can learn new steps, change their role, or disrupt the choreography altogether.

A distinguishing feature of this book is its emphasis on action. While conceptual clarity is vital, it is not enough. Across the chapters, we extend the concept of *microinterventions*—small, everyday acts that individuals can use to disarm bias, interrupt racism, and shift harmful dynamics in real time. We also introduce the concept of *racial microprotections*, which are developmentally grounded practices that help children resist internalizing racial dominance and instead cultivate resilience rooted in antiracist values. These tools, featured in Part IV, are designed for use in education, healthcare, human resources, and community settings for those seeking ways to move from awareness to accountability. Throughout the book, we offer strategies that support readers in translating intention into action, whether they are addressing racism in the moment or preparing the next generation to confront it with clarity and courage.

We envision this book reaching a wide range of readers who seek to deepen their critical consciousness and take part in the collective work of dismantling racism. Our framework speaks to educators, mental health practitioners, healthcare providers, human resource professionals, and everyday citizens. *Breaking the Deadly Dance of Racism* can serve as a primary or supplemental text in programs across education, social work, counseling and clinical psychology, communication, and medicine. It is also relevant for workshops, trainings, and courses that address white allyship, bystander intervention, systemic oppression, bullying, harassment, and workplace equity. Because of its metaphorical framing and practical emphasis, we hope the book resonates beyond the classroom, especially with those working to build inclusive institutions and empowered communities. Whether readers are just beginning their racial justice journey or seeking deeper clarity and courage, we offer these insights as a path

toward reflection and action—and as a shared language for disrupting the choreography of racism in everyday life.

ORGANIZATION

Breaking the Deadly Dance of Racism is organized into four major sections and ten chapters. Each section represents a core dimension of racism and antiracism, progressing from individual expressions to institutional, systemic, and cultural patterns, and from remediation to prevention. This structure allows us to trace how racism is enacted, internalized, avoided, resisted, and reproduced, while also offering a scaffolded approach to personal growth, collective action, and structural transformation. In the chapters that follow, we build on the metaphor of the dance to explore how these roles and systems operate in concert. The chapters are designed to move readers from understanding to action, providing both conceptual tools and practical strategies for interrupting the rhythms of racism at every level of society.

Part I—Introduction

Chapter 1—The Dance of Racism: Perpetrators, Targets, Bystanders and **White Allies**

Part I introduces the central metaphor of racism as a dance, a set of patterned and interactive movements shaped by history, systems, and social roles. Chapter 1 lays the conceptual foundation for the book, presenting the four primary roles (perpetrator, target, bystander, and white ally) and situating them within the broader choreography of racism. We explore how these roles are learned, normalized, and reinforced through cultural messages and institutional practices, and how they operate in concert to uphold racial injustice. This chapter also frames racism not only as individual acts of bias but also as a collective performance embedded in everyday life. By naming the roles, rhythms, and ground rules of this deadly dance, we begin the process of interrupting it.

Part II—The Dancers

Chapter 2—Barriers to Perpetrator Awareness and Reparative Action

Chapter 3—Target Survival and Resilience: Overcoming Racism

Chapter 4—Barriers to White Bystander Awareness and Anti-Racist Action

Chapter 5—Barriers to Ally Awareness: A Call for Courage

Part II focuses on the four primary roles individuals may occupy in the dance of racism: perpetrator, target, bystander, and white ally. These chapters examine how people move in and out of these roles in everyday life and how these movements are shaped by psychological defenses, cultural norms, social learning, and systemic forces. Each chapter identifies common cognitive and emotional barriers that prevent individuals from recognizing their roles and engaging in reparative or transformative action. Topics include denial, moral exclusion, fear of social punishment, internalized oppression, and performative allyship. By naming these barriers and offering pathways toward accountability and growth, this section helps readers develop deeper insight into their own positionality and encourages reflection on how relational roles can either maintain or disrupt the choreography of racism.

Part III—Social, Systemic, and Cultural Influences that Facilitate Racism

Chapter 6—The Deadly Dance of Racism: Symbiotic Roles, Scripts, and Ground Rules

Chapter 7—Overcoming Cultural, Systemic, and Institutional Racism

Part III expands the lens from individual roles to the broader forces that script, reinforce, and legitimize racism in daily life. These chapters examine the societal stage on which the dance of racism unfolds. We explore how social narratives, institutional policies, and cultural values create the conditions that make racism appear ordinary, expected, and even invisible to those in positions of privilege. Chapter 6 focuses on the symbiotic nature of the four roles and the scripted rules that govern their interactions, often reinforcing white superiority and devaluing the cultural and epistemological traditions of communities of color. Chapter 7 explores how systemic and cultural racism operate through media, education, law, and public policy, and offers strategies for identifying and challenging these forces. Together, these chapters underscore the importance of dismantling not only

interpersonal bias but also the deeply rooted structures that sustain racial inequality.

Part IV—Anti-Bias Strategies and Actions to Challenge Individual, Institutional, and Cultural Racism

Chapter 8—Microintervention Strategies to Disrupt, Diminish, and Dismantle Individual Racism: Arming Targets, Bystanders, and White Allies

Chapter 9—Microintervention Strategies to Disrupt, Diminish, and Dismantle Systemic Racism (Macroaggressions): Arming Targets, Bystanders, and White Allies

Chapter 10—Racial Socialization and the Microprotections that Shape Antiracist Development

Part IV offers concrete, actionable strategies for disrupting racism at every level of society. These chapters move readers from awareness to engagement by presenting tools for interrupting individual bias, mobilizing institutional change, and preparing future generations to resist racial injustice. Chapters 8 and 9 focus on microinterventions, providing specific guidance for targets, bystanders, and white allies to confront racism in real time and across systems. These include scripts, scenarios, and skill-building practices for disarming bias and transforming resistant environments. Chapter 10 introduces the concept of racial microprotections, a set of developmentally grounded practices that help children understand race, resist internalizing messages of racial hierarchy, and build antiracist values. This final chapter emphasizes the role of caregivers, educators, and mentors in racial socialization and underscores the importance of prevention as a long-term strategy for racial justice.

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PART ONE
Introduction

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CHAPTER ONE
The Dance of Racism: Perpetrators, Targets, Bystanders, and White Allies

> We will have to repent in this generation not merely for the hateful words and actions of the bad people but for t\he appalling silence of the good people.
>
> —Dr. Martin Luther King

> The world is a dangerous place to live, not because of the people who are evil, but because of the people who don't do anything about it.
>
> —Albert Einstein

It is very difficult to turn on TV sets, listen to radio broadcasts, read newspapers, or visit social media outlets without hearing or witnessing incidents of racial hatred, bias, bigotry, and discrimination engulfing our society and the world. It has also become all too commonplace to personally witness incidents of racist expressions at our worksites, among neighbors, between strangers, in classrooms, and in our daily interactions with others. In the current political "Make America Great Again!" (MAGA) climate, surveys and governmental reporting agencies indicate that overt expressions of racism, anti-Semitism, and all forms of bias and bigotry seem to be on the rise in our society (Alper et al., 2024; Novotney, 2023).

Disturbing as these moral, civil, and/or criminal transgressions may be, it is even more alarming to hear that these occurrences are all too frequently met with apathy and inaction on the part of onlookers, or even those who are victimized by hateful acts of racism (Murrell, 2020; Williams et al., 2023). Scholars, social justice advocates, and political pundits have observed that silence and inaction represent complicity on the part of observers who fail to take action (Sue, 2015), allow the continued oppression and harm to People of Color (POC) (Houshmand & Spanierman, 2021), communicate to onlookers that such actions are acceptable (Scully & Rowe, 2009), and directly undermine the values of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) (Hurd et al., 2022). Indeed, the current Trump Administration has issued

executive orders “outlawing” DEI initiatives and programs, forcing many governmental agencies, institutions of higher education, business and industry to terminate equity action plans (Murray & Bohannon, 2025; Patel, 2025). More disturbing has been the number of institutions who have remained silent about such actions and/or willingly capitulated to the demands of the MAGA agenda, thereby threatening decades of hard-won anti-discrimination work and laws (Moore, 2025).

The two opening quotes by Dr. Martin Luther King and Albert Einstein point out the dangers and hazards of inaction. This book is a call to action to break the deadly dance of racism which has made many of us collaborators in protecting, fostering, and perpetuating racial bias, bigotry, and discrimination. In general, our society enforces passivity and inaction in our citizens by rewarding those who remain silent and by punishing those who dare challenge it. Whether we are aware or not, all of us have a role to play in the racism dance. We use a dance metaphor to explain how racist behaviors are allowed to flourish though the biased scripts and well-rehearsed steps of white supremacy. Throughout this book, we explore and analyze four interlocking roles played by the citizenry by which racism thrives: perpetrator, target, bystander and white ally.

Perpetrators are majority group individuals (white Americans) who express their culturally conditioned racial biases toward others. Targets are POC who are the objects of racial bias, often in the forms of microaggressions or macroaggressions. Bystanders can actually be anyone who witnesses a racial transgression worthy of action and intervention. White allies are dominant group individuals who have awareness of racism, and who profess to support non-dominant groups in the struggle against racism. Whether one is a perpetrator, target, bystander or ally, the failure to challenge racist acts on personal and systemic levels not only has devastating consequences to POC, but to onlookers and even perpetrators (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). The psychosocial costs of racism to POC and white Americans are summarized below (Spanierman & Heppner, 2004; Sue & Spanierman, 2020).

- For perpetrators, to have their implicit and explicit biases go unchallenged reinforces their distorted sense of racial reality, that they

are superior beings, and that they are free of bias and discrimination. It allows them to maintain their innocence and naivete.

- For POC, acts of racism assail their racial cultural identities, treat them as second-class citizens, and damage their psychological well-being. In addition, individual, institutional, and cultural racism produces racial inequities in education, employment, healthcare, and all aspects of their standard of living.
- For bystanders who might not have the critical consciousness of racism, inaction reinforces their beliefs that such acts are harmless and insignificant. Left unopposed, such behaviors become “normal,” ordinary, and acceptable.
- For well-intentioned white allies, who hold power and privilege, inaction can result in guilt or shame that they have not acted in accordance with their values of humanity and equity. Furthermore, it promotes feelings of powerlessness, dishonor, and cowardice.
- For society, uncontested racism goes far beyond the individual and interpersonal levels. Systemically, allowing racism to go unchecked creates a hostile, disrespectful, alienating, and invalidating environment that has devastating consequences for our nation. Some of these societal consequences will be discussed in later chapters.

CHALLENGE, CHANGE, AND TRANSFORMATION: THE RACIAL REVOLUTION

We believe that racism is tearing this country apart and that racial strife and disharmony will increase as visible racial/ethnic minorities move toward becoming a numerical majority in the next few decades. It is predicted that between 2030 and 2060, POC will become a numerical majority, with the Latinx population becoming the largest group, followed by African Americans and Asian Americans/Pacific Islanders (Vespa et al., 2020). In fact, white Americans are already a majority in California, New Mexico, Nevada, Maryland, Texas, and not surprisingly Hawaii. In other words, the US population is undergoing a radical demographic transformation that is

often referred to as the “diversification of America” or literally “the changing complexion of society” (Sue et al., 1998). But there are other demographic changes occurring in the population that are adding fuel to the racial political polarization in America.

The graying of America tells a story that the United States is on a long transition to an aging society where adults 65 and older will outnumber our young in several short decades (Wessel, 2024). Projections indicate that the US population will barely increase because of lower birthrates of white Americans, and that immigration will be the primary means of growth. Thus, the workforce will ultimately be composed of immigrants and POC, who as a group have higher birthrates but, due to discriminatory practices, are less likely to be educated and more likely to earn lower wages. If anti-immigrant sentiment, racial bias, and discrimination continue to thwart employment opportunities for these groups, it will have frightening consequences for the Baby Boomer and Gen X generations. The threat of mass deportations, arrests of “illegal immigrants,” and forbidding them employment, education, and healthcare have had a chilling effect on their standard of living and bode poorly for the economic stability of the country.

The growing ranks of the elderly who are mainly white must depend upon Social Security, employer-provided pensions, and their savings when they retire. It is obvious that the health and viability of retirement programs and other sources of income will increasingly be dependent upon immigrants and POC as they become the majority in the workforce. If, however, they remain the most underpaid, underemployed, undereducated, and underappreciated workers, it portends poorly for the financial security of white retirees and for our society as a whole (Sue et al., 1998). Couple this with the feminization of the workforce, where women employees have increased in numbers, but they too encounter employment bias and obstacles that decrease their earning power.

The Rise of Whiteness and White Supremacy

As POC threaten to become a numerical majority, as increasing numbers of women enter the labor force, and as we become an aging society, major social, economic, and political changes have disrupted the lives of many white Americans. They resent that white-cherished values and a familiar “way of life” are vanishing, that change is being forced upon them without

their informed consent, and that political correctness has replaced honesty and authenticity (Sue, 2023). Indeed, some social scientists have hypothesized that the increased bias and bigotry in our society are directly related to this fear. The backlash to the changing demographics has resulted in a rebirth and rise in white supremacy. This concept is so antagonistic to our notions of freedom, equality, and social justice that few white Americans would ever consider themselves to be white supremacists. We usually associate white superiority with groups like the Proud Boys, Neo-Nazis, Klan, or Skinheads. Yet, the power of white supremacy ideology is so deeply ingrained in our society that its operation is nearly invisible. To have any hope of overthrowing the invisibility of white supremacy, we need to be able "to see it." As long as we are unaware of its existence, how it affects our daily lives, how it oppresses and denigrates, and how it harms everyone and our society, we will not be motivated to end it. Whiteness and white supremacy form the basic foundations of the racism dance. To truly appreciate the omnipresent influence of white supremacy, we need to define and analyze how it manifests itself in our daily lives and in the institutions we support.

White supremacy is a doctrine of white racial superiority that justifies discrimination, segregation, and domination of persons of color based upon an ideology and belief system that all other non-white groups are racially inferior (American Psychological Association, 2021; Jones, 1997). There are some key elements in this definition that need elaboration.

- First, since it is a "doctrine," white supremacy rests on a set of interlocking beliefs and principles that are taught and inculcated into people. Such a socialization process occurs through education, the media, and how your family and friends transmit beliefs related to racial superiority to their children and one another.
- Second, the teachings are characterized by beliefs that white people and, by extension, white western-European culture are superior to non-white groups. Jones (1997) has labeled this cultural racism; the individual and institutional expression of the superiority of one group's cultural heritage (arts, crafts, language, religion, tradition, values, and beliefs) over groups of color.

- Third, the beliefs are not necessarily based upon reason, facts, or data, but faith and dogma. This conviction represents a worldview in which a white epistemology elevates white western ways of knowing, being, and behaving.
- Fourth, the doctrine is deeply embedded in individuals, in our institutions, and in our cultural values, beliefs, and traditions. As a result, it inherently discriminates, segregates, and oppresses persons of color.
- Finally, whiteness and white superiority are socially conditioned into everyone, including perpetrators, targets, bystanders, *and* white allies. The influence of white supremacy and its manifestation reside outside the level of conscious awareness. Thus, it remains invisible and considered normal and acceptable.

Sue (2023) asserts that the political slogan, for example, MAGA camouflages white supremacy and taps into a thirst to return to a glamorized era where POC, women, and other marginalized groups "knew their place."

> The MAGA slogan conceals a call to return to former days of clearly defined white power and privilege, when women were homemakers instead of in the workforce, when marriage was between a man and a woman, and when homosexuality and other "queer" lifestyles were considered sinful and a mental disorder. Many of these bigoted beliefs and attitudes represent implicit biases that are outside the level of conscious awareness. It couches the rhetoric of white supremacy in the language of individual freedom and individual rights. Hate speech is justified as "free speech," gun control is an attack on "the right to bear arms," offending marginalized group members is seen as "political correctness," and vaccine mandates are seen as governmental intrusion (Sue, 2023).

As different worldviews and lifestyles collide, the inevitable demand for change in every facet of American life will increase. Our old and traditional ways of doing things will no longer be adequate to deal with the diversity of the country. With the pressure to change will come clashes between competing groups as to which will have the power to make decisions that

will affect how we live in this society. The nature of education, how the criminal justice system operates, how business is conducted, how to deal with climate change, immigration policy, and every facet of American life will be challenged. Unless we can resolve these differences peacefully through shared collaboration and allow for equal access and opportunity for all groups in society, our nation will not survive the inevitable turmoil.

Addressing Racism

The need to address racism is the responsibility of everyone. That is why we wrote this book. Disarming and dismantling racism should not be left solely to POC and requires all of us (bystanders, white allies and even perpetrators) to find the moral courage to confront the discriminatory acts of others, the inequities that reside in our institutions and our society, and in the forced imposition of white western cultural traditions and values upon POC. To be successful, however, means first and foremost honestly confronting ourselves: who are we as racial/cultural beings? It is important to remember that race, ethnicity, and culture are functions of everyone. It is not just a “Black thing,” an “Asian thing,” or only reserved for POC. Race, culture, and ethnicity is something that belong to white Americans as well. Furthermore, what biases, prejudices, fears, and racial stereotypes do we harbor? How do we overcome our racial fears to honestly look at ourselves and one another? What can we do to take action against racism?

Our purpose in writing this book is to provide tools for us to confront racism on the three levels in which it resides: (a) individual level—dominant group members (white Americans) discriminating against persons of color, (b) institutional level—structures, policies, and practices that unfairly *deny* persons of color *equal access and opportunities*, and (c) cultural level—imposition of white Euro-American cultural heritage upon other groups while negating or destroying the cultural heritage of POC. In many respects, cultural-level racism forms the base from which all forms of racism are expressed. When white Euro-Americans use power to perpetuate their cultural heritage and impose it upon other POC while diminishing the importance of or destroying another group's way of life, it represents racism of the most extreme kind (cultural genocide). History, for example, is replete with governmental actions used by the United States to stamp out the language and religious practices of Native Americans (Sue et al., 2024).

In its contemporary form, when educators forbid the use of a second language in their classrooms, mock accents, refuse to teach accurate racial history or ethnic studies, ban books on critical race theory, outlaw DEI programs, criminalize the use of “diversity,” “equity,” and “inclusion” language in educational institutions, and denigrate non-Christian religious practices, they are engaging in cultural oppression (Folberg et al., 2023; Jones, 1997; Sue, 2003). As we shall shortly see, making the “invisible” visible, freeing ourselves from our racist cultural conditioning, and taking action to disarm racism in ourselves and others are major challenges.

It is also important for us to realize that overcoming, disarming, and dismantling racism must deal with its multiple tentacles, some of which are often not acknowledged. While POC, for example, are often the targets of racism, white Americans are also victimized without their informed consent. Their passage to enlightenment is different than that of POC, but there are similarities. For white Americans, the journey is likely to be filled with unpleasant insights about themselves as racial/cultural beings and the realization that they share responsibility for the pain and suffering caused to others. For them, becoming allies in the battle against racism is the ultimate goal. For POC, overcoming internalized racism and developing pride in their cultural/racial identities and heritage are paramount in their struggle against racism (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019). Research suggests a positive racial identity acts as a powerful buffer against the forces of racism that tend to denigrate their racial/cultural being.

Finally, all of us need to make a clear distinction between white EuroAmericans (as a people) and the ideology of white supremacy. It is the latter that represents the oppressive stable arrangements and practices through which collective actions are taken (government, business, unions, schools, churches, courts, and police) and by which rewards and career opportunities are conferred on white people while foreclosing those for POC. Although white EuroAmericans are most likely to benefit from white supremacy, they are not the enemy (Sue, 2003). When given a chance, white people can become valuable allies. What, however, must perpetrators, targets, bystanders, and white allies do to overcome the racism and bias that resides in them and others? Here, we briefly outline three aspirational goals that are foundational steps toward racism liberation: critical consciousness, self-reckoning, and anti-racist action. We incorporate these concepts into

our upcoming individual chapters that discuss the roles played by the citizenry.

Critical Consciousness

All of us have been miseducated about our history of oppression, falsely sold a bill of goods about the superiority of white culture, and given implicit and explicit messages about the inferiority of persons of color (Guthrie, 2004; Loewen, 2018). We have internalized these beliefs and values and unknowingly act upon them to the detriment of groups of color. In some ways, both POC and white Americans are the victims of white supremacy, although the victimization of white people is different than that of POC. For POC, they become the targets of racist beliefs, attitudes, and behavior. For white Americans, they are socialized into oppressor roles without their informed consent. As someone once stated, “no white child was ever born proudly proclaiming that they wanted to be a racist, sexist, or homophobe.” White people took on these roles through a painful process of cultural conditioning. As long as POC and white Americans remain unaware and serve as puppets to our racist socialization, the manifestation, dynamics, and impact of racism will remain invisible. The invisibility of racism to perpetrators, targets, onlookers and allies helps to maintain the status quo and renders anti-bias actions unnecessary. As we will see, the concept of critical consciousness applies both to the oppressed and the oppressor.

The Oppressed

When POC internalize beliefs of inferiority about themselves, they may not only suffer from low self-esteem but also act as agents of the dominant culture by oppressing themselves, their own group and other groups of color. The concepts of internalized racism, self-loathing, and colorism are the results of a hidden societal curriculum that teaches POC that their cultural heritage is inferior when compared to white culture (Sue et al., 2022). Descriptors like “less developed,” “uncivilized,” “primitive,” or even “pathological” are often used to describe groups or societies that differ from white Euro-American lifestyles. Physical characteristics such as dark complexion, black hair, and brown eyes; practicing non-Christian religions (Islam, Confucianism, Polytheism—many gods, etc.); valuing collectivism,

present time orientation, and cooperation over competition; and linguistic characteristics such as bilingualism, non-standard English, speaking with an accent, use of nonverbal and contextual communication, and reliance on the "oral tradition" are usually seen as less desirable and even pathological by the society (Sue et al., 2024). Research consistently reveals that individuals who are physically different, who are second language speakers, and who adhere to different cultural beliefs and practices are more likely to be evaluated negatively in our schools, places of employment, and public/social venues. POC may be seen as "less intelligent," "less qualified," "more unpopular," abnormal, and as possessing "more undesirable traits."

It is dehumanizing and painful for children of color to be raised to believe in their own inferiority, to be possessed of low self-esteem and self-hate, to aspire to the status quo but never fully accepted, to suffer poor mental health from repressed anger and rage, and to be forced to accept their fate in life via passivity and inaction (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019). Worse yet, they may begin to doubt their sanity, feel hopeless and helpless, and come to view their own racial and ethnic heritage as undesirable obstacles to be overcome. In *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, Freire (1970), in his work with oppressed Brazilian laborers, proposed the concept of *critical consciousness*, the ability to reflect on and become critically aware of the social injustices and inequities caused by social, economic, and political oppression. He asserts that the first step to liberation and empowerment is "naming" an oppressive event, condition, or process so it no longer holds power over those that are marginalized. For POC, freeing themselves from their miseducation, understanding how society has imposed white standards upon them, reclaiming their ethnic identities, empowering themselves, and working to overturn oppression can only come about through critical consciousness.

What, however, is the process by which POC can attain critical consciousness and liberate themselves from the constant bombardment of denigrating messages they receive from their teachers, peers, neighbors, coworkers, and the mass media? Much of what we know about racial/cultural identity development among POC comes from the foundational work of William E. Cross (1971) and Cross (1991). Although his "Nigrescence model" was developed and applied specifically to African

Americans (process of becoming Black), many have applied similar concepts to Asian Americans, Latinx Americans, Native Americans, etc. (Sue et al., 2022). In general, racial/cultural identity development models postulate a movement from conformity and acceptance of white Western standards by POC to an acceptance and valuing of their own racial identities and values. In many respects, the Nigrescence model is the attainment of critical consciousness by African Americans: (a) the realization that they have been victimized and sold a false bill of goods from white society; (b) redefining assimilation and acculturation as forced compliance; (c) increased understanding of the sociopolitical forces in society that creates dominate–subordinate relationships (racism, oppression, and discrimination); and (d) asking the question, "Why should I be ashamed of who and what I am?"

Critical consciousness can be attained in many ways for POC, but it is often unplanned and developed through experiences of bias and discrimination. African American college students who have attempted to assimilate into white society and deceived themselves that they are accepted into it may experience a series of personal incidents of bias and discrimination (mistaken for a cafeteria server, profiled on campus, avoided by white students, considered less intelligent by a professor, etc.) that remind them they cannot escape their racial identities and that they will never be fully accepted into white society. In other words, regardless of how westernized and white the person strives to become, they will never "fit in" and gain acceptance from white Americans. For others, major racist events occur, such as the murders of George Floyd, Breana Taylor, and other African Americans, Asian hate crimes that blame them for COVID-19, and the overt increase in anti-Muslim hate crimes that shatter their illusions of white America and start them on a path to overthrowing the shackles of oppression and to redefining their own racial/cultural heritage.

Increasingly, however, communities of color are turning towards planned methods of developing critical consciousness through intentional anti-racist education or through the racial socialization process (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019). As Freire (1970) asserts, there is nothing like a value-free education. Education either indoctrinates a person into accepting the teachings of the status quo, or it teaches people to observe, reflect, deconstruct, and challenge its biased basic premises. With respect to race

and racism, Loewen's (2018) book, *Lies My Teacher Told Me*, illustrates how history textbooks used in classrooms perpetuate falsehoods about the superiority of white Americans and how they portray POC as inferior. The need for critical analysis of a racially biased curriculum, hearing the voices of those most silenced and oppressed, and supplementing accurate racial history are steps toward an anti-racist curriculum. In addition, many parents of color have begun to teach their sons and daughters to understand white supremacy and racism and how to protect and immunize them from the forces of racism. Using the concept of "microprotections," Sue et al. (2021) reveal how parents of color rely on racial socialization/education of their children to (a) develop racial literacy and consciousness, (b) promote ethnic pride, and (c) prepare them for racism.

The Oppressor

Although Freire was mainly concerned with having those who are oppressed develop critical consciousness, many have translated the concept to apply to majority group members as well (Jemal, 2017). Forcing those with power and privilege to achieve insight into how systems of oppression operate and to consider the roles they play in the subjugation and domination of POC are the keys to mental liberation. Because we have been born and raised in a racialized cultural context, our role in oppression is often unintentional, automatic, habitual, and outside our level of awareness. According to psychologists Hanna et al. (2000), well-intentioned white Americans often engage in what they call "secondary oppression." While white Americans may not actively oppress through blatant force, most of them are secondary oppressors because of their inactivity and the benefits they derive from the historical and continuing oppression of others.

As a result, the oppression they engage in is not necessarily the overt, intentional, and individual acts of violence perpetrated upon citizens of color. However, subtle unintentional discrimination, implicit bias, and microaggressions are no less damaging and, oftentimes, more harmful than their intentional counterpart (overt racism and hate crimes). Maya Angelou (1978) has likened the subtle, indirect, and everyday forms of racism visited upon POC to "death by a thousand cuts." She has indicated that it is not the white supremacist whom she fears most, but ordinary well-intentioned white Americans (neighbors, teachers, employers, and healthcare providers)

who miseducate our children, determine who to hire, retain, promote, and fire, and provide inferior healthcare treatments. In other words, it is everyday well-intentioned white people who are mainly responsible for creating the lower standard of living for POC, not the overt hate-mongers.

Paulo Freire (1970) has observed that unequal social relations often go unchallenged because they foster and encourage "cultures of silence" that disguise and silence social and political contradictions inherent in systems of oppression. On the one hand, the United States may assert that it is a nation of equal access and opportunity, and on the other hand, it structures programs, policies, and practices that favor white Americans while denying it to POC. On an individual level, white Americans may profess to be bias-free, but engage in actions that unknowingly discriminate against other POC. Freire asserts that such contradictions are rendered invisible through a socialization and educational process.

On a systemic level, our society uses a "public transcript," a master narrative that legitimizes the position and values of the dominant culture, suggests it is the natural order of things, and instills in its citizens blinders that prevent them from being conscious of inequities that exist for POC (Bell, 2003; Sue, 2015). These belief systems (ideologies) are repeated over and over in our educational curriculum, in movies and plays, in proverbs and fables, in folklore, and in the everyday stories we tell one another. The repetitiveness of these themes ultimately becomes "truth and reality." In other words, the master narrative tells us that we are a democratic society, that anyone who works hard enough can succeed, that egalitarian values form the foundation of our society, that people should not be judged by the color of their skin, that racism is a thing of the past, that good, moral, and decent people do not discriminate, and that truth and justice are important (Sue, 2015).

Bell (2002, 2003) challenges the myths inherent in the master narrative, which she labels "sincere fictions." Critical consciousness is the ability to see, analyze, and deconstruct the contradictions inherent in such social, political, and economic ideologies, to comprehend their harmful impact (injustices and inequities), to give voice to such paradoxes, and to take appropriate action for the good of the self, others, and the society at large. Using the "master narrative" analogy, some have observed that POC tell a different story, a counternarrative, about their racial realities that threaten to

unmask the ugly secrets of racism. In essence, the counternarratives from POC directly challenge the beliefs and ideologies of the dominant society: (a) meritocracy is a myth, (b) equal access and opportunity is for white people only, (c) racism is alive, well, and thriving in our society, (d) color-blindness is a myth, (e) no white person is immune from inheriting the biases of the society, (f) systemic racism advantages white people and disadvantages POC, (g) whiteness and white privilege form the foundations of US culture, and (h) white Americans averse to acknowledge the truth about their complicity in the perpetration of racism (Bell, 2002). As we have seen, POC who live under the oppression of the master narrative (told that their realities are wrong, that they are oversensitive or paranoid) but are able to discern its lies and falsehoods leads to a validation of their sanity, assures them they are not crazy, confirms their racial realities, and provides them with words and concepts to describe their experiences.

Critical consciousness is an educational concept by which oppressors and oppressed develop an ability to perceive, analyze, and deconstruct social and political injustices, to free themselves from their cultural conditioning, to see beyond the obvious, to not be easily fooled, and to take action to address and rectify inequities. Raising awareness of racism is a major challenge to all parties involved because we are socialized not to recognize its disguised forms. Freire (1970) contends that there is nothing like a "neutral" education, but one that either socializes conformance to the dominant society (accept the master narrative) or one that can be exercised in the "practice of freedom" and liberation (consider counternarratives). Racism, bias, and bigotry are deeply embedded in our society and psyche, and solutions directed toward symptoms do not address the virus of white supremacy. Only by naming and facing the unpleasantness and ugliness of racism will we move toward healing and emancipation. Developing critical consciousness is the first step toward clarity, liberation, and a needed racial reckoning.

Self-Reckoning

Very few white Americans would deny that white nationalists who engage in hate crimes and racial violence toward POC qualify as being racist and anti-Semitic and that the perpetrators should be severely punished. The near unanimous public outcry against hate groups and the condemnation of these

acts are both reassuring and disturbing at the same time. It is reassuring because the vast majority of white Americans would join POC in taking action against those who would target and hurt someone on the basis of skin color or other differences. It is disturbing, however, because fair-minded and decent white Americans, those that condemn these heinous acts, also perpetrate acts of racism as well (Bonilla-Silva, 2021). The concept of secondary oppression suggests that for most white Americans, they do not have to be actively racist to contribute to the racism dance (Hanna et al., 2000). Inaction, itself, is tacit agreement that racism is acceptable; and, because white Americans enjoy the benefits, privileges, and opportunities of the oppressive system, they inevitably are racist by both commission and omission.

Honest racial self-reckoning is about embracing and facing the truth about ourselves as racial/cultural beings, about our roles in the instigation and perpetuation of racism, and having the faith and courage in dealing with unpleasant insights. Psychologists have always known that people are not necessarily rational beings but rationalizing ones and that they have an incredible capacity to fool themselves and to maintain their positive self-image even in the face of contradictory information. Consciousness raising and self-reckoning are painful to perpetrators because they believe and perceive themselves as good, moral, and decent human beings who would never engage in racist acts. Therein lies the dilemma. The belief in the goodness of their moral character makes it abhorrent to accept the fact that they harbor racist beliefs and attitudes; more frightening, however, is the realization that they have unknowingly engaged in discriminatory practices. Thus, white Americans and our society are likely to focus on racism as only extreme acts of hatred, thereby reassuring themselves that they are not capable of prejudice, bias, and discrimination. Racism denial results in self-deception by which conversations on race are avoided—being color mute, maintaining silence when everyday incidents of racism occur, professing color blindness, avoiding interracial interactions, denying emotions of anxiety around POC, and minimizing feelings of guilt for their inaction.

Racial self-reckoning is painful, frightening, and an unpleasant process to undergo for white Americans. These two passages from white psychologists, Mark Kiselica (1998) and Sara Winter (1977), exemplify their racial awakening and the overwhelming emotions and cognitive

insights that arise from an honest self-examination of their roles in the racism dance.

> I was deeply troubled as I witnessed on a daily basis the detrimental effects of institutional racism and oppression on ethnic-minority groups in this country. The latter encounters forced me to recognize my privileged position in our society because of my status as a so-called Anglo. It was upsetting to know that I, a member of White society, benefited from the hardships of others that were caused by a racist system. I was also disturbed by the painful realization that I was, in some ways, a racist. I had to come to grips with the fact that I had told and laughed at racist jokes and, through such behavior, had supported White racist attitudes. If I really wanted to become an effective, multicultural psychologist, extended and profound self-reckoning was in order. At times, I wanted to flee from this unpleasant process by merely participating superficially with the remaining task…while avoiding any substantive self-examination
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> (Kiselica, 1998, pp. 10–11).

> Let me explain this healing process in more detail. We must unearth all the words and memories we generally try not to think about, but which are inside us all the time: “nigger,” “Uncle Tom,” “jungle bunny,” “Oreo”; lynching, cattle prods, castrations, rapists, “black pussy,” and black men with their huge penises, and hundreds more. (I shudder as I write.). We need to review three different kinds of material: (a) all our personal memories connected with blackness and black people including everything we can recall hearing or reading; (b) all the racist images and stereotypes we've ever heard, particularly the grossest and most hurtful ones; (c) any race related things we ourselves said, did or omitted doing which we feel bad about today…Most whites begin with a good deal of amnesia. Eventually the memories crowd in, especially when several people pool recollections. Emotional release is a vital part of the process. Experiencing feelings seems to allow further recollections to come. I need persistent encouragement from my companions to continue
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> (Winter, 1977, p. 3).

Self-reckoning for POC is an equally difficult and painful journey. It is impossible for anyone born and raised in the United States from inheriting

the racial biases of our forebears and our society, including persons of color. In other words, the socialization process also imbues within POC stereotypes and biases about themselves (internalized racism) and about other groups of color. Kendi (2019), an African American man, confesses that he is a lifelong racist and has supported ideas, actions, and policies that by nature are racist. In his view, everyone, not just white Americans, have been raised in such a way to be racist, sexist, and homophobic. Although we agree that POC can be biased, bigoted, and harbor stereotypes about other groups of color, we do not consider these to be forms of racism and differ from the stance of Kendi.

In the United States, it is white people who dominate and control the institutions and social policies that create and enforce “American” cultural values and norms. Relative to white people, POC are relatively powerless on a societal level. On the basis of that fact alone, racism in the United States can only be attributed to white Americans and not to persons of color. Yes, POC can harm and oppress one another. Yes, when African Americans act in discriminatory ways toward Asian Americans or vice versa, they act as agents of a racist society, but it is not racism because POC just do not control the levers of power and cannot oppress on a systemic level. Regardless of this academic argument, however, the bias POC have toward one another can lead to interracial/interethnic conflicts and harm. Like white brothers and sisters, POC must also overthrow their cultural conditioning. The goals may be different, but self-reckoning must occur. For POC, it is overthrowing (a) the feelings of inferiority that lead to low self-esteem, (b) the negative scripts we have been taught about other racial/cultural groups, and (c) the belief that white Americans are the enemy and cannot become allies.

Self-deception is energy depleting, creates an inauthentic and unfeeling self, and allows us to continue in our oppressive ways. Facing and embracing the truth, however, allow us to break the shackles of dishonesty, to once again claim our humanity, to free us from living falsehoods, and to empower us. The transformation from deception to awareness requires the following: First, all of us must be willing to tolerate the unpleasantness associated with an honest appraisal of our biases and prejudices. Second, we must begin to challenge our own racial reality. We must begin to understand ourselves as racial/cultural beings and how it potentially distorts our view of race and

racism. Third, white Americans cannot continue to view POC as subhuman aliens and inferior beings. Likewise, POC must begin to understand that white people are not the enemy, but it is the doctrine of white supremacy. We must begin to understand our worldview through experiential reality, rather than the images fed to us by the mass media and the educational system. Finally, a racial self-reckoning will free us from all the psychic energy expended toward denying our own racial/ethnic heritage, self-hate, internalized racism, and colorism with all the nested and embedded emotions of fear, humiliation, defensiveness, anger, and guilt associated with race and racism.

Anti-Racism (Words and Deeds)

> In a racist society it is not enough to be non-racist, we must be anti-racist.
>
> —Angela Davis

Critical awareness of racism (critical consciousness), realizing that no one is immune from inheriting racist attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors, and accepting the distressing knowledge that you harbor and have engaged in racism (personal reckoning) are not enough to combat prejudice and discrimination without active anti-racist interventions (Helms, 2014; Hughey & Smith, 2022). Kendi (2019), in his best-selling book, *How to Be an Antiracist*, asserts that being "non-racist" is a problematic concept because it denotes "neutrality." He submits that the opposite of "racist" isn't "not racist" (non-racist), but "anti-racist." In many respects, Kendi's distinction is a good one, but he fails to recognize the major difference between *"becoming non-racist"* as a dynamic developmental process *and being non-racist* as an end point or static goal. Almost all white racial identity theorists postulate a developmental process by which white people move from naivete to awareness of racism, to realization of their roles in its perpetuation, to forming non-racist identities, and finally to being committed to anti-racist actions (Hardiman, 1982, Helms, 2014; Ponterotto, 1988). Furthermore, Kendi seems to view the concepts of "non-racist" and "anti-racist" as an either/or dichotomy related to an identity, rather than viewing anti-racism as actions (words and deeds) that can arise from either orientation.

If individuals, however, become stuck at a non-racist stage of development or consider it sufficient in their own personal identity and development, then, like Kendi, we believe it to be problematic. Such individuals are fooled into believing that as long as they do not personally discriminate, consciously condemn racism, and are not active racists, they have achieved their personal goal of being non-racist. This becomes a form of complacency where individuals believe they have adequately dealt with their own personal racial hang-ups and achieved the goal of becoming non-racist. It can become a rationalization for inaction and allows the maintenance of the status quo. Being anti-racist as an end point may result in short-term involvement, expression of antiracist commitments only when convenient, and engaging in recognition-seeking for one's antiracist activities. These individuals may refrain from personally discriminating, can discern stereotyping and racism in TV commercials, television characters, advertisements, and other public displays, recognize bias and discrimination in education and employment, and publicly condemn hate crimes and racism. But they fail to be actively anti-racist. In many respects, they exist in an imaginary "never-never land," where they maintain a self-congratulatory smugness about being better than others because of their "woke" status*: I am not like those hate-mongers. Racists are only the Skinheads and Klan. I don't discriminate. I'm not prejudiced. I believe in equality. I am a good and moral person. I am better than that*.

Active and Passive Racists

The distinction between being non-racist and anti-racist is an important one. Perhaps, the difference is best exemplified in a metaphor used by Tatum (1997) to describe the cycle of racism and her distinction between active and passive racists.

> I sometimes visualize the ongoing cycle of racism as a moving walkway at the airport. Active racist behavior is equivalent to walking fast on the conveyor belt. The person engaged in active racist behavior has identified with the ideology of White supremacy and is moving with it. Passive racist behavior is equivalent to standing still on the walkway. No overt effort is being made, but the conveyor belt moves the bystanders along to the same destination as those who are actively walking. Some of the bystanders may feel the motion of the conveyor belt, see the active racists ahead of them, and choose to turn around, unwilling to go to the same destination as the White supremacists. But unless they are walking actively in the opposite direction at a speed faster than the conveyor belt—unless they are actively antiracist—they will find themselves carried along with the others.
>
> (Tatum, 1997, pp. 11–12)

Tatum's walkway analogy makes a distinction between being an active racist and a passive one. Despite having a non-racist identity, if one does not engage in antiracism actions, neglects confronting racism in others, and fails to challenge systemic oppression, one may be a passive racist. To understand the metaphor, it is important to explicitly point out the symbolism being used.

First, the moving walkway represents the powerful, insidious, continuous, and invisible nature of racism. It is headed in the direction of white supremacy, where from birth, we are placed on a conveyor belt that represents the biased societal cultural values and its institutional programs, policies, and practices. The movement of the belt is barely noticeable, and people are lulled into the belief that it represents the “right direction.”

Second, what one does on the conveyor belt determines whether they are active racists or passive ones. Active racists walk in the direction of the conveyor belt and encourage others to do likewise, hoping to reach their destination quickly in order to enjoy the rewards of a racist society. These individuals may be white nationalists who walk quickly on the belt, but most are people oblivious to the manifestation, dynamics, or impact of racism. They are the ones who believe in the sincere fictions of American society (Bell, 2003).

Third, passive racists may be likened to those who disavow racism and refuse to walk in the direction of white supremacy. Yet, as they stand on the walkway, despite their non-racist stance, they are carried in the direction of white superiority, where they become secondary oppressors (Hanna et al. 2000). Despite their conscious beliefs of justice, equity, and fairness, inaction on the walkway means that these individuals are also ultimately responsible for the oppression of others.

Fourth, according to Tatum's (1997) metaphor, anti-racists would be individuals who refuse to move in the direction of the walkway and who actively walk or run in the opposite direction of the belt. The problem is that unless you are moving faster than the belt in a reverse direction, and unless you have unlimited energy to do so for the rest of your life, fatigue and exhaustion will overtake you. This is true for both white Americans and persons of color.

Finally, we offer another dimension to the walkway analogy by stating that simply moving or running in the opposite direction is not enough. We must stop the belt or reverse its direction to be effective in ultimately dismantling racism. In speaking about the conveyor belt analogy, Sue et al. (2022) summarize the challenge:

> The questions being posed here to trainees are challenging. How do we motivate White Americans to (a) notice the subtle movement of the walkway (making the invisible visible), (b) discern the ominous direction it is taking (toward White racial supremacy), (c) begin to move in the opposite direction (antiracism), and (d) stop the conveyor belt or reverse its direction (institutional and societal change)? As discussed earlier, becoming nonracist means engaging in soul searching, individual change, and working on the self; becoming antiracist, however, means also taking personal action to end external racism that exists systemically and in the actions of others (p. 142).

Challenges to Anti-Racist Actions

There are numerous other concerns that confront people and prevent them from taking anti-racist actions: (a) fear of punitive consequences and (b) response uncertainty that leads to paralysis. When targets, white allies, or onlookers take action to stop or disarm racist expressions or actions, they

are almost always “swimming upstream” or going against the prevailing, acceptable, and normative biased values and standards of the society. As a result, their intervention actions are not appreciated, considered inappropriate, condemned, and often punished.

Fear of Punitive Consequences

In essence, retaliatory measures have the direct and indirect effect of making people complicit in the perpetuation of racism by enforcing silence and inaction. Sue et al. (2021) have identified five potential punitive costs of taking anti-bias actions.

1. ***Isolation***. One of the greatest fears of engaging in anti-racist intervention is the social consequences of ostracism and rejection by family, friends, neighbors, coworkers, and colleagues for violating biased traditional family, social, employment, or community norms (Malott et al., 2019). Family or friends may not understand and appreciate having someone challenge or point out racist language or behavior; they may feel offended, embarrassed, or falsely accused. People, including family members, may begin to avoid the person, no longer share confidences with them, and no longer offer social support (Tatum, 2002). White allies often state that the greatest backlash to their newly found attempts to confront racism is the break in their prior relationships and the loss of the intimacy and support (Malott et al., 2019).
2. ***Loss of Position and Power***. Many people strive to attain a position of influence, respect, and dominance. They strive to better their lives socially, economically, and politically. Going against the “company line” may jeopardize their aspirations or current positions: it may result in their loss of a promotion, not being elected to positions of authority, or even being fired from a place of employment. The potential loss of power and privilege and the economic costs of going against the prevailing norms of the community may discourage anti-bias actions.
3. ***Attacks on Character***. Throughout history, people who speak out against unfair oppressive laws and interpersonal expressions of bias and discrimination have often been met with attacks on their character.

They have been described, at best, as “bleeding heart liberals” and, at worst, flawed, whiners, immature, deranged, and/or trouble-makers. For POC who protest, they are often characterized as playing the race card, representing criminal elements, being paranoid, and not loving their country. By attacking the integrity or motives of protestors and attributing their actions to personal flaws, it undermines the legitimacy of the bias issues being raised.

4. ***Stress and Burnout***. It goes without saying that POC who constantly deal with bias, especially microaggressions, are under constant stress. The term *racial battle fatigue* has been used to describe the exhaustion and fatigue that can occur from continuously responding to racism in their daily lives. For white allies or bystanders, pushback against their attempts to intervene and to negate or disarm bias can also lead to unceasing pushback from family, friends, and colleagues. Anti-racist actions and their consequences can lead to burnout, a state of emotional exhaustion, feelings of helplessness, and pessimism.
5. ***Violent Threats and Physical Harm***. Anti-racist actions that seek individual and institutional change often threaten the status quo and the power and privilege held by many white Americans. As a result, to keep anti-racists from rocking the boat and upsetting the balance of power, threats of retaliation can take many forms: (a) mild expressions of disapproval—silence, name-calling, or ridicule and (b) direct threats of retaliation—name-calling, potential loss of a job, or ostracism. In extreme cases, physical intimidation or bodily harm may be instigated.

Response Uncertainty and Paralysis

One of the greatest barriers in taking anti-racist action is response uncertainty, where people witness a racist transgression but are unsure of how to respond. Even if the person overcomes the fear of punitive actions, they may be paralyzed from not knowing what to do (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Sue et al., 2009). Thus, inaction may not be so much avoiding responsible behavior but rather a “freeze effect” born from the individual's lack of an effective response repertoire. Admonitions to “do something” are frequently heard from anti-racist activists, but the question is what? Should you confront the perpetrator forcefully or gently? Will the target appreciate your intervention or resent it? By intervening, will you make the situation

worse? What specific strategies, skills, or tactics have been identified to be most effective in disarming racist behaviors and actions? Are some anti-racist actions more appropriate for targets than for white allies or bystanders? How can POC and white people prepare and arm themselves with the tools to effectively respond to prejudice and discrimination?

Scholars have often noted that effective anti-bias actions must be learned, practiced, and constantly rehearsed so that they become part of the automatic repertoire of responses in the individual (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Scully & Rowe, 2009). Sue and Spanierman (2020) have noted that bias in interpersonal interactions often occurs so quickly that by the time an ally or target decides how to respond, the transgression is over. The latency between a biased act and a response offers only a brief period to take responsible action. If the person lacks the "comeback" response to a racist incident or feels awkward and hesitant to act, the educational opportunity is lost.

To address this issue, Sue and colleagues (Sue et al., 2019, 2021) have noted the paucity of studies on anti-bias strategies that they call "microinterventions" and a useful classification that can identify their types, strategic goals, rationale, and tactics. They conclude that education and training are required to learn and master the use of microinterventions. In their taxonomy, they propose four strategic goals of microinterventions: (a) make the "invisible" visible, (b) educate the perpetrator, (c) disarm the micro/macroaggressions, and (d) seek outside support and advice. Under each of these four categories, they propose tactics that can be practiced and rehearsed by targets, white allies, and bystanders and used to neutralize and disarm interpersonal and systemic bias when they appear. A number of studies suggest that such training is effective in counteracting biased and discriminatory behaviors (Alsaidi, 2021; Awad & Connors, 2023; Grass et al., 2024; Walker et al., 2022). We will elaborate on these tactics in later chapters.

THE DANCE OF RACISM

In this chapter, we have raised several critical questions that are addressed throughout the book. First, how do we get our citizens, of all races, roles, and positions, to recognize the manifestation, dynamics, and harmful

impact of racism? Second, how do we get them to be aware of and to resist the sociopolitical process and forces that discourage anti-racist actions and reward them for their silence and complicity? Third, on an individual level, what prevents good, moral, and decent individuals from taking action to intervene when a moral transgression occurs? Fourth, how can we encourage POC and white Americans to overcome their fears and societal obstacles to take responsible action to overcome racism? Although there are many commonalities that discourage anti-bias actions, we also recognize that the roles people play may offer different challenges depending on whether one is a perpetrator (Chapter 2), target (Chapter 3), bystander (Chapter 4), or white ally (Chapter 5).

To understand how each of us may be complicit in the perpetuation of racism and why viewing anti-racism solutions as isolated to only individuals, we provide another metaphor about breaking the deadly dance of racism, how all four participants or actors (perpetrator, target, bystander, and white ally) may unintentionally conspire with one another to allow racism to go unchallenged, and what conditions and actions are needed to dilute, diminish, and disarm racial bias and bigotry. Finally, in what ways do our societal and institutional programs, policies, and practices contribute to the racism problem? We believe that it does little good to become anti-racist on an individual level when the very society we live in punishes us for taking such actions. In the remaining chapters, we assert that breaking the deadly dance of racism must also address the biased socialization practices and the dynamic interplay of systemic racism.

The Dance Metaphor

> Imagine the following scenario. At a social event, a small group of people are gathered around a jokester, telling an offensive racist joke. As the punchline is delivered, some are obviously distressed by the joke, while others appear oblivious to the racist connotation. Those in the audience who disapprove of the story, however, remain silent, and some even feign laughter. A window into the thoughts and reactions of four different roles played by participants provides clues into why racism continues unabated in our daily interactions.
>
> **Perpetrator** (when called out about the offensive nature of the joke): It wasn't my intention at all! Can't you take a joke? Why are you people so oversensitive? Don't be so paranoid. I'm sorry if **you** were offended.
>
> **Target:** Did what I think happen, really happen? I am totally shocked and angry. How insulting and hurtful. Should I do or say something? I shouldn't be such a coward, I ought to say something! But, if I call it out, what are the consequences?
>
> **Bystander:** I really don't understand why people are so upset. It was just a harmless joke, and really funny. Let's give each other a break! Why is everything always about race?
>
> **White ally:** That wasn't funny at all. But what can I do, I'm only one person? If I say something, people will think I can't take a joke. Or I could make the situation worse. The individual (target) might resent my intrusion or not want my help.

The dynamics of racism and its expression can be likened to a dance performance composed of individual actors, each fulfilling their designated roles that are choreographed and filled with symbolic meaning. The symbolic meaning of the dance is scripted by hidden white supremacist guidelines composed of scripts, ground rules, and norms where individual performers are expected to follow the established rhythmic movements and interactions that are well rehearsed and constantly fortified by our biased societal rules. The dance reinforces a story of white superiority and POC inferiority, attempts to mask the racist meaning of the performance, and discourages improvisation that may deviate from a racist script. Most of the dancers follow the dance steps willingly and without question (perpetrators

and many bystanders), others feel awkward and forced (white allies), and still others reluctantly comply or decline to participate because their "toes" are being stepped on (targets). Those who hesitate or resist are considered uncoordinated "bad dancers" or poor partners in the dance of racism.

Our use of a conceptual "dance metaphor" is not meant to trivialize or to diminish the harshness and gravity of racism but is used to illustrate how racist scripts force compliance among dancers, to analyze symbiotic social interactions, and to illustrate the importance of performative resistance in subverting and breaking the roles, expectations, and norms in the dance of racism (Butler, 2002; Hasford, 2016). Indeed, sociologist Erving Goffman (1959) was among the first to successfully use dramaturgy (actors, audience, scripts, performance stage, and props) to successfully analyze social interactions. Likewise, research on racial microaggressions (Sue & Spanierman, 2020) and difficult dialogues on race (Sue, 2015) suggests four possible roles played by "dancers" when a racist incident occurs: *perpetrator, target, bystander, and white ally*. Uncovering the internal dialogue or reactions of these four actors, their symbiotic relationships to one another, and the scripts they follow provides clues as to why the dance of racism makes silence and inaction so prevalent in our nation. In future chapters, we explore the major factors that make breaking the dance of racism so difficult on an individual, symbiotic, and institutional/societal basis.

First, on an individual basis, the common and unique challenges faced by the perpetrator, target, bystander, and ally to confront and call out racism are revealed throughout the book. Although the reluctance to confront a racist incident is often similar for all those involved, the role of each dancer contains distinctive features that are seldom delineated. Most attempts to overcome silence and apathy, for example, have approached the task with a "one size fits all" approach (Bullock et al., 2021). Yet, it is clear that target reactions to a racist event differ considerably from bystanders who may lack critical consciousness of the manifestation, dynamics, and impact of implicit bias (Dovidio et al., 2002). Even the awareness of racism by white allies does not necessarily guarantee anti-racist actions (Szekeres et al., 2023). For targets who are pained by racism, taking care of oneself first is a top priority; for bystanders, developing critical consciousness is important; and as we have emphasized, being non-racist is insufficient to overcome

inaction—one must become anti-racist (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Helms, 1995). Understanding the unique obstacles to breaking the cycle of racism for each of the individual roles is discussed in future chapters.

Second, success in overcoming apathy and inaction must attune to the dynamic interplay of all four dancing roles. Few studies have focused upon the symbiotic interactions that occur between perpetrator and target, ally and target, bystander and perpetrator, etc., which make it difficult to disarm racism without considering the potential influence of other actors on one another. For example, most studies on racial microaggressions focus primarily upon the harmful impact of perpetrators on targets, but few analyze the lively exchange between all four roles, reactions/responses that either worsen or lessen the effect, and the complexity engendered in the clash of racial realities (Xie & Galliher, 2022). The murder of African American George Floyd in 2020, for example, raised the question as to why so many onlookers and even fellow police officers stood idly by while a fellow white officer placed his knee on Floyd's throat for a full nine minutes and choked him to death. Although there are many important factors influencing the actions of others (race of the perpetrator, target or bystander, different interpretations of the situation, group harmony and balance, etc.), one explanation is the “bystander effect,” where researchers found that the more people who witness an emergency situation, the less likely a person is to take action or intervene.

Focusing on the holistic interactions of all four groups is important because displays of racism do not merely happen between perpetrator and target; incidents of racism often occur in the presence of a larger audience (i.e., bystanders and allies). Their presence in witnessing a microaggression, for example, and their action or inaction have a profound impact upon the outcome.

Third, disarming microaggressions and other forms of biased behaviors requires understanding the systemic, ecological, and normative umbrella that reinforces and supports racism and bias (Skinner-Dorkenoo et al., 2021). In the dance of racism, for example, the dancers are playing and performing roles dictated by implicit and explicit social and institutional norms and rules. Understanding how cultural racism and white supremacy impact interpersonal interactions supplies clues as to what must be addressed at the societal and organizational levels (Bryant et al., 2021).

Active interventions are either enhanced or negated depending upon existing institutional policies and the social norms of communities. It has been found, for example, that organizations that profess values and policies of cultural plurality in their workspace (recognizing and valuing differences) diminish discriminatory behaviors among workers, while those that operate from a racially color-blind philosophy actually encourage greater expressions of bias toward employees of color (Plaut et al., 2009). Additionally, a racially color-blind approach in institutions also acts as a *macroaggression* that produces threat among employees of color (Sue et al., 2021).

Final Words

> I am only one; but I am still one. I cannot do everything, but still I can do something. I will not refuse to do the something I can do.
>
> —Helen Keller

We know how overwhelming it can be to think about a single individual taking action and possibly making a difference. Racism seems so pervasive, entrenched, and powerful to overcome. We wrote this book specifically to help everyone overcome the anxiety and painful realization of their roles in the perpetuation of racism. But we also provide specific concrete suggestions, skills, and actions that targets, bystanders, white allies and even perpetrators can do to disarm and diminish racism and to no longer remain silent in the face of bias and discrimination. While the process of overcoming racism in ourselves, others, and the wider society is not an easy task, the potential benefits are many. Those who have undertaken the journey often remark that they have personally benefited (Goodman, 2011). They have increased their racial literacy, improved their interracial and interethnic interactions, experienced a broadening of their horizons, increased their appreciation of people (all colors and cultures), become less afraid and intimidated by differences, been able to communicate more openly and clearly with their family, friends, and coworkers, and experienced a greater spiritual connectedness with all groups (President's Initiative on Race, 1998, 1999; Sue, 2003).

Equally important are the potential benefits to our institutions and to our society. In business and industry, for example, creating an accepting and

respectful work climate increases business innovation, facilitates creativity and better ideas, enhances problem solving, and increases better decisions due to an increased talent pool and perception by Employees of Color that they are welcomed and appreciated (Sue et al., 2021). In organizations that value diversity, better morale leads to low turnover and is perceived by the public in a positive way. For society, an anti-racist environment maximized the growth of all citizens and lives up to its values of equity, diversity, and equal access and opportunity for everyone.

The journey to anti-racism is a long one filled with potholes and challenges. But while the path is seemingly long and arduous, we are reminded of the old Chinese proverb: *A journey of a thousand miles begins with a single step*.

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PART TWO
The Dancers

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CHAPTER TWO
Barriers to Perpetrator Awareness and Reparative Action

> The white complicity claim maintains that white people, through the practices of whiteness and by benefiting from white privilege, contribute to the maintenance of systemic racial injustice. However, the claim also implies responsibility in its assumption that the failure to acknowledge such complicity will thwart whites in their efforts to dismantle unjust racial systems and, more specifically, will contribute to the perpetuation of racial injustice
>
> (Applebaum, 2010, p. 3).

Who are perpetrators of racism? Most of us would agree that white neo-Nazis, the Proud Boys, skinheads, the Klan, and other white supremacist groups fit this label. Indeed, in the current political climate, blatant racial hatred has made a troubling resurgence, with explicit racism (sometimes coded) increasingly expressed and tolerated. The Trump Administration's deliberate enactment of racist policies and rhetoric has emboldened others to act in discriminatory ways toward POC (Chen et al., 2023; Rouse & Telhami, 2022). Mounting evidence indicates not only a rise in overt and normalized racism within segments of the white population (Giani & Méon, 2021; Jardina & Piston, 2023) but also a troubling shift in perception: nearly one-third of White Americans now believe there is “a lot more” discrimination against white people than POC (Rouse & Telhami, 2022). This stark contrast to the lived experiences of African Americans, Asian Americans, Latinx Americans, Arab Americans, and Native Americans underscores the widening gap between perception and reality. Growing tolerance for racism is likely to influence both explicit and implicit bias, though ongoing research is needed to document the precise nature of the effects.

This chapter builds on Applebaum's (2010) white complicity claim, exploring who perpetrators are, how their complicity operates, and why it matters. In contrast to the mistaken belief that racism resides only in white

supremacists, we define perpetrators in the *deadly dance of racism* as white people who would not consider themselves racist but nonetheless are complicit in advancing a white supremacist system.

Regardless of their intent, for most white people in the United States, being a perpetrator is the default standard. Although this claim may unsettle many white Americans, we believe it is critical to explain and contextualize it here. Because the deadly dance of racism includes interactions with POC, it is almost impossible for POC not to experience just about every white person as a perpetrator to some degree. Although perpetrators may be well-intentioned individuals who would not deliberately engage in racial discrimination, their slights and invalidations toward POC express prejudice, paternalistic assumptions, and negative stereotypes embedded in the institutions and cultural fabric of US society. In earlier work, we emphasized that micro-level, individual racism exists in a macro-context of structural, systems-level racism (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). Because perpetrators commonly view racism as an individual phenomenon located among extreme social actors and generally do not acknowledge structural racism, they often are unaware of how their offensive statements or biased behaviors both reflect and reinscribe the macro-context of structural racism. Given this understanding of perpetrators, in this chapter we outline barriers to perpetrator awareness as well as how perpetrators tend to respond when called out for racial invalidations and slights. We also offer strategies for raising racial awareness, calling perpetrators in, calling them out, or using both approaches, depending on the context, to break the dance of racism and work toward a future rooted in accountability, relational repair, and racial justice.

OVERCOMING PERPETRATOR UNAWARENESS

Various psychological and sociological theories have sought to describe and explain perpetrators. For example, social psychologists have described perpetrators both as symbolic racists, those who support policies that favor white people while maintaining the illusion of race neutrality (Sears & Kinder, 1971), and aversive racists, those who explicitly endorse egalitarian values but hold implicit biases (Dovidio et al., 2002). Delineating an

ultramodern form of racism, Neville et al. (2000, 2013) defined color-blind racial ideology as the denial, distortion, and minimization of race and racism. Both Neville et al. (2013) and Bonilla-Silva (2021) explained how this seemingly neutral position of racial color-blindness (i.e., not seeing race or racism) is a form of racism in and of itself. Bonilla-Silva (2021) named the phenomenon “racism without racists” to show that ignoring and denying racism serves to maintain the racial status quo with whites in the dominant position. In a 2024 interview about his book, *What This Comedian Said Will Shock You*, Bill Maher, the host of HBO's *Real Time*, exhibited color-blind racial ideology when he said, “Clearly, racism is simply no longer everywhere. It's not in my home. And it probably isn't in yours.” (Bennett and Lane, 2024) Maher's sentiments are typical of moderate white liberals who tend to (a) minimize the role of racism and white privilege, (b) believe in a meritocratic and just world, and (c) maintain a view of themselves as good, decent, moral, and fair.

Strong social conditioning—what developmental scientists call white racial socialization—shapes white racial identity development, sets the stage for perpetrators' dance moves, and maintains white racial dominance in the United States. White racial socialization occurs through families, neighborhoods, media, and schools, and such socialization informs how white youth learn about race, racism, and racial privilege. Although white racial socialization can transmit messages of white supremacy or racial justice, research on white racial socialization in families tends to identify “white silence” (i.e., the absence of discussion about race and racism) or the transmission of color-blind racial ideology (Neville et al., 2013) across generations. For a brief review of studies on white racial socialization (see Spanierman, 2022).

Because perpetrators live, breathe, and move within families, neighborhoods, schools, and workplaces, where they most often are socialized to deny, distort, or minimize race and racism, they experience barriers to becoming aware of structural racism and their complicity in such a system. These barriers to perpetrator awareness manifest in multiple dimensions (i.e., cognitive, affective, behavioral, and spiritual), and, in prior work, we argue they are tied to costs of being in the dominant racial group position (Spanierman & Heppner, 2004; Sue & Spanierman, 2020; see also Goodman, 2011). In short, when a perpetrator dominates or dehumanizes

others, even unintentionally, they also dehumanize themselves. As Segrest (2001) suggested in *The Souls of White Folks*, there is pain inherent in inhabiting and maintaining domination—a sort of psychic wound. Thus, we agree with Trepagnier (2017) that it is crucial to shift focus from whether one is a racist to understanding one's level of racial awareness. Below, we describe cognitive, affective, behavioral, and spiritual barriers to racial awareness and how these barriers operate among perpetrators in the deadly dance of racism. Although we discuss these dimensions separately, we acknowledge they are not mutually exclusive. All four domains interact and overlap in myriad ways.

Cognitive Barriers

White people face a range of cognitive barriers to racial awareness, including distortions of reality, misrepresentations of POC, and misperceptions of themselves. These cognitive barriers to awareness are pervasive and are, in part, perpetuated by color-blind racial ideology (Neville et al., 2000, 2013). Like color-blind racial ideology and perhaps most closely aligned with our concept of cognitive barriers, King (1991) identified dysconscious racism as an "uncritical habit of mind that justifies inequity and exploitation … a form of racism that tacitly accepts dominant white norms and privileges" (p. 135). King describes dysconscious racism as an impaired consciousness, as opposed to unconsciousness, representing a distorted way of thinking. Germane to the discussion of cognitive barriers is Helms's (1995) theory of white racial identity development, which focuses on white people's thoughts and feelings about their own racial group and POC, as well as their understanding of structural racism and white privilege. In particular, the racial identity status she calls "contact" is characterized by obliviousness of race and racism, avoidance of racial stimuli, and a pull-yourself-up-by-your-bootstraps mentality.

Distorted Sense of Reality

Because white people are socialized to either completely ignore racial issues or to minimize race and racism, perpetrators tend to exhibit a distorted sense of reality akin to King's (1991) dysconscious racism. It is easy for perpetrators to tacitly accept white values and practices as normative because they see racism as located only in individuals (e.g., neo-

Nazis); they either are unable to see or refuse to consider structural forms of racism. For example, racially illiterate white people likely are unaware of racial disparities in education, imprisonment rates, unemployment, household income, family net worth, and healthcare (for disparity data, see Economic Policy Institute, 2022). Perpetrators are unaware of laws, policies, practices, and cultural values that support and sustain racial disparities and may even blame POC for their situations. Jones (1997) described cultural racism as the individual and institutional expression of the belief in the superiority of one's cultural heritage over all others. Cultural racism imbues the power of one group to define the values and worldview of a society. When white people have declared what is considered normal and what is deviant, they define reality through their own self-interests. There is an inability to accept POC's perceptions of reality or their experiences as valid.

White racial socialization most often works to maintain the status quo and keep white people at the top of a racial hierarchy. Because of their willful self-segregation and self-isolation, even well-meaning white people's worldviews oftentimes are not informed by the perspectives of POC, leading to an incomplete and distorted white worldview—one that seems fair and just, with equal opportunities for all. The white worldview becomes normative, seems natural, remains unseen, and is extremely hard to unlearn. In the rare cases where someone or something pierces the white bubble and allows perpetrators to see pervasive racial disparities in society, they may experience confusion, anxiety, or guilt about the coexistence of democracy and racial inequities. Helms (1995) refers to this as the *disintegration* status in white racial identity development. Disintegration involves a critical event or events that pierce the white bubble. Subsequently, white individuals might experience guilt and anxiety as they feel forced to choose between loyalty to their own group and the larger moral and humanistic issues that arise in a racially unjust system. If the ambivalent nature of disintegration is too emotionally taxing, whites may move to *reintegration*, in which they idealize whiteness and experience outright disdain for POC.

Although the education system has the potential to offer an important context to counter white hegemonic social conditioning, few schools implement policies and practices to address race and racism intentionally in ways that support inclusion and the development of positive racial

identities. In the cases where school districts have taken baby steps to address white racial unawareness, they are under threat of right-wing legislatures targeting them. Not surprisingly then, most US schools and curricula impart a white, Western European perspective as the culmination of human achievement in ways that distort, deny, or minimize the histories of POC in the United States. In *Lies My Teacher Told Me: Everything Your American History Textbook Got Wrong*, Loewen (2007) analyzed widely used US history textbooks to highlight their inaccurate, incomplete, and whitewashed portrayals. For example, the texts do not address the forced removal and genocide of American Indians and instead tend to emphasize the heroic nature of European explorers. These sorts of omissions in the education system reproduce negative biases and color-blind racial ideology across generations. Moreover, the recent book banning and assault on critical race theory in education not only prevent POC from learning about their communities' integral contributions but also deny white people from learning an increasingly more complete account of US history, thus increasing the odds of perpetuating white ignorance, fear, and dominance. In the current moment, rather than a passive avoidance of learning POC's experiential realities, book banning and assaults on diversity and equity exemplify active resistance to any information that might counter white hegemonic conditioning.

Most often, white racial socialization through schools and other societal institutions involves intergenerational transmission of color-blind racial ideology. White people are socialized to deny or minimize race and tend to learn that it is impolite to discuss racial issues. Thus, it is not surprising that white participants in our research and others' have reported using several strategies to minimize race and racism. Neville et al. (2013) categorized these strategies as color-evasion and power-evasion. We define each and provide some examples to illustrate.

Color evasion refers to minimizing racial differences and emphasizing sameness. Color-evasive remarks are common among white people. On its face, it might seem a good thing to ignore racial differences and see all people as the same. However, as Neville et al. (2013) explained, emphasizing sameness denies racial differences, negates experiential realities, and, in turn, promotes cross-racial tensions. Examples include:

- In one of our studies, a white university student said, “We are all Americans,” and “We're all the same and we're all God's children … Jesus loves every color children” (Spanierman et al., 2008, p. 857).
- Similarly, in a study among white Christians, a participant stated, “We're all one race. We're all sons of God [laughs], red, yellow—it doesn't matter what color your skin is. We're all part of this together” (Mehta et al., 2022, p. 630).
- A colleague remarked to one of us (Derald Wing Sue): “When I look at you, I don't see you as an Asian American at all. You're no different than me. We're both Americans. Why can't we simply relate to one another as human beings? After all, there is only one race in this world. It's called the human race” (Sue, 2003, p. 132).

Power evasion refers to denying societal racism by emphasizing the myth of meritocracy—the notion that equal opportunities are available for all and based solely on individual abilities. Examples from prior research include:

- White student participants claimed that racism is not as much of a problem in society as it used to be—some even declared racism is a thing of the past (Spanierman et al., 2008).
- White undergraduates accused POC of using racism as an excuse to explain away their predicament. One woman stated, “Sometimes I think it's ‘cause they just want an excuse to be like … ‘I don't have good grades because I am a minority.’ I think a lot of people use race as a crutch and just kind of want … the easy way into things and the easy way out of things” (Spanierman et al., 2008, p. 858).
- In a study among white adolescents asking about their racial privilege, one interviewee responded, “Not personally, no [I haven't experienced white privilege]. Um, I haven't really noticed, um, much racism in the places that I live or spend my time. Um, and so I can't say that I noticed any differences in the way that I was treated from a person that wouldn't be white” (Dull et al., 2024).

Color-blind racial ideology makes its way into law, which in turn reproduces the existing racialized social order. In her 2014 dissenting opinion on upholding Michigan's ban on affirmative action in public

universities, Supreme Court Justice Sonia Sotomayor highlighted how these barriers to perpetrator awareness influence US Supreme Court Justice opinions. Challenging the racially color-blind opinion, she wrote:

> Race matters … because of persistent racial inequality in society—inequality that cannot be ignored and that has produced stark socioeconomic disparities…
>
> And race matters for reasons that really are only skin deep, that cannot be discussed any other way, and that cannot be wished away. Race matters to a young man's view of society when he spends his teenage years watching others tense up as he passes, no matter the neighborhood where he grew up. Race matters to a young woman's sense of self when she states her hometown, and then is pressed, “No, where are you really from?” regardless of how many generations her family has been in the country. Race matters to a young person addressed by a stranger in a foreign language, which he does not understand because only English was spoken at home. Race matters because of the slights, the snickers, the silent judgments that reinforce that most crippling of thoughts: “I do not belong here.”
>
> In my colleagues' view, examining the racial impact of legislation only perpetuates racial discrimination. This refusal to accept the stark reality that race matters is regrettable. The way to stop discrimination on the basis of race is to speak openly and candidly on the subject of race, and to apply the Constitution with eyes open to the unfortunate effects of centuries of racial discrimination

(Sotomayor, 2014, Schuette v. Coalition to Defend Affirmative Action).

Distorted View of People of Color

Another cognitive barrier to perpetrator racial self-awareness is a distorted view of POC. As a consequence of self-segregation and lack of meaningful, equal-status contact with POC, white people tend to base their perceptions on indirect knowledge imbued with racial stereotypes. Such misperceptions that homogenize racial otherness are grounded in longstanding stereotypes that play as truths promulgated through the racial socialization mechanisms described above (e.g., Hollywood movies, social media, history textbooks, and so on). Because these tropes are longstanding and widespread, white

people tend to believe them as facts and essentialize POC. Even when white people do not consciously work from racial stereotypes, their implicit attitudes consistently associate POC with the tropes documented below (Greenwald & Banaji, 2017).

As Stewart (2021) reminded us in a *Medium* essay, the n-word (and we would add related epithets) is tied to intergenerational pain for POC. Thus, naming these stereotypes in academic writing comes at a cost to POC. We acknowledge the painful histories tied to these stereotypes and include them here to show how these images (a) continue to shape the hearts and minds of white perpetrators in the dance of racism and (b) manifest in daily microaggressions that have cumulative effects for POC. Ultimately, we hope that naming these negative stereotypes might peel off one layer of the onion for perpetrators and help them see how their beliefs are rooted in centuries-long misperceptions of POC that deny their experiential realities and maintain the racial hierarchy with whites on top. We aim to shift the blame from the targets to white people's distorted perceptions. Below, we report stereotypes that emerged among our research participants and students enrolled in our counseling and psychology courses.

White research participants and students alike shared a range of their negative associations with Black Americans. For example, common responses were “lazy,” “stupid,” and “impulsive.” One respondent remarked, “My view of them is that they're very dependent on … welfare.” Other stereotypes of Black people were that they are hostile, angry, and rude. In a study among Black women, participants reported experiences with projected stereotypes such as the “angry Black woman.” They also met with expectations to be “loud and boisterous,” and they were told “to lower their voice in certain settings” (Lewis et al., 2016, pp. 767 and 771). White respondents in our work consistently reported images of Black people as dangerous criminals, pimps, and drug dealers. Some described Black people as having insatiable sexual appetites, invoking the Jezebel image. These images call up images of slavery and have persisted for centuries. While most stereotypes of Black Americans were negative, there were some seemingly positive tropes, such as Black people are great athletes with excellent physical prowess. However, white people often pigeonhole Black athleticism into boxes—such as basketball players and sprinters—and respond negatively to Black excellence in athletic activities outside of the

box. For example, Serena Williams, perhaps the greatest woman tennis player of all time, faced countless racist incidents both on and off the court. For instance, sports news journalists and online commentators often described Serena Williams as a “gorilla,” “manly,” and “savage” (Frisby, 2017). Moreover, “Serena is criticised consistently for … her ‘natural advantage,’ as if her incredible ability is getting in the way of the Eastern European porcelain blondes just behind her in the ranking” (Whelan, 2015).

Our white research participants and former students also expressed stereotypes about Latinx Americans. Most often, they deemed Latinx Americans foreigners, illegal aliens, welfare recipients, income tax evaders, and “taking our jobs.” Ironically, at the same time they perceived Latinx Americans as employed in “jobs that nobody wants,” such as domestic servants and farmworkers. Negative stereotypes involved lack of skill (e.g., poor English, uneducated, and stupid) and lack of responsibility (e.g., untrustworthy, lazy, sloppy, careless, and always late). They also shared tropes of drug dealers and gang members, reflecting danger. Again, they shared a seemingly positive stereotype of Latinx Americans being religious, but at times this stereotype was coupled with dogmatism or naivete.

Regarding Indigenous Peoples (including those among more than 550 federally recognized American Indian tribes and Alaska Native entities), white research participants and former students shared their deeply entrenched stereotypes that rationalize and justify their marginalization in exchange for taking their land. For example, white respondents presented images of Native Americans as savage, bloodthirsty, and uncivilized. Importantly, Indigenous Peoples also shared their encounters with such stereotypes. In a qualitative study among members of the Saginaw Chippewa Indian Tribe, participants reported that white people think they are carrying tomahawks under their coats (Senter & Ling, 2017). Alongside these violent tropes stands the noble, vanished savage that gave way to white manifest destiny. Across our studies and courses, white respondents also stereotyped Native Americans as alcoholics, poor, nonverbal, superstitious, and uneducable.

When reflecting on their images and beliefs of Asian Americans, white respondents often ascribed the model minority myth such that they are smart, studious, hardworking, and excel in science and mathematics. The model minority myth considers Asian Americans as achieving high

educational and socioeconomic success—a group that made it. However, the model minority myth denies the rich heterogeneity among Asian Americans and denies their experiences with racism (Poon et al., 2016). The myth also pits Asian Americans against other communities of color, who subsequently are blamed for “not making it” like Asian Americans. Additionally, white participants in our research deemed Asian Americans asocial, quiet, passive, obedient, and submissive, which had negative consequences for them in social, academic, and workplace settings (e.g., not being considered for leadership roles). Respondents also reported stereotypes of Asian Americans as spies—sneaky, backstabbers, and disloyal. Asian American men were considered unmasculine and asexual, whereas Asian American women were viewed as exotic and sexually pleasing. Importantly, even seemingly positive stereotypes (i.e., the model minority myth) support and maintain white dominance and supremacy.

Because these distorted views of POC are pervasive and seem like facts to perpetrators, white people often blame the targets of racism for their lived conditions. This blaming dance of racism is rooted deeply in law and in history. During the 19th century, for instance, Samuel George Morton attributed cranial size and shape to intelligence, thus “scientifically” showing POC inferiority was a consequence of smaller brains. During the early 20th century, psychological studies in the United States and Europe were plagued with the racial biases and prejudices of earlier centuries, such as intelligence testing post World War I, which served to reinforce the biological, intellectual, and cultural inferiority of POC (Guthrie, 2003). For centuries, perpetrators have been steeped in the biological inferiority paradigm of POC (Carter & Qureshi, 1995). Twentieth-century anthropologists worked to shift the focus from biology to culture, a dance move that did not eliminate the deficit frame that informed 19th-century pseudoscience. White people proliferated the notion that POC's cultures promoted rejections of white norms and thus, deprived POC of resources and experiences that otherwise would “lift” them out of disadvantage. The underlying idea was that POC could just work harder by changing their values, such as valuing rather than rejecting education, and pull themselves up by their bootstraps to realize the American dream. Often, POC who have “made it” are singled out in ways that reinforce cultural deficit framing.

Distorted View of Oneself

Another significant barrier to racial awareness among perpetrators is a distorted view of oneself. Such distorted self-perceptions include (a) lack of self-awareness as having a race; (b) a false sense of superiority, worth, and entitlement; and (c) a tenacious self-image as good, moral, and virtuous, despite participation in perpetuating racism.

Because white values and practices are considered normative and often go unseen (Frankenberg, 1993), many white people display an almost total lack of racial self-awareness. White people tend to see themselves as raceless and consider race as something only POC possess. In research among white Americans, we have encountered evidence of this lack of racial self-awareness. For example, when asked, "What does it mean to be white?" respondents replied:

- "Frankly, I don't know what you're talking about! … I come from Italian heritage. I'm Italian, not white" (42-year-old white businessman; Sue, 2003, p. 115).
- "Is this a trick question? … I've never thought about it … I wish people would just forget about race differences and see one another as human beings … we should all be proud to be Americans" (26-year-old white female student; Sue, 2003, p. 116).
- "Never thought about being white because it's unimportant. People are individuals and color isn't important" (34-year-old white female stockbroker, Sue, 2003, p. 117).
- "Oh, I would say I've never really been aware of [my race] just because … I've always been in the majority being white" (white female undergraduate student, Drustrup et al., 2022, p. 975).

When white people see themselves as raceless, they also tend to be oblivious about structural racism (i.e., how racism is embedded in institutions, laws, and policies) and have no awareness or desire to reflect on their unearned racial privileges (McIntosh, 1988). Neville et al. (2000) defined white privilege as "an expression of power arising from receipt of benefits, rights, and immunities … characterized by unearned advantages and a sense of entitlement that results in both societal and material

dominance by whites over people of color” (p. 262). White people are socialized explicitly to deny they too have a race and, as such, racial privilege (McIntosh, 1988). In other words, perpetrators deny their unearned benefits and rely on POC deficit models to explain away racial disparities in society. It is important to note that white people are not simply passive recipients of unearned white racial privileges. Rather, white racial privilege is acquired through and reinforced by systems of domination (Leonardo, 2004).

Another dimension of a distorted view of self is a conscious or unconscious belief in self-superiority and entitlement. In comparison to POC, white people are raised to believe they are smarter, more talented, better behaved, etc. The fallacy of superiority applies to white people across social class statuses and relies on the marginalized status of POC. In *Faces at the Bottom of the Well*, legal scholar Derrick Bell (1992) captured the relational aspect of whites' sense of superiority and its associated costs:

> Black people are the magical faces at the bottom of society's well. Even the poorest whites, those who must live their lives only a few levels above, gain their self-esteem by gazing down on us … at whatever cost to them or to us (p. iv).

White superiority comes at the expense of POC (and at the expense of white people themselves). There is a long history supporting Bell's analysis. In *Black Reconstruction in America*, W. E. B. Du Bois (1998 [1935]) referred to the “public and psychological wage” to distinguish the benefits given to working-class whites to prevent solidarity with their Black counterparts against white elites (p. 700). Such “wages of whiteness” were linked to increased status and social privileges, such as more respectful treatment and admittance to public spaces (Roediger, 1999). Buck (2001) further articulated how the psychological wage of whiteness underpins white people's sense of racial superiority even among working-class whites:

> This sense of superiority … was supposed to make up for their otherwise difficult situation, providing them with a “psychological wage” instead of cash—a bit like being employee of the month and given a special parking place instead of a raise
>
> (Buck, 2001; p. 35).

At times, a distorted view of self involves perpetrators' accepting the myth of reverse racism. For example, in a study among 12 white undergraduate men, Cabrera (2014) found respondents espoused perceptions of reverse racism that they framed as objective realities; they positioned themselves as victims. Jayakumar and Adamian (2017) also discussed how their white student participants at Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) perceived reverse discrimination and espoused claims of victimization. These examples illustrate a deeper contradiction. When white people believe the contradictory fallacies that they are both superior to POC and simultaneously disadvantaged, they are further blocked from understanding the historical legacy of institutional racism and how it operates in contemporary society.

Another self-distortion is maintaining a self-image as good, moral, and virtuous. Dennis (1981) referred to this as having a double social and psychological consciousness—holding on to a belief in democracy while remaining oblivious to systems of injustice that deliver their entitlements. To address this internal tension and resolve cognitive dissonance, white people tend to locate racism only in extremists, which relieves them of any responsibility for racial injustice by assuming the dance of the “not racist” white—participating in a performance that distances the self from racism while leaving racial injustice intact. For example, Drustrup et al.’ (2022) white student respondents spoke of racism in ways that maintained their image of themselves and of other white people as not racist. Leonardo and Zembylas (2013) described this as a white alibi maneuver, which locates racism in other white people (or one's former self) for the purpose of showing how the actor is a good person by juxtaposing it against the “bad,” racist white. Even white liberals whose intimate partners are POC engaged identity management techniques that allowed them to declare, in essence, “I'm a better white than those whites” (Lambert-Swain, 2023, p. 2639). Those white students enrolled in HBCUs told racial stories about how they were not racist like other whites (Jayakumar & Adamian, 2017). The authors referred to this as the white relativism effect, which allows white people to continue living with the illusion they are not complicit in racism and thus maintain their view of themselves as moral, good, and just.

If perpetrators were to acknowledge systemic racial inequities, their complicity in racial oppression, and their unfair advantages based on racial

privilege, they might shatter their notions of themselves as good and just. Therefore, as Sue et al. (2021) suggested, perpetrators tend to protect themselves in cocoons of innocence and naivete. From this self-preservation perspective, it simply is easier for perpetrators to remain oblivious to issues of race and racism. Ironically, however, by maintaining color-blind racial ideology, white people increase their likelihood of perpetrating racial microaggressions and other racial injustices.

Affective/Emotional Barriers

Perpetrators also face a range of emotional barriers to achieving racial awareness, including fear, anger, and apathy. These emotions are related to the cognitive distortions described above and further prevent white people from becoming aware of structural racism and acknowledging their complicity in systems of dominance and oppression.

White Fear

White people's fear takes several forms and is a major impediment to racial awareness. Rooted in racial tropes of POC as criminal and dangerous, especially Black and Brown men, white fear often reflects white people's anxiety that POC will steal from them, hurt them physically, and/or rape white women. Since its emergence in the 20th century, network news media and Hollywood motion pictures alike historically have overrepresented Black and Brown people (especially men) as violent criminals, drug dealers, and thugs, which both prompts and reinforces irrational white fear. White people have been socialized to avoid POC on the streets (e.g., cross to the other side) and to stay out of neighborhoods with high concentrations of POC. Former president Donald Trump often amplifies white fear with comments, for instance, about majority-Black cities such as Detroit, “It's like living in hell,” and Baltimore, “A rat and rodent infested mess.” Like Jewish people in Hitler's Nazi regime and throughout a social media-connected globe today, POC also are likened to vermin with fear of infestation in the United States and European Union. In July 2024, referring to the site of the Republican National Convention, for example, Trump described Milwaukee as a “horrible city.” Milwaukee is a highly segregated city, with Black people comprising approximately 38% of the population, which far exceeds the national average of 12.5%. White people's

perceptions of communities of color as violent and dangerous play into the circular nature of the dance of racism. Irrational fear of POC prevents white people who experience it from establishing meaningful cross-racial relationships and thus precludes them from having personal experiences that might otherwise counter their irrational beliefs.

Regardless of their personal accomplishments, advanced education, or monetary wealth, POC consistently report they are on the receiving end of irrational white fear. In 2018, New York City police officers erroneously targeted James Blake, a former professional tennis player ranked as high as #4 in the world, as a credit-card fraudster, threw him to the ground, and took him into custody. In another example, Shayne Lee, a professor of sociology at the University of Houston, described his experience: “As a six-foot-three-black man it's possible that I haven't gone a day in the last ten years without someone showing fear in my presence. Until something changes, we black men must learn to live with ‘the fearful white gaze’” (Blake, 2020). In a widely publicized example in 2009, Harvard professor and prominent Black intellectual Henry Louis Gates, Jr. was arrested while trying to enter his own home in Cambridge, Massachusetts. The lock on his front door had jammed, and his neighbor reported a break-in as she saw him trying to force the door open. These incidents exemplify how irrational white fear serves as a barrier to racial awareness by reinforcing harmful stereotypes and deflecting deeper reflection on systemic racism. White fear in the 21st century can have direct material and psychological effects on people like Blake, Lee, and Gates.

Irrational fear of POC helps to explain widespread false reports to law enforcement, like the Gates example. Although pervasive for decades, smartphone videographers bring these reports—when white people call the police to report Black people for selling bottles of water, sitting and waiting for friends in Starbucks, taking a nap in their university residence hall common area, or canvassing in neighborhoods during a bid for US Congress—into the public eye. Seaton (2021) referred to these false reports as *weaponizing whiteness*. A striking example was when white woman Amy Cooper called the police on birdwatcher and Harvard graduate Christian Cooper in New York City's Central Park. She called out to him, “I'm going to tell them there's an African American man threatening my life,” even though he was simply looking for birds and expressing concern that her

cocker spaniel was off leash. She followed through with her threat and called 911, but both parties left before the police arrived. In an opinion piece in the *New York Times*, Mr. Cooper's sister expressed grave concern about what could have happened if the police had arrived earlier: “I have no doubt that if the police had showed up … my brother's Ivy League degree and impressive résumé would not have protected him” (Cooper, 2020). In too many instances—and *any* is too many—irrational white fear has had deadly consequences for POC.

White fear also plays out in electoral politics and government, particularly in law and legislation, creating a sort of line dance of racism joining voters, state legislators, and members of the federal government. The notion of Black and Brown people as dangerous shows up in political rhetoric, for instance, such as when former President Trump refers to Mexican immigrants as drug dealers, criminals, and rapists. “Immigration” here is not immigration generally; it is racialized immigration and naturalization law that targets Black and Brown people in particular. Regarding state law, for example, the Arizona Senate passed SB 1070 in 2010, also known as the “Show Me Your Papers Bill,” which encouraged racial profiling to locate and deport undocumented immigrants. Trump’s and others' xenophobic rhetoric continues to rationalize this sort of legislation by galvanizing white fear of Black and Brown “caravans” streaming across the border to take jobs and cheat the social safety net—even, according to Trump, “Black jobs” and “Hispanic jobs,” as if jobs themselves should be racialized. During his unsuccessful 2020 campaign bid, Trump pleaded with white suburban women, “Why won't you love me? I'm saving your neighborhoods [from dangerous Black and Brown people]?” In another example, during Trump's 2024 acceptance speech for the Republican nomination, he declared, “I will not let these killers and criminals into our country. I will keep our sons and daughters safe.” Trump is exploiting white people's long-standing xenophobic attitudes to gin up their white fear of Black and Brown people migrating from south to north in the contemporary moment to garner support from fearful white voters who seek a strongman to protect them. Fueled by white fear, such political rhetoric mobilizes voters to support policies and leaders that further entrench systemic racism, often at the expense of democracy itself.

A related form of white fear is racial status threat, which in the simplest terms refers to white people's fear of losing power and privilege. Racial status threat is tied to demographic shifts, such as in the United States, where Hispanic (i.e., Latinx) and Asian American communities are projected to grow more than 100% by 2050; white Americans are the only racial group that is projected to decrease. In fact, by 2050, non-Hispanic white Americans are expected to shrink from 58.88% of the US population to 48.43%, thus becoming a numerical minority (U.S. Census Bureau, 2023). Social psychologists have designed experiments to investigate status threat based on racial demographic shifts. For example, Craig and Richeson (2014) examined white participants' feelings toward POC in two conditions: (a) a racial threat condition wherein white Americans were the numerical minority and (b) a control condition with current demographic data with white Americans as the majority racial group. The researchers found significantly greater in-group preference for other white people and less warm feelings toward POC in the racial threat condition. It is likely racial status threat will increase in the United States as demographics continue to shift toward whites becoming the numerical minority.

So, why all this fear about numbers? Why does it matter so much to white people if they are the numerical majority or minority? White people tend to believe that sharing their piece of the pie with POC ultimately will weaken their position and diminish their quality of life. Norton and Sommers (2011) found this view of racism as a zero-sum game was associated with greater perceptions of reverse racism among white people. Their findings suggested that white people viewed reverse racism against white people as a bigger societal problem than anti-Black bias. Belief in a zero-sum game, grounded in fear of losing power, is thus a major barrier to perpetrator awareness and action and even facilitates white people voting against their economic interests. In *Dying of Whiteness: How the Politics of Racial Resentment is Killing America's Heartland*, Metzl (2019) learned that white men in rural towns in Kansas, Missouri, and Tennessee felt as if their voices weren't being heard and Trump was the answer. In other words, they felt as if Trump gave them back their voices. However, this feeling of having their voices heard comes at a substantial cost—supporting policies that hurt their and their families' health and well-being. McGhee (2022) in *The Sum of Us* also featured the material costs of racism to white people who voted against their interests. Tracing the history from the forced removal and murder of

Indigenous peoples and enslavement of Africans, and drawing from W.E.B. Du Bois's public and psychological wage,[1] McGhee (2022) explained:

> The narrative that white people should see the well-being of people of color as a threat to their own is one of the most powerful subterranean stories in America … Today, the racial zero-sum story is resurgent because there is a political movement invested in ginning up white resentment toward lateral scapegoats (similarly or worse-situated people of color) to escape accountability for a massive redistribution of wealth from the many to the few (p. 15).

Finally, in some instances, white fear is fear of a revolution or uprising by POC that is rooted historically in 18th- and 19th-century white fears of slave uprisings. We witnessed these sorts of sentiments during summer 2020 when white people acted out their white fear of Black Lives Matter (BLM). A St. Louis married couple, both of whom were lawyers, for example, stood in front of their home brandishing firearms they pointed at BLM protestors passing by on a public street. Fear of a Black or Brown revolution likely is tied to feelings of threat that whites will lose power and privilege and perhaps even suffer the wrath of racial oppression currently inflicted upon POC in the United States. In its most extreme form, white fear represents white people's fear of the great replacement rooted in eugenics (e.g., Bracke & Hernández Aguilar, 2023) or even literal cultural extinction (i.e., extinction of the white way of life). In *White Rural Rage,* Schaller and Waldman (2024) wrote:

> Rural White citizens are warned they are under siege. They are constantly told that horrible people who live in and govern our cities—racial and religious minorities, feminists, homosexuals, White liberals, and Democrats in general—threaten the survival of the traditionalist, White Christian values venerated by so many who reside in the rural White heartland (p. 16).

White Rage

In response to feeling threatened, white fear may transform into expressions of anger toward POC (Goodman, 2011). This type of anger, also referred to as white rage (Davis & Wilson, 2022; Spanierman & Cabrera, 2014), may involve extreme negative feelings toward POC, such as racial hatred,

arrogance, a sense of superiority, and a desire for dominance (Feagin, 2020). Although overt expressions of white rage seem to have given way to the dance of color-blind racial ideology since the Civil Rights era, scholars and journalists highlight the pervasiveness of "whitelash" (i.e., the longstanding cycle of violence against racial progress in the United States; Lowery, 2023). For example, in response to the US Supreme Court's 1954 *Brown v. Board of Education* decision to desegregate schools, there was massive white resistance using laws, public funds, intimidation, and violence. More recent examples involve widespread state legislature efforts to ban critical race theory and any teaching about diversity and equity from school curricula. Again, we see the dance of racism is circular such that lack of knowledge begets strong emotions, which in turn prevents acquiring new knowledge to raise awareness of racial issues.

In addition to overt expressions of intimidation and violence, feelings of white rage may be more subtle. Davis and Wilson (2022) described how increasing demographic and cultural diversity is linked to the perception that white people's circumstances are changing for the worse—getting fired, getting canceled, walking on eggshells, etc. Potential responses to these perceptions are annoyance with POC "whining" about racial injustice, resentment about a perceived climate of political correctness, and frustration of having to walk on eggshells around POC and their allies. We have seen examples of this form of white rage in our research with white students and among white adults in the community. In one study, for instance, white undergraduates reported being angry that POC complain and use their race to gain benefits in society: "I get irritated that … people gripe about things and use their color as an excuse" (Spanierman et al., 2008). In another study, in response to a research question posed by Derald Wing Sue (2003), a 65-year-old retired white male construction worker replied:

> Look, what are you… Oriental? You people are always blaming us for stereotyping and here you are doing the same to us … I get angry at the colored people for always blaming us … when my grandparents came over to this country, they worked 24 hours a day to provide a good living for their kids. My wife and I raised 5 kids, and I worked every day of my life to provide for them. No one gave me nothing! I get angry at the Black people for always whining … they just have to get off their butts and work rather than going on welfare (p. 116).

White rage is particularly prevalent among white men and likely spawns from their racial and gender privilege. Although white men across social class status and urbanicity have reported experiences with white rage, much of the scholarship focuses on middle- and working-class white men. For example, in a study among middle- and working-class white men, Kimmel (2017) identified participants' experiences of “aggrieved entitlement”—expectations of unparalleled privilege and a concomitant sense that those benefits are being taken away by POC and white women. This response is particularly relevant for white working-class men who feel threats to their power and identity as if their authority is being undermined. Schaller and Waldman (2024) explained how some white folks in the rural US heartland feel desperate, helpless, and angry enough to lose faith in American institutions. Moreover, the authors argue that white rage has become a serious threat to American democracy. As Cobb (2017) suggested, “In Trump's world, whites are the only disadvantaged [group].” Thus, white rage is tied to perceptions of reverse racism and resentment that fuel policies that claim to restore white privilege and authority (Metzl, 2019, p. 7). Frustration, rage, and racial resentment all get in the way of opening oneself to learning about the realities of racial injustice. When people are consumed with anger and fear, there is little space for learning or self-improvement. These emotions become yet another rehearsed step in the deadly dance of racism that keeps perpetrators stuck in patterns of entitlement, defensiveness, and denial.

In *White Rage: The Unspoken Truth of Our Racial Divide*, Anderson (2016) described the structural context of white rage, embedded in laws and US history. Here, “white rage” refers to the policies that undermine the advancement of POC, such as banning books that offer perspectives on the lived experiences of people outside of the cisgender, heterosexual, white Christian norm. Thus, to understand white people's racial anger, we must understand the cycle of how one's individual feelings interplay with laws, policies, practices, and institutions.

White Apathy

Another emotional barrier to perpetrator awareness involves a general sense of apathy about racism. It is a privilege to be able to ignore race and racism, and this privilege can be exercised passively—below conscious awareness

—or exerted actively and deliberately. Regardless of whether passive or active, the purpose of white apathy seems to be protecting one's ego and self-image as virtuous as well as maintaining the status quo.

In its more passive forms, apathy is linked to an unknowing acceptance of color-blind racial ideology and the cognitive distortions we described above. Trepagnier (2017) described the passivity involved in silent racism among well-meaning whites. If someone believes that racism no longer exists, they will have no reason to care about addressing racial injustice. If someone believes they are raceless, they will have no interest in exploring their white racial privilege. Thus, they collude with subtle forms of racism. D'Andrea and Daniels (2001) found apathy as one of the most prevalent emotions among white participants who exhibited what they called a liberal disposition (i.e., interested in learning about multicultural issues, but not about how racism affects POC's lived experiences). Linked to this general sense of racial apathy, their participants lacked empathy, understanding, and compassion for POC and their daily experiences with racism. Nearly a quarter of a century later, Drustrup et al. (2022) found that white undergraduates similarly viewed racism as a problem only for POC and exhibited “white racial indifference,” referring to a lack of desire to increase their awareness of race and white supremacy (p. 975). The researchers suggested that white racial indifference allows white people “to appear innocent by positioning their lack of experience and knowledge about race to be a function of the world's natural order and out of their control” (p. 975). They concluded that the “subtle and likely unconscious process” of white racial indifference likely is a strategy for maintaining white comfort and virtuousness. It seems the pain associated with acknowledging the realities of white supremacy and one's complicity makes it easier for white people to be complacent and not care.

Jayakumar and Adamian (2017) asserted that scholars likely have assumed too much naivete on the part of whites, and, in response, we draw attention to what we consider a more active form of racial apathy. Yap and Ichikawa (2024) highlighted the concept of active ignorance (i.e., needing not to know versus not knowing), which is consistent with our notion of active racial apathy. Applebaum (2020) also described what might be an active form of white apathy. Considering epistemic injustice and how certain lived realities and ways of knowing have been marginalized, ignored, minimized,

or mocked, she discusses the concept of whites' willful hermeneutical ignorance (i.e., calculated maneuvers to evade one's power and dominance in the US racial hierarchy). Importantly, white racial apathy has been a topic of recent empirical investigation (Brown et al., 2023). We are hopeful this work will shed light on antecedents, consequences, and potential interventions to disrupt white apathy and break the dance of racism.

Behavioral Barriers

Behavioral barriers to perpetrator awareness are rooted in white individuals' lack of meaningful relationships with POC. These sorts of barriers limit or restrict the ways white people belong in the world. We discuss both self-segregation and self-censoring, two primary behavioral barriers to white racial awareness and doing the moral thing that supports the values of a multicultural, multiracial democracy.

Self-Segregating

White people's lives are organized in such a way that their equal-status interactions most often are with other white people (Bonilla-Silva et al., 2006). Because white people tend to self-segregate, their mostly white neighborhoods also present barriers to racial awareness and reinforce cognitive distortions and unsettling emotions linked to race and racism. Even when in interracial relationships, white people tend to live in white neighborhoods (Lambert-Swain, 2023). Segregation indices track racial segregation in both neighborhoods and schools. These indices show even the most diverse US cities are highly segregated (e.g., Chicago). Data highlight racial segregation in schools, both within and between districts. Even when the racial make-up of a school is racially diverse, the prevailing structural norm tends to track “gifted” students into academic paths that reinforce racial segregation (McCardle, 2020). White self-segregation, buttressed by powerful negative images of POC, sets the stage for misinformation, white ignorance (Mills, 1997), denial of complicity in the reproduction of racist systems (Applebaum, 2010), and lack of meaningful intergroup contact that can reduce prejudice (Allport, 1954). Thus, the choreographed dance of racism is set to wash, rinse, and repeat.

Self-Censoring

Another behavioral barrier to perpetrator awareness is censoring oneself, especially in front of mixed racial groups, for fear of appearing racist. Picca and Feagin (2007) refer to this self-censoring phenomenon as frontstage racism in their book *Two-Faced Racism*. In other words, perpetrators frontstage rhetoric in the company of POC differs markedly from their backstage conversations with other white people. DiAngelo's (2018) concept of white fragility captures the notion of white people being too uncomfortable to discuss racial issues. In a recent study among white university students, Ortiz et al. (2024) found evidence of white fragility and self-censoring such that white students felt silenced in the classroom. Participants reported they felt like they did not have anything to contribute to discussions about racial issues, they did not want to appear racist, and they feared being canceled.

In addition to self-censoring when in mixed racial company, white people also might censor themselves around other white people. For example, as white students in our classes learn about race and racism and their complicity for the first time, many zealously want to share their new knowledge with family and friends. They might go home for the Thanksgiving holiday and try to change the celebration, informing their family of settler-colonialism and the genocide of Native Peoples. Oftentimes, their revelations are not well received. Instead, they are met with resistance and criticism of their “socialist” professors. Some decide to keep the peace and pull back on their arguments, whereas others feel a moral obligation to explain further and hold firm to their newfound position. In extreme cases, they (or their loved one) sever the relationship, which comes with the pain of loss. The message is clear: step out of line by critically discussing race and racism, and you risk losing family and friends. Thus, it is not surprising that many white liberals choose to remain silent on such issues. Taken together, self-segregation and self-censorship limit white people's opportunities to gain awareness, challenge their distorted views, and take initial steps toward racial accountability.

Spiritual Barriers

In addition to cognitive, affective, and behavioral barriers, white people often face spiritual barriers—not necessarily religious in nature, but

involving a deeper disconnection from shared humanity, relational responsibility, and moral clarity—that impede their awareness of racism and their complicity in systems of oppression. Goodman (2011) and Kivel (2017) described the spiritual costs of racism to white people as involving pervasive disconnection—from the self, from other human beings, and from a broader sense of shared existence. While framed as costs, these dynamics can also be understood as key barriers that obstruct racial awareness and reparative action. This disconnection is shaped by dominant US cultural values, particularly individualism and an overemphasis on personal autonomy, which fracture a sense of collective responsibility and mutual care (Sue, 2003).

By contrast, many communities historically marginalized by white supremacy—including Black, Indigenous, Latinx, and Asian groups—embrace worldviews that intertwine spiritual, social, and moral life. These traditions emphasize mutual responsibility, collective well-being, and deep respect for human dignity, underscoring the idea that justice and care are inherently relational. The African American freedom struggle, for example, has long drawn upon spirituality not only in religious practice but also as a broader ethic of resilience, healing, and justice. As Gallego (2020) emphasized, spirituality within the African diaspora is inseparable from communal healing and political resistance. These traditions frame justice not merely as a structural goal but as a lived commitment to relationality and collective well-being. Such frameworks offer a powerful counterpoint to white-dominant culture's emphasis on separateness.

Sue (2003) observed that while early European immigrants brought collectivistic and spiritually rooted traditions, forces such as industrialization, westward expansion, and the rise of capitalist ideology, including the Protestant work ethic, encouraged isolation, competition, and material success as cultural priorities. Over generations, these forces severed many white Americans from ancestral ties, communal bonds, and a broader sense of shared purpose, reinforcing whiteness as synonymous with self-sufficiency and detachment. Sue (2015) further noted that many white individuals struggle to articulate what it means to be white, reflecting an absence of racial self-awareness and a void of deeper identity meaning, which can reinforce spiritual alienation.

This legacy fosters a worldview that prioritizes personal achievement over collective well-being. Such a framework obscures the deep interconnectedness of human experience, making it difficult for white individuals to recognize that harm inflicted upon POC also reverberates back on themselves. This spiritual disconnection undermines empathy and stifles moral discernment, both of which are key capacities for disrupting racism (Goodman, 2011; Kivel, 2017). When white people view themselves as separate from others, it becomes easier to minimize, excuse, or ignore racial harm and to dehumanize POC, thus stripping them of full humanity and moral worth. This disconnection fuels racial color-blindness and false neutrality, allowing systemic racism to persist unchecked (Goodman, 2011; Kivel, 2017).

The erosion of empathy and compassion, qualities nurtured by a sense of spiritual connection, not only enables racism to flourish but can also foster inner conflict and a diminished sense of purpose for white people themselves (Kivel, 2017; Morrison, 2016). While these harms differ fundamentally from the direct oppression faced by POC, they reflect a spiritual wounding that undermines authentic connection and growth. The pressing concern, however, is not white discomfort but how these barriers blunt awareness, block accountability, and perpetuate racial injustice.

Overcoming spiritual barriers requires white individuals to reclaim a sense of shared humanity and cultivate a relational ethic grounded in justice, empathy, and mutual care. Whether expressed through secular or faith-based practices, this involves reintegrating moral responsibility into racial justice commitments. As Sue (2003) affirmed, dismantling racism is not simply a political or intellectual task—it is a profoundly spiritual endeavor that calls us to heal fractured relationships and work in solidarity to co-create a more just, loving, and compassionate world.

WHEN PERPETRATORS ARE CALLED OUT

Extending our discussion beyond cognitive, affective, behavioral, and spiritual barriers to perpetrator awareness, we consider some additional choreographed moves that continue the dance of racism. In particular, we are interested in perpetrator responses to being called out. In other words, what happens when a target exclaims, “Ouch! That really hurt,” or a

bystander says, “Hey, that's not cool!” Being called out offers an opportunity for corrective action—to right the wrong—but all too often defensiveness ensues and leads to a doubling down. Everybody makes mistakes. However, rather than owning up to the misstep, perpetrators are likely to become defensive, disclaim racist intent, and blame the target for being oversensitive (Mekawi et al., 2023).

Drawing from his own and his colleagues' experiences working in colleges and universities across the country, Pewewardy (2003) identified 100 defensive tactics that prevent honest and meaningful dialogue about diversity. These strategies are relevant for considering how perpetrators might respond when called out. Indeed, we have come across many of these responses in our own research projects. For example, “the silencer” ignores comments concerning race by changing the topic or not responding at all. Behind the scenes and out of view of POC, they may complain to other white people that POC are “playing the race card.”

Because perpetrators tend to be fearful of appearing racist, they hear critiques of racism as attacks against them personally and, in response, make strong denials of their complicity in racism. When someone brings inequity to their attention, for example, they may exclaim, “I didn't own slaves … my grandparents didn't own slaves. Yap and Ichikawa (2024) described how defensive behaviors are especially salient when critiques target an identity that one holds dear. The response is a reaction to a perceived moral injury. These sorts of defensive responses function to preserve the perpetrator's sense of self as a good person, as we described above with perpetrators' distorted view of self. At the same time, such defensiveness prevents white people from engaging in the kind of honest dialogue that promotes racial awareness and empathy.

Another common defensive reaction is blaming POC during the interaction. For example, when called out for delivering a racial microaggression, perpetrators may declare that the target is “oversensitive” and “can't take a joke.” Additionally, they might tell the target to “Build a bridge [and get over it]!” According to Pewewardy, “the patronizer” assumes superiority and even offers strategies for POC, rather than reflecting on their own biases and assumptions.

Perpetrators (i.e., both symbolic and aversive) tend to overfocus on their intentions rather than the effects of their actions: “You're taking my statement all wrong. I meant it as a compliment!” In some instances, perpetrators may go so far as to flip the script and say that the target is offending *them* by raising the issue, “I was up all night long because of your reaction yesterday. You need to think about what our conversation did to *me*. This reflects the assumption that POC should protect white folks' feelings or must make concerted efforts to discuss racial issues with and/or educate white people (Liu, 2017). This self-focus does little to repair relationships and further alienates perpetrators from POC and their allies.

Finally, in some cases, perpetrators might attempt to offer an apology. However, oftentimes the apology is insufficient, recentering the perpetrator's feelings, not taking responsibility, and exacerbating the problem. It seems the first step for perpetrators is to ask themselves, “Am I ready, willing, and able to acknowledge my own biases, assumptions, and stereotypes?” Only when answering in the affirmative are perpetrators able to see their participation in the deadly dance of racism and begin to break the cycle.

STRATEGIES FOR PERPETRATORS TO BREAK THE DEADLY DANCE OF RACISM

The following strategies are designed to help white individuals who have perpetrated racism (knowingly or unknowingly) take concrete steps toward change. These are not linear or one-time actions, but ongoing commitments that can interrupt harmful patterns, foster accountability, and promote authentic racial justice work. Although many strategies may feel personally challenging or uncomfortable, they are necessary for transformation—both at the individual and systemic levels—and for repairing the fractures in our shared humanity. This work is not only about dismantling oppression but also about rebuilding connections grounded in justice, compassion, and mutual care.

1. ***Acknowledge Your Racial Socialization*.**

   Begin by reflecting on your attitudes, feelings, and beliefs about POC. Recognize that none of us is immune to the effects of racist

socialization. As Winter (1977) emphasized, even well-meaning white people are shaped by stereotypes and racist ideologies from an early age. de Saxe and Ker (2023) suggested that writing a racial autobiography can help white individuals examine their racial biases and assumptions, recognize and reflect critically on their racial privilege, and understand how structural whiteness has shaped their worldview. This reflection helps interrupt automatic biases and allows you to take conscious steps toward anti-racism.

2. ***Educate Yourself*.**

   Self-education is foundational to developing racial awareness. It signals a willingness to take responsibility for your own growth rather than relying on POC to teach or validate you. Read widely, attend workshops, and engage with racial justice media. Even brief interventions can help—such as the “True Colors” documentary, which has been shown to reduce color-blind racial attitudes (Soble et al., 2011). The viral video, *White Racial Responsibility*, by Dixon White also offers an accessible entry point into understanding white accountability. Importantly, seek out authors from a wide range of racial and cultural backgrounds to avoid recentering whiteness in your learning.

3. ***Broaden Your Horizons*.**

   Intentionally seek out opportunities to learn from and connect with people from diverse racial and ethnic backgrounds. This is not about collecting friendships or forcing proximity but about valuing perspectives that challenge your own. Participate in community dialogues, multiracial organizations, and cultural events where you are not the center. Be a curious learner and listen more than you speak, while also remembering it is not POC's responsibility to teach you everything.

4. ***Admit Past and Present Racist Behavior*.**

   Transformation begins with honesty. Acknowledge the things you've said, done, or failed to interrupt that have perpetuated racism. This work can feel uncomfortable or even painful, but it is essential. Rather than falling into shame or denial, recognize that growing up in

a racist society makes racist missteps inevitable. This includes acknowledging participation in racial microaggressions—whether subtle slights, assumptions, or invalidations—that cumulatively uphold systemic racism. What matters is how you respond and repair. As noted below, developing recovery skills, such as offering sincere apologies, is crucial, as is ongoing self-monitoring.

5. ***Acknowledge Your Complicity*.**

   Applebaum's (2010) white complicity claim reminds us that you do not have to be overtly racist to participate in or benefit from racial injustice. Recognizing complicity is the first step toward moral responsibility. It requires shifting from defensiveness to an ethic of moral accountability and action.

6. ***Recognize Your White Privilege*.**

   Understanding white privilege doesn't negate your personal struggles, it situates them within broader systems shaped by race. Recognizing how opportunities, safety, and legitimacy more easily accrue to white people provides clarity about structural inequities. This awareness should become a springboard for solidarity and reparative action. Ultimately, recognizing privilege must lead to concrete steps that redistribute power and resources.

7. ***Treat Racism Like Daily Hygiene*.**

   Jay Smooth (TEDx, 2011) offered a memorable metaphor that can lower defensiveness: think of confronting your racism like brushing your teeth. It is not about being perfect. Rather, it is about ongoing maintenance. If someone tells you that something is stuck in your teeth (or that something you said was harmful) receive that feedback with humility, not defensiveness. Remember: the goal is not to prove you are “not racist,” but to keep your awareness sharp and your behavior aligned with your values. This mindset helps shift you from guilt and denial toward growth and repair.

8. ***Develop Empathy Without Overidentifying*.**

   If you hold a marginalized identity (e.g., woman, non-binary, queer, and so forth), draw upon that experience to deepen your empathy for POC, but never assume equivalence. As Reason et al. (2005) noted,

while parallels can foster insight, overidentification can blur important differences and invalidate POC's unique racialized experiences. Let your empathy ground your listening, compassion, and commitment to justice.

9. ***Offer Sincere Apologies and Repair Harm*.**

   When you cause harm, focus on the impact, not your intent. Believe the person who names the harm. Offer a sincere apology: acknowledge your behavior, name its effects, and share what you will do to make amends. Avoid defensiveness or centering your feelings. Repair is an action, not just a sentiment. For example, if you made a dismissive remark in a meeting, a meaningful apology might include acknowledging the specific harm, saying “I'm sorry” both privately and (if appropriate) publicly, and taking steps—such as additional equity training or implementing new practices—to prevent recurrence. Consider checking back in later to ensure harm has been addressed. Sustained accountability matters.

10. ***Reject the Zero-Sum Myth and Build Solidarity*.**

    Racism perpetuates the illusion that gains for POC mean losses for white people. McGhee (2022) dismantles this zero-sum narrative, showing how racism harms everyone. Reframing racial justice as a collective good opens space for mutual benefit, deeper relationships, and shared liberation. For example, McGhee illustrated how investments in public infrastructure, schools, and clean air (long opposed by racially divisive politics) improve life for all when equitably funded and maintained.

CONCLUSION

These ten strategies can help white perpetrators of racism, whether their behaviors have been subtle or overt, interrupt the deadly dance of racism. By practicing self-awareness, humility, and responsibility, they can begin to repair relationships, challenge unjust systems, and nurture deeper connections across racial lines. Taken together, these strategies offer a roadmap not only for personal growth but also for collective transformation. Through sustained self-work and authentic solidarity, white perpetrators can

move from complicity to co-creation of a just, inclusive society—helping, at last, to break the deadly dance of racism.

In sum, we underscore that perpetrators are not merely extremists on society's fringes but often well-meaning individuals complicit in upholding racial injustice. Through understanding the barriers to awareness, recognizing common defensive responses, and committing to concrete strategies for transformation, white people can begin to disrupt their participation in racism's deadly dance. The path forward demands humility, sustained effort, and a deep recommitment to shared humanity, and with each step, we move closer to a more just and liberated world.

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Note

1 We recommend Roediger's (1999) *Wages of Whiteness* and Buck's (2001) *Worked to the Bone: Race, Class, Power, and Privilege in Kentucky* for a deeper dive into how white working-class Americans consented to the

public and psychological wages of whiteness to feel better about their subjugated social class position.

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CHAPTER THREE
Target Survival and Resilience: Overcoming Racism

For purposes of this article, targets are people of color (POC); African Americans, AMENA groups (American Arab, Middle Eastern, and North African), Asian Americans, Latinx Americans, and Native Americans who are subjected to bias and discrimination in the form of racial microaggressions and macroaggressions from members of the dominant majority group or its institutions. This chapter is divided into three major parts.

First, we provide a brief historical picture of five different Groups of Color, reveal their lived experience or perceptions of racism/bias directed toward them, and identify common stereotypes many white Americans consciously or unconsciously harbor about each group. This is important because POC suffer from not only historical or intergenerational trauma, but the microaggressions or biases they encounter are often related to stereotypes. For example, African Americans are more likely than other groups to experience microaggressions related to criminality and dangerousness, Asian Americans and Latinx Americans experience themes of perpetual foreigner in their own country, and some AMENA group members face "terrorist" perceptions and fears (Sue & Spanierman, 2020).

Second, we spend considerable time discussing the harmful impact of racism through the manifestation of microaggressions and macroaggressions. Microaggressions are interpersonal expressions of bias and bigotry, while macroaggressions are expressed through the programs, policies, and practices of institutions and the larger society (Sue et al., 2021). Three forms of psychological suffering and pain are identified: (a) racial battle fatigue that arises from people of color having to contend with the never-ending onslaught of individual and institutional racism, (b) historical and intergenerational trauma that results when the psychological impact of atrocities is passed on to future generations, and (c) the

manifestation of internalized racism where POC internalize negative views of the self and their own group.

Third, we focus on how targets of bias are placed in an unenviable position of dealing not only with the pain, humiliation, and injustice of racism but also with the ambivalence of deciding what to do in a perceived “no-win” situation. Calling out perpetrators (deviating from the dance script) can result in serious detrimental consequences, especially when power differentials exist between perpetrators and targets (Rasinski & Czopp, 2010). Failing to act, however, may result in negative self-ruminations, self-recriminations, a sense of self-betrayal, and a loss of integrity (Sue et al., 2019). In other words, targets often face a situation in which they are “damned if they do, and damned if they don't.” We offer potential solutions for POC not only in maintaining their integrity but also on how they can dismantle racism and survive in a racialized society.

THE PREVALENCE OF RACISM EXPERIENCED BY TARGETS: WHO ARE PEOPLE OF COLOR?

In Chapter 1, we observed that POC are destined to become a numerical majority and that many in our society are threatened by the projected demographic changes. The increase of POC is spawned by their higher birthrates and increased immigration numbers. This has resulted in a rise in prejudice and discrimination directed toward these groups. Recent surveys provide overwhelming support that POC perceive prejudice, bias, and discrimination as a major reality in their lives and that it is responsible for their inability to get ahead in our society: African Americans (Pew Research Center [PRC], 2024a), Asian Americans (PRC, 2023), Latinx Americans (PRC, 2021), Muslim Americans (PRC, 2024b), and Native Americans (NPR/Robert Wood Johnson Foundation/Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health, 2017). We outline common and unique experiences of racism encountered by the five Groups of Color in the current times, but we also include brief historical racism documentation as well. It is important to note that historical racial trauma has increasingly been found to be a significant stressor that leads to post-traumatic stress disorder, or the “soul wound” for

POC (Duran, 2019). For example, the enslavement and harsh treatment of Black people (Lee et al., 2023), the genocide of Native Americans and their cultures (Gone, 2023), and the incarceration of Japanese Americans during World War II (Nagata et al., 2019) were major historical oppressions and traumas that have left an indelible mark on the psychological well-being of generations of POC.

Discrimination Against African Americans

Black Americans number 14.4% of the US population and have grown 32% since 2000 (PRC, 2024c). The history of Black oppression and suffering for over 400 years in the United States is well documented: forcibly taken from their motherland and enslaved, subjected to inhumane conditions during the middle passage to America, sold as property to plantation owners, forced to give up their African names in exchange for European ones, separated from family members, branded, whipped, beaten, maimed, and used by slave owners to satisfy their sexual appetites (Jones, 1997; PRC, 2024a; Wilson et al., 2024). The enslaved were treated not only as personal property but also as subhuman beings, low on the evolutionary scale, and considered incapable of higher-order thinking. Systemic racism justified and reified these beliefs of African Americans through a system of scientific racism (Jones, 1997).

Scientific racism is the misuse of science to justify discrimination, to support notions of inferiority in POC, and to pretend that “empirical evidence” exists to justify racist beliefs and practices (American Psychological Association [APA], 2021; Winston, 2020). The 1840 census figures, for example, were fabricated to support the contention that freedom for Black Americans was unnatural and caused them debilitating anxiety, contentment with subservience was the natural state of Black mental health, and the customary state of Blacks were childlike and happy-go-lucky (Thomas & Sillen, 1972). Many medical journals presented racially biased beliefs that the biological makeup of Blacks (anatomical and neurological) was inferior to that of Whites. Racist fantasies regarding Black intellectual inferiority and justification for slavery were based upon fabrications: (a) their brains were smaller and less developed, (b) they were less prone to mental illness because their brains were less developed, and (c) the dreams

of Blacks were juvenile in character and not as complex as those of white people.

Psychiatry and psychology cooperated and helped perpetuate the myth that enslavement was the natural order for Blacks, and the professions created psychiatric labels that provided a rationale for their continued captivity and oppression. Enslaved Blacks, for example, who attempted to escape from bondage were labeled as suffering from “Drapetomania,” a psychiatric disease that caused them to run away and to seek freedom. Blacks who stole food to feed their families, resisted the orders of slave masters, and showed anger and resentment toward mistreatment were considered to be suffering from “Rascality,” a disease that caused the enslaved to commit petty offenses and not obey rules. Extreme forms of punishment (beatings, whippings, and violence) to correct these resistant actions were justified because of a condition called “Dysaesthesia Ethiopica,” a disease that made the enslaved indifferent and insensible to punishment.

Some of the most common stereotypes of African Americans are the following: *criminals, dangerous, hostile, angry, impulsive, musically inclined, good athletes, large sex organs, insatiable sexual appetites, unintelligent, lack abstract thinking, superstitious, concrete, can't swim, dense craniums, animalistic, undesirable, drug dealers, smelly, mentally retarded, mentally ill, addicts, abnormal, pimp, and prostitutes*.

Lived Reality for African Americans in Modern Times

The lived reality of African Americans is almost inconceivable in the harshness of what they have had to endure. Not only must they face continual prejudice and discrimination, but they must also face the continuing threat of physical violence and harm (PRC, 2022, 2024a).

- Nearly 80% of African Americans say they have personally experienced prejudice and discrimination, and that it is the main reason they cannot get ahead.
- 60% identify police brutality and the criminal justice system as unfair and a major problem to them.
- Unconscious bias of white people was at the top of the list as a major obstacle in their lives, followed by structural racism.

- 63% named the historic financial race gap as extremely problematic to their attempts to lead a better life.
- 57% state they have experienced limited access to quality housing, quality education, and healthcare.
- An overwhelming number of African Americans expressed pessimism in reducing racial inequality in individuals and institutions.
- Many also indicate that despite the renewed focus on racism, they have experienced no improvement in their life conditions.
- Many see ongoing and intentional bias in institutions purposely designed to advantage white Americans and purposely disadvantage African Americans.

Discrimination Against Asian Americans

Asian Americans comprise slightly over 7% of the population of the United States and grew 35.6% from 2010 to 2020. In 2021 and 2022, anti-Asian hate crimes spiked to an all-time record high fueled by the belief that China, and thus Chinese Americans, was to blame for the pandemic (PRC, 2023). When President Donald Trump referred to the coronavirus as the “Chinese virus,” anti-Asian slurs and hate crimes rose astronomically. Unfortunately, the negative views of the Chinese and the blame attributed to them for the pandemic were generalized to nearly all groups of Asian descent.

Anti-Asian sentiment in the United States, however, has a long history dating back to the 1800s and is not just a recent phenomenon due to COVID. Many are unaware that Asians in America have suffered from some of the most inhumane treatment of any racial group: large-scale massacres of the Chinese in 1851 in California and Wyoming are recorded, laws denied them the rights of citizenship, their testimony in courts was deemed inadmissible, and racist immigration laws were passed to exclude them from entering the United States (Daniels, 1971). Indeed, the phrase “not a Chinaman's chance” alludes to the personal disempowerment of these historical acts. Similar inhumane treatment of the Japanese (passage of the Alien Land Law—forbidding Japanese from owning land), Filipinos, Koreans, Native Hawaiians, and refugees (Vietnamese and Cambodians) encountered hatred, blame, and an unwelcome environment (PRC, 2023;

Sue & Sue, 1999). The incarceration of 110,000 Japanese Americans during WWII (2/3rds were citizens by virtue of birth) into concentration camps continues to be a major moral stain on the conscience of white America and a haunting memory for many Asian Americans.

Ironically, Asian Americans have also been subjected to the model minority myth: a minoritized group who have been successful in society. They have been seen as hard-working, family-oriented, intelligent, and especially good in math and sciences. The model minority myth is a simplistic and problematic perception of Asian Americans. (a) It perpetuates the belief that AAPIs are not a minority group in need of special consideration (invisibility and neglect), masks the discriminatory struggles they have and continue to experience, and shortchanges the group from receiving the necessary financial and moral commitments. (b) It reasserts the erroneous belief that any group in society can succeed if they work hard enough (the myth of meritocracy and blaming the victim for their lot in life). (c) It represents a divisive concept for those in the status quo to pit one group against another by holding up Asian Americans as an example to other Groups of Color (PRC, 2023; Sue & Sue, 1999).

Some of the most common stereotypes of Asian Americans are the following: *foreigners, spies, sneaky, backstabbers, disloyal, passive, unassertive, inhibited, dependent, unmasculine (men), domestic/exotic/sex objects (women), wealthy, stingy, lacking leadership skills, poor drivers, inarticulate, model minority, bright, hard-working, studious, quiet, good in math, science, and technology, and family-oriented*.

Lived Reality for Asian Americans in Modern Times

The lived reality of Asian Americans is filled with stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination. Some conclusions drawn from a large-scale survey are summarized below (PRC, 2023).

- 90% of Asian Americans attest to having experienced discrimination in one form or another in their day-to-day lives.
- 78% of adults have been treated as a foreigner, perpetual alien, or outsider and not a “true American.” These included being told to go back to their own country, acting as if they could not speak English,

being criticized for speaking another language, and mispronouncing their names.

- 63% have been treated as a model minority: acted as if they were good in math and sciences, but not creative thinkers.
- 35% of Southeast Asians say they have been held back at security checkpoints for secondary screening.
- 32% say they know of someone who has been attacked, intimidated, and threatened since the COVID outbreak.
- 40% say they have received inferior service at stores and restaurants.
- 37% have had encounters with strangers in which they have been called offensive names.
- 20% of adults say they have been discriminated against in the workplace because of their race: they have not been promoted when otherwise qualified, received lower pay than white co-workers, lost their jobs, and/or been demoted.

Discrimination Against Latinx (Hispanic) Americans

Those who identify as Latinx Americans comprise 19% of the US population; from 2010 to 2022, the group grew at a rate of 26%, second only to Asian Americans/Pacific Islanders. Except for Native Americans, more Latinx individuals have ancestors from the original lands of the Americas. Latinx Americans trace their roots to a diverse number of Spanish-speaking countries: Mexico, Puerto Rico, Cuba, El Salvador, the Dominican Republic, Central and South America, Spain, and others. Because “Hispanic” is a pan-ethnic designator and not a racial one, Latinx individuals may come from any racial group. About 25% identify as Afro-Latinx and another quarter as “indigenous.”

Since the mid-19th century, anti-Latinx prejudice and discrimination in the form of mob violence, lynchings, mass deportations, and segregation in all forms have been part of the lived reality of Latinx Americans.

Because so many groups fall under the category of Latinx, we select Mexican Americans as an example of the historical underpinnings of anti-Latinx sentiment. When the United States won the Mexican-American War

in 1858, it seized over 50% of Mexican territory but granted citizenship to those Mexicans who remained. The flow of migrants from Mexico to the United States was welcomed by employers, especially the railroads that needed cheap labor. With increased immigration, however, came increased resentment, prejudice, and hatred of Mexicans, to such a point that they were segregated into poor urban barrios, denied entry into white establishments, and subject to negative beliefs: lazy, stupid, unsanitary, and a danger to decent folks. During the California Gold Rush, white miners enacted vigilante justice against Mexican Americans in order not to share a portion of the wealth. With the onset of the Great Depression, and when jobs became scarce, anti-Mexican sentiment became so pronounced that the United States forcibly removed up to 2 million people of Mexican descent (60% were American citizens) from the country.

The anti-Mexican reaction has been shared by many Latinx Americans and continues to the present day, where the issue of immigration has become a "hot potato" and is played out in the current political climate. The Trump administration, for example, has threatened a mass deportation of undocumented immigrants. Although immigration is often associated mainly with Latinx Americans, it also touches other groups as well (Haitian immigrants). In a presidential political debate on September 10, 2024, between candidates Donald Trump and Kamala Harris, Trump claimed that Haitian immigrants were eating the pets of white citizens (cats and dogs) in Springfield, Ohio. Despite proving the claim false, Haitian residents have been threatened, and many fear for their lives. The small town has experienced bomb threats, school closings, and anti-migrant rallies. The believability of this claim is fueled by a longstanding immigrant trope of Latinx Americans that exposes racism and discrimination.

Some of the most common stereotypes of Latinx Americans are the following: *Illegal aliens, drug dealers, criminals, dangerous, taking jobs away from whites, untrustworthy, lazy, uneducated, poor, welfare recipients, liars, drunkards, carefree, irresponsible, greasy, poor English, religious, and farm workers*.

Lived Reality for Latinx Americans in Modern Times

The long history of anti-Latinx prejudice and discrimination has taken a huge toll on the psychological and physical well-being of the group. The

perception of Latinx people is filled with suspicion and mistrust of white Americans and their institutions.

- 54% of Latinx adults indicated they had experienced discrimination in some form.
- In descending order, the discriminative experiences were (a) acted as if they were unintelligent, (b) told to “go back to your own country,” (c) criticized for speaking Spanish, (d) feared for their personal safety, (d) stopped by police, and (e) called offensive names.
- Skin color is a major factor in whether a Latinx person experiences discrimination: 54% with lighter skin tone, while 64% with darker skin.
- Skin color (light or dark) or colorism has also been internalized by many Latinx people and is frequently acted out within their group.
- Over 50% of Latinx individuals report hearing racially insensitive comments or racist jokes from family and friends.
- Over 50% say having lighter skin allows them to “get ahead.”
- Nearly half say that race and racism are not given the attention they deserve as impediments to their advancement in society.

Discrimination Against Native Americans

The Native American/American Indian population comprises nearly 3% of the population of the United States; from 2010 to 2020, it increased in numbers by 160% (Jones et al., 2021). Considerable controversy surrounds who is considered to be Native American: US Census depends on self-report, while Congress imposed a 25% blood quantum standard. Ironically, it is the only racial group that has a legal definition, primarily intended to historically decrease the number of indigenous people who would qualify for government land and services.

It may sound hyperbolic, but it is realistic to say that the United States was built on stolen land, taken from the original indigenous peoples of this country who have resided on this continent for some 10,000 years. Yet, the history of Native Americans is the history of colonization, racism, and genocide perpetrated by white people. White supremacy was the mainstay

of a philosophy exemplified in the ideology of “manifest destiny.” It was a view that the United States was destined to expand from coast to coast, had a right to all the land, and even had the approval of God. As the waves of white settlers moved across the country, most thought nothing of subjugating, eliminating, and killing “heathens” that they saw as primitive savages. The struggles between white settlers and Native Americans often resulted in massacres of Natives (Trail of Tears, Wounded Knee, etc.). In order to quell the constant conflicts between Native Americans and white settlers, the US government signed a series of treaties with the various tribes.

Despite these early treatises that guaranteed tribal national sovereignty, Andrew Jackson signed the “Indian Removal Act” in 1830, taking away the tribal lands of Native Americans and forcing them to reservations. The forced relocation resulted in cruel “death marches” in which some 15,000 died from starvation, exposure to the harsh elements, and disease (Network Advocates for Catholic Social Justice, 2024). As greedy white settlers desired gold, timber, buffalo, and land, the legal system conspired through convoluted bending of laws to steal the land's resources from Native Americans who depended upon them for survival. Resentment over broken treaties, the loss of a way of life, and brutal treatment by the military led to Native uprisings, which provided justification for the mass eradication of Native Americans. President Abraham Lincoln, for example, ordered the hanging of 38 Dakota men for their roles in the rebellion, the largest mass execution in US history.

Cultural genocide was practiced through removing children from their parents and placing them in boarding schools run by Christian organizations in an attempt to destroy their Indian identities and replace them with “civilized” white ones. The phrase “Kill the Indian, Save the Man” symbolized the movement and intent: they had their hair cut, wore Anglicized clothes, used white names, and were forbidden to speak their own language and prohibited from practicing their religions. As late as 1978, it was legal to kidnap Native children from their families and make them attend white-run boarding schools (Network Advocates for Catholic Social Justice, 2024).

Some of the most common stereotypes of Native Americans include the following: *savages, primitive, bloodthirsty, uncivilized, animalistic, passive,*

uneducated, uneducable, superstitious, poor, drunkards, impulsive, non-competitive, passive, and subhuman.

Lived Reality of Native Americans in Modern Times

The 500 years of colonialism, genocide, displacement, and oppression have resulted in extreme poverty, educational and employment inequities, high mortality rates, and the highest suicide rates of any group among the young. The experiences of historical and current discrimination lead to a number of findings (Findling et al., 2019).

- 75% of Native Americans say that discrimination against them exists in the United States. This includes personal and institutional discrimination.
- When asked what form of discrimination is most harmful or problematic, they are nearly evenly split between individual prejudice (41%) and the law and governmental policies (39%).
- Native Americans report high incidents of racial slurs, violence, harassment, and discrimination in the workplace.
- 39% have experienced insensitive or offensive comments, 35% slurs, 38% violence, 34% threats or non-sexual harassment, and 23% sexual harassment.
- Suicide rates are the highest among this group because of cultural disconnection, alienation, and pressures to assimilate and acculturate to non-Native ways.
- Native Americans also report that personal discrimination occurs across a wide range of situations: being underpaid and not promoted, applying for jobs, interacting with police, going for health services, interacting with the police, trying to vote or participate in politics, attending college, and trying to buy or rent a house.
- Interestingly, they say discrimination is more prevalent in neighborhoods in which they are the majority. Their larger presence is believed to be a greater threat to white Americans than when they are in the minority.

Discrimination Against American Arab, Middle Eastern, and North African (AMENA)

Are American Arabs, Middle Easterners, and North Africans (AMENA) considered POC? For our purposes the answer is "yes" because AMENA individuals generally do not view themselves as white, nor do the majority of white Americans. Although people of AMENA descent are considered non-white in nearly all parts of the world, the US Census classifies these groups as "white." As a result, accurate counts of their population are estimates, with great variability because the Census has no category labeled "MENA," and because of the confusion over defining "Arabs," "Middle Eastern," and "Muslim." "Arab" generally applies to people who speak Arabic as their mother tongue or whose ancestors used it as their native language. The problem with this definition is that Arabic is one of the official languages in 26 countries or territories. Further, the Middle East is not a fixed term or region but comes from a European perspective in that "east" is relative to Western Europe. Compounding the confusion is who are considered "Muslim." Although most people associate Muslims with the Middle East, most do not live there. Indeed, it is estimated that there are 1.6 billion Muslims in the world, but the greatest numbers reside in Indonesia (Southeast Asia).

The MENA population is estimated to be about 1% of the population of the United States, but it is seriously undercounted because there is no category for MENA identity on the US Census, as respondents are considered to be white or "other." There are major problems encountered by AMENA people due to their statistical invisibility and being considered to be white. First, many feel left out and relegated to an obscure identity existence that impacts their psychological well-being. Second, the inability to compile statistics on AMENA groups has major policy implications: achievement gaps in education are unknown, poverty rates and employment inequities cannot be accurately determined, medical researchers are unable to determine elevated health risks for this population, the drawing of political boundaries to determine equal representation is overlooked, and experiences of prejudice and discrimination remain hidden.

Given this limitation, however, it is clear that AMENA people face much prejudice and discrimination in the United States (PRC, 2024b).

Islamophobia, anti-Muslim or anti-Islamic fears and negative emotional reactions toward Muslims has existed for centuries throughout the world but was given impetus in the United States following the terrorist attack of September 11, 2001. Unfortunately, the tentacles of Islamophobia have proven harmful to non-Muslim Arabs and Middle Eastern Americans as well through a perceived association the groups have with Islam (Awad et al., 2019). Anti-Muslim or anti-Arab rhetoric, slurs, and hate crimes have been directed toward AMENA groups. Anti-Muslim feelings have been used as a political platform with the 2001 Patriot Act and the passage of a Muslim Ban in 2017. The current Israel-Hamas war has also resulted in an upsurge of hatred and discrimination toward AMENA groups.

Some of the most common stereotypes of AMENA Americans include the following: *terrorists or villains, disloyal, barbaric, oppression of women, sexually depraved, belief in Sharia law, Islam as a violent religion, bombers, fanatics, brutal, militant, extremist, no value on life, and foreigners*.

Lived Reality of AMENA Americans in Modern Times

Many of the stereotypes associated with Arabs, Middle Easterners, and North Africans cut across all the groups. One of the most powerful engines of perpetuating these stereotypes has been the entertainment industry, where Muslims, for example, are portrayed as violent, mean, and dangerous. Some of the lived experiences of AMENA Americans are summarized below (Awad et al., 2019: Gamble, 2024; Najm, 2019: PRC, 2024b):

- 75% of Muslims say there is much discrimination against them. In fact, of all groups of color, they were seen as experiencing the most discrimination.
- 48% stated they had experienced at least one act of discrimination during the past year.
- From 2014 to 2015, hate crimes against Muslim Americans rose 67%.
- In only a 3-month period in 2023, the Council on American-Islamic Relations received a staggering total of 3,578 complaints of bias and discrimination against Muslims.

- The highest categories of complaints involved employment discrimination, hate crimes, and education discrimination.
- Since the start of the Israel-Hamas war, Muslims (70%) say discrimination has increased, while Arabs (64%) say the same.

IMPACT OF RACISM ON PEOPLE OF COLOR

We have already spent time discussing the manifestation of racism at the individual, institutional, and cultural levels. To understand their impact on POC, however, we frame our discussion around two major concepts: microaggressions and macroaggressions. Racial microaggressions are the brief and commonplace daily verbal and behavioral interpersonal indignities, whether intentional or unintentional, that communicate hostile, derogatory, or negative slights, invalidations, and insults to POC because of their racial heritage (Sue et al., 2021). Macroaggressions, however, reside in racially biased systemic, institutional, or community philosophies, policies, programs, practices, and structures (Pérez Huber & Solorzano, 2014). Although both result in oppression and harm to POC, they differ from one another. Microaggressions reside in the biases of an individual (perpetrator), while macroaggressions exist in institutions and social systems. Another distinction is that the expression of microaggressions is directed toward an individual (target), while macroaggressions are directed toward large groups or classes of people. Further, combatting microaggressions means change at the individual level (attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors), while with macroaggressions, change is directed at dismantling systems of oppression (Sue et al., 2021). In Chapter 1, we also mentioned a third overarching umbrella of racism (cultural racism) from which individual (microaggressions) and institutional biases (macroaggressions) arise. We will cover the manifestation, dynamics, and impact of cultural racism in Chapter 7.

Microaggressive Harm to People of Color

On an interpersonal level, the existence of microaggressions and their harmful impact were originally challenged as “much to do about nothing” and as “macrononsense” by critics (Lilienfeld, 2017; Schacht, 2008; Thomas, 2008). Lilienfeld (2017) claimed that science did not support their

existence and that widespread testimony as to their presence by POC could be attributed to social contagion. He further asserted that microaggressions were no different than everyday incivilities that white Americans could experience from a rude clerk or neighbor. His advice, therefore, was that these insults were harmless and that POC were playing victims and should "suck it up." Lilienfeld also called for an end to all anti-microaggression training programs in colleges, universities, and places of employment.

The debate over the existence of microaggressions and their detrimental consequences has been largely settled (Sue & Spanierman, 2020; Williams, 2020). Microaggressions are real and not trivial, insignificant, or harmless, but have immediate and long-lasting negative emotional, cognitive, behavioral, and physical consequences on targets. They diminish psychological and physical well-being, increase depression and negative feelings, assail the mental health of recipients, impede learning and problem-solving, generate stereotype threat, create the imposter syndrome, and lower job performance and morale (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). Two major meta-analytic studies, with over 200 combined samples, reveal strong support for these assertions and conclusions (Costa et al., 2023; Lui & Quezada, 2019).

Contrary to claims of critics that microaggressions are no different than everyday non-group-based insults, research reveals that microaggressions differ from common expressions of rudeness in the following ways (Sue et al., 2021):

- Microaggressions are constant and continual in the life experience of POC. They occur from the time one awakens in the morning until one goes to sleep at night, from the moment of birth until death. Although a white person may experience disrespect from an impolite or boorish person, the incident is not ceaseless and unremitting.
- Microaggressions are not only incessant but also cumulative and may snowball into a heavy attack on the integrity of POC. Maya Angelou has indicated that the everyday slings and arrows of racism can be likened to "death by a thousand cuts." Any single racially based insult or slight may represent the "straw that breaks the camel's back."

- The collective and symbolic nature of microaggressions are constant reminders to POC that they are held in low esteem, considered inferior, and are second-class citizens. Thus, a single microaggressive incident may appear insignificant to an outsider, but to POC it represents how white America perceives and treats them.
- Last, microaggressions symbolize the historic injustices perpetrated against groups of color; enslavement of Africans, forced appropriation of Native lands, and the incarceration of Japanese Americans. Intergenerational trauma and the lingering effects of historical oppression have been found to take a heavy contemporary toll on POC (Gone, 2023; Lee et al., 2023; Nagata et al., 2019, 2025).

Macroaggressive Harm to People of Color

On a systemic level, macroaggressions have been found to produce a hostile and invalidating climate and to create disparities in education, employment, and healthcare for POC (Bowdler & Harris, 2022). The rules and regulations that come from biased programs, policies, and practices are either considered to be standard operating procedures (SOPs) or are codified into customs and laws. Many macroaggressions are quite obvious and consciously intended to subordinate groups of color while advantaging white Americans. The most insidious ones, however, are not obvious in their discriminatory nature. They are often rules, regulations, and customs that have existed for years and apply to everyone. The notion that treating everyone the same (using a uniform standard) regardless of race, gender, or other group attributes is believed to be non-discriminatory. What white Americans with power and privilege don't realize is that equal treatment can be discriminatory, and differential treatment is not necessarily preferential. What POC are asking for is not so much equal treatment but fair treatment that allows for equal access and opportunity (Jones, 1997; Sue, 2008). Fair treatment often requires using different criteria for different groups in order to guarantee equal possibilities.

A prime example of biased SOPs is using standardized testing to make educational decisions from grade school to college and using performance appraisal systems at places of employment to determine who to hire, retain, promote, and fire (Rosales & Walker, 2021; Sue, 2008). In both cases, their use is applied equally across different populations, but they produce

unequal outcomes that may be racist and biased in nature. Standardized testing has been described as an instrument of racism and a biased system that has abused POC by denying them equal access and opportunity (APA, 2021). Standardized tests are usually normed and weighted toward white populations, contain idioms of expressions or knowledge more familiar to certain groups, and favor affluent students who are more likely to be exposed to the content.

Criteria and policy used to hire, retain, and promote workers share such bias in that they favor white employees. Many companies, for example, adhere to the importance of seniority in retaining employees during times of economic downturn. The statement “last hired, first fired” is such a rule that unfairly discriminates against POC who are likely to be the last hired and thus, the first to be discharged. Other examples of SOPs include bank lending practices that consider creditworthiness on the basis of home locations, which are likely to be used in segregated neighborhoods, and close off economic opportunities to POC. School boards that determine curricula taught to children may elevate the contributions of white Americans while ignoring the contributions of POC (Loewen, 2018), and media portrayals that foster stereotypes rather than realistic images.

In many cases, biased rules and regulations are legalized such that they impact POC in a very negative way. We have already provided historical examples such as the expropriation of Native American land, the legalized institution of slavery, Jim Crow laws, the Chinese Exclusion Act, and the incarceration of Japanese Americans during WWII. Contemporary examples include the passage of strict voter ID laws that discriminate against voters of color, the Muslim travel ban, Trump's 2018 family separation policy, gerrymandering, diverting educational funds from public to private schools, laws forbidding transgender persons to serve in the military, and so on. Thus, macroaggressions that operate from systemic racism are detrimental to the quality of living for POC and result in inadequate healthcare, housing inequalities, educational disparities, employment bias, and poverty.

The Consequences of Racial Trauma

Both racial microaggressions and macroaggressions intersect and combine to produce an inhumane and shattering life experience for POC: raised from

birth to believe they are lesser human beings; bombarded by negative messages about their inferiority; portrayed as subhuman beings, aliens, criminals, and unintelligent people; restricted to inferior housing, education, employment, and healthcare; considered genetically deficient; evaluated as possessing abnormal lifestyles; harassed, physically assaulted, and murdered; and denied equal access and opportunities in nearly all institutions of our society describe the lived experience of POC. Relentless and cumulative racism directed at targets can result in racial trauma or race-based trauma: the mental, emotional, and physical injuries caused by bias and discrimination (Carter et al., 2013). It can be experienced by POC directly from the actions of others, from vicariously witnessing racist encounters, from the racist policies and practices of the wider social system, or even from having it transmitted intergenerationally. We briefly describe three forms of race-related stress or racial trauma experienced by POC: (a) racial battle fatigue, (b) historical and intergenerational trauma, and (c) internalized racism.

Racial Battle Fatigue: Psychological and Physical Consequences

The term “racial battle fatigue” was first coined by Smith and colleagues (Smith, 2004; Smith et al., 2007; Smith et al., 2011) to describe the psychological, physiological, and behavioral stress responses to microaggressions. The concept, however, is apropos in describing the detrimental reactions of POC to a litany of racist encounters across a broad spectrum of life situations at the individual, institutional, and cultural levels. Race-related stress taxes the biological and mental well-being of targets. First, on a physiological level, it depresses the immune system and makes POC more susceptible to illnesses such as colds, coronary heart disease, high blood pressure, and negative somatic symptoms such as sleep disturbances, headaches, fatigue, etc. (Smith, 2004; Sue & Spanierman, 2020).

Second, race-related stress can cause cognitive disruptions, emotive upheaval, and behavioral disturbances (Carter et al., 2013; Spanierman et al., 2021). In a review of the literature, Sue & Spanierman (2020) have summarized the impact of racism on targets. POC may exhibit diminished intellectual functioning, such as lower problem-solving skills, distraction

from the task at hand, increased confusion (especially to implicit bias), doubt about their intellectual abilities, and proneness to stereotype threat. Race-related stress symptoms are most pronounced at the emotive level. The demeaning, insulting, humiliating, and threatening nature of micro/macroaggressions may foster fear and anxiety, depression and depressive symptoms, and rage and anger. On a behavioral level, POC may approach white Americans with a great deal of hypervigilance and skepticism, reluctantly conform to the wishes of the dominant group by concealing their true feelings, behave in ways so as not to offend those in power, and isolate or minimize their interactions with white Americans. Healthy paranoia, cultural mistrust, code-switching, and concealment may represent survival tactics used to endure in a racist society.

Race-related stress evokes a threat/battle phenomenon in POC as they attempt to ward off daily racist encounters, to protect against demeaning biases and stereotypes, and to survive racially hostile and invalidating environments. POC must constantly be on guard for ceaseless racist attacks, anticipate where they will occur next, and prepare tactics and strategies to deal with them. The synonym DWB (driving while Black) refers to incidents of Black drivers being profiled and stopped by police officers while driving a vehicle. African American parents have taught their teenage sons to (a) anticipate being stopped by the police, (b) prepare to comply with following all directions and commands, (c) make no sudden or unexpected moves, (d) be respectful toward the officers, and (e) know they are likely to be treated with greater suspicion and force than their white counterparts (Sue et al., 2021). DWB incidents illustrate many of the emotional upheavals of race-related stress: *anger* and *rage* at being racially profiled, *fear* and *anxiety* of being harmed, *humiliation* for having to “go along to get along,” *disrespect* from law enforcement, and *helplessness* in the face of threat. Forced compliance may also lead to feelings of *cowardice* and *betrayal* of one's own integrity for not having the “courage” to assert one's rights. Thus, racial battle fatigue can lead to physiological and psychological burnout, where constant biological and psychological arousal (hypervigilance) depletes biological and psychological resources, which often leads to fatigue, hopelessness, and helplessness.

Historical and Intergenerational Trauma

The history of the United States is the history of racism and colonialism: mass murders, genocide, imprisonment, stolen land and unjust appropriation of property, enslavement, forced removal and/or deportation, concentration camp incarceration, and many others too numerous to list (Gone, 2023; Jones, 1997; Nagata et al., 2025; Sue, 2003). Duran (2019) coined the term "soul wound" to describe the ongoing pain and suffering that Natives experience from their history of oppression due to some of the most horrendous and inhumane treatments perpetrated against indigenous people: military conquest, massacres, enslavement, death marches, diseases, kidnapping of the young, starvation, and forced assimilation. Historical trauma for Native Americans has three characteristics. First, it is colonial in origin, where white Europeans and European Americans subjugated them. Second, it is collective in its impact and affects whole communities and is not confined to any one individual. Third, historical trauma is cumulative over time, because the impact of one atrocity has repercussions for future generations (Gone, 2023).

This last characteristic is important to acknowledge and understand. For example, POC are aware that historical injustices continue to affect current and future generations. Oftentimes, when reminded of past historic injustices, perpetrators will pronounce that their parents or grandparents did not own "slaves," that they did not steal land from Native Americans, and that they were not responsible for the incarceration of Japanese Americans. They further may suggest that POC should "let go" of the past and not play the "victim card." They fail to realize, however, that the callous and brutal actions of the past continue to affect the current standard of living for POC; stolen land means they continue to be deprived of real estate, and enslavement continues to reverberate in higher poverty rates for African Americans. Many white Americans don't realize that while they personally did not own "slaves" nor did they unjustly pilfer land from Natives, they still benefit from these past historic injustices. The real estate and homes they own, for example, symbolize the fruits of unjust actions built at the expense of the lives of POC.

In addition to affecting the standard of living of POC, historical and intergenerational trauma are intertwined in such a way that long-term horrific atrocities can result in collective trauma that can be passed on to

future generations. In *Healing the Soul Wound*, Duran (2019) describes the persistent impact of collective historical trauma that goes far beyond the original targets to their children and to their descendants. Holocaust survivors, for example, seem to be affected in the same way as the victims themselves, giving credence to the belief that historical trauma can result in intergenerational trauma (Yehuda & Lehrner, 2018).

Can trauma, however, be actually passed on to future generations? Although many might acknowledge that the symptoms of historical trauma can be passed on to an offspring through disturbed childrearing (parents transmitting their fears, pain, suffering, and disturbances through socialization practices), the concept of intergenerational trauma posits a biological component (Dias & Ressler, 2014). Epigenetics is the study of the biochemical processes of changing environmental conditions that alter gene expression. In most cases, changes in the DNA serve an adaptive purpose, but under harsh conditions and continued trauma, epigenetic changes in the genes may contain the signatures of collective pain and suffering that are passed on to future generations (Dias & Ressler, 2014; Sue et al., 2025; Yehuda & Lehrner, 2018). Although the biological mechanisms are still being explored, little doubt exists that historical and intergenerational trauma effects exist among many POC (Duran, 2019; Gone, 2023; Lee et al., 2023; Nagata et al., 2025). Historical trauma not only manifests symptoms similar to those who were originally targeted but also compounds current racial injustice to subsequent generations.

Internalized Racism, Self-Esteem, and Racial Identity

In the 1940s, Clark and Clark (1947) conducted a classic study ("Doll Tests") to investigate the effects of segregation on African American youngsters. Children from 3 to 7 years of age were presented with two identical dolls except for their color and race (dark vs. light skin) and asked a series of questions concerning their ability to discern the white and brown doll from one another, their ascription of good or bad characteristics to each, which one they preferred, and which was most like them. A large majority of the Black children assigned positive characteristics to the white doll and negative traits to the brown doll. They also indicated they preferred the white doll over the black one. When asked to choose which doll was most like them, many chose the white one and/or revealed emotional

turmoil when selecting the black doll. Some children would refuse to answer the question and run out of the room crying. Dr. Kenneth Clark reports one child pointing to the brown doll and saying, “That's a nigger. I'm a nigger” (Legal Defense Fund, n.d.).

The Clarks were very disturbed by the findings, and concluded that insidious, harmful, and powerful forces were at work in our society that damaged the self-esteem of Black children such that their racial identities were seriously compromised. Since that time, scholars have studied the phenomenon of *internalized racism*, the acceptance and internalization of racial stereotypes, beliefs, and ideologies that support white supremacy (David et al., 2019). Racial identity development theorists have recognized this phenomenon across nearly all racial/ethnic minority groups: African Americans, Asian Americans, Latinx Americans, Native Americans, and AMENA (David et al., 2019; Sue et al., 2021). Although internalized racism may be manifested in many ways, some are the following: (a) accepting the superiority of the dominant group's cultural values, traditions, beliefs, and customs, including physical appearance; (b) belief in the inferiority of one's own cultural heritage; (c) acceptance of the current cultural hierarchy; (d) using white standards to evaluate their own worth and identity; (e) internalizing self and group inferiority with subsequent feelings of shame and embarrassment; (f) attempting to personally escape or disown their own race; and (g) suffering from low self-esteem and self-worth. Internalized racism has a significant impact on the psychological well-being of POC. It has been found that it leads to self-doubt, disrespect for one's own race, self-loathing, depression and psychological distress, and lower levels of life satisfaction (David et al., 2019).

In closing, it is important not to view internalized racism from only an individual perspective. Internalized racism is a damning indictment of larger social-psychological forces of cultural racism that are imposed upon POC from the moment of birth. The locus of the problem does not simply reside in the victim. This is a very important point to make because POC may also fail to make such a distinction. Almost all groups of color use insulting terms or epithets (sell-out, “Uncle Tom”) or demeaning racial analogies to describe POC who have sold out: Oreos (African Americans who are Black outside but white inside), bananas (Asian Americans who are yellow outside but white inside), and apples (Native Americans who are red

outside but white inside). When POC use such derogatory terms toward members of their own groups whom they perceive as having sold out, they often do not understand that individuals suffering from internalized racism are victims of a dominant-subordinate process of power imposition. The usage of these terms and their distortions leads to “victim blaming” and detracts from the real systemic culprit.

TARGET SURVIVAL AND COPING

Given our review of the how racism impacts the lived experience of POC, the important question, therefore, is how do targets adaptively cope with the constant bombardment of racist insinuations, invalidations, and attacks to their humanity? How do they break free from scripted racist propaganda that forces them to remain naïve, to accept the explanations of the dominant society, and to “go along to get along?” Research seems to indicate three developmental transformations required for effective coping: (a) consciousness raising, (b) self-care coping, and (c) empowering for action (Brown et al., 2023; Houshmand & Spanierman, 2021; Houshmand et al., 2019; Sue et al., 2021).

Consciousness Raising

In a series of studies, Sue and colleagues (Sue et al., 2008; Sue et al., 2009) formulated the “microaggression process model,” later refined by Sue and Spanierman (2020) to identify the internal struggle of targets when potentially biased actions are directed toward them. When microaggressive incidents occur, targets must first notice or become aware of them before any action can be taken. Therein lies the first barrier to taking action. Although overt displays of racism (e.g., hate crimes, ethnic slurs, and obvious racist actions) can be clearly identified and labeled, those that are disguised, hidden, or outside the level of awareness of perpetrators, and in many cases targets, are much more difficult to discern. Microaggressions in the form of implicit bias are often disguised as innocent statements or even compliments. Statements like “You're pretty for a dark girl” to an African American female or “You speak excellent English” to an Asian American may seem to be compliments, but the hidden message or meta-communication to the targets contains offensive meanings (e.g., “Black

females are usually unattractive, but you are an exception" and "Asian Americans are perpetual foreigners and not true Americans").

Depending upon socialization and discriminatory racial experiences, targets may not be able to decipher the hidden meanings of microaggressions and remain oblivious to their expression (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019). More disturbingly, POC may also perceive these statements as flattering compliments devoid of biased meanings. Even when targets entertain the possibility that remarks or actions may be racially motivated, considerable doubt and internal questioning ensue (Sue et al., 2008, 2009). "Did what just happen, really happen?" "Was that a racist statement?" "Am I being too paranoid?" "Was it intentional or unintentional?" "Should I say something?" "But what should I do or say?" "If, I call it out, what are the consequences?" Such internal dialogues can sow seeds of doubt in the minds of POC, have them question their own racial realities, and lead to a depletion of psychic energies (Sue et al., 2007). The pressure to remain unaware and oblivious to microaggressions is further reinforced by perpetrators who genuinely disclaim biased intent when called out and imply that targets are "oversensitive." For POC, making the "invisible" visible is a major precondition to sanity, empowerment, and action.

Raising consciousness or awareness of racism (overt and subtle) may prove to be a monumental undertaking, especially for Children of Color (Heberle et al., 2020). In a society that tells them racism is a thing of the past, that equal access and opportunity are open to everyone, that their racialized experiences are invalid, and that POC are oversensitive to perceived racial slights, some are led to doubt their own senses and come to believe that their experiences of racism are not real (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019; Sue et al., 2021). The racial socialization literature implies that survival of POC to the forces of racism requires a clarity of vision that allows them to read the hidden messages and codes of racism (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019; Dotterer & James, 2018). Critical consciousness and racial literacy involve the ability of POC to be aware of oppressive systemic forces and their subtle manifestations at the individual, institutional, and cultural levels (Freire, 1970). Being unaware of racism and/or doubting their own sanity possesses major psychological harm for POC, in that it may lead to accepting a false reality and internalized racism. Thus, it is important to help POC to become aware of the dynamics of racism, not only to validate

their realities but also to be able to take actions to cope with the pain of racism.

Self-Care Coping

Regardless of race or ethnicity, all of us have a strong need to be liked, accepted, and well-regarded by family, friends, peers, and significant others in our lives. Positive social connections are a core feature of maintaining a healthy identity and emotional well-being (Cregg & Cheavens, 2023). The need to be accepted by others is especially strong in the formative years of development for children and adolescent identities and self-esteem. It is painful, for example, for Children of Color to realize they are not liked, considered inferior and unintelligent, and seen as lesser human beings simply because of their visible racial/ethnic differences (Jones, 1997). The microaggressive messages of inferiority from those around them (Sue & Spanierman, 2020), coupled with the desire to be accepted by majority group members (Cross, 1991; Helms, 1995), can lead to dissonance. On the one hand, being naïve and oblivious to racism (denial of racism) helps some POC to maintain their false sense of worth in the eyes of the majority culture. On the other hand, becoming conscious or aware of racism can be a painful realization that members of the dominant culture perceive them in negative ways, leading to humiliation, anxiety, anger, frustration, and depression (Costa et al., 2023). Although raising consciousness about racism is a necessary condition for effective self-coping and empowerment for action, it can be a distressing process. Considerable research seems to suggest that critical consciousness and an awareness of systemic racial oppression are correlated with experiences of marginalization, oppression, and even violence (Heberle et al., 2020; Kelly, 2018; Roy et al., 2019). Ironically, parents and loved ones who try to protect their sons and daughters from experiencing racial oppression may actually be preventing the development of racism awareness (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019; Sue et al., 2021).

Although Sue et al.'s (2009) early work on microaggressions was aimed at how to educate perpetrators through adaptive target responses, he observed that participants of color were more concerned with how to deal with the pain of a racist incident directed toward them. In the face of constant derogations, put-downs, and slights, how could POC possibly prioritize

perpetrator benefits over the distress and suffering of targets? This led Sue to state that "the first rule of thumb for targets, is to take care of yourself first" (Sue et al., 2019). Racial battle fatigue, exhaustion, and draining of psychic energy tax the resources of target groups to fully confront perpetrators, disarm microaggressions, and educate others (Smith et al., 2011). In order to be effective, targets must have a positive view of their racial/ethnic identity, be able to ward off racial insults and invalidations, be immunized against the ravages of racism, and be well-grounded in who they are as a racial/cultural being (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). But how do POC acquire these protective attributes, and how do they cope with the slings and arrows of racism? Fortunately, there is considerable research directed toward the topic of coping, protective strategies, resilience, and social support used by targets (Brondolo et al., 2009; Brown et al., 2023; Cregg & Cheavens, 2023; Houshmand et al., 2014; Houshmand & Spanierman, 2021; Houshmand et al., 2019; Lewis et al., 2013; Manohar & Kline, 2023; Mellor, 2004; Sue et al., 2021). See Spanierman et al. (2021) for a review of coping and resilience strategies.

Microaggressions are detrimental to POC because they threaten or assail the emotional well-being of recipients and attack their racial identities through exclusion (unwillingness to engage socially, emotionally, and physically with POC), derogation (messages of inferiority), and categorization (stereotypical beliefs/feelings) (Manohar & Kline, 2023). Targets of microaggressions have developed a number of strategies to counteract these harmful discriminatory racial encounters: withdrawing for self-protection, role shifting, armoring, cognitive reinterpretation, self-affirmations, cognitive reinterpretation, humor, spirituality and religion, and social support (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019; Houshmand & Spanierman, 2021; Houshmand et al., 2019; Mellor, 2004; Sue et al., 2019). All of these individual strategies can be grouped into four underlying survival categories.

First, it is important for targets of microaggression to be aware of what is happening to them, to know they are not oversensitive, misreading the actions of others, or "crazy," and to be able to "name" the discriminatory event or insult. Paulo Freire (1970), in *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, said the first step to liberation and empowerment is "naming" an oppressive event,

condition, or process so it no longer holds power over those that are marginalized.

Second, targets of microaggressions must learn to choose their battles carefully. To cope with the constant invalidations and insults of a racialized society can lead to emotional and physical exhaustion, or what has been labeled “racial battle fatigue” (Smith et al., 2011). Often, POC who choose not to respond to an indignity may be overwhelmed with self-loathing and/or a loss of integrity because they did not act. In this case, POC must see their inaction or withdrawal not as a failure, but as a survival strategy acquired through centuries of oppression.

Third, self-care and comfort for many POC involve seeking validation, support, and meaning from a higher power. Many turn toward religion and spirituality as a means to nourish their souls, to counteract the constant bombardment of racism, to affirm their humanity, and to immunize them against the ravages of racism.

Fourth, social support in the form of family, friends, and allies has been found to be one of the most powerful means of warding off microaggressions, affirming their racial/cultural being, strengthening them against the constant forces of invalidation, providing advice and suggestions, communicating they are not alone in their struggles, and providing a safe environment to be nourished and strengthened.

Empowering for Action

Related to the issue of self-care is often the feeling of helplessness, hopelessness, and sense of powerlessness that accompany a target's experience of a racist event (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008). Reasons for target inaction span the spectrum from fear of reprisals (being labeled a “troublemaker,” consequences of economic or physical penalties, etc.) to response uncertainty (Byrd, 2018). Even if the target overcomes these inhibitions, they often are at a loss of how to respond, leading to paralysis or inaction. Thus, empowerment for action is facilitated when (a) targets are able to overcome their fears associated with taking action and (b) when they possess a repertoire of well-rehearsed intervention strategies to call out and disarm microaggressions.

First, the fear of repercussions by calling out a racist event, especially when a power differential exists between perpetrators and targets, is numerous and realistic (Byrd, 2018; Rasinski & Czopp, 2010; Sue et al., 2019): (a) isolation from peers, (b) loss of position and power, (c) attacks on character, (d) stress and burnout, and (e) violent threats and physical harm. Perhaps the most powerful means of minimizing and overcoming these fears is to seek out social support and allies (Kim et al., 2008; Manohar & Kline, 2023). The old adage that "there is strength in numbers and safety in numbers" seems operative here. The feeling of safety, empowerment, validation, and increased resources to counteract racism are enhanced through group support and connection (Feeney & Collins, 2015). Isolation from peers is counteracted by belonging to a group; loss of position and power is balanced through increased efficacy with allies; attacks on character are neutralized through validation of identity and worth; stress and burnout are diluted through emotional and moral support; and violent threats and physical harm are protected by group identity and strength. In general, social support and group connection immunize targets against microaggressive messages and discriminatory actions, preserve their emotional and spiritual energies, strengthen feelings of empowerment and self-efficacy, and facilitate anti-bias actions (Sue et al., 2021).

Second, overcoming the challenges to anti-bias actions assumes targets have within their response repertoire the ability to confront, call out, and disarm the bias and discrimination visited upon them. While research has focused on coping and self-care, less work has been focused upon how targets can stop, disarm, or educate perpetrators (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Brown et al., 2023; Scully & Rowe, 2009). One of the common barriers to action can be labeled the "freeze effect" when confronted by microaggressions in which targets feel paralyzed to act, primarily because they lack the tools, actions, or strategies needed to disarm the biased event. Further, many targets do not have the experience or practice in confronting bias and discrimination. Microaggressions occur automatically and quickly, and by the time targets decide what to do, the event is generally over. Sue and colleagues (Sue et al., 2019, 2021) have introduced the term "microinterventions," which they define as "Everyday anti-bias actions taken by targets, parents, significant others, allies, and well-intentioned bystanders to counteract, diminish, or neutralize individual (microaggressions) and the institutional/societal (macroaggressions)

expressions of prejudice, bigotry, and discrimination" (Sue et al., 2021, p. 30). Note that the use of microinterventions is not confined to targets only but to anyone or any group that observes a moral racial transgression and is motivated to act.

Arming targets with a repertoire of microintervention strategies requires (a) identifying strategies and tactics to combat bias and (b) practicing and rehearsing when, where, and how to take action to disarm them (Scully & Rowe, 2009; Sue et al., 2019). Microinterventions can be grouped into four strategic goals (Sue et al., 2021). First, *making the microaggression visible* is intended to bring the bias to the forefront of the perpetrator's awareness, to indicate they have engaged in an offensive manner, to strike back, defend, and stop the bias, and to force the perpetrator to consider the impact or meaning of their behavior. Second, *educate the perpetrator* is intended to teach the perpetrator as to how the behavior was offensive, to facilitate a one-to-one conversation, to have a more enlightened conversation about the event, and to have the perpetrator explore the origins of their beliefs and attitude. Third, *disarm the microaggression* is intended to directly call out and stop the microaggression, to empower the target with a sense of control and self-efficacy, to increase perpetrator awareness by having them think before they speak or act, and to plant seeds of change for future action. Forth, *seek external support and alliance* is intended to partake in regular self-care to maintain psychological and physical well-being, to provide a safe environment to express thoughts and feelings, to support, validate, and immunize the target's racial identity and lived reality, to receive advice and suggestions about dealing with discriminatory racial experiences, and to be empowered by group support. Under each of these four strategic goals, Sue and colleagues (Sue et al., 2019, 2021) provide many specific tactics that can be taken by targets to disarm and neutralize microaggressions.

In conclusion, consciousness raising, self-care coping, and empowerment for action are consistent with the "confronting prejudiced response model" (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Morris & Goodwin, 2008) and the "microaggression process model" (Sue et al., 2008, 2009). Both describe the movement from awareness to action and the intermediary steps to targets taking action against racism. Both also emphasize the importance of practice, rehearsal, and learning specific anti-bias actions for problematic situations. Although studies on the positive impact of microaggression and

microintervention training on targets are limited, the few that exist are promising. For targets, microintervention and anti-bias training have been found to provide a repertoire of anti-bias responses, strengthen feelings of empowerment and self-efficacy, defend worth, integrity, and self-esteem, validate and affirm racialized experiences, increase group and racial/ethnic pride, and minimize sense of helplessness (Alsaidi, 2021; Crenshaw et al., 2023; Faller et al., 2024; Jones & Rolon-Dow, 2018; Kniffley et al., 2023; Walker et al., 2022). Most of these workshops have been conducted in medical settings with interns, residents, and physicians of color.

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CHAPTER FOUR
Barriers to White Bystander Awareness and Anti-Racist Action

Bystanders are people who witness unjust, unacceptable, and potentially harmful behaviors or emergency situations that are worthy of comment or action (Scully & Rowe, 2009). In general, anyone can be a bystander (other targets and allies), but in this chapter, we focus on individuals who are members of the majority group and who authentically believe in equity and racial justice but possess only a nebulous or superficial understanding of race and racism (Sue et al., 2019). Like our earlier description of perpetrators as "aversive racists," bystanders also seem to consciously endorse egalitarian values but harbor implicit biases that make it difficult for them to recognize their own discriminatory actions and those expressed by others. They are able to sympathize with targets of racism, consciously condemn racism, and genuinely believe that they are good, moral, and decent human beings who are fair and unbiased (Murrell, 2020). They represent the plurality of people in our society, and many have difficulty recognizing biased behaviors, other than the most extreme forms of overt racism.

In many respects, bystanders share common characteristics with perpetrators, in that they are also prone to express bias outside the level of conscious awareness. In the deadly dance of racism, for example, they are likely to find racist jokes amusing, to consider microaggressions as "small infractions" that are not worthy of personal involvement, to downplay the seriousness of biased actions, and/or to dismiss bias objections as overreactions (Haynes-Baratz et al., 2021; Murrell, 2020). Unless they recognize the seriousness or biased nature of discriminatory acts, bystanders may encourage the actions of perpetrators through their silence or even overtly approve them. More disturbing is that they, too, may engage in similar behaviors (be perpetrators).

Overcoming silence, inaction, and complicity is a monumental task for bystanders. The need for microaggression training and for bystander

intervention training is great (Scully & Rowe, 2009; Sue et al., 2019). The American Psychological Association (2022) uses the term “upstander” as opposed to “bystander,” to designate an individual who recognizes acts of bias and discrimination and who takes action to confront and challenge the injustice. Every phase of becoming an upstander, however, is predicated upon the individual's racial literacy, understanding of individual, institutional, and cultural racism, and development of critical consciousness. In many respects, the challenge on this front is similar to that for perpetrators. As long as the manifestation, dynamics, and impact of racism, and especially the subtleness of microaggressions, are invisible to bystanders, no action is to be expected.

It is possible to view bystanders and white perpetrators as existing on a continuum (a) from unawareness of racism to the development of critical consciousness, (b) from detachment and inaction to engagement and action, and (c) from being non-racist to becoming anti-racist. Overall, the ultimate goal is to stop the discriminatory actions of perpetrators and to move them from being offenders to allies and from being bystanders to upstanders. In Chapter 1, we outlined three internal changes of white Americans that facilitate anti-bias action: critical consciousness, self-reckoning, and anti-bias empowerment and action. In Chapter 2, we discussed how major psychological barriers (cognitive, emotive, behavioral, and spiritual) had to be overcome to take positive anti-racist actions. In this chapter, we focus primarily upon social-psychological forces that either discourage or encourage bystander intervention.

FORCES SHAPING BYSTANDER INACTION OR ACTION

Because we have already spent considerable time addressing the internal factors that must be overcome to stop personal expressions of racism and to take anti-bias actions, we will focus primarily upon social psychological forces that influence bystander action and what conditions need to exist to move white bystanders to take a stand and to intervene when an unfair racial transgression occurs. To understand the complexity of bystander activation, however, we first draw upon studies and findings accumulated through social psychological research on emergency situations where

individuals witness others in need of help (a motorist with a disabled car, someone drowning, a bullying incident, a sexual assault, a suicide attempt, a drunk driver, etc.) but fail to respond. Second, because most of the studies on bystanders have focused on non-racial situations, we explore the impact of race or the racialization of bystander action or inaction and discuss the implications it has on bystander involvement. We provide a framework for how bystander training programs and our society can maximize upstander interventions in the face of discriminatory racist events.

The Bystander Effect: Silence and Inaction

> In 1964, an Italian American woman, Kitty Genovese, was sexually assaulted and brutally murdered while returning home from work in the middle of the night. She drove her car to the back of her building parking space. As she walked toward the apartment complex entrance, she was attacked by a man wielding a large hunting knife. Genovese cried for help and struggled and fought for her life throughout the ordeal. Although the attacker was initially frightened off by the lights and voices emanating from curious apartment residents, he returned several times to stab her again and again. It was reported that the incident lasted for over ½ hour, was witnessed by 38 dwellers, and no one intervened or called the police. Many reasons were given for why residents said they did not act: they thought it was a “lover's quarrel,” they were afraid, they believed others would call the police, they did not see the entire incident, and even that they were too “tired.”

The Kitty Genovese murder sparked widespread condemnation about public apathy and extensive discourse about the reasons for inaction among onlookers and has become a storyline in movies and television programs. The question posed by many media outlets was “Why did witnesses to an obvious assault upon a neighbor lead to a failure to help?” Although it has since been reported that the incident was overstated (inaccurate report of number of witnesses and that no one called the police) (Manning et al., 2007), the Genevese murder set off a wealth of social psychological research about bystander inaction (Darley & Latane, 1968, 1970). The failure of witnesses to intervene in an emergency situation has been labeled the “bystander effect,” a phenomenon in which the presence of others who

observe an emergency situation inhibits the willingness to help someone in need.

Many of the explanations for bystander inaction fall under the theory of social influence, whereby people's thoughts, attitudes, emotions, and behaviors are influenced by the presence of others (Cialdini & Goldstein, 2004; Davlembayeva & Papagiannidis, 2024). The dynamics and principles uncovered from social influence theory make it clear that bystander perceptions, beliefs, behaviors, and even feelings can be affected by interactions with others and/or social norms that dictate appropriate group behavior. In the deadly dance of racism, for example, perpetrator, target, ally, and bystander behaviors are affected through the reciprocal and symbiotic relationships between the participants. In this section, we identify five social psychological explanations that influence bystander behaviors: diffusion of responsibility, social proof, evaluation apprehension, cost/benefit analysis, and bystander-victim similarity and relationship.

Diffusion of Responsibility

When the Genovese murder struck the headlines, many described the inaction by onlookers as evidence of a “cold, heartless, and unfeeling” populace concerned only with its own self-interests and welfare. Research, however, suggests that the number of bystanders who witness an emergency affects their willingness to help for many other reasons and is rarely correlated with uncaring and unsympathetic attitudes (Darley & Latane, 1970; Staub, 2023). In groundbreaking laboratory findings, investigators discovered that a greater number of witnesses to an emergency situation seemed to diminish the possibility that the victim would receive direct help or even that it would be called to the attention of others. In one study, researchers asked participants to fill out a questionnaire either alone or in the presence of others in a waiting room (Darley & Latane, 1968). As they began the task, smoke seeped into the room, indicating the possibility of a fire. When naïve participants were alone, nearly 70% reported the smoke within two minutes, while those in the presence of others reported the emergency only 38% of the time.

Darley and Latane (1970) called this the “bystander effect,” in that as the number of witnesses increased, there was a “diffusion of responsibility” among onlookers leading to a decrease in the likelihood of anyone

intervening. In other experiments, where the victim seemed to be experiencing an asthma attack (heard through an intercom), or when a female confederate seemed to be distressed in public, the findings were similar: the greater the number of witnesses, the less likely aid would be offered (Darley & Latane, 1968 Staub, 2023). The investigators explained that when a single individual is confronted with a crisis, they are likely to feel directly responsible for aid. When others are present, however, the sense of concern and obligation is drastically diminished in the belief that other onlookers also bear the responsibility for helping. In support of these findings, it was found that one of the most common reasons given for lack of personal action in the Genovese murder was a belief that "others would intervene or call the police."

Social Proof

In general, the bystander effect has been replicated in numerous situations. Although diffusion of responsibility has been offered as one explanation, social proof (often referred to as pluralistic ignorance or false consensus) has also been used to explain the inaction of onlookers (Cialdini, 1984, 2021). In general, the phenomenon of social proof is characterized by a belief that others hold opinions different from theirs, and as a result, they conform their beliefs and behaviors to that of the reference group. When an emergency occurs, the individual has to first notice the event and then define it as an urgent situation requiring action to alleviate the potential harm. In many situations, especially ambiguous ones, people search for the meaning of a particular incident or event by taking their cues from others. How a situation is defined or interpreted is strongly influenced by the action or inaction of others.

Let us return to our laboratory example of naïve participants who were filling out forms when smoke began to slowly fill the room. Participants who were alone noticed and acted quickly to bring the issue to the attention of the experimenters. On an individual level, they defined the situation as a possible emergency. Those who were with others, however, failed to take quick action (some did not act at all) because other bystanders (confederates) appeared unconcerned and calm. Thus, they concluded that the smoke was not indicative of a potentially dangerous situation. Social psychologists believe people often take their cues from others in helping

define the situation. Being the only bystander in an apparent emergency, for example, makes the individuals rely on their own observations and beliefs. Thus, when they associate smoke with the possibility of a fire and believe that their lives or that of others might be in danger, they are likely to take quick action.

When in the presence of others, however, bystanders tend to look to one another for confirmation (proof) about whether an emergency exists. The fact that others completing the forms remained inactive and seemingly casual about the situation when smoke flowed into the room meant that others were unconcerned and did not define it as a dangerous or an emergency situation. If, however, others were to become excited, anxious, or panic-stricken, the situation would be deemed dangerous. Thus, rather than acting on their own observations and beliefs, they mistakenly accept the definition of reality from the larger audience and act accordingly. Social proof is most likely to occur in very ambiguous situations or when people are at a loss of how to respond; thus, they will turn to others to help them define the situation so that proper behavior can be determined (Cialdini, 2021). The phenomenon of social proof can create perception errors, misjudgments, and false consensus. In Chapter 6, we expand upon the concept of false consensus and how it plays a major role in the racism dance.

Evaluation Apprehension

Both the diffusion of responsibility and social proof explanations fall under the category of social influence, the phenomenon of how people's beliefs, feelings, and actions are changed or affected by social interactions with others. Likewise, evaluation apprehension is another form of social influence where people or bystanders experience fear or anxiety about being judged or evaluated negatively by others (Zhou et al., 2019). When in mixed company or with strangers, people tend to manage their impression on others through projecting what they believe will be viewed positively about them and to abstain from words or actions that may be received negatively (Bolino & Turnley, 1999). Evaluation apprehension has been found to negatively impact idea generation in the workplace, to focus too much attention on avoiding mistakes, to hinder creativity, to limit honesty, to foster ingratiation to the group, and to affect bystander readiness and

motivation to respond in a helping manner (Bolino & Turnley, 1999; Jones, 1984; Sue, 2015).

When a man falls to the ground in public and appears to be in medical distress, bystanders are placed in the unenviable position of having to determine the cause of the distress, decide on what action to take, ascertain whether help is wanted or not, and consider how the possible intervention will be perceived by others: “Is the man having a heart attack?” “Is he intoxicated.” “Did he simply trip?” “Does he want my help?” “Do I know how to help?” “If I act, what will others think?” The first three questions are vulnerable to the dynamics of social proof, while the last three questions may be affected by evaluation apprehension. Onlookers may hesitate to intervene or help because of (a) fear of how their behaviors will be perceived by others, (b) whether they will embarrass themselves, (c) whether they are accurately reading the situation, (d) whether they will make a mistake, (e) whether they can provide effective assistance, (f) whether others will approve, (g) whether they will be held responsible if something goes wrong, (h) whether the victim welcomes their aid, and even (i) whether there will be legal consequences for their “wrong” actions (being liable for making an incorrect medical intervention). People experiencing evaluation apprehension may hesitate to provide assistance or not intervene at all. In the case of an emergency, delay or inaction may have very dire consequences.

Costs/Benefits Explanation

In some ways, evaluation apprehension may represent a subset of the *cost-reward explanation* of bystander readiness to respond in a helpful way. According to social exchange theory, bystanders may use a cost/benefit analysis to determine whether to engage or refrain from helping actions based upon their perceived gains as opposed to the risks or sacrifices they may incur (Blau, 1964; Cook & Rice, 2006). The model focuses on the role of altruism, empathy, and prosocial urges that are aroused when we witness someone who is injured, unfairly treated, homeless, or being assailed. The emotional arousal of sympathy and vicarious identification is uncomfortable, and eliminating the pain of the victim (helping) also alleviates the discomfort of the bystander. People high in altruism and whose personal values align with their prosocial behaviors are likely to

intervene in emergencies because it is consistent with their image of “having done the right and moral thing.” Their rewards or benefits for helping others (personal satisfaction, social approval, and acting in accordance with their values of right and wrong) far outweigh the costs of inaction (Dovidio, 1984).

However, if the costs or consequences of helping overshadow the benefits, strong ambivalence or inaction is likely to occur. In many respects, situational factors may raise or lower the cost of helping and determine whether to intervene. Offering help to a pedestrian who trips and falls in the street is often perceived as requiring minimal effort, but witnessing a public assault of a stranger in the subway increases the labor and potential negative consequences of intervening. If the nature of the emergency requires only a minimal effort or expenditure of energy on the part of the bystander, help is more likely to occur. Helping a victim in this situation is rewarded by “feeling good about oneself,” social approval by other bystanders, and a sense of having done the right thing.

Costs of intervention, however, may increase and override the benefits of altruistic behavior as the situation becomes increasingly risky, unsafe, or even dangerous. According to the cost/benefit model, a failure to help still produces aversive arousal (guilt, shame, and self-betrayal feelings) that is often alleviated through rationalization and reinterpretation of the situation. In the Genovese murder, for example, personal intervention against the attacker is a high-cost action that may result in the bystander's potential harm. To reduce culpability and personal responsibility, bystanders may simply reinterpret the situation through rationalizing their inaction. In the Genovese murder, for example, onlookers may justify their inaction by reinterpreting the situation. Many residents who heard the cries of pain and pleas for assistance rationalized their failure to help because they defined the incident as a non-dangerous one and simply an argument between two people.

Similarities and Relationships

In their work on motivational responsibility of bystanders, Darley and Latane (1970) speculated that one of the factors to consider was the actual or perceived similarity and relationship between bystander and victim. Similarity is one of the variables believed to increase attraction between

bystander and victim and increases identification, empathic and altruistic responses, and the likelihood of providing aid (Dovidio, 1984). But what specific real or perceived attributes between bystander and victim influence bystander helping? Feeling that we are similar to someone else can vary widely: (a) mutual personal attributes—beliefs, values, interests, attitudes, motivations, and even intellect; (b) shared group identify—race, ethnicity, gender, age, and religious orientation; and (c) external commonalities—preference for food, music, clothing, and sports. Research illustrates, for example, that bystanders who shared a social category with the victim were more likely to intervene in a street violence scenario, friends were more likely to help a friend than a stranger, and even that a victim wearing a football jersey of a team the bystander supported increased the chances of receiving help (Levine & Crowther, 2008). It would be naïve to believe, however, that any or all similarities increase interpersonal attraction in ways that would impact bystander behavior.

Because we generally select friends who share our passions, interests, attitudes, and even political leanings, similarities are powerful factors that determine the closeness of a relationship and our sense of obligation toward them. It would make sense that a readiness to help would be more quickly forthcoming for a close acquaintance, friend, or family member than for a stranger needing assistance (Sue et al., 2019). That is because our sense of closeness, intimacy, and attraction increases our empathic responses to the pain and suffering of those we cherish and motivates us to intercede on their behalf. Although we may offer assistance to strangers, our empathic responses may not be as high, our readiness to intervene is lessened, and our sense of reciprocal obligation and responsibility may be diminished. Diffusion of responsibility, social proof, evaluation apprehension, and cost/benefit analysis outcomes may become a greater burden to overcome for strangers than close acquaintances. Table 4.1 summarizes social influence explanations that affect bystander action or inaction. Note, however, that most of the explanations have dealt primarily with non-racial situations.

Bystander Intervention: Conclusions

It is clear that people's perceptions, beliefs, and behaviors are influenced by others, and thus, by extension, it is not surprising to find that bystander

actions are likewise affected. In an emergency situation, action or inaction is either enhanced or negated by the presence of others, which may influence the amount of responsibility felt by the individual (diffusion of responsibility), how they interpret the situation (social proof), whether others will approve or disapprove of their intervention (evaluation apprehension), whether their actions generate sufficient rewards that outweigh the costs (cost/benefit analysis), and whether they perceive themselves to share similarities with the victim. Although there are many other factors that influence bystander behavior (dangerousness of the situation, type of emergency, where the incident occurs, and the type of intervention required), social influence theory supports our contention that when racist incidents occur between a perpetrator and target, white allies and onlookers can be swayed by these five social dynamics. Given our knowledge of how social forces may influence and impede bystander behavior, how do we counteract their potential negative outcomes? How do we, for example, minimize diffusion of responsibility, disrupt false consensus (social proof), lower evaluation apprehension, reward prosocial behaviors (cost/benefit), and enhance empathy and human commonalities (similarities) to increase upstander actions?

Table 4.1 Social Influence Dynamics in Bystander Actions: When Race Enters the Equation

Social influence theory explains how peoples' attitudes, beliefs, or behaviors are swayed by the presence of others. Most of the findings on how people are shaped, persuaded, or influenced by social dynamics have dealt primarily with non-racial emergency situations or events. Race and racism present unique challenges to bystander actions and must be considered when social influence theory is used to explain behaviors.
1. Diffusion of Responsibility. As the number of bystanders increases, there is a “diffusion of responsibility” among onlookers, leading to a decrease in the likelihood of anyone taking action to intervene or help. 2. Social Proof (Pluralistic Ignorance). When in the presence of others, bystanders often tend to look to other people for confirmation about the meaning of events (proof), to define what is happening, and to determine appropriate behaviors. 3. Evaluation Apprehension. Bystander behaviors are influenced by their fears and anxieties over being judged and evaluated negatively by others when they contemplate taking action. 4. Cost/Benefit. Bystanders often use a cost/benefit analysis to determine whether to engage or refrain from helping actions based upon their perceived gains as opposed to the risks or sacrifices they may incur. 5. Similarity. Similarity is believed to increase or decrease attraction between bystander, perpetrator, and victim and either increases or decreases identification, empathic and altruistic responses, and the likelihood of providing aid. 6. Obedience and Conformity. Bystander action or inaction is subject to the influence of obedience and conformity, especially to those who occupy legitimate positions that allow them greater authority over others. 7. Social Contagion. A phenomenon by which attitudes, emotions, or behaviors are rapidly spread to people (bystanders) through the

spontaneous imitation of an authority figure or others.

First, awareness of the social forces that influence bystander behavior represents the first step toward overcoming inaction. Although not a sufficient condition for intervention, it may be a necessary one. If bystanders witness an emergency with other onlookers and are aware that diffusion of responsibility may occur, they can say to themselves, “I am responsible and must act. I cannot wait for others to intervene. If not me, who else?” Furthermore, enlisting the aid of other bystanders by making eye contact with them (or pointing to them) induces shared rather than diffused responsibility. Studies indicate that witnesses to an emergency must first notice the event and feel responsible to help (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Darley & Latane, 1970).

Second, some studies indicate that anonymity and willful ignorance allow the bystander to escape responsibility. For example, Staub and Baer (1974) had a student confederate pretend to collapse on the street when a passerby approached within 50 yards. Although some offered help, a few paused, looked away, and crossed the street. They purposefully avoided the situation or did not want to acknowledge or know what was happening. Inaction can seemingly be overcome when one-to-one personal contact is made with onlookers (Staub & Baer, 1974). Making eye contact and singling out individuals prevents them from escaping into the morass of anonymity and responsibility.

Third, combating social proof and defining an emergency immediately have been found to be very effective. Bystanders can loudly declare the incident to be an emergency, “*this is a life and death situation*” (defining the situation rather than leaving it ambiguous), and by exclaiming “*one of **us***” needs help (inducing shared identity and similarity). These straightforward statements or actions may appear simplistic, but their impact is both enormous and significant (perhaps saving a life). Involving others has also been found to undermine hesitation to act, as it lowers evaluation apprehension through social support and reduces the costs of intervention (safety in numbers).

Last, knowledge and awareness of the bystander effect may also be useful to targets/victims when it comes to an emergency situation. In his many

years of work on bystander inaction, Cialdini (2021) utilized what he learned when he became a victim of an auto accident. He describes how he knelt beside the door of his disabled car as drivers slowly drove by, staring at him intently, trying to ascertain what had happened, struggling with what actions to take, and believing or hoping that others would provide aid. Being one of the pioneers in the theory of social proof, Cialdini knew he had to help motorists define his situation as an emergency. He loudly asked for “help” (emergency), looked directly at certain drivers, pointed to and spoke to them (responsibility), requested that one driver call the police, and asked two others to pull over and provide aid (defined appropriate actions). The response, he reports, was immediate and gratifying. Once one driver pulled over, others followed suit. The bystanders cleaned up the blood on his head, volunteered to be witnesses, and some offered to ride in the ambulance with him.

These two incidents provide clues as to how upstanders can neutralize or diminish the social forces that promote inaction and apathy. It also has major implications for education and training, or for how organizations can promote prosocial behavior when help is needed. Recent years have seen an increase in bystander intervention training programs and in requests for workforce intervention programs to combat sexual and racial harassment, biased comments, and inappropriate jokes. In schools, attention has been placed on intervening in bullying incidents and suicidal threats and clues. Organizations can do much by implementing policies that affirm appropriate and inappropriate behaviors, emphasize that it is the responsibility of all to intervene when transgressions or emergencies occur, provide a “safe place” for employees to report wrongdoing, and reinforce and reward prosocial behaviors. Creating a culture of responsibility will make it easier for everyone to overcome the inhibiting influence of social influence norms.

THE RACIALIZATION OF BYSTANDER INTERVENTIONS

> On May 25, 2020, George Floyd, a 46-year-old African American man, was handcuffed and pinned face down to the ground for over nine minutes under the knee of Derek Chauvin, a white police officer. Two other officers helped restrain Floyd's arms and legs. The entire incident was caught on video as Floyd appeared in medical distress, constantly stated he could not breathe, and in the end pleaded for his mother. Even when no action and resistance were observed from Floyd and when bystanders indicated that he was no longer conscious, Chauvin continued to nonchalantly leave his knee on the throat of Floyd. When one of the officers could find no pulse, there was a failure to provide resuscitation efforts and emergency medical care as required in standard police procedures. He was pronounced dead that evening. All the officers were fired from the Minneapolis Police Force, and Chauvin was convicted of murder. The murder of George Floyd set off a series of demonstrations in Minneapolis, weeks of protests across the nation, accusations of racism, calls for police reform, and numerous solidarity statements against anti-blackness by organizations
>
> (The New York Times, 2022).

As in the Genovese murder, questions about bystander inaction rose to the forefront. Why did the other officers who witnessed the murder of Floyd fail to intervene? Why did civilians not take action to stop the gruesome and fatal event? In what ways do race, racial violence, discrimination, and prejudice impact the likelihood of victims receiving help or even becoming targets? Although there are similarities between the two murders, when we consider how “race” may impact bystander behavior, the analysis can become quite complicated. In this tragedy, there were two classes of bystanders: three fellow officers who knew and worked with Chauvin, and most of the civilian onlookers who had minimal relationship with him. In addition to the five social psychological reasons for bystander inaction, what lessons can we distill from the murder of George Floyd, especially when the race of perpetrators, targets, allies, and bystanders becomes a significant factor?

Conformity and Obedience to Authority

It is a well-known social psychological phenomenon that people are strongly influenced by the beliefs and actions of others, and they will conform both their behaviors and beliefs to align with those of the group (Franzen & Mader, 2023). The classic study of Solomon Asch (1951) has become foundational in understanding conformity among peers. In the study, naïve participants were asked to judge the length of lines with a group of confederates who gave wrong answers. Interestingly, some 38% of the naïve volunteers gave the same answers as the confederates, even when it was obviously incorrect. Conformity as a powerful social effect has been found to apply across many situations, including political opinions, racial attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors (Franzen & Mader, 2023; Sue et al., 2019).

Conformity has also been found to be intimately linked to concepts of authority and obedience (Milgram, 1974). In our society, for example, some individuals occupy positions that allow them greater authority over others (police officers, judges, political leaders, CEOs, etc.). They have a legitimate right to demand compliance and possess the power to reward or punish the actions of others. People are socially conditioned to obey the orders or demands of those individuals in charge. Those in charge often model acceptable standard conduct for others to follow. Law enforcement officers are entrusted by society with the upholding of laws and discouraging criminal acts that violate them. Within limits, they are allowed to use force against others to prevent unlawful behaviors, to control them, and/or when their lives are in jeopardy (Boxer et al., 2021).

Police Officers as Bystanders

Derek Chauvin was not only a white policeman with a right to exercise such force, but he was also a field training officer, the most senior member of the group, whose actions were difficult to question or even disobey by his fellow officers. Yet, several of the police officers in court testimony expressed concern about Chauvin's use of “excessive force” and the well-being of Floyd. Nevertheless, they stood idly by, made only minimal efforts to make Chauvin aware of Floyd's medical distress, and failed to render medical aid once he had stopped breathing (Henderson, 2023). In many ways, the officers may have been conforming to the unspoken demands of Chauvin and complying with the authority vested in him. History is replete

with examples of those in leadership positions who engaged in unlawful and immoral behaviors, and either encouraged or commanded subordinates to do likewise (torture, mass executions, wartime killing of innocent civilians, etc.). In the My Lai massacre of 1968, for example, over 500 innocent villagers (including women and children) in Vietnam were raped and murdered on the orders of Lt. William Calley. He was the platoon leader who had his men round up villagers in groups to be shot to death. As in the Floyd murder, many questions arose as to culpability and why many of his men followed Calley's orders or served as passive bystanders (Yousif, 2024).

Unquestioned obedience and conformity to orders can lead to a form of "social contagion," a phenomenon by which attitudes, emotions, or behaviors are rapidly spread to people through the spontaneous imitation of an authority figure or others (Levy & Nail, 1993). People can become "caught up in the moment," where their emotions overwhelm their judgments of right or wrong, and they engage in atrocities against their internal moral values and standards. It has been proposed that many of the soldiers under Calley's command were not only following orders but also engaging in a contagious release of pent-up emotions where they no longer distinguished civilians from enemy soldiers. This is especially true when a victim or target is perceived as an "other being" and dehumanized, a major explanation of the cause of racism (Sue et al., 2021). In Chapter 6, we cover the concept of "social bias contagion" as one important variable affecting the dance of racism (Bauer et al., 2018).

Findings on obedience and compliance to authority come from a groundbreaking study conducted by Yale social psychologist Stanley Milgram (1963), who led naïve participants to believe that they were delivering powerful, painful, and harmful electrical shocks to a confederate. Milgram originally undertook the obedience study as a means of answering the question posed by the Holocaust: Why did so many German soldiers and civilians follow the orders of the military to murder millions of Jews during WWII (Milgram, 1974)? During the experiment, confederates cried out in pain, asked not to continue, and even feigned heart problems. It was clear that the naïve volunteers experienced a reluctance to continue but did so under the encouragement of the experimenter. Some 65% of the participants delivered the maximum shock, despite having such actions go

against their own personal moral values of humanity and concern for the welfare of others. Milgram concluded that obedience to an authority figure was strong and that many people will obey orders that would result in harm to another.

Thus, it is possible to explain the inaction of police officers (bystanders) in the murder of Floyd from our understanding of social influence theory and the symbiotic relationships between the key players. From the perspective of other officers, Derek Chauvin represented an authority figure (obedience and conformity), and by his actions communicated that Floyd was a dangerous criminal, an “other being” who needed to be controlled (social proof). He also modeled the use of excessive force (social contagion), possessed the power to reward or punish his subordinates (cost/benefit), came from the same profession and training as the other officers (similarity), and elicited doubt about whether to intervene (evaluation apprehension). In addition, diffusion of responsibility may have played a role in diluting the obligation of the three law enforcement witnesses.

Civilians as Bystanders

The civilian bystanders were also not immune from being influenced by the presence of armed police officers who held authority over the entire situation. Although the emphasis in this chapter is on white observers, the reaction of Bystanders of Color provides meaningful clues to distilling the psychological dynamics of helping behaviors. In this case, most of the civilian onlookers were Black, identified with Floyd, and believed harmful excessive force was being used (Eastman, 2021). Public perception that the civilian bystanders were passive about the struggle occurring between Floyd and the other officers is a false one. They indeed tried to intervene but were waved off by police officers who responded to them in a threatening manner (Eligon, 2021). The power dynamics made physical intervention very risky (pulling Chauvin off of Floyd) and could result in harm to the bystander or even lead to criminal charges. Their efforts to intervene, however, were caught on video and expanded in court testimony during Chauvin's murder trial. One of the bystanders filmed the encounter; several shouted at the officers to stop; one screamed “you are killing him”; another witness even stepped off the curb in an attempt to help Floyd but was ushered back by an officer; one begged them to check Floyd's pulse

when he lost consciousness; and one even called the police on the police (Eastman, 2021; Eligon, 2021). All these efforts were to no avail as bystanders witnessed the slow-motion death of Floyd.

The impact on the civilian bystanders who racially identified with Floyd was devastating, as almost all, in court testimony, expressed feelings of guilt, helplessness, remorse, self-blame, and lingering pain in their inability to do anything to save his life (Eligon, 2021). In the deadly dance of racism, POC suffer immensely when they witness "one of their own" being harmed, mistreated, and unjustly deprived of their civil rights, especially when they feel powerless to help. An 18-year-old female witness to the death of George Floyd exemplifies the emotional toll racism has taken on the psyche of an individual:

> "When I look at George Floyd, I look at my dad. I look at my brothers, I look at my cousins, my uncles. Because they are all black," said the 18-year-old that filmed the viral video of the arrest.
>
> "I look at that and I look at how that could have been one of them," said Darnella, the first of four witnesses who the judge permitted to speak off-camera because they were minors at the time of the incident.
>
> "It's been nights I stay up apologising and apologising to George Floyd for not doing more and not physically interacting and not saving his life," she continued.
>
> "But it's not what I should have done. It's what he should have done," she said in a reference to Mr. Chauvin
>
> (BBC, 2021, np).

Most studies on the bystander effect deal with inaction on the part of those witnessing an emergency or transgression, but we may be able to learn much by reversing the question: Why did the civilian bystanders take action? Did race have anything to do with the treatment of Floyd or with the readiness of onlookers to come to Floyd's aid? Certainly, it is clear that the majority of civilian onlookers was Black, could identify with Floyd, and personalized the incident, and their racial similarity to the victim made empathy greater. As we have seen, similarity, especially race, is a powerful determinant of motivating action. Their urge to intercede on Floyd's behalf, however, was thwarted by the large power differential between the officers

and bystanders. Many social scientists believe that race and racism played a large role in how Floyd was treated and his eventual death (Dvoskin et al., 2023; Murrell, 2020; Sue et al., 2019). To understand the racial dynamics involved, we turn our attention to police culture in order to understand how race and racism intersect with bystander action and inaction. The analysis of police culture symbolizes how racialization of societal norms and how individual beliefs, attitudes, and behaviors influence not only the willingness of bystanders to offer aid but also the willingness of perpetrators (and some onlookers) to allow an injustice to occur.

Norms and Police Culture

Although the United States has an overarching culture that is shared by many, it is also composed of many subcultures that may be unique to specific organizations, professions, and communities. Cultural norms influence attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors of its members. Law enforcement is said to have a "police culture" characterized by (a) extreme in-group loyalty to fellow officers, (b) a sense of isolation from the communities they serve, and (c) a "blue wall of silence" (secrecy) concerning internal affairs (Henderson, 2023; Roscigno & Preito-Hodge, 2021). How do these characteristics get played out in policing? What impact did race and racism have in the case of George Floyd? What lessons can we learn from this sad and disastrous incident?

First, fellow officers at the Floyd murder shared many similarities with one another (training, occupation, and entrusted with power) and came from the same police culture that united them, regardless of race. They strongly identified with "blue culture," containing unwritten rules stressing loyalty to one another and a code of silence to protect them from genuine threats (Hall et al., 2016). The sense of brotherhood/sisterhood and the need to depend on and/or be accepted by their peers can create a subculture where fellow officer misdeeds are willfully ignored, their seriousness downplayed, and are either unreported or falsely manufactured (Skolnick, 2002).

Second, police culture has been found to be extremely insular and separated from the community and its inhabitants. In many respects, the isolation represents a closed system where reality is formed within their ranks as a means to protect against the criminal subculture that could endanger their lives (Skolnick, 2002). Unfortunately, the inability to connect with the

wider community and the perception that danger lurks around every corner of the neighborhood can lead to a paranoid “we versus them” mentality (Silver et al., 2017). Citizens in neighborhoods become suspects, not to be trusted, up to no good, surreptitiously engaging in criminal conduct, and potentially dangerous to the well-being of officers. Such a worldview in the eyes of police culture lessens sympathy and empathy toward civilians, objectifies them as other beings (criminals), and enhances dehumanization (Henderson, 2023). Such a culture with norms of silence, secrecy, and solidarity becomes susceptible to racist views of POC, and especially in Black communities.

Isolation, Group Loyalty, Power, Secrecy, and Racism: Societal Implications

Although police culture is quite unique, it is equally influenced by society's beliefs and images about People of Color, and in the case of George Floyd, images of Black men in our society. In a nation that harbors negative stereotypes of POC, these images are socialized into children from the moment of birth and are reinforced throughout adulthood (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019; Jones, 1997). We have already discussed stereotypes of African Americans in Chapter 2, but their detrimental impact is clearly seen in law enforcement (Hall et al., 2016). Beliefs about the character of Black Americans (criminals, hoodlums, super predators, drug peddlers, prostitutes, and pimps) and their “formidable physicality” result in a fearful social impact on police officers (dangerous, hostile, angry, and impulsive). In a major review of the literature on racial bias and law enforcement, Hall et al. (2016) summarized their findings:

1. Dangerousness, violence, and criminality for African Americans seem intimately linked to one another and could explain why young Black men are 21 times more likely to be killed than their white male counterparts by the police. In computer simulations, unarmed Black suspects are more likely to be shot at than their white counterparts; police are also quicker to shoot at an armed Black suspect than a white suspect.
2. It has been found that African American youths are estimated to be older or “more adult-like” than white youngsters. When unarmed

African American Tamir Rice (12-year-old child) was killed by a white male police officer within seconds of their encounter, he estimated Rice to be 20 years old. Mistaking Black youngsters to be adults predisposes police to use greater force, especially if they believe they are in danger.

3. African Americans are often perceived as being subhuman. This originates from historical beliefs that Africans and Black Americans are at lower stages of evolution and are more subhuman, ape-like, and animalistic. Not only does this contribute to the dehumanizing of African Americans, but it also allows officers to see them as "other beings" and be more likely to behave toward them in a punitive manner without guilt or remorse.
4. There is a common belief and fear of African Americans as superhuman in strength, physically formidable, and intimidating (especially Black males), with *higher pain thresholds*. During slavery, Blacks were believed to exemplify a psychiatric condition known as "Dysaesthesia Ethiopica" (Cartwright, 1851), which was defined as being indifferent and insensible to pain and punishment; it required severe punishment and frequent whippings to control and motivate them to work. This historical belief may explain the use of extreme physical force (excessive or deadly force) to subdue Black suspects in law enforcement. Some have also argued that such a belief may also account for why medical doctors frequently fail to prescribe pain medication to African American as opposed to white patients (Hoffman et al., 2016).

What implications can we derive from the George Floyd murder, law enforcement, and its impact on bystanders to a racially motivated incident? In many respects, some of the characteristics of police culture (isolation, in-group loyalty, and secrecy) are a microcosm of our society. As such, it also becomes prone to inheriting, manufacturing, perpetuating, and reinforcing racial bias and discrimination, especially as it relates to bystander failure to help (Dovidio et al., 2002).

Isolation and Segregation

It is clear that our society remains quite segregated, and US neighborhoods are more so than a generation ago (Menendian, 2021). Racial residential segregation determines the quality of schools that children attend, safety in streets, law enforcement surveillance, economic opportunities, and accumulation of wealth. Most POC experience isolation from higher-level mainstream opportunities, which confines them to housing discrimination, economic discrimination, high maternal mortality rates, greater chance of incarceration, lower educational opportunities, and high unemployment rates (Menendian, 2021). The exclusion from mainstream culture has a detrimental effect not only upon POC but upon white Americans as well. It denies them interracial contact, the opportunity to interact and get to know them as "real people" with feelings, hopes, and aspirations; it allows them to form stereotypic images of POC from biased second-hand information and/or falsehoods presented in the mass media; and it diminishes *empathy, sympathy, and compassion* toward POC (Sue, 2003). As we have indicated, these last three qualities seem central to bystander action.

Ethnocentric Loyalty and Allegiance

The police culture of *loyalty*, "we vs. them," and the in-group and out-group mentality is similar to *ethnocentric monoculturalism* in our society when applied to POC. Sue et al. (2023) have defined ethnocentric monoculturalism as composed of five interacting components: (a) a societal belief in the superiority of the dominant group's history, values, traditions, religion, language, physical appearance, and ways of being; (b) a belief in the inferiority of all other groups and their ways of life (POC); (c) the use of power (social, political, economic, etc.) to impose the dominant group's way of life upon all others; (d) the ethnocentric standards are manifested in all aspects of life (individual, institutional, and cultural systems); and (e) white Americans are socially conditioned so that the process is wrapped in an *invisible veil of secrecy* that operates outside the level of conscious awareness. Stereotypes, biases, racial hatred, fear of differences, and discriminatory behaviors are rendered invisible or disguised so that white naivete and innocence are protected (Sue, 2015). When white bystanders, for example, witness a racist incident directed toward a target, they may not

intervene because of their implicit beliefs that POC are less worthy of help and deserving of their "unfair" treatment.

Power and Authority

Power and authority are undeniable forces in determining the actions of others, and especially bystander behaviors. In general, we usually associate power with military might, economic might, or political might. An imbalance of power, as in the case of officer Chauvin, can lead to an abuse of power, whereby other officers were hesitant to intercede and where civilian onlookers were fearful to help. It was indicated in Chapter 1, for example, that the current political climate is replete with politicians and leaders who model racist behaviors and blatantly seem to condone racist language and actions. As a result, our society has experienced an increase in bias, bigotry, and racism. On a more interpersonal level, however, Sue (2003, p. 103) defines power as *the ability to act on the needs, desires, beliefs, and values of one entity in order to influence, control, and define the existence of another*. Thus, those whose racial characteristics deviate from the dominant group, whose lifestyles are not considered desirable, and whose behaviors are deemed inappropriate experience forced compliance. The power to impose is strengthened through making the operation hidden, covert, or disguised in such a way as to facilitate compliance, conformity, and obedience in the general population. As indicated in an earlier chapter, true power is the ability to define reality: POC are lesser human beings and deserving of the discriminatory treatments they receive. Thus, when a racist incident occurs, bystanders may not notice the biased meaning of the treatment, assume that the person is deserving of the behavior (victim-blame), or conform to the groups non-action norms.

Silence and Secrecy

Secrecy and the "blue wall of silence" in police culture are similar to what Sue (2015) has labeled "a conspiracy of silence" when matters of race, racism, whiteness, and white privilege arise in the larger society. The history of the United States has been the history of racism directed toward POC, an unacknowledged secret that is ignored, diluted, or distorted to salve the collective conscience of white America (American Psychological Association, 2012; Bell, 2002). Children are taught that we live in a society

that teaches us a belief in meritocracy, that anyone can succeed if they work hard enough, that this is a land of opportunity, and that racism is a thing of the past (Bonilla-Silva, 2021). We are indoctrinated to believe that race is unimportant, that we are all human beings, and that we should be a color-blind nation (Bell, 2003; Sue, 2015).

In the current political climate, book banning, censorship, and outlawing of DEI programs and language are examples of attempting to control the knowledge and content of race and racism, to deny that racism exists, and *to absolve white Americans from the responsibility of confronting individual and institutional bias* (Nishimura et al., 2024; Pen America, 2024). In a one-year period from 2023 to 2024 the highest banning of books occurred, where an overwhelming number dealt with race, racism, and LGBTQ+ characters or topics (Pen America, 2024). The backlash against DEI programs arose as a reaction to the murder of George Floyd and the emergence of the Black Lives Matter movement. As of 2023, over a dozen state legislatures have passed bills reining in D.E.I. programs in colleges and universities (Nishimura et al., 2024). Rewriting history by leaving out race and racism, implementing societal norms that limit discussions of race, and encouraging strategic color-blindness tend to allow white Americans to pretend that racism does not exist (Bell, 2003; Bonilla-Silva, 2021; Loewen, 2018). The overall result is bystanders who lack critical consciousness of racism and its manifestations.

Everyday Racism and Microaggressions: Impact on Bystanders

In the Genevese and Floyd murder cases, the despicable actions of the perpetrators, the undeserved suffering of the targets, and their need for help were relatively clear and obvious. It is more debatable and less clear-cut, however, whether Floyd was profiled and whether race played any role in (a) the use of excessive force, (b) the failure of other officers to stop Chauvin, and (c) the inexcusable lapse in providing first aid once he stopped breathing. Blatant and overt forms of racism are more easily recognized, and most bystanders would condemn their expression as appalling, loathsome, and unacceptable, especially hate crimes. Except for hesitations, ambivalence, and apprehensions about intervening that arise

from our knowledge of social influence theory, the need for action in both cases is quite obvious.

In the case of microaggressions (everyday racial indignities, slights, insults, and invalidations expressed publicly toward POC), their expressions are often subtle, indirect, and covert in nature (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). Everyday racism, or "casual racism," are terms used to describe discriminatory behaviors or biased statements at an interpersonal level; they vary on a continuum from being blatant (racial epithets and obvious discrimination) to being subtle, ambiguous, and elusive. Everyday racism in the form of microaggressions is a common expression among the general populace and is inculcated into our daily dialogues with one another, considered normal banter or actions in the form of racist jokes, racial innuendo, and negative body language (Dovidio et al., 2002; Sue & Spanierman, 2020). Perpetrators of microaggressions may be unaware of the demeaning nature of their statements or actions, but they do not go unnoticed by targets, who are often pained and left confused about how to respond. The everyday expressions of bias, prejudice, and discrimination can occur in many situations: between coworkers and students, among neighbors or strangers, in traditional or social media, between supervisors and supervisees, between teachers and students, at neighborhood gatherings, at social events, on formal and informal occasions, and so on. Some common examples are the following.

Microaggressive behaviors from perpetrator (white) to target (POC):

> You're pretty for a Black girl.
>
> You speak excellent English (to 3rd generation Chinese American)
>
> Those people (Latinx) have a poor work ethic.
>
> (Jokingly) What are you carrying in your backpack, a bomb? (to Muslim friend).
>
> When a Black man enters elevator, a white female passenger stiffens up, clutches her purse tightly and moves away.
>
> A white employee proceeds to tell a racist joke to co-workers.

As we have shown in past chapters, these everyday and common microaggressions experienced by POC are demeaning and offensive and

often result in racial battle fatigue. Although they may appear harmless, their impact can take a toll on the well-being of targets but may result in any number of inequitable outcomes in education and employment. Bystanders and allies who witness these encounters are in a position to disarm and neutralize their expressions and impact. For those bystanders who lack critical consciousness of a racist transgression, however, they may simply not respond, thereby reinforcing the behaviors of the perpetrator and communicating to other bystanders that such comments and behaviors are acceptable. Even onlookers who are aware of the biased nature of the remarks may fail to respond because of the bystander effect and/or a lack of knowing what to do. We will address this issue later in Chapter 7. For now, we turn to how race may influence bystander actions.

Race and Bystander Action

Early psychological research and work on bystander inaction and intervention did not focus on issues of race, racism, and anti-bias actions (Personette, 2023). Rather, the focus was on the silence and apathy of bystanders in the face of non-racial emergency situations (Darley & Latane, 1968) and/or on witnessing sexual harassment/assaults, criminal acts, child abuse, public intoxication, domestic violence, suicide clues, and unsafe behaviors or situations. Although the "bystander effect" has become a bedrock principle of explaining inaction, its unmitigated use to explain failure to act conflates other factors that inhibit or facilitate action. Interventions are affected by the personal and social costs of actions (Rasinski & Czopp, 2010; Rasinski et al., 2013), whether retaliation or negative consequences are present (Sue et al., 2021), whether it is an emergency or non-emergency situation (Darley & Latane, 1970), the degree of ambiguity of the event (Fischer et al., 2011), the relationship of the bystander to those needing help (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2014), target and bystander attributes (Dvoskin et al., 2023), cultural dictates and norms (Staub, 2023), and even whether a bystander is a young child or an adult (Murrell, 2020).

One of the most powerful explanatory variables of bystander action/inaction is when "race" enters the equation (Dovidio et al., 2002). Testing the concept of aversive racism, investigators set up an experimental situation in which a confederate faked being an injured motorist (either Black or White)

in a disabled car. They created two conditions: (a) one in which passing drivers believed they were the only witnesses, and (b) one in which drivers believed that many others saw the same situation. In the first condition, the investigators found that 80% of the time offers to help were equal for both the white and Black motorists. In the latter condition, however, offers of help for the Black victim were 38%, while for the White victim, they were 75%. In other words, passing motorists were twice as likely not to offer aid to the Black Confederate than the white one. The implications are frightening: If the situation was a real life-threatening one, the Black driver would be twice as likely to die as the white driver! From earlier findings of the bystander effect (diffusion of responsibility or any of the other social influence explanations), one would have predicted that there would be no difference in rates of help, that passing motorists would have offered help equally, but it was only the Black motorist who lacked significant offers of help. Did race play a role in the decision not to help?

Aversive racism theory asserts that unconscious bias, a person's belief that they are truly non-racist, and helping behaviors are intertwined with one another. Dovidio et al. (2002) reasoned that “unintentional racists,” those who hold a self-image of themselves as good, moral, and decent human beings, who publicly denounce racism, and who honestly believe they are free of bias and racism, are unlikely to discriminate against POC when appropriate behavior is clear and unambiguous and where right or wrong is well-defined. In situations that are ambiguous or when other reasons can be given for discriminatory actions, unintentional bias is likely to come forth. For example, in the second condition, White bystanders who failed to help offered many different reasons for their inaction (i.e., they assumed others had already summoned help, or they planned to call when they got to their offices). If these reasons were valid, however, why did White bystanders continue to offer help to White motorists at such a high rate? The investigators concluded that unconscious bias is most likely to (a) manifest itself as a failure to help, rather than a desire to hurt; (b) emerge in ambiguous situations where right or wrong behavior is not clear; and (c) allow witnesses alternative explanations that rationalize away their inaction. Since microaggressions tend often to be ambiguous and unclear, it offers a major reason for inaction by targets, allies, and bystanders. These findings suggest that bystander interventions in cases where race and racism are

involved are affected by unconscious racial bias and the race of the bystander and target.

The groundbreaking studies on aversive racism and failure to help have been instrumental in opening up the floodgates to exploring race and racism as factors to consider in bystander behaviors (Dovidio, 1984; Dovidio et al., 2002; Gaertner et al., 1982). Some other findings of importance are outlined below, when the bystander is white and the target is African American.

1. Bystander help or interventions are less likely to occur when opportunities exist to rationalize away their inaction through using justifiable reasons that have nothing to do with race. Rationalizations that cover up racial bias are most frequently seen in pressing events that are unclear and/or ambiguous (Dovidio, 1984; Saucier et al., 2005).
2. Bystanders are less likely to help when they have no face-to-face contact with targets. When they witness a transgression or emergency from a distance and are personally removed and anonymous, the greater the likelihood they are to withhold aid (Saucier et al., 2005).
3. In high-level and severe emergency situations, it has been found that bystanders are more prone to discriminate and offer less help (Saucier et al., 2005). It has been hypothesized that intense emergency situations increase emotive reactions and cognitive load in bystanders, thereby inhibiting conscious control of biases. Other explanations involve (a) perceiving the Black victim dilemma as less severe than the white victim, and (b) high emergency situations may require prolonged interracial contact, thus disincentivizing helping (Personette, 2023).
4. The race of perpetrators and targets or their dyadic combinations can influence bystander action. This is especially true whether the aggressor is white or a POC (Personette, 2023). Differences exist in interventions when the situation involves a white bystander and a white perpetrator as opposed to a situation where the perpetrator is a POC.
5. Finally, it is important to note that almost all studies on the role that race plays in bystander decisions to help or intervene are with African American targets and not on other POC (Xie & Galliher, 2022). It

remains to be seen whether these findings can be generalized to Asian Americans, Latinx Americans, Native Americans, and MENA groups.

Racial Consideration in Activating Bystanders

Recently, bystander intervention in the face of microaggressions directed toward POC has become an urgent call and a focus of numerous studies (Andrade et al., 2023; Awad & Connors, 2023; Haynes-Baratz et al., 2021; Kurtz & Tucker, 2023; Manohar & Kline, 2023; Murrell, 2020). Many of the approaches follow Latane and Darley's (1970) bystander intervention model for activating citizens to take responsible action. The five necessary steps for overcoming inaction are (a) notice the event, (b) perceive it as an emergency, (c) decide to take responsibility, (d) determine what action is required, and (e) take action. Although the model has proven helpful to bystander intervention training, it must be noted that its application to race-related situations may make it qualitatively and quantitatively different.

Inaction in addressing incidents of racism is filled with terms such as “omission bias,” “collusion,” and “conspiracy” (Andrade et al., 2023; Braun, 2000; Sue, 2015). The term “collusion,” for example, refers to discriminatory racist situations where there is an unspoken agreement between individual parties (i.e., perpetrators, bystanders, and allies) and existing systems of oppression to remain silent, to withhold help, and to maintain the status quo (power and privilege) against POC (Andrade et al., 2023). Through socialization and cultural conditioning, cooperation with current systems of racial oppression occurs consciously and unconsciously, where bystander permissiveness toward bias is encouraged and denial of bias and racism rewarded, all for the purpose of maintaining naiveté and innocence and avoiding guilt (Braun, 2000). Thus, although the stages of bystander activation appear logical and straightforward, racial factors and bias may strongly influence the outcome. The CPR proposed by Ashburn-Nardo et al. (2008, Ashburn-Nardo & Karim, 2019) integrates unique features and challenges posed to bystanders when confronting incidents of bias, prejudice, and discrimination. We outline how racial factors affect each juncture in the decision-making process faced by bystanders in appraising and taking action.

***Stage 1—Notice the Incident, Event, or Emergency*.** In most emergency situations (e.g., fire, car accident, assault, or other dangerous situations), the pressing nature for some form of intervention is more obvious and clear-cut than incidents of unintentional bias often disguised as how people normally behave or in the case of organizations, standard operating procedures (Sue, 2015). Besides the difficulty of recognizing a racial transgression, the problem is compounded by some who look away, evade acknowledging the situation, and actively avoid knowing what is happening (Staub, 2023). It has been noted, for example, that some bystanders will avoid eye contact with a target or victim, move away or cross the street, and behave as if nothing out of the ordinary has occurred. Two factors seem to be operative here: (a) an actual inability to notice bias and (b) pretending not to notice a discriminatory incident (i.e., willful ignorance). Helping bystanders to notice and recognize racial microaggressions would seem to be different in both cases. In the former, helping bystanders recognize prejudice, discrimination, and stereotyping is the main goal. This is where bystander intervention training must contain a racial awareness component and aid trainees in developing critical consciousness. In the case of willful ignorance, the factors that lead to this phenomenon must be addressed. Are the avoidance behaviors due to bystanders' own deep-seated racial biases or the operation of social influence explanations (cost/reward dilemma, evaluation apprehension, diffusion of responsibility, etc.)? Again, solutions to inaction may vary depending upon the reasons.

***Stage 2—Interpret the Situation as a Racial Transgression*.** Noticing an unusual remark or action is not necessarily perceiving it as unjust and requiring intervention. The bystander must have the ability to decipher the hidden implicit meaning of racist behaviors and to interpret them as unjust and harmful to the target. We have already discussed how many perceive microaggressions as insignificant, harmless, trivial, innocuous acts, and/or disguised in ways that mask their racist meanings. Interventions do not occur when bystanders perceive discriminatory racist events as non-racist in nature or when the harm they perceive to targets is negligible (i.e., unworthy of comment or intervention). Indeed, bystanders who hold this view may perceive the challenges or reactions from targets as an overreaction,

oversensitivity to slights, inability to take a joke, paranoid, or attribute victim-blaming characteristics to the target (e.g., “angry Black man or woman”). Relying on what others do or say may lead to a false consensus or a mistaken interpretation of the problematic situation (social proof), especially when other bystanders do nothing and communicate no action is required. Being aware of how the behavior of others may affect the definition of the problem may act as a counterbalance to misinterpretations. Again, as we have repeatedly emphasized, critical consciousness, or the ability to understand how racism is embedded in individuals, institutions, and our society, is important.

***Stage 3—Accept and Take Responsibility*.** In most non-racial emergency situations bystanders are lauded by others and reinforced by our society for taking responsible action. An individual who rushes in to save a drowning swimmer, a person who stops a sexual assault, a stranger who helps deliver a baby in public, and a citizen who delivers first aid to a heart attack victim are societally sanctioned actions. Indeed, those who take responsibility to act are often rewarded for their actions and called “heroes” or good Samaritans. Except for extreme cases of overt racism (i.e., hate crimes), bystanders may be averse to taking responsibility because they may feel unprepared or powerless to take action, fearful of becoming involved in explosive racial issues, and perceive anti-racist interventions as not socially sanctioned or approved by others. Challenging a racist comment or remark disrupts group harmony, makes others uncomfortable, and frequently leads to isolation from one's own group and that of society (Williams et al., 2023). In most cases, taking individual responsibility may feel like a lonely affair, especially when others remain inactive and seemingly unconcerned. Williams et al. (2023) have coined the term “civil courage” to refer to individuals who are aware of the negative consequences of challenging individual and systemic racism but persist in their efforts. They suggest that aligning personal values and intentions with action is vital to combat racial injustice. The authors outline a number of behavioral prescriptions that increase civil courage: create a friendship support network, assess one's own racial identity, expose oneself to different racial groups, challenge the status

quo, etc. All of these activities increase caring, empowerment, and a deep sense of obligation and responsibility to the welfare of others.

Stage 4—Determine What Action Is Required. Ascertaining proper and correct action poses a major problem, not only for bystanders but for targets and allies as well. In most non-racial emergency situations, the appropriate and proper responses are clearer, although other factors may prevent or inhibit action. In the case of implicit bias or microaggressions, however, the paralysis of not knowing what to do (i.e., "freeze effect") may be quite pronounced (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Sue et al., 2009). In these cases, it may not be so much an avoidance of responsible action, but that the bystander simply does not know what anti-bias actions to take. In the opening scenario, where a racist joke is being told, the admonition to "say something" or "do something" is insufficient to generate effective action. Simply recognizing a racist transgression is inadequate when bystanders lack the antiracist intervention skills in their behavioral repertoire. A number of researchers and practitioners have provided actions that bystanders can take to disarm microaggressions (Awad & Connors, 2023; Scully & Rowe, 2009). Hollaback (2017) proposes the 5 D's to bystander intervention: Distract (interrupt and sidetrack), Delegate (ask a third party for help), Document (take notes or record the event), Delay (check with the target, offer support), and Direct (make known your disapproval and stop the biased actions). We will have more to say about the different models proposed for bystander intervention in a future chapter, but suffice it to say that intervention tactics must not only be learned but also rehearsed and practiced so they become automatic. Microaggressions and discriminatory acts often occur so quickly that they are over by the time a bystander decides to take action.

Stage 5—Take Action to Challenge and to Call Out Racism. Knowing what action to take and how to disrupt and disarm racism does not guarantee that interventions will occur. Breaking the deadly dance of racism is filled with potential negative consequences and pushback in a society that desires to maintain the status quo (Andrade et al., 2023). Like targets, well-intentioned bystanders are fearful of retaliation for their social justice/advocacy actions, isolation from

peers for “rocking the boat,” being labeled a troublemaker or “white liberal,” and losing positions of influence and power (Sue et al., 2021). These punitive consequences are intended to keep those who might potentially challenge racism silent, thereby being complicit with the perpetuation of racism. In one study, Szekeres et al. (2023) found that bystanders with strong egalitarian values expressed high intent to confront prejudice when it occurred, but when placed in a real situation, they failed to act on their intentions. Disturbingly, high egalitarian values only predicted *hypothetical intention* to confront, but not *actual confrontation* of prejudice. The investigators also concluded that behavioral uncertainty along with fears of retaliation played a crucial role in increasing the discrepancy between intent to act and actual action.

CONCLUSIONS

Many have indicated that investing time and energy to overcome the hurdles to bystander intervention is a necessity, as it represents an untapped resource in disarming and neutralizing racism (Ashburn-Nardo & Karim, 2019; Nelson et al., 2011; Scully & Rowe, 2009). Some argue that bystanders are in a better position to intervene because confrontation from targets is often dismissed as defensiveness (Xie & Galliher, 2022). The benefits far outweigh the costs, especially when the interventions come from non-target individuals: (a) it shifts the unfair burden of ending racism from targets to others; (b) it represents an unexpected and immediate positive validation to POC; (c) it communicates displeasure from a source other than the target (oftentimes someone from the perpetrator's own group); (d) it models appropriate intervention behaviors to other onlookers; and (e) it forces the perpetrator to confront their own biases (Sue et al., 2021).

Our journey in exploring the bystander effect, social influence theories, and the racialization of bystander action or inaction provides many clues to motivating targets, allies, and bystanders to exhibit civil courage (Williams et al., 2023). Although a number of bystander intervention programs have been developed and implemented in training, many lack emphasis on the impact of race and racism on helping behaviors and interventions

(Personette, 2023). We propose that all bystander training programs and initiatives (a) incorporate how race impacts the actions of perpetrators, targets, allies, and bystanders; (b) promote self-awareness of implicit bias, racial identity, and intergroup racial influences; and (c) utilize exercises designed to explore, develop, and reinforce civil courage (Personette, 2023; Sue et al., 2019; Williams et al., 2023). We suggest that it is not enough to simply add a component of implicit bias training to bystander education, but we advocate merging anti-racism and bystander training into a unified whole. Race, culture and ethnicity are functions of everyone and permeate our interactions with one another. To not view bystander intervention from a racial lens is to maintain the illusion of whiteness, to neglect the lived reality of people of color, and to pretend that findings of bystander interventions are applicable to everyone regardless of race.

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CHAPTER FIVE
Barriers to Ally Awareness: A Call for Courage

Who are white racial justice allies, and how do they differ from white bystanders who do not intervene? In Chapter 4, we described a certain type of bystander (i.e., *an upstander*) who recognizes and takes action to disrupt racism (see American Psychological Association, 2022). In this chapter, we are concerned with consistent and committed upstanders, also referred to as white racial justice allies. Scholars and activists increasingly call for a shift from allyship to accompliceship or co-conspiratorship, arguing that *ally* often connotes passive support without risk (Ekpe & Toutant, 2022; Love, 2020). We use *ally* in its aspirational sense, recognizing that effective white racial justice work requires more than symbolic gestures—it demands accountability, risk-taking, and solidarity (Ore, 2021). More specifically, we draw from Spanierman and Smith's (2017a) review of the literature, which outlined aspirational characteristics of white racial justice allies:

- Demonstrate a nuanced ***understanding of structural racism*** and white privilege
- Enact a ***continual process of self-reflection*** about their positionality and privilege
- Experience a ***sense of responsibility*** to use their racial privilege to facilitate equity
- Engage in ***actions to disrupt individual and structural racism*** in their own communities
- Participate in coalitions and work in ***solidarity with POC***
- Encounter resistance, ***prepare for backlash***, and shore up resources to persist

The elements of this aspirational definition map onto our earlier discussion of developing critical consciousness in the Freirean sense, engaging in what can be a painful self-reckoning, and ultimately implementing anti-racist actions that transform systems. Below, we elaborate briefly on each of the aspirational characteristics of white racial justice allies. We also describe potential hazards of doing ally work, which could have antithetical outcomes and perpetuate racism. These barriers can be understood as choreographed moves in a larger dance that maintains racial dominance. Performative gestures, paternalism, fragility, overidentification, and saviorism are not random missteps; they are patterned,

repeated movements that keep the deadly dance of racism in motion. Recognizing these steps, and committing to disrupt them consistently, allows allies to break the rhythm, disrupt the flow, and co-create new movements of racial justice and solidarity. Additionally, we describe white people's motivations for ally work and link them to POC perspectives on what effective and sustained racial justice ally work looks like. Finally, we discuss structural and emotional barriers to white ally efforts, as well as address why white allies are often hesitant to act. We conclude the chapter with strategies for how to be an effective, sustained white ally, changing the script and thus breaking the dance of racism.

ASPIRATIONAL CHARACTERISTICS OF WHITE ALLIES

Demonstrate a Nuanced Understanding of Structural Racism and White Privilege

White racial justice allies move beyond simplistic notions of racism as individual acts of meanness or overt bigotry. Instead, they cultivate a sophisticated and systemic understanding of how racism operates at multiple levels: individual, institutional, structural, and cultural. This includes recognizing how White privilege is embedded in everyday interactions, organizational policies, and national narratives. True racial justice allies grasp that structural racism is not merely a remnant of the past but an ongoing system that harms people of color (POC) materially, symbolically, and socially, while continuing to advantage White people—often invisibly. They understand that their social position grants them access, credibility, and safety in ways that POC are routinely denied, and they use this understanding to interrogate the status quo, not defend it.

Enact a Continual Process of Self-Reflection About Their Positionality and Privilege

A key marker of allyship is a sustained commitment to self-interrogation. White allies must not only identify their racial privileges but continuously examine how those privileges shape their assumptions, behaviors, and blind spots. This self-reflexivity is not a one-time reckoning. Rather, it is a lifelong practice of disrupting internalized dominance, resisting the lure of White innocence, and remaining vigilant against complacency. Effective allies recognize that they were socialized into systems that reward Whiteness, and they commit to unlearning these scripts through reading, listening, relationship-building, and deep personal work. Importantly, this reflection does not happen in isolation; it is enriched

through accountability to communities of color and peer dialogue with other White people engaging in antiracist work.

Experience a Sense of Responsibility to Use Their Racial Privilege to Facilitate Equity

White racial justice allies understand that awareness alone is insufficient; with awareness must come responsibility. This sense of responsibility is not about rescuing or leading POC. It is about leveraging privilege to dismantle the very systems that created the imbalance in the first place. As Dixon White (the public persona of Jorge Moran), a self-described “redneck” and racial justice activist, put it, white racial responsibility begins with acknowledging the hard truth of one's own cultural conditioning and privilege. In his *Introduction to White Racial Responsibility*, White outlined six steps that guide white people from this initial reckoning toward meaningful engagement. True allyship, he emphasized, requires moral courage: the willingness to face the painful realities of race, self, and society, and to use one's privilege not to dominate but to challenge the very system that confers it.

Engage in Actions to Disrupt Individual and Structural Racism in Their Own Communities

Allyship is not abstract. It is local, embodied, and visible. White allies take action where they have the most influence—whether in family conversations, neighborhood associations, workplace decisions, or voting behaviors. They understood that while large-scale policy change is crucial, everyday racism is often sustained through the unchallenged habits, assumptions, and silences of “ordinary” White people. Importantly, effective white allies recognize that this responsibility is enacted not for applause or affirmation, but because maintaining silence or neutrality in the face of racism is an act of complicity. In practice, this means using one's voice in rooms where POC are absent, redirecting opportunities to more marginalized colleagues, and naming inequity even when it's uncomfortable or costly. These actions may seem small or even go unnoticed, but their cumulative impact can disrupt the continuity of racism in white-dominant spaces.

Participate in Coalitions and Work in Solidarity with POC

White racial justice allies do not view themselves as the center of racial justice work. Instead, they understand that meaningful change is built through relationships, collaboration, and sustained solidarity with POC-led movements. True solidarity means stepping back when necessary, listening deeply, and

accepting that their analysis will always be partial without the lived experiences of POC. It also means honoring boundaries, being accountable, and learning from criticism without retreating. Allies recognize that their presence in coalition spaces is not inherently helpful unless they bring humility, consistency, and a willingness to follow.

Encounter Resistance, Prepare for Backlash, and Shore Up Resources to Persist

Allyship is not safe work. It invites discomfort, alienation, and resistance—especially from other white people. Allies may be labeled "divisive," accused of "virtue signaling," or dismissed by family, colleagues, or institutional leadership. Rather than be deterred, committed allies anticipate these challenges and proactively cultivate support systems to sustain their work. This includes peer accountability groups, mentorship, spiritual practices, or grounding in a community of purpose. They draw strength not from being seen as "good White people," but from a fierce alignment with justice. They understand that the backlash they face is a pale shadow of what POC endure, and they stay in the work anyway.

POTENTIAL HAZARDS OF WHITE ALLYSHIP: REINFORCING THE STATUS QUO

Scholars (Droogendyk et al., 2016; Hernández, 2020; Kutlaca & Radke, 2023; Patton & Bondi, 2015; Spanierman & Smith, 2017a) and activists (Simon, 2023; White Woman Whisperer, 2021) alike have emphasized the potential hazards of white ally work that reflects more of a transitory performance than a consistent or lasting commitment to racial justice and that may even do harm to communities of color. Below, we address the nuanced nature of white ally work by noting some of the more common hazards. In particular, we discuss the superficial nature of ally work, the tendency to seek recognition and to center oneself in the work, the prevalence of paternalistic attitudes, and the inclination to overidentify with POC.

Engaging in Superficial and Performative Gestures

A predictable hazard of white ally work is participating in a superficial or provisional manner with greater concern for how one appears than for contributing to efforts that promote equity. Like businesses who display Black Lives Matter signs as a marketing tool, individuals can do the same sort of self-marketing (Metta, 2020). Social media presents one such context where individuals can

display a curated version of themselves they want others to see. For example, posting a black square on Instagram as an act of solidarity during Blackout Tuesday might represent superficial digital allyship if the individual does not also engage in ally behaviors in their personal and professional spheres (e.g., holds themselves accountable and acts in ways that promote equity in "real life"). In a study among 20 social media influencers—a racially diverse group of women—Wellman (2022) found that, for many, they perceived posting the black squares as performative allyship used to build and maintain credibility with followers. Specifically, influencers of color perceived white influencers' postings as performative when they only shared others' posts without creating their own content or when they did not personally engage with the content they were sharing. As Kalina (2020) contended, "We cannot simply care about racism or anti-Semitism when it is convenient, when it is 'in the moment' or when it is trending …" (p. 478).

Superficial ally gestures in digital and non-digital (i.e., real-life) spaces might be related to seeking recognition or kudos for one's self-proclaimed ally efforts, which has been referred to as performative activism or performative allyship (Amponsah & Stephen, 2020). Performative allyship often involves virtue signaling—an attempt to show others that one is good, moral, socially conscious, "woke," or even that one is better than other white people. Instead of focusing on social change, performative allyship tends to center the personal gratification of the self-proclaimed ally. While performative allyship oftentimes is motivated by a desire to be perceived as concerned and compassionate, we remind readers that "true activism values results over recognition" (Holda, 2023). Aspiring white allies must avoid the trap of seeking recognition and instead focus their efforts on disrupting everyday racism and ultimately transforming systems of white dominance, such as addressing inequities in education, health care, and the justice system.

Acting Paternalistically

Another common hazard of racial justice ally work involves acting paternalistically in ways that subtly signal white superiority. Paternalistic ally behavior often is linked to the white savior trope, wherein a white person swoops in to rescue and care for a person of color who otherwise would not succeed (e.g., Sandra Bullock's award-winning portrayal of Leigh Anne Tuohy in the motion picture *The Blind Side*). Movies such as *The Blind Side*, *Dances with Wolves*, and *Freedom Writers* center the white characters, such as Leigh Anne Tuohy, as the catalysts for change and downplay the voices and strengths of POC. Moreover, these films tend to be highly acclaimed because they make white people feel good

about themselves and deny the harsh realities of systemic racism. Even amid the best of intentions and feel-good responses among white people, paternalism sends implicit and explicit messages that POC are dumb, misguided, and/or incapable of taking care of themselves.

Another example of white paternalism is service learning, in which university students (often middle-class) go to low-income communities of color to provide some sort of community project (e.g., restoring a public park). Although service-learning has the potential to make a positive impact on communities, it also has the potential to reinscribe power differentials. In one of our studies (Houshmand et al., 2014), students expected to be appreciated as “do-gooders” who will “fix” the community (p. 38). Furthermore, students and others who provide community service can be guided by a missionary ideology, imposing their approach on the community rather than allowing the community to guide the process and define success on its own terms.

Yet another example of paternalism is a self-proclaimed white ally who attempts to usurp POC leadership at a protest, rather than playing a supportive role as a partner committed to fighting racial injustice. Speaking to this form of paternalism, racial justice educator and founding director of Allies for Change Melanie Morrison (2013) explained:

> If we charge ahead, eager to impose our solutions and interventions, we replicate old patterns of missionary zeal as we plant our ally flag and run the risk of jeopardizing those we are presuming to ‘help.’ Our work as allies must always and everywhere be grounded in humility, collaboration, and accountability. This means becoming engaged in organizations led by people of color, respecting the priorities they identify as strategies for change, and sustaining our engagement over time. It also means learning about the ways people of color have resisted racism long before we arrived on the scene.

Despite the best of intentions, a paternalistic approach reinforces the deficit model (i.e., the idea that POC's struggles are due to their own shortcomings as opposed to structural barriers), suggests POC need white people's help or charity to succeed, maintains the status quo, and does little to transform systems.

Overidentifying with People of Color

Yet another potential hazard for aspiring white allies is overidentifying with POC and assuming one can fully understand their experiences with racism, perhaps due to experiences with other forms of oppression (e.g., sexism). While it is possible one form of oppression can help a white person empathize with other forms of oppression, this is a nuanced and complicated process. For instance, some studies

have found evidence that greater experiences with heterosexism among gay and lesbian people are associated with more positive racial attitudes (Kleiman et al., 2015). However, overidentifying involves assumptions of equivalence that negate POC's lived experiences. Instead of having the intended effects of empathizing and connecting, overidentifying tends to invalidate and create distance. For example, when a white woman assumes that she understands her Asian American colleague's experiences with racism during the COVID pandemic because she herself has had experiences with sexism, she ostensibly invalidates her colleague's experiences and shuts down the conversation. Overidentifying is particularly relevant for helping professionals, such as social workers and counselors. In cases where they overidentify with their clients of color, they may inadvertently negate their experiences, deliver racial microaggressions, and impede the working relationship.

Performative Allyship as a Starting Point?

While we acknowledge the potential hazards of white racial justice allyship and share common critiques of performative efforts, we also recognize how some such performances could be a first step into genuine activism. First, it is important to keep in mind the developmental process of becoming an ally is incremental (Reason et al., 2005). Second, we have no way of knowing the true motivations underlying someone's actions. Third, by calling out or canceling potential allies rather than calling them in for deeper self-exploration, accountability, and solidarity, we are doing the work of white supremacy. In other words, we may be dismissing white folks who have good intentions but lack the requisite knowledge, self-awareness, and other tools to move from superficial efforts to deeper, more meaningful work to disrupt racism. In a study among 10 white participants committed to antiracist action, Malott et al. (2019) found that confronting other white people with “the attitude of shaming or morality” often backfired and resulted in counterproductive exchanges (p. 90). Instead, as we suggest later in this chapter, role models could help aspiring white allies lessen their defensiveness, listen to POC's experiences, cultivate empathy and compassion, acquire intervention strategies, and commit to a lifelong journey of supporting racial justice. The choice between calling out and calling in reflects broader strategic decisions about how white individuals can engage in antiracist work. We explore these decisions further when we discuss strategies for effective allyship.

MOTIVATIONS FOR ALLY WORK

What motivates white people's racial justice efforts, and how do they sustain their commitments? In the social psychological literature, researchers distinguish

between internal and external motivations for ally work. Like the performative allyship we described above, external motivation involves wanting to appear a certain way to others (e.g., appear as unbiased, good moral, and decent) or seeking to meet one's own needs (Radke et al., 2020). In a series of studies, Burns and Granz (2023) found that white ally motives often are ambiguous to Black perceivers. Although Black participants desire and value meaningful white ally engagement, such engagement could appear insincere and externally motivated. Given the centuries of unfair and unjust treatment of POC at the hands of white people, suspicion of white people's ally motives is completely understandable. In the next section, we take a deeper dive into POC perceptions of white racial justice allies.

In contrast to externally motivated ally efforts, internal motivation refers to sincere efforts to promote fairness, equity, and justice. Radke et al. (2020) provided a more nuanced categorization, referring to both out-group-focused motivations (i.e., genuine interest in addressing disparities to improve the status of marginalized groups) and morality motivations (i.e., driven by moral beliefs and an imperative to respond). Some white people experience a moral imperative to promote fairness and affirm humanity (Sabucedo et al., 2018; Williams et al., 2023). These white racial justice allies recognize they may be less likely than their counterparts of color to be accused of having a chip on their shoulder or supporting a personal agenda (Spanierman et al., 2017). Subsequently, they might receive fewer negative consequences than POC and may be more effective at reaching other white people in the fight against racial injustice (Xie & Galliher, 2023). Not surprisingly, Chu and Ashburn-Nardo (2022) found that white ally interventions driven by personal values and morals were perceived as less suspicious than those driven by image concerns. In their study, internal, as opposed to external, motivation for ally efforts played an important role in the well-being of Black perceivers.

Childhood and Family Background

What are the origins of sincere interest and ally commitments? What are the critical incidents in white people's lives that propel them to action? While there are no decisive answers to these questions, several studies point to a range of experiences and turning points in white people's lives that foster internal motivation toward racial justice. Across qualitative interview studies among white antiracist allies (Smith & Redington, 2010), white scholars of multicultural psychology (Spanierman et al., 2017), and white university students (Goldie et al., 2024; Munin & Speight, 2010), participants reported the influence of their childhood and family background on their support for racial justice. Interestingly,

being raised in either a progressive home or a racist home stood out among participants' experiences. The former instilled values of equity and justice, whereas the latter “led them to rebel against racism in their own lives” (Smith & Redington, 2010, p. 544). Some participants remarked on the social justice orientation of their families' religious congregations (e.g., Quaker) and identified clergy as early role models. They also mentioned how playing on sports teams with POC and interacting literally on an equal playing field provided opportunities for meaningful relationships that served as the impetus for their interest in racial justice.

Several participants made connections between racism and their own experiences with childhood victimization or bullying based on their social group identities (e.g., growing up in a poor family living in trailers and garages). They also described experiences of being the “other” as an important part of their development as an ally (Munin & Speight, 2010, p. 258). Some participants reported how intergenerational trauma, such as having family members who survived the Holocaust, sensitized them to different forms of oppression. Such experiences helped them understand the day-to-day and long-term harmful effects of oppression.

Participants also spoke of being influenced by human rights movements of the 1960s and 1970s such that their lives became grounded in principles of equity, justice, and radical feminism. Time will tell whether the racial reckoning sparked by George Floyd's murder in May 2020 will generate similarly lasting commitments to racial justice in some white individuals. However, the recent political and institutional backlash against DEI efforts casts uncertainty on the durability of these commitments, highlighting the need for sustained advocacy and vigilance in the pursuit of racial justice.

Critical Incidents or Turning Points

In addition to their childhood experiences, participants across several qualitative studies mentioned critical incidents—or turning points in their lives—that sparked their interest and commitments to racial justice. In a widely used model of white racial identity development, Helms (1995) referred to these critical incidents as dissonance-inducing events that put a spotlight on racial disparities in a way one had not considered earlier. In one of our studies, for example, a white professor explained how witnessing racism toward young scholars of color being denied tenure motivated his activism in appeals processes (Spanierman et al., 2017). Such qualitative findings are consistent with quantitative research in social psychology (Uluğ & Tropp, 2021). In a recent study among white protesters who marched in support of Black Lives Matter during the summer of 2020, participants reported

feeling “a sense of urgency to do something” after witnessing the callousness and brutality of George Floyd's murder on television (Spanierman et al., 2025 [manuscript in preparation]).

Other participants described their exposure to influential books, movies, or public figures (e.g., nationally acclaimed scholar on racial issues in America Dr. Beverly Tatum) (Smith & Redington, 2010). For example, one participant shared his reaction to reading the first edition of Sue's (1981) *Counseling the Culturally Different*: “[It] shook me to my core … I had no idea when I read the book that it would change my life” (Spanierman et al., 2017, p. 632). Many described the influence of their professors and university courses that addressed social justice, as well as the profound impact of antiracist training experiences (e.g., Smith & Redington, 2010). Among white women in an anti-racist discussion group, for instance, participants explained that white people must first come to terms with and admit their own racism before becoming an anti-racist ally (Case, 2012).

Participants with longstanding commitments to racial justice oftentimes discussed the importance of meaningful relationships with POC as both guiding their actions and encouraging them to persist when they felt defeated. One participant explained that he would not have been able to continue doing the work without the affirmation of his colleagues of color (Spanierman et al., 2017). Relatedly, in a quantitative study among more than 300 white ally activists, results showed a direct link between social support for their ally activities and degree of involvement in racial justice work, as well as well-being (Fingerhut & Hardy, 2020). Thus, it is not surprising that Reason et al. (2005) underscored the importance of training educators to assist white students through various points in their racial ally development journeys.

POC PERSPECTIVES OF WHITE RACIAL JUSTICE ALLIES

> The movement is for those who are truly fed up, who are tired, and who actually understand that radical change doesn't happen overnight. It is for dedicated individuals who want to create a world where their children no longer have to march for basic justice and equality. It is for those who want to be seen and heard in order to take active actions to reform the system. If this isn't you … understand that you were never right for the part of an ally in the first place
>
> (Kelley, 2020).

If the purpose of being a white ally is working in solidarity with POC to bring about social change, one way of distinguishing between performative and genuine white racial justice allyship is to ask POC what they perceive as effective allyship (e.g., Brown & Ostrove, 2013). In the above quotation, speaking to her theater colleagues shortly after George Floyd's murder, McKenna Kelley explained that POC do not want performative activism but rather want allies who will consistently take actions to transform the systems and structures that uphold racism.

In the studies we described above, we reviewed findings that underscore POC's justifiable suspicions of white people's motives for ally work (e.g., Burns & Granz, 2023). POC are not only sick and tired of racism, but they are also sick and tired of white people's performative efforts. They are sick and tired of explaining themselves in the hopes that aspiring allies will acknowledge POC perspectives and center POC experiences. Importantly, the literature also suggests white people's transparency and humility can serve as a sort of antidote to performative allyship. Wellman (2022) found that some white social media influencers posted black squares but struggled to create content about structural forms of racism like police brutality. When white influencers were transparent and shared their self-doubt about engaging in ally work, they were perceived by Black participants as more trustworthy. Ultimately, Black social media influencers said all they wanted was to know people cared about their well-being and that those beyond the Black community were invested in their livelihood and safety.

In a qualitative study focused on POC's perceptions of white allies, Hinger et al. (2023) identified central elements of committing fully to white racial justice allyship. While generally consistent with Spanierman and Smith's (2017a) literature review we presented at the beginning of this chapter, participants of color offered a nuanced conceptualization and several key insights. For example, they emphasized the need for critical self-awareness among white allies. POC wanted white allies not only to recognize white privilege but also to examine their motives for engaging in ally work (Hinger et al., 2023). Additionally, participants emphasized the need for white allies to build trust in their relationships with POC (see also Selvanathan et al., 2023). Building trust involves practicing empathy and compassion, as well as respecting POC's boundaries. Participants also expressed a desire for white allies to establish a balance between acknowledging a shared humanity and recognizing differences (Hinger et al., 2023). Recent research by Bayne et al. (2024) reinforced these priorities, emphasizing that BIPOC participants most valued white allies who demonstrated sustained commitment beyond moments of crisis and who engaged deeply with the personal discomfort required for meaningful change. Consistent across studies, part of relationship

building involves actively supporting Black leadership and engaging in supportive actions without dominating or taking over the efforts of Black people (e.g., Selvanathan et al., 2023).

Hinger et al. (2023) also highlighted the importance of accountability for effective allyship. POC want white allies who are receptive to their feedback and who will persevere in the work. They want allies to overcome their own defensiveness and white fragility. Additionally, POC called for white allies who are willing to sacrifice their own racial privilege (see also Mathew et al., 2023), including their physical safety. We are reminded of the moms in Portland, Oregon, during Black Lives Matter protests who physically placed themselves between police officers and protestors of color in an act of solidarity. Although imperfect due to controversy such that some Black members felt their voices were not valued, the wall of moms provides an example of sacrifice and risk-taking. A related theme that emerged in the literature was POC urging aspiring white allies to strive for continual self-improvement (e.g., Selvanathan et al., 2023). For example, they insisted white allies seek feedback and refine their approaches based on such feedback. POC also highlighted the importance of calling in other white people and engaging them in racial justice efforts (Hinger et al., 2023). They viewed genuine allyship as holding oneself accountable for continual self-improvement and at the same time holding other white people to higher standards of knowledge and action in support of racial justice.

In a conceptual piece, a pithy sort of letter addressed to “Dear White People,” Patton and Haynes (2020) outlined their perspectives as Black women for reimagining whiteness in the struggle for racial equity. They urged white readers to overcome their defensiveness and accept the authors' lived experiences as truths. Moreover, they reminded white readers that they cannot have it both ways —they cannot proclaim a commitment to racial justice and at the same time maintain white privilege and interests that undermine Black liberation. Their recommendations continue to underscore the importance of aligning allyship with deep accountability and relinquishing privilege.

WHITE ALLIES ARE FEW AND FAR BETWEEN (STRUCTURAL BARRIERS TO BECOMING AN ALLY)

Why are there so few white racial justice allies? This question is central to understanding the challenges of sustaining antiracist commitments. Due to centuries-long white racial socialization, generation after generation has been

enculturated to deny, distort, and minimize racism, embedding white supremacy into all aspects of US society. Fair-minded and justice-oriented white people are subjected to the same white racial socialization as perpetrators—namely, silence about racism and color-blind racial ideology (for a brief review of white racial socialization, see Spanierman, 2022a). As we outlined in Chapter 2, these socialization processes make it difficult for white people to understand the pervasive, insidious nature of structural racism and white privilege. McIntosh (1988) asserted that white people are taught intentionally not to see their racial privilege, instead believing their achievements arise solely from individual merit. As Kendi (2019) argued, the most dangerous racist policies are those disguised as neutral or invisible, requiring deliberate antiracist work to dismantle. In other words, there are both implicit and explicit systems in place that preserve the US racial hierarchy with whites at the top. Because recognizing one's racial privilege is a key pathway to becoming an ally (Case, 2012), these structural barriers carry significant consequences.

Given that white people tend to live in highly segregated neighborhoods, opportunities to interact with equal-status POC are rare, making it difficult for white people to build empathy and understanding of POC's lived experiences. Coalition-building, too, is uncommon. As we discussed in Chapter 2, white racial segregation is not accidental but a deliberate, systemic strategy designed to maintain social distance and protect white advantage. The phenomenon of white flight—popularized in the 1950s and 1960s to describe the mass exodus of white residents from racially and ethnically diverse urban centers—has persisted well into the present day. Researchers have documented ongoing patterns of white flight and resegregation in middle-class suburban neighborhoods (Kye, 2018). White self-segregation in neighborhoods and schools serves to maximize intergenerational wealth and privilege within white families, while simultaneously restricting POC's access to equitable resources and opportunities. This structural segregation reinforces racial hierarchies, keeps disparities in place, and creates significant barriers to white allyship.

Moreover, white people are socialized to view resource allocation as a zero-sum game, believing that gains for POC necessarily mean losses for themselves (McGhee, 2021; Norton & Sommers, 2011). Importantly, much of this racial socialization operates invisibly; it is “in the air” and feels natural, which allows it to evade scrutiny. Physical segregation, combined with negative stereotypes (e.g., the trope that POC are dangerous) and the fear of losing privilege or status, discourages intentional processes of allyship development. As a result, when white people do become racial justice allies, their development is often serendipitous rather than the product of systematic support or deliberate pathways (Cross &

Reinhardt, 2017). These systemic dynamics help explain why genuine white racial justice allies remain few and far between (Spanierman & Smith, 2017b).

At the same time white people are socialized in ways that block awareness of systemic racism and white privilege, they receive little to no socialization toward becoming racial justice allies. Most white people are unable to name white abolitionists or other role models for genuine and effective allyship. Beyond incomplete and sanitized histories of US racial struggles, there is no formal curriculum teaching white people how to support antiracist efforts or build solidarity. As with learning any complex skill, such as skiing, someone might teach themselves through trial and error, but success is far more likely when guided by instructors, structured lessons, and intentional practice. Rather than taking a serendipitous approach, we agree with Cross and Reinhardt (2017) that systematic efforts are needed that teach white people the fundamentals (e.g., knowledge of institutional racism, self-awareness of positionality and privilege, and intergroup dialogue skills).

Social cognitive career theory (Lent et al., 1994) offers a helpful lens here, suggesting that individuals' beliefs about their own self-efficacy, along with their expectations of outcomes, shape their interests and long-term goals. Extending this framework to social justice commitments, Miller et al. (2009) found that among university students, social justice supports and barriers indirectly affected their social justice commitments through self-efficacy beliefs and outcome expectations. In practical terms, this means educators and practitioners should actively bolster white racial justice supports—such as offering white ally role models, creating affirming communities, and providing concrete tools—while also preparing aspiring allies to navigate and withstand barriers, including criticism or backlash from friends, family, or institutions.

THE EMOTIONAL LABOR OF ALLYSHIP

Because white racial socialization makes it nearly impossible *not* to be racist in US society, becoming an ally involves a “herculean struggle,” “intestinal fortitude,” and “support from others” (Sue, 2017, pp. 707, 710). In those rare cases where white people break through white racial socialization and recognize structural racism and white privilege, they often grapple with a painful self-reckoning (Helms, 1995; Spanierman & Cabrera, 2015; Sue et al., 2019). As we discussed in Chapter 1, such self-reckoning tends to involve an internal struggle marked by a range of emotions including sadness and despair, anger and moral outrage, and guilt and shame. Genuine white allies recognize that while the

emotional labor of allyship can be painful, it pales in comparison to the burden POC carry in confronting racism.

Across several qualitative studies, white participants have reported experiencing sadness, hopelessness, and even despair when they learn about the pervasiveness of societal racism and its effects on POC (see Spanierman et al., 2008; 2017). Although these emotions might be linked to sympathy for POC, devoid of empathic perspective-taking, they also might be linked to a more developed form of empathy from understanding the racism that POC must endure on a daily basis (Feagin et al., 2020; Thomann & Suyemoto, 2018). Because some white participants reported feeling hopeless, believing there is nothing they can do to change racial injustice, pathways to racial justice action are crucial (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008).

As white people learn how racism permeates societal institutions and practices, they might experience anger. For example, they might feel anger for learning a sanitized portrayal of US history in school, or they might feel duped by biased media portrayals of racial issues (e.g., blaming residents of the ninth ward for their plight during Hurricane Katrina). Anger also might reflect a sense of moral outrage (i.e., justifiable anger, frustration, or disgust involving violation of a moral standard or principle; Rushton & Thompson, 2020). Although not a necessary precursor, research has shown that moral outrage is a significant predictor of collective action among allies (Krauth-Gruber & Bonnot, 2020; Spring et al., 2018; Thomas & McGarty, 2009). Reflecting the link between moral outrage and action, white protesters during the summer of 2020 remarked how empathizing with POC's anger and outrage about police brutality helped them connect with their own anger and sense of urgency to do something (Spanierman et al., 2025 [manuscript in preparation]).

Evidence suggests white individuals might experience feelings of guilt, shame, or self-loathing as they learn about racial injustice and their complicity (DiAngelo, 2011; Grzanka et al., 2019; Spanierman, 2022b; Thandeka, 1999; Thomann & Suyemoto, 2018). They might experience white guilt in response to not doing enough to support racial justice (Spanierman et al., 2017). In some cases, white people participate in ally efforts only to assuage their guilt (for a review, see Radke et al., 2020). Other research indicates white guilt can facilitate pro-social action (see Spanierman, 2022b). For example, white students who scored higher on a measure of white guilt demonstrated a greater willingness to confront white privilege (Pinterits et al., 2009), as well as greater support for affirmative action (Iyer et al., 2003; Spanierman et al., 2012). Channeling guilt in ways that are linked to a sense of responsibility for the liberation of all people seems an

important part of the process for becoming effective white allies (Helms, 1990; Iyer et al., 2003; McKinney, 2005).

After experiencing dissonance-producing events that elicit strong emotional responses, white individuals face several possibilities. If the emotions are too overwhelming, they might retreat into the comfort of white silence, racial colorblindness, or even a more deeply entrenched sense of racial superiority (see Helms, 1995). Another possibility, which we suspect is common among white racial justice allies, is having the courage to be emotionally vulnerable and to transform emotions such as guilt and outrage into a sense of responsibility and action. White racial justice allies understand that allyship is a lifelong journey that requires humility and sustained commitments to critical self-reflexivity, including experiencing painful emotions. Ultimately, the emotional journey toward allyship can lead to a sort of liberation for white people (Martin, 2017).

HESITANCY TO ACT: WHITE ALLY PARALYSIS

Even when white people understand the effects of structural racism and have the courage to face painful emotions, they may still feel paralyzed and powerless to act (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008). Research consistently shows a disconnect between white individuals' self-proclaimed ally identities and their actual behaviors to disrupt racism. For example, in a study of 31 white undergraduate psychology students, Williams et al. (2021) found that only 3.2% consistently engaged in ally behaviors across three laboratory experiments. Participants were much more likely to think about ally behaviors than to carry them out—a pattern consistent with Mathew et al.'s (2023) findings, where diversity educators of color described a word–action gap among white allies on campus, with racial justice language often appropriated without active efforts to dismantle racist systems. A key empirical concern is whether white ally intentions stand in for concrete actions, perhaps letting white people off the hook for backing up their proclamations. As we introduced in Chapter 1, two major barriers often help explain why white allyship stalls on the dance floor of racial justice: response uncertainty and fear of punitive consequences.

Response Uncertainty

Aspiring white allies may genuinely want to take action but often feel unsure about how to engage in meaningful ally work. Because allies are few and far between, white racial justice role models are sorely lacking. As we noted earlier, there is an urgent need for systemic, intentional training to equip white people with the tools for effective action (Cross & Reinhardt, 2017). Without such

preparation, aspiring allies may fear doing it wrong (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Bourke, 2020) or worry that their interventions could backfire or be unwelcomed by POC (Burns & Granz, 2023).

A related challenge, what Malott et al. (2019) called “uncertainty of tactic,” refers to the overwhelming nature of structural racism, which can make aspiring white allies unsure how to intervene in specific moments (pp. 90–91). In these situations, uncertainty can push white people to overfocus on their own feelings and reactions, a dynamic that invites white fragility (DiAngelo, 2011), marked by preoccupation with how one is perceived and discomfort discussing racial issues. This empirical finding also connects directly to Kendi's (2019) conceptual argument that antiracist work is not about achieving perfection but about practicing an ongoing commitment to action. Without explicit guidance and support, allies may stall, unsure of their next steps and risk ultimately recentering white concerns and derailing collective progress.

Fear of Punitive Consequences

Beyond internal uncertainty, white allies also face external risks that can feed paralysis. One major source is fear of punitive consequences. Linked to the fear of doing it wrong, white allies may worry about being called out by POC, whether in public or private, which can be emotionally jarring. In recent years, public figures, academics, and corporate leaders have been “canceled” even when they believed they were acting in good faith. Importantly, we do not suggest that all public critique is misplaced; rather, the perception of punitive consequences can deter aspiring allies from staying engaged. Without preparation for how to navigate critique and feedback, aspiring white allies may lack the resilience to withstand questions about their sincerity—a challenge described by participants in our prior research as the ongoing process of “negotiating whiteness,” or repeatedly proving themselves to address credibility concerns among colleagues of color (Spanierman et al., 2017, p. 635).

At the same time, white allies may face backlash from other white people, including family and friends, who perceive them as disloyal, overly sensitive, or working against their own group (Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Goodman, 2011; Malott et al., 2019; Spanierman et al., 2025 [manuscript in preparation]). This resistance may include ridicule, such as being labeled a “snowflake” or “bleeding-heart liberal,”and in workplace settings, advocating for racial justice can even jeopardize one's job (Malott et al., 2019). Across multiple studies, participants reported feeling estranged, struggling to maintain ties with white peers who failed to grasp the realities of systemic racism (Malott et al., 2019; Smith & Redington, 2010; Spanierman et al., 2025 [manuscript in preparation]).

Crucially, to counteract white ally paralysis, Williams et al. (2023) introduced the concept of civil courage. White individuals who possess civil courage are aware of the potential costs of acting (such as being criticized by POC or rejected by other white people) but choose to persist based on a moral imperative. While white allyship can entail significant personal and social costs, research has also emphasized the profound joy and sense of meaning that committed white allies report—including the experience of living authentically, with purpose, and in connection to a broader shared humanity (Smith & Redington, 2010; Spanierman et al., 2017).

SUMMARY AND SYNTHESIS: THE HAZARDS OF WHITE RACIAL JUSTICE ALLYSHIP

Before we explore strategies for accountable and sustainable allyship, it is crucial to pause and synthesize the recurring hazards that white allies encounter on their journey. Drawing on the chapter's analysis and a broad body of racial justice scholarship, including activist critiques of performative allyship, Table 5.1 summarizes key hazards, their underlying causes, the harms they pose to POC, and the antidotes needed to counteract them. To illuminate deeper patterns, we have clustered these hazards into three overarching categories: self-centering hazards, control and superiority hazards, and emotional avoidance hazards. Clustering these hazards highlights how seemingly distinct pitfalls often stem from similar underlying dynamics.

Collectively, these hazards can be understood as choreographed moves in a larger dance—a dance that maintains racial dominance. Performative gestures, paternalism, fragility, overidentification, saviorism, centering whiteness, and ally paralysis are not random missteps; they are repeated movements that sustain the deadly dance of racism. Recognizing these steps and the patterns they fall into allows allies to break the rhythm, disrupt the flow, and co-create new movements of justice and solidarity.

The first cluster, self-centering hazards, captures pitfalls where white allies make themselves the focal point of racial justice efforts,whether through virtue signaling, overidentifying with POC, or dominating the narrative. The second cluster, control and superiority hazards, reflects ways white allies assert dominance, often under the guise of “helping,” such as through paternalism or white saviorism. The third cluster, emotional avoidance hazards, highlights patterns of defensiveness, fragility, and paralysis that derail meaningful action and re-center white comfort over justice.

Table 5.1 Summary and Synthesis of the Hazards of White Racial Justice Allyship

HAZARD	DESCRIPTION	ROOT CAUSE	HARM TO POC	ANTIDOTE
Self-Centering Hazards				
Engaging Performative Allyship	Performing antiracist actions for self-image rather than impact	Desire for validation, assuaging white guilt	Distrust, emotional labor, undermed true solidarity	Practice transparency and accountability, cultivate humility, and focus on tangible outcomes over optics
Centering Whiteness	Making oneself the focus of racial dialogues or interventions	Narcissism, unexamined dominance	Amplified white perspectives, derailedi conversations, and denial of lived experiences	Decenter the self, amplify POC voices, and practice deep reflexivity about ally motives
Overidentifying with People of Color	Conflating allyship with shared identity, minimizing differences	Ego-driven alignment with POC, leading to blurred personal boundaries	Erasure of lived experiences, forced intimacy, misrepresentation of the ally role	Respect POC boundaries, acknowledge limits of understanding, develop accurate empathy
Control and Superiority Hazards				
Acting Paternalistically	Believing one knows what's best for POC or speaking over them	Internalized superiority, lack of cultural humility	Disempowerment, silencing, replication of dominance	Follow the lead of POC, practice deep listening, and build trust
Engaging in White	Trying to "rescue" POC	Desire to maintain	Loss of agency, replication of	Act in solidarity,

HAZARD	DESCRIPTION	ROOT CAUSE	HARM TO POC	ANTIDOTE
Saviorism	instead of working collaboratively	power, lack of trust in POC leadership	colonial and racial dynamics	centering community needs over personal recognition
Emotional Avoidance Hazards				
Displaying White Fragility and Withdrawing	Retreating from racial discussions when challenged or uncomfortable	Low emotional resilience, racial stress intolerance, limited capacity to navigate racial discomfort	Emotional labor caring for white people, stalled icollective progress, maintenance of racial hierarchies	Build stamina for discomfort, be receptive to feedback from POC and accountable white peers, and engage in self-care to stay in the work
Becoming Paralyzed (Ally Paralysis)	Freezing or withdrawing from antiracist efforts due to guilt, fear of mistakes, or perfectionism	Fear of making mistakes, absence of white role models, socialization that discourages risk-taking and prioritizes white comfort	Inaction that burdens POC to educate, undermines momentum for change	Normalize discomfort, build emotional resilience, channel guilt into collective responsibility, and develop civil courage

By making these patterns explicit, we aim to help readers recognize common pitfalls, understand their root dynamics, and prepare themselves to engage in antiracist work with greater humility, integrity, and effectiveness. Understanding the choreography of these hazards is only the first step. Breaking free from these

entrenched patterns requires intentional, sustained effort. In the next section, we offer strategies designed to help white allies disrupt these ingrained habits and engage in sustained, accountable racial justice work.

HOW TO BE AN EFFECTIVE WHITE ALLY: STRATEGIES TO BREAK THE DANCE

> Allies represent a crucial faction in the work for social justice; as members of the dominant population who advocate for the oppressed, they are important collaborators in this struggle
>
> (Munin & Speight, 2010).

Given the complexities involved in engaging in effective allyship, we acknowledge there is no one-size-fits-all approach. Different contexts call for different strategies, and, as we emphasized earlier, becoming a white ally often is an incremental, developmental process (Reason et al., 2005). Importantly, the choice between calling out and calling in is not merely a matter of tone but of relational strategy. As the national organization for white people engaged in racial justice, *Showing Up for Racial Justice*, reminds us, effective white allyship requires balancing accountability with empathy, inviting aspiring allies into growth rather than shutting them down.

Drawing from POC perspectives and those from committed white allies, the literature offers some general principles to guide racial justice ally efforts. To move from intent to action, from the superficial to sincere, we recommend the following strategies. These strategies reflect a layered approach, helping allies build knowledge, deepen reflexivity, work in their own communities, and sustain long-term engagement. This progression, from self-education to systemic disruption, ensures that allyship moves beyond personal growth toward tangible societal change.

Educate Yourself

Aspiring white allies must take the initiative to educate themselves rather than relying on POC to do the labor for them. This does not mean learning in isolation. White allies should read books, watch films, attend workshops, and engage with podcasts to better understand POC perspectives, US history, and ongoing racial disparities (for suggested resources, see Patton & Haynes, 2020). Additionally, research suggests the power of intergroup dialogue courses in fostering self-awareness and developing the ally traits that POC desire (Alimo, 2016; Ford, 2012; Yeung et al., 2013).

Because there is no systematic training on how to be a white ally in the US education system, white allies can work through structured, skills-based guides, such as *Beyond White Fragility* (Mekawi et al., 2024). Allies can do this work individually or in affinity groups, which tend to offer another layer of support to white allies on their journey. White people might consider joining antiracist organizations, such as *Showing Up for Racial Justice*, where they will find a wealth of webinars (e.g., "White people, we have work to do!"), toolkits (e.g., "From scarcity to solidarity"), white role models, local organizing projects, and opportunities to engage in a wide range of racial justice actions. As one white protester participant suggested in our research, "Joining a SURJ chapter was like finding an on-ramp—suddenly, I wasn't guessing anymore; I had steps, people to learn from, and accountability."

Engage in Continual Reflexivity and Personal Growth

Genuine and effective allies must commit to continual, critical self-reflexivity (Calderon & Wise, 2020; Kendi, 2019; Spanierman & Smith, 2017a). An important aspect of reflexivity involves seeking constructive feedback from POC and white people who are further along on their journey and responding non-defensively. As Kratz (2023) explained, "Allyship is about progress over perfection and mistakes are likely … Rather than being right, it is about being open to new information and shifting perspectives." Aspiring allies must not only seek feedback but must equip themselves with the skills to listen actively to the feedback—even when critical—and adjust their methods (Calderon & Wise, 2020). Approaching ally work with an attitude of humility, curiosity, and openness to learning offers a way of coping with the trials and tribulations of antiracist work (Malott et al., 2019). We recommend being gentle with oneself and not expecting to do things perfectly. As our research participants explained, developing recovery skills to address mistakes is a crucial part of the process (Spanierman et al., 2017). Being a white racial justice ally is an aspirational and ongoing developmental process—a lifelong journey—that requires continual efforts (Malott et al., 2019; Sue, 2017).

Work in White Communities

As civil rights leaders of color long have urged, white allies should focus on addressing the problem of white racism within their own communities (e.g., Carmichael & Hamilton, 1967). Research shows the most effective strategies for reaching other white people tend to be using less directive and more supportive tactics—a combination of gentle confrontation with support (e.g., Malott et al., 2019). White allies should take responsibility to initiate purposeful conversations

about whiteness and racism with white people in their lives (Patton & Haynes, 2020; Spanierman et al., 2017). White allies could, for example, initiate conversations with family and friends about racial microaggressions. When having these conversations, it is important to meet people where they are rather than where you want them to be. In other words, match the intervention to the person's developmental level (Malott et al., 2019).

Additionally, white allies could encourage other white people to attend ally workshops, book clubs, or discussion groups to help raise awareness of the problem of white racism (Hinger et al., 2023; Smith & Redington, 2010). White allies who are further along on their journeys should serve as role models to aspiring allies who face response uncertainty or who fear punitive consequences.

When white allies work in their own communities to address the problem of white racism, it is important to demonstrate empathy and compassion for white people who are not yet as far along. Although there may be a tendency to shame other white people, call them out, or even cancel them, we want to reiterate that such responses do the work of white supremacy and lessen the pool of potential allies. We have noticed a tendency to criticize and call people out for performative activism without considering that superficial attempts may be an entry point for helping someone along their ally journey. In some ways, criticizing performative allyship becomes yet another form of performance, as it does little to transform systems. Thus, we strongly recommend following the principle used by the national organization for white people engaged in racial justice *Showing Up for Racial Justice* (SURJ): call white folks in instead of calling them out. Calling in invites others onto the dance floor, building collective momentum toward dismantling white dominance.

Develop Meaningful Relationships with POC

While white allies should work within their own communities, meaningful relationships with POC remain at the heart of effective allyship. Allies must build these relationships with consistency, transparency, and integrity (Goldie et al., 2024; Hinger et al., 2023; Spanierman et al., 2017). In addition to acting with integrity, research suggests that close and lasting cross-racial friendships in which white people recognize and discuss power and oppression are more likely to promote social change than less meaningful forms of cross-racial contact (MacInnis & Hodson, 2019). Thus, we urge white allies to invest time, energy, and sincerity in establishing meaningful relationships, building trust, and discussing power, privilege, and oppression with POC.

Amplify POC Voices, Listen, and Decenter Whiteness

White allies should resist the urge to center themselves and instead amplify POC voices. Moreover, allies must give up the need for thanks or accolades for their racial justice efforts. Rather, white allies should act because they care, have strong moral convictions, and want to do the right thing. As the literature suggests, white allies should put aside the desire to lead and instead work in a supportive role with communities of color (e.g., Goldie et al., 2024). Otherwise, allies risk behaving in a paternalistic manner—as white saviors. Instead of fighting for racial justice on behalf of POC, allies should acknowledge POC's ability to fight for themselves. At the same time, white people should seek to disrupt racism for their own liberation and for a better society (Calderon & Wise, 2020).

Move Beyond Intention to Action

Good intentions are not enough. Allies must practice translating awareness into action (Kelley, 2020). Research suggests lower-risk behaviors, such as educating oneself, being kind to POC, listening to POC perspectives, and supporting POC-owned businesses, can set the stage for higher-risk actions, such as active resistance of oppression, challenging anti-Blackness, leveraging one's privilege, and ultimately transforming systems (Goldie et al., 2024).

Sue et al. (2019) outlined a framework of microinterventions, which offers a promising approach for moving from low-risk to higher-risk ally behaviors. Ultimately, microinterventions seek to disarm, dismantle, and disrupt microaggressions. Sue et al. (2019) set forth four strategic goals. The first strategy is to make the invisible visible (e.g., exposing the the hidden message beneath the conscious communication). As we noted above, the most effective approach may be a combination of confrontation and support. A second microintervention strategic goal is to disarm the microaggression—a more confrontive approach. Sue et al. recommend using this strategy when there is a need to address behavior that causes immediate harm to targets. A third strategic goal is to educate the perpetrator. Because racism is embedded in daily living, those who deliver microaggressions may be unaware they are doing so. Brief educational tactics can help people see that their words or actions can cause harm despite their innocuous intentions. Finally, the fourth microintervention goal is to seek external reinforcement and support. As we noted above, allies, too, can put themselves at risk by confronting perpetrators directly. This leads to our next key recommendation for allies, which is to develop self-care strategies to persist in the work.

Develop Self-Care Strategies to Persist

As Spanierman and Smith (2017a) conceptualized in their definition of white allies, racial justice efforts often provoke difficult reactions, ranging from painful emotions to rejection by white family and friends. We therefore urge aspiring white allies to proactively shore up their resources to manage emotional strain and setbacks. White allies should always anticipate backlash, including punitive consequences, and cultivate supportive networks to sustain their work. Notably, adopting a posture of humility can help buffer the sting of strong emotions and interpersonal pushback (Malott et al., 2019). As we highlighted in Chapter 1, allies "need persistent encouragement" to stay engaged (Winter, 1977). Supportive relationships are a vital form of self-care; having supportive friends and colleagues, both POC and white allies, with whom to share the joys and challenges of ally work is essential for reducing burnout and maintaining momentum (Malott et al., 2019). At the same time, it is important to nurture relationships outside of ally efforts to allow for periodic "psychological breaks" (Malott et al., 2019, p. 92). While we acknowledge research indicating that POC want white allies to engage consistently and fully, we also emphasize that white allies must fortify their emotional resources to counteract white fragility and sustain long-term, effective allyship. Ultimately, persistent engagement—even when imperfect—builds the collective force necessary to advance racial justice.

VISUALIZING SUSTAINED AND ACCOUNTABLE WHITE ALLYSHIP

To support aspiring white allies in sustaining accountable racial justice work, we have synthesized the core characteristics that emerged across the literature and from POC perspectives. Figure 5.1 visually depicts these essential characteristics, highlighting their interconnected nature and reinforcing the idea that effective white allyship is not defined by any single trait but by a constellation of commitments working in tandem. This visual summary offers a practical framework that allies can return to as a compass to guide their ongoing development and deepening their engagement over time.

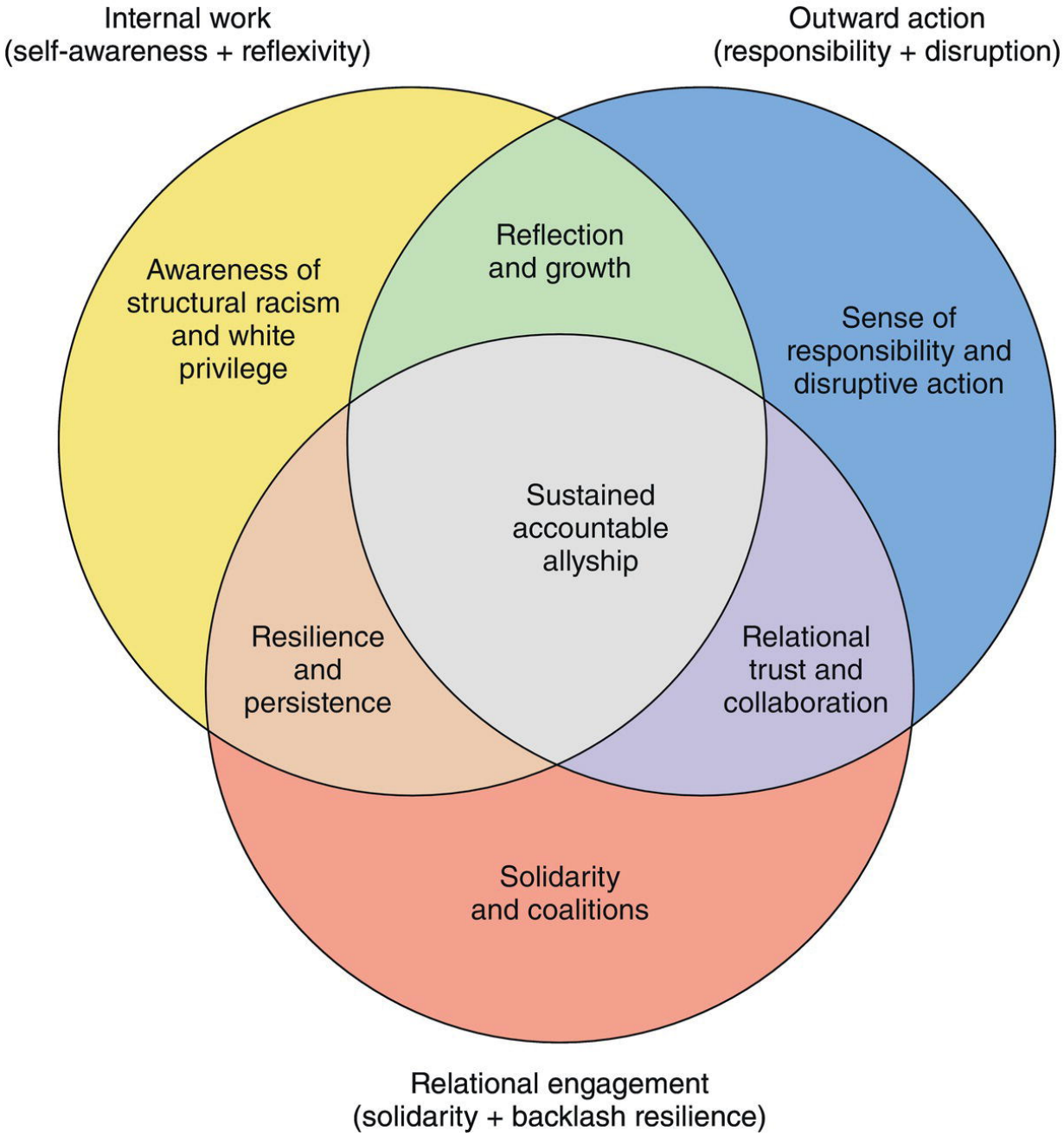

Figure 5.1 Essential Characteristics for Sustained and Accountable White Allyship

CONCLUSION

As white allies move through the lifelong journey of racial justice work, they will inevitably encounter discomfort, setbacks, and resistance from within themselves and from the systems around them. True allyship is not a destination but a lifelong practice, one that requires humility, accountability, and the courage to keep

showing up even when the path feels uncertain. In doing so, white allies can help co-create a future rooted in justice, dignity, and liberation for all. Breaking the deadly dance of racism requires more than intention—it demands that white allies step off the familiar floor, resist the pull of old patterns, and embody new, accountable ways of moving in racial justice work in relationship with communities of color.

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PART THREE
Social, Systemic, and Cultural Influences that Facilitate Racism

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CHAPTER SIX
The Deadly Dance of Racism: Symbiotic Roles, Scripts, and Ground Rules

We have come a long way in describing the common and unique challenges faced by perpetrator, target, bystander, and white ally in breaking the deadly dance of racism. For each of these players, we have provided anti-racist changes that need to occur to become cognizant of racism and systems of oppression and how each can personally challenge and disarm bias and discrimination.

In Chapter 2, we indicated how decent, moral, and "justice"-loving white Americans are socialized into oppressor roles, how cultural conditioning disguises and makes invisible the reality of racism, and how cognitive, emotive, and behavioral distortions allow them to remain naïve and innocent. As a result, perpetrators are able to maintain their personal beliefs of racial justice and fairness while at the same time remaining ignorant of their own discriminatory behaviors and their complicity in allowing institutional racism to flourish. A number of initiatives and proposals were made about how to penetrate perpetrator awareness, change their behaviors, and act to disrupt the racism dance.

In Chapter 3, we identified five target groups by which racial microaggressions and macroaggressions are directed: African Americans, Asian Americans, Latinx Americans, Native Americans, and AMENA groups (American Arab, Middle Eastern, and North Africans). We outlined how current and historical racial trauma may lead to physical and psychological distress, racial battle fatigue, internalized oppression, and lowered standard of living. We concluded that the first rule of thumb for targets was to take care of themselves first, as racism in all forms was painful and energy depleting. We outlined three major categories of target coping and survival drawn from the research literature: consciousness raising, self-care coping, and empowerment for action.

In Chapter 4, the important role of white social justice allies in breaking the deadly dance of racism was strongly stressed. We spent considerable time

describing the process of becoming an ally, the internal changes that need to occur, and the distinction between becoming non-racist and anti-racist. Although many white Americans might have an awareness and understanding of racism, taking anti-racist action may not follow. The emotional labor (fatigue and exhaustion) and the cost involved in being anti-racist may engender negative or punitive consequences such as disapproval by family and friends, isolation, lack of promotions or salary increases at places of employment, loss of power and privilege, etc. We offer suggestions of how to overcome these barriers.

In Chapter 5, we defined bystanders as white Americans who witness a racially based discriminatory act or action that is worthy of comment or intervention. In many respects, bystanders are similar to perpetrators in that they generally operate in an invisible veil of racial obliviousness. We review findings on the bystander effect and how social influence theory explains the inaction of bystanders in emergency situations. Most of these studies, however, were conducted on non-racial emergency situations. We noted that when race enters the equation, however, it sets in motion a completely different set of dynamics that affects the action or inaction of onlookers. Research suggests that responsible bystander intervention depends upon five different sequential processes: (a) notice the event, (b) perceive it as an emergency, (c) decide to take responsibility, (d) determine what action is required, and (e) take action.

All participants in the racism dance face unique interpersonal barriers to taking action in the face of a racial transgression. Critical consciousness, or awareness of the multidimensional nature of racism and its detrimental impact, is an important first step to overcoming racism. Equally important is arming people with the strategies and tools to disarm or neutralize microaggressions and macroaggressions. Although our chapters on these four protagonists have focused primarily on individual change, these roles do not occur in isolation from one another. To neglect viewing expressions of racism from a larger frame of reference (the interplay of all four dancing roles, effects of social influence, and larger systemic influences) may undermine anti-racist effectiveness.

In many cases, for example, racism is encouraged and reinforced by the actions or inactions of other actors (bystander effect), who themselves adhere to institutional and societal scripts or ground rules that influence

racist expressions. It is important to view the interactions between the dancers as dynamic, often interdependent, and occasionally symbiotic in nature. Microaggressions, for example, often occur in the presence of an audience, and the roles and actions of onlookers may determine whether the racist behavior is encouraged or discouraged. Focusing solely on individual change independently of one another may lead to failure unless the symbiotic and systemic dynamisms are addressed as well.

UNINTENDED CONSEQUENCES OF SILENCE AND INACTION

There is no better example of how the interplay of perpetrator, target, bystander, and white ally action and/or inaction legitimizes racism than in our opening example of a jokester telling a racist joke in Chapter 1, page 16. We have already shown that the presence of onlookers to iniquitous events affects the possible action of others. In this case, the jokester believes the story is harmless fun aimed at entertaining others and enjoys being the center of attention. Most onlookers (bystanders) directly or indirectly (laughing, clapping, smiling, or being silent) encourage the "witticism" by their rapt attention and amused reactions. For both perpetrators and onlookers, critical awareness of racist meanings and harm to POC is seldom entertained. Even those individuals (including allies) who recognize the racist overtones and believe the joke is in bad taste may remain silent, be frozen about what action to take, and decide to "go along to get along," thereby being complicit in the perpetuation of racism. As a result, the unfair responsibility of calling out or confronting the joke and jokester falls upon targets. To do so, however, is filled with threat and vulnerability, especially when power differentials exist in the social and economic relationships of targets. The result is that jokes or microaggressive actions often remain unchallenged because no one objects or calls out the racist nature of the story. The inactivity of all the players creates a symbiotic relationship where silence, conformance, obedience, and group acquiescence are normative, rewarding, and strongly enforced (Andrade et al., 2023; Dvoskin et al., 2023). Passivity in the face of racism also promotes a "false consensus" and contributes to "bias contagion," which in turn fuels the further expressions of prejudice and discrimination.

False Consensus Effect

Perpetrators and bystanders, being in the majority, often define the race-related witticism as harmless fun and set the ground rules for acceptable behavior. As we mentioned previously, both protagonists may lack critical consciousness of race and racism issues and may unintentionally engage in biased conduct. When perpetrators engage in microaggressions, the acceptance and approval of bystanders reinforce such behaviors, communicate to others that such biased conduct is normative, and encourage similarly related behaviors. Both parties operate under a well-known social psychological phenomenon labeled the "false consensus effect" (Ross et al., 1977), which is highly related to our earlier discussion of social proof in Chapter 4. It is a cognitive bias that distorts the perception of reality, leading people to overestimate the extent that others share their beliefs, attitudes, and behaviors (Bauman & Geher, 2002). Believing that racist jokes are harmless fun, that racism is overblown, and that political correctness discourages authenticity, perpetrators and bystanders fail to view microaggressions as "real" and rather define them as trivial, harmless, and insignificant in interracial interactions (Lilienfeld, 2017; Williams, 2020).

The false consensus effect also influences how people predict or judge the actions, reactions, and decisions of others. Research suggests that false consensus distorts evidence that is at odds with the person's belief or behavior (Aronson et al., 2015). Perpetrators are likely to perceive those who object or challenge their actions (targets or allies) as somehow personally flawed. This aspect of the false consensus effect is directly linked to another psychological phenomenon: blaming the victim (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). Those who object to or call out a microaggression are often seen as "unable to take a joke," "oversensitive," misreading the situation, and/or overreacting. POC, for example, are often pathologized for their reactions and objections; they are paranoid, irrational, and angry. Thus, the false consensus effect not only provides perpetrators permission to engage in discriminatory actions ("others will find it amusing,") but creates a social norm where others are pressured to "fit in" or conform. The false consensus effect is also linked to the concept of "groupthink," where targets and allies are less likely to challenge the status quo and more likely to

conform to the majority opinion. When this occurs, it reinforces the tendency of others to engage in similar biased behaviors.

As shown earlier, social influence theory posits that the pressure to conform and to go along with the group or situation can be a powerful force that envelops even those who do not share the sentiments of the perpetrator. White allies who may be uncomfortable with the racist joke and who remain silent are inadvertently providing tacit approval to the actions and perpetuating the false consensus. They are, however, rewarded for their silence, accepting attitude, and complicity. Likewise, targets who fail to speak out are seen by others as individuals who can take a joke, make fun of themselves, and be "a good sport." Bystanders who observe such actions are validated for their beliefs and similar actions. All of these roles, whether desired or not, produce toxic symbiotic interactions and relationships that directly and indirectly communicate that it is okay to engage in racist behaviors and that such behaviors are *normal and customary*.

Socialization is the major force defining the roles and expectations that different identities are to play and how such identities should interact with one another (Andrade et al., 2023). When a discriminatory situation occurs, individuals (whites and POC) are first and foremost culturally conditioned not to recognize such actions as racial in nature and/or to view them as normative. Thus, most are taught to endorse such actions, to approve it, and to reproduce it. Those who recognize the oppressive nature of the situation are caught in a web of forced compliance and discouraged from calling out or confronting the behavior. They may attempt to remain neutral by trying to walk a tightrope and by neither actively rejecting nor validating the discrimination (Braun, 2000). Desmond Tutu once said, "If you are neutral in situations of injustice, you have chosen the side of the oppressor." The ultimate outcome of such individual and group dynamics is that the dance of racism continues uninterrupted and may even gain greater strength in our society through a form of bias contagion.

Social/Bias Contagion Effect

Has the overt and covert expression of racism, sexism, anti-LGBTQ, and anti-immigrant sentiment increased in our society? As we mentioned in Chapter 1, there is a rising backlash in our society to the changing demographics. Numerous polls, tracking services, and research findings

suggest that incidents of hate crimes, bias and discrimination, and dehumanizing attitudes toward marginalized group members surged during Trump's first presidential election campaign, throughout his presidency, and after he left office (Jardina & Piston, 2023). The spike in racist incidents at both the explicit and implicit levels is seen in the speech of politicians, comedians, newscasters, the public, social media, and even globally (Giani & Méon, 2021; Muller & Schwarz, 2018). The escalation of hate speech, racist innuendos, and discriminatory actions has proven stressful and hurtful to marginalized group members. With Trump's election to a second term as President of the United States, he has promised the “mass deportations” of undocumented immigrants, a promise that seemingly has fallen upon a sympathetic populace. What accounts for the increase in racism? Are people becoming more racist or simply freer to express their biases and to act out in discriminatory ways? The answers to these questions have potential implications for developing policies or strategies to disrupt the “dance of racism.”

The social contagion of ethnic hostility has received considerable attention in the research literature and offers possible insights into the current upsurge in racism (Bauer et al., 2018; Chen et al., 2023; Jardina & Piston, 2023). The term “social contagion” refers to a phenomenon by which attitudes, emotions, or behaviors are rapidly spread to people through the spontaneous imitation of others; recipients do not perceive initiators as intentionally trying to influence them (Levy & Nail, 1993). Social contagion has been applied to explain fads, trends, rituals, hysteria, dishonesty, general crime, eating disorders, body imagery, self-harm, suicide, etc. (Chen et al., 2023; Davis & Pimpleton-Gray, 2017; Horesh et al., 2021; Levy & Nail, 1993). Likewise, some have reported that the concept of racist contagion can account for the rise of bias and bigotry not only in the United States but also on a global level (Giani & Méon, 2021). Can racism or their expressions (overt, covert, explicit, or implicit) be transmitted through witnessing biased actions (words and deeds) of others? And, as an extension, can microaggressions be contagious, especially if left unchallenged?

Many have observed that the overt expression of racist rhetoric by our political leaders and those in authority seems to sanction hate speech, bigotry, and violence toward those who differ from them in terms of race,

gender, and sexual orientation/identity (Jardina & Piston, 2023; Ruisch & Ferguson, 2023; Sue, 2023). It may have a contagious effect on others by providing permission for people to unashamedly and overtly act out deep-seated biases without fear of social disapproval or retribution. Laboratory studies support the belief that social contagion of ethnic hostility and bias is real and a powerful force in the expression and perpetuation of racist attitudes, emotions, and behaviors (Bauer et al., 2018; Chen et al., 2023; Weisbuch & Pauker, 2011).

In a series of studies, Bauer et al. (2018) found that when adolescents were exposed to destructive behavior by peers directed at an ethnic minority group vs. "co-ethnics," susceptibility to harming out-groups more than doubled. They concluded that intergroup hostility is contagious, can be triggered by peers, and is especially large in magnitude when peers respond with bias as opposed to observing positive behaviors. They conclude that the readiness to be hostile toward out-groups may be quite latent in "peaceful times," but may arise when tensions or contextual forces encourage conflicts. Although most studies on bias contagion focus on its transmission among the majority group population, there is also evidence that bias contagion crosses racial group boundaries. In one study, Asian Pacific Americans were exposed to a pattern of biased and non-biased interactions between whites and African Americans. Those exposed to the biased interactions exhibited more biased nonverbal behaviors toward African Americans when interacting with them (Meyers et al., 2023).

In their original taxonomy of microaggressions, Sue et al. (2007) suggested that microaggressions could be directed to targets verbally, nonverbally, and environmentally. Consistent with the bias contagion models, hearing derogatory statements (hate speech, verbal denigration of POC), and/or witnessing them may increase the biased attitudes of others and lead to greater discriminatory actions. Most studies on microaggressions have focused on the verbal offenses directed at individuals or group targets. Sue and Spanierman (2020) have speculated that nonverbal microaggressions may be potentially more harmful than even verbal offenses; not only do they denigrate and assail the target, but they also serve to send meta-communications (hidden) to children and bystanders. A mother, holding her young child, who tenses up around an African American man and appears frightened, communicates nonverbally that the person is potentially

dangerous and is to be avoided. The nonverbal transmission of intergroup bias, hostility, and fear has been studied extensively (Bauer et al., 2018; Chen et al., 2023; Giani & Méon, 2021; Meyers et al., 2023; Rozin & Royzman, 2001; Ruisch & Ferguson, 2023; Weisbuch & Pauker, 2011). In general, the following conclusions can be drawn from these studies.

1. Bias contagion occurs not only at the verbal (statements) and behavioral (observable discriminatory actions) levels, but also nonverbally (tone of voice, frowns, less smiling, and unfriendly behavioral interactions).
2. Bias contagion has a differential impact on an observer when it is directed at an out-group or in-group member; witnessing discriminatory actions toward an out-group individual produces twice the number of biased actions.
3. Bias contagion is not confined to only one racial group; it seems to cross racial group boundaries.
4. Disturbingly, there is evidence to indicate that unethical and immoral behaviors (dishonesty, tax evasion, corruption, and crime) are more contagious than ethical or prosocial behaviors; by extension, this suggests that racism or racist actions may be more contagious as well.

If racism is contagious, does it mean that racist attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors are increasing in our society? This is a difficult question to answer. Although clear evidence exists to support bias contagion, some believe that racist beliefs and attitudes already exist widely in individuals and can be triggered under certain circumstances. One explanation, for example, posits that shifting social norms toward greater acceptance of racist attitudes and behaviors were fostered by the rhetoric of political elites (Giani & Méon, 2021), and that the election of Donald Trump legitimized these attitudes. Trump's racist messaging and his election signaled to others that it was alright to express pre-existing racial animus. Thus, many white Americans felt more comfortable in publicly expressing dehumanizing attitudes without fear of social retaliation. A second explanation involves polarization of attitudes and beliefs around race and racism. Surveys seem to suggest that those with egalitarian views and anti-racist attitudes became more so in the Trump era, while those who harbored biased views

experienced an extreme backlash in the opposite direction (Jardina & Ollerenshaw, 2022). A third explanation questions the stability of racial attitudes and proposes that they have not only shifted but changed in such a way as to align with partisan political identities (Giani & Méon, 2021). Regardless of explanations, however, overt expressions of racism, bias, and bigotry are significantly higher than in the past several decades. As a result, bias contagion becomes an increasingly dangerous phenomenon for our society to confront and disarm. The uninterrupted dance of racism will continue to feed off bias contagion and the false consensus it generates.

THE ROLE RELATIONSHIPS IN THE DANCE OF RACISM

It was the fourth Republican debate held on December 6, 2023, between presidential contenders Chris Christie, Ron DeSantis, Nikki Haley, and Vivek Ramaswamy. It was heated and loud, with each candidate hurling insults and blame toward one another. Because of Nikki Haley's recent rise in the polls, she became the center of many derogatory accusations. Ramaswamy was especially hostile and abusive, hurling sexist innuendos at her throughout the debate. At one point, one of Haley's male opponents, Chris Christie, interrupted the tirade of Ramaswamy and angrily made the following statement:

> We're now 25 minutes into this debate. And he (Ramaswamy) has insulted Nikki Haley's basic intelligence, not her positions, her basic intelligence! She doesn't know regions; she wouldn't be able to find something on a map that his three-year-old could find. Look, if you want to disagree on issues, that's fine. And Nikki and I disagree on some issues, but I'll tell you this, I've known her for 12 years, which is longer than he's (Ramaswamy) even started to vote in a Republican primary. And while we disagree about some issues and we disagree about who should be President of the United States, **what we don't disagree on is this is a smart, accomplished woman and you should stop insulting her**.

Although many in the audience (onlookers and bystanders) applauded loudly, Haley (target) appeared both appreciative and uncomfortable with

Christie's remarks. Was Christie's defense of Haley an example of authentic allyship (see Chapter 5) when he called out sexist behavior on the part of another man (perpetrator)? After the debate, the internet was full of appreciative statements from viewers about Christie's performance, but some women viewers were wary and less complimentary. Was this a noble or sincere act, they asked, or one couched in ulterior political motives (performative gesture)? As a woman, was Haley not capable of defending herself against the “sexist” attack? Although Christie might have intended to call out sexism, did his protective stance only reinforce the belief that women are “incapable” of handling male aggression on their own? Did it not also promote “chivalrous” sexist behavior on the part of men? Can well-intentioned interventions by allies worsen the situation, create greater conflict, and turn off targets and bystanders?

Most research on racial allyship comes from the perspective of white allies with power and privilege but seldom from the targets or bystanders point of view (Hinger et al., 2023). Furthermore, they often assume that the outcome of interventions is positive. The above example illustrates the importance of considering the viewpoint of targets, their receptivity to interventions, and the possible negative consequences that may ensue from ally actions. As we indicated in Chapter 5, some have suggested that ally interventions are not always desired by targets nor received positively by even onlookers (Bullock et al., 2021), can create greater mistrust about the motives of those who intervene (Ponce de Leon et al., 2024), and may result in greater oppressive feelings and increased inequities (Knowlton et al., 2022). The nature of allyship is an emotional, complex, and delicate balance between the perception of targets, allies, bystanders, and the desired outcome.

Although Christie's intervention on behalf of Haley illustrates the issue of men being allies for women to disarm sexism, it raises similar important questions that are equally applicable to allies in the struggle against racism. The interplay of target and ally interactions is seldom studied in the scientific literature; they primarily focus on encouraging majority group members to speak out against racism without considering the perception and reactions of targets or the cultural and contextual implications of ally actions (Ponce de Leon et al., 2024). How do POC perceive allies and the manner in which they confront or challenge racism? Likewise, when bystanders witness an anti-racist ally intervention, what sense do they make

of it? There is evidence that race (of aggressors, targets, and interveners), the types of interventions used (subtle, direct, confrontational, educational, etc.) (Xie & Galliher, 2022), communication styles, the paradox of power differences, and the perception of ally authenticity (Knowlton et al., 2022) can determine the receptivity of targets and bystanders to white allies.

Communication and Intervention Styles

Considerable evidence exists that communication styles are influenced by race, culture, ethnicity, and gender (Sue et al., 2022). African American styles can be described as more direct, confrontational, passionate, and animated (Kochman, 1981; Shade & New, 1993); White Americans as more objective, controlled, task-oriented, and unemotional (Palmer, 2007); and Asian Americans as more subtle, indirect, low-keyed, and emotionally restrained (Kim, 2011). There is a strong possibility that communication styles also influence how one challenges or intervenes when a microaggression occurs. When a target chooses to respond, they may do so based upon cultural dictates. Likewise, when an ally chooses to intervene on behalf of targets, they may also do so based upon their cultural conditioning of what is deemed to be appropriate actions. What complicates the entire process is the negative perception that targets and bystanders may have of well-intentioned white allies who use culturally incongruent intervention or conflict resolution styles (Croucher et al., 2012; Gabrielidis et al., 1997).

For example, white allies who choose to intervene or call out a biased comment or behavior may do so in a direct and confrontational manner. Asian American targets may react negatively to the help of allies because it is antagonistic to their values of relational harmony, saving face, restraint of strong feelings, and subtlety in communication. In one study, Xie and Galliher (2022) investigated the intervener's race (White or Asian) and three types of interventions used (directly calling out the racist connotations vs. subtly stressing the norms of justice and equity vs. a support-based nonjudgmental approach). The investigators found that (a) Asian American targets and white observers had greater negative perceptions of interveners who used the more confrontational approach, (b) the support-based actions, however, were perceived more favorably by Asian American targets and white bystanders, and (c) surprisingly, even the more indirect approach

evoked negative reactions from Asian targets. There are several important takeaways from this study.

First, the type of intervention is important in how targets perceive their potential allies and whether they welcome their help. Likewise, positive or negative reactions from white bystanders are also influenced by the type of intervention being used. In the case of Asian Americans, ally interventions that confront and challenge the perpetrator may appear antagonistic to targets who value "face saving," indirectness, and subtlety in confronting problems, including microaggressions. Calling out a microaggression explicitly may be perceived as rude, crude, and abrasive behavior on the part of white allies and evoke sympathy for the perpetrator rather than displeasure. As a result, the distaste and negative reactions may be transferred onto well-intentioned allies rather than the perpetrator. This dynamic may only preserve the status quo and reinforce the dance of racism. For Asian American targets or bystanders, the more nuanced, subtle, and indirect approach to challenging microaggressive perpetrators may be more favorably received.

Second, although the authors speculate that Latinx Americans may also prefer less confrontational interventions because of their cultural values of *respecto* and *personalismo*, this has not been empirically studied. Yet, it is reasonable to assume that different racial/cultural groups may perceive directness or indirectness of interventions more favorably or unfavorably. While Asian Americans may prefer a support-based intervention from allies, it may not be true for African Americans and other racial/ethnic groups. African American styles of communication seem to occupy the other end of the spectrum when compared to Asian Americans (Kochman, 1981; Sue et al., 2022). In discussion, dialogue, or debate, African Americans are more direct and confrontational where ideas and issues are tested in the crucible of argumentation (Shade & New, 1993). Although Asian Americans value restraint of strong feelings, and white Americans see emotions as antagonistic to reason (Palmer, 2007; Sue, 2015), the presence of strong affect, passion, and animation are considered expressions of sincerity and authenticity by many African Americans. When a white ally intervenes on behalf of an African American target, the subtle or support-based approach may appear to be insincere, to comfort the perpetrator, to alleviate white fragility, to support the status quo, and to avoid the issue of

racism. In other words, such actions from the perspective of African American targets or bystanders may appear to be weak, diluted, insincere, and ineffective ways of challenging racism.

Third, there are several other worthy issues to consider in the Xie and Galliher (2022) study that have implications for ally intervention. While we have been addressing the broad domain of race/culture on communication/intervention styles, the authors speculate that racial identity and racial consciousness of targets and allies are important factors in predicting preference of race-related interventions. It has been shown that racial consciousness, identity, and pride buffer POC against the detrimental impact of microaggressions (Forrest-Bank & Cuellar, 2018). It may be that greater racial consciousness also means greater critical consciousness and greater sensitivity to the manifestation of racism (Sue et al., 2021). The reduction of ambiguity may actually intensify anger and frustration, which means more receptivity to confrontational ally interventions and greater negative perceptions of aggressors (Xie & Galliher, 2022).

Likewise, white racial identity development has been shown to influence recognition of racism in self and others (Helms, 1995). White Americans vary on a continuum in their ability to recognize race, racism, whiteness, and white privilege (Sue et al., 2022). The concept of color blindness has been found to be a powerful dimension of a less evolved white racial identity and may affect white people's perception of interventions (Neville et al., 2013). With respect to white bystanders high in color-blind racial ideology, there is a greater tendency to view white aggressors more positively (Xie & Galliher, 2022). Those with high color blindness, not surprisingly, empathize more with the perpetrator and may inadvertently minimize the biased act. In other words, the presence of white bystanders high in color blindness may discourage or even nullify a well-intentioned intervention regardless of its subtlety or directness.

Sincerity, Authenticity, and Trust

> I (Derald Wing Sue) have often been asked by white students how they can become an ally, how they can form coalitions with POC, and how they can be helpful? When I hear this question, I usually respond by asking them why they want to be an ally to POC? The answers are very revealing. Some are unable to answer the question. Some seem to have little knowledge or understanding of the groups they hope to help. Others answer quickly that "it is the right thing to do," that they are committed to social justice, and they seem to wear allyship as a self-congratulatory badge of honor. The answers indicate to me that they have not done the personal work to become worthy allies, that they lack knowledge and understanding of the communities they hope to serve, that they may prove more a burden than a help, and that their motives to help are unclear and/or suspect.

For POC, the motivation behind allyship, especially for those with power and privilege, is an important consideration used to ascertain the credibility of allies (Burns & Granz, 2023). Targets may view allies with suspicion because their motives are unclear or ambiguous: (a) they may be motivated to "look good," (b) to garner tangible rewards (politicians courting marginalized group members), (c) to conceal their underlying biases, (d) to dilute social justice issues, and (e) to downplay conflict in the service of interpersonal or group harmony (Mashburn et al., 2021). These motives only maintain the status quo and allow racism to continue unabated. Although allyship can be a powerful force in promoting diversity and equity and in disarming daily acts of interpersonal racism, studies suggest that beneficiaries have a proclivity to view many ally actions negatively, as insincere and inauthentic (Burns & Granz, 2023; Knowlton et al., 2022). In general, targets of bias simply do not trust their white allies unless proven otherwise.

Yet, most POC acknowledge that disarming and dismantling racism cannot be accomplished without the aid of white allies. Indeed, studies suggest that majority group allies are oftentimes more persuasive and effective than target group members in confronting racism (Gulker et al., 2013; Rasinski & Czopp, 2010). So, trust between targets and allies is important in forming effective coalitions that share common goals and strategies in the struggle

against racism. Too often “allies” do not understand the lived experience of POC, have not done the personal work to confront their own biases, offer unhelpful white solutions, and are more motivated to appear egalitarian than authentically dismantle racism (Hinger et al., 2023; Mathew et al., 2023). Many white Americans are externally motivated to alleviate white guilt, to improve their self-image, those of their group, or organizations, and to gain favor or tangible rewards. Their actions are not internally motivated by a sincere desire to help achieve the values of equity, inclusion, and equal opportunity. As we indicated in the last chapter, allies often take the roles of a “paternalistic protector” or “white savior” by continuing to dominate POC, making decisions on behalf of targets, and considering their white solutions to be better.

This type of allyship is harmful to POC because it only serves to disempower them, disregards and silences their voices, perpetuates the power differential of a racial hierarchy, and reinforces the belief that POC are dependent and incapable of helping themselves without white intervention (Knowlton et al., 2022). Many marginalized group members also point out the emotional labor and emotional toll taken upon them when working with allies. Although allies may be well-intentioned, their lack of critical consciousness, lack of understanding themselves as racial/cultural beings, lack of experience in combatting racism, and inability to understand the lived reality of POC often makes them more of a burden than of a benefit. Indeed, allyship may unfortunately prove to drain the psychic energies of targets who are constantly educating white allies. Unenlightened white ally actions may do more harm than good and risk a backlash from targets who are averse to working with them (Knowlton et al., 2022). This may explain why POC are less likely to join anti-racist movements that are ally-led rather than ones led by groups of color (Iyer & Achia, 2021).

We believe that the responsibility of fostering trust must ultimately fall on white Americans and not on POC. The credibility of white allyship is predicated on whether allies are worthy of belief, capable, entitled to confidence, reliable, and trustworthy. They must demonstrate in no uncertain terms their sincerity and commitment to anti-racist actions. Research demonstrates, for example, that the ultimate test of ally credibility is determined by (a) expertness (multicultural awareness, knowledge, and skills) and (b) trustworthiness (honesty, sincerity, and humility) (Hinger et

al., 2023; Mathew et al., 2023; Sue et al., 2022). Expertness is more an ability variable often asked of allies by marginalized group members. Does the ally possess the necessary knowledge, skills, experience, and internal work to serve as an advocate for POC? Have they done the work to become competent and effective allies? On the other hand, trustworthiness of allies relates to their sincerity, openness, honesty, and perceived lack of motivation for personal gain. Do they sincerely act in ways to benefit POC? It is easy enough to claim the status of ally, but POC are wary of such claims from majority group members when they are not followed by appropriate actions. Perceived trustworthiness is crucial and probably more important than expertness. Allies can be experts but not trustworthy.

Credibility of allies, thus, is ascertained through the quality of interpersonal interactions with POC and their demonstrated anti-bias actions. Just as we all make evaluations of one another (in social and work situations), allies are analyzed and judged constantly in their interactions with POC. Marginalized group members are likely to subtly or overtly test the trustworthiness of allies. Challenges to credibility involve passing tests related to the following questions: “Can you really understand what it is like to be a POC in a primarily white, western, and monocultural society?” “Can I trust you?” “What makes you any different from all my white teachers, neighbors, and co-workers who state they are for equality, but fail to prove it in their actions?” Depending upon how allies handle these challenges will either enhance or negate their trustworthiness. In the struggle for equal rights, it is behavioral evidence of expertness and trustworthiness that must be demonstrated in situations of injustice. How do allies behaviorally demonstrate their credibility beyond words? There are a number of factors proposed by social justice advocates that seem to enhance acceptance of allies and ally behaviors (Burns & Granz, 2023; Mathew et al., 2023; Ponce de Leon et al., 2024).

First is the concept of “costliness” (the degree to which allyship requires resources, effort, or sacrifice), such as the willingness to sacrifice one's own personal reputation, to persist in the face of threat, and to share power with targets in confronting racism, which signals sincerity and authenticity to targets. When allies find themselves in situations where taking anti-racist actions may result in punitive actions, they often remain silent and fade into the background. Those, however, who are willing to advocate on behalf of

social justice issues and risk the loss of position and power, attacks on their character, social isolation, and even violent threats and physical harm increase their trustworthiness in the eyes of targets.

Second, consistency in challenging and confronting racism suggests to targets that those allies have a lifelong and continuing commitment to anti-bias actions. Anti-racist interventions are not simply one-time actions but occur whenever injustice rears its head. Has the ally, over the course of time, consistently advocated and acted on behalf of racial justice across many situations? Do they have a long-time track record of social justice and anti-racism actions?

Third, public displays of anti-bias actions are seen by allies as more indicative of sincerity and likely elicit greater trust. When white allies publicly challenge an organizational policy or action in front of fellow white managers, confront a racist jokester, or attend an anti-racist public protest, they are signaling their sincerity and commitment.

Fourth, allyship often involves a “paradox of power” in which ally power used benevolently, in partnership with POC, can be enormously effective and successful in combatting racism. All too often, however, it can insulate allies from understanding the lived reality and experiences of POC, divert attention away from and minimize target contributions, reinforce the dependency of marginalized groups, and replace target solutions for white ones, thereby continuing to silence and oppress POC (Knowlton et al., 2022; Sue et al., 2021). Many times, the greater the power differential that exists between well-intentioned allies and POC, the greater the mistrust and suspicion. Knowlton et al. (2022) proposed the concept of cultural or “expressed” humility as a means to counteract the paradox of power and to increase trust. They believe that it is the duty and responsibility of allies to balance their positional power with the personal power of targets.

Expressed humility is an attitudinal stance and orientation that sincerely (a) acknowledges one's own limitations and shortcomings, (b) appreciates the strengths and contributions of POC, and (c) enhances an openness to learn from others (Knowlton et al., 2022; Mathew et al., 2023). Some behavioral demonstrations of expressed humility include (a) seeking advice and suggestions from marginalized group members about their shortcomings and limitations and about what they need to do to become effective, (b)

displaying appreciation for the strengths and assets of marginalized group members by “backstaging” themselves, and (c) spotlighting contributions by giving credit to target individuals. When allies demonstrate these qualities, when they are genuinely humble, when they willingly give up power or share it with POC, and when they highlight voices of those with less power in exchange for their own, marginalized group members are likely to perceive allies as sincere, authentic, and trustworthy.

In closing, as greater numbers of dominant group members express an interest in helping marginalized group individuals, and as building effective coalitions is an important necessity to combat racism, the need to understand the relational dynamics between allies and targets becomes urgent. Likewise, being aware of perpetrator – ally, bystander – target, and the numerous relationship combinations between the parties involved is crucial to breaking the dance of racism. Understanding the dancers in isolation from one another will yield only limited knowledge about how to address racism. In addition, not only do we need to appreciate the interpersonal interactions between all the roles in the dance of racism, but also the “stage” on which the dancers perform. The race-related ground rules and regulations that dictate the performance originate from cultural racism and a master narrative from which racial scripts are written for perpetrators, targets, bystanders, and allies.

CULTURAL SCRIPTS AND GROUND RULES IN THE DANCE OF RACISM

> The true tale of the lion hunt will never be told as long as the hunter tells the story.
>
> African Proverb

The performance stage in which the dance of racism takes place is comprised of an overarching umbrella of white supremacist notions that are translated, imposed, and enforced into the actions of individuals and upon the social policies and practices of our institutions and society (Jones, 1997; Jones & Rolon-Dow, 2018).[1] Although these racist systemic norms are imposed on all the dancers, they form a race-related ecological environment that acts as a pervasive *social toxin* to POC (Michaels et al., 2023). Social

guidelines, rules, and scripts choreograph our behaviors toward one another, dictate what are appropriate and inappropriate interpersonal interactions render their biased and harmful nature invisible, and, when necessary, enforce compliance through incentives and punitive actions. Because biased beliefs and actions are culturally conditioned from the moment of birth, the well-rehearsed racist dance steps become programmed, automatic, and unquestioned.

It is important to note that cultural scripts and ground rules arise from a master narrative, a public transcript that legitimizes the position of the dominant group, suggests it is the natural order of things, and cloaks it in the values of justice and fairness (Cose, 1997; Warren, 2000). Challenging the dance of racism involves a counter-narrative that may expose racial biases, prejudices, stereotypes, and discriminatory behaviors (Bell, 2002). Often referred to as “white talk” (master narrative) vs. “backtalk” (counternarrative), the competing stories represent a clash of racial realities that threatens to unmask the dirty secrets of racism (Sue, 2015). In order to maintain the racially biased equilibrium, (a) cultural scripts are used to inculcate the master narrative into our worldview, and (b) conversational ground rules are developed that prevent us from honestly addressing race and racism.

Cultural Narratives (Storytelling) and Racial Scripts

Cultural narratives are stories, myths, proverbs, and beliefs told to or shared by members of a cultural group or society about its past, present, and future. They are derived from and contain the cultural assumptions, norms, values, and practices that are deeply embedded in the collective consciousness of a group and its worldview (Bell, 2002, 2003). They lay the foundations for shared interpretations, mutual communication and understanding, rules for interpersonal transactions, expectations for standards of behavior, and affirmation of a group's values, traditions, customs, practices, and ideologies (Imada, 2012).

The stories people tell one another contain a framework for determining reality and for evaluating right or wrong, good or bad, normal or abnormal, acceptable or unacceptable, and valuable or worthless (Hasford, 2016). Cultural narratives or storytelling that emanate from a society contain the seeds of its aspirational values, customs, and beliefs. The adventures of

Daniel Boone, Kit Carson, and Davy Crockett glorifies “rugged individualism”; the story of young Abraham Lincoln's refusal to lie about chopping down a family cherry tree (Honest Abe) communicates a premium on truth; and the story of Columbus discovering America reflects the pioneering and adventurous spirit so valued in the Western world.

When applied to race relations and racism, Takaki (1998) has referred to storytelling as a master narrative, or a public transcript that legitimizes the superiority of white Americans. Note, for example, most stories about historical figures who are idolized or elevated comprise a group of white Western European men; POC and women are mainly absent. The consequence, whether intentional or not, is to communicate to women and POC that they and their contributions are unimportant and/or nonexistent. Although there is nothing wrong with reflecting society's values, their unmitigated imposition upon POC can have devastating consequences. Proverbs, for example, contain hidden meanings that may prove antagonistic to POC: “God helps those who help themselves” (individualism). “When in Rome do as the Romans do” (assimilate and acculturate). “Action speak louder than words” (action over being). The themes of white superiority are everywhere and transmitted through our textbooks, institutions, mass media, social media, entertainment industry, TV commercials, advertisements, newspaper articles, and importantly, family, friends, peers, and neighbors (Imada, 2012; Williams, 2007). When applied to individuals or groups, cultural narratives provide scripts and ground rules that dictate or influence what we believe and how we think, feel, and act.

In the United States, the dance of racism is heavily scripted for all the individual performers. When perpetrators engage in racially biased actions, when bystanders accept the actions as normative, and when targets and white allies remain silent, they are adhering to, or forced to comply with, narratives, ground rules, and ideologies that result in racial/cultural scripts that afford White people greater status, power, and privilege, while denigrating and disempowering groups of color (Skinner-Dorkenoo et al., 2021; Williams, 2007). Microaggressions, for example, can be seen as expressions of racial cultural scripts expressed by perpetrators and shared by those who witness them (bystanders). These racist scripts are derived from a master narrative that disguises their racist implications and makes

them invisible to white Americans (Williams, 2007). The themes from the master narrative are told in stories that surround beliefs of "America" being a fair, just, and egalitarian society: "*We live in a meritocratic society. Anyone who works hard enough can succeed in society. Equal access and opportunity are open to all. Racism is abhorrent but now a thing of the past. White Americans are good, moral, and decent people who do not discriminate. The color of one's skin is unimportant*."

Feagin (2001) refers to these beliefs as "sincere fictions" that mask their racist implications and allow white Americans to live their lives in innocence, naivete, and without guilt. In opposition to the narrative of a just society, there is a hidden counter-narrative told by many POC that threatens to unmask the ugly secrets of sincere fictions: "The advantaged position of white Americans are attained through oppression, power and privilege (Sue, 2015); meritocracy is a myth and intended for whites only (American Psychological Association, 2012); racism continues to be part of the lived reality of POC; color blindness denies the racialized experiences of POC (Neville et al., 2013); and it is good, moral, and decent white Americans who do the most harm to POC." When white Americans and POC engage in a racial dialogue, they are often telling opposing narratives or stories that represent a clash of racial realities (Sue, 2015). Because power and privilege reside with white Americans, they have the ability to define reality, to suppress dissenting views, and to silence and punish those stories that do not fit the master narrative. Thus, silence and inaction on the part of an audience serve to suggest that racist actions are acceptable and normal, fuel false consensus, and promote bias contagion.

The belief in the superiority of white ways of knowing, being, and behaving (white epistemology), and the inferiority associated with being a POC, is part of a master narrative in our society (American Psychological Association, 2012; Winston, 2020). More importantly, the master narrative of inferiority and pathology associated with POC is reinforced with societal beliefs that compound and amplify blame to the detriment of POC. Although education is often seen as the key to combatting racism, it can also be the tool by which a nation's power hierarchy can perpetuate its false racial reality by restricting accurate knowledge production and by presenting one-sided narratives (Ron & Gindi, 2022). As in the proverb

about the lion hunt, the story is told only from the perspective of the hunter and not from that of the lion.

In his best-selling book, *Lies My Teacher Told Me*, Loewen (2018) presents countless historical inaccuracies gleaned from American history textbooks that elevated contributions of White European American males while denigrating those of POC. In history classes, for example, students were taught that Columbus discovered America. Despite more enlightened attempts to correct the misinformation, *Columbus Day* is still a celebrated holiday by which the discoverer, a White European male, is glorified and by which indigenous inhabitants are denigrated and considered *discovered*. Little is made of the fact that Columbus was lost, believed he landed on the continent of India, and incorrectly named the indigenous people "Indians." Truth be told, it could be argued that it was Native Americans who discovered the lost and confused explorer! While this may appear to be a minor omission or error in history textbooks, it has a major psychological and harmful impact upon Native Americans that continues today (Sue & Spanierman, 2020).

The falsehood positions a White European male as the active, superior discoverer and indigenous people as passive and inferior (*the discovered*). Worse yet, Native American students are placed in a damned if you do and damned if you don't dilemma. When teachers ask, "Who discovered America?" on a test, White students who answer "Columbus" are filled with pride and a sense of validation. Native American students who know a different history, however, are either forced to answer in the affirmative (thereby selling out their integrity in order to obtain a good grade), or by denying the falsehood, they are punished with a poor grade (Sue, 2017). In this case, we are witnessing the operation of cultural oppression and racism, where the worldview of one group is imposed upon a less powerful or marginalized one. Regardless, there is great harm occurring when the master narrative falsely liberates, validates, and reinforces the worth of one group while denigrating and requiring forced compliance from another.

In addition to these historical falsehoods, there is another hidden curriculum and a less conscious master narrative that socializes white Americans into believing that certain groups or individuals are unworthy, undesirable, outsiders, and dangerous; that they are lesser human beings to be avoided; and that they are deserving of their lesser treatment and status in life (Bell,

2003; Hasford, 2016; Williams, 2007). When white Americans encounter individuals who differ from them in terms of race, culture and ethnicity, when they are unaware of their own worldviews, and when they are unable to relate to the lived experience of POC, they are likely to respond toward them with microaggressions that (a) pathologize their cultural values and communication styles, (b) spontaneously impose detrimental stereotypes on them, (c) interpret sociopolitical non-conformance as abnormality; (d) perceive them as intruders or second class interlopers, (e) mistakenly attribute problems to reside within them rather than the social system, (f) engage in "victim-blaming", (g) ignore the importance of racial and cultural differences; and (h) approach POC through a color-blind lens (Neville et al., 2013; Sue et al., 2022; Yip et al., 2021). Thus, there is both an implicit and explicit prejudice and bias toward persons of color that is fostered by our society. Racial microaggressions and macroaggressions are expressions of scripts that are based on biased attitudes and sincere fictions.

Protecting Racism: Ground Rules for Racial Interactions

In addition to racial scripts that lead to a plethora of microaggressions and macroaggressions, society creates ground rules that prevent honest racial interactions: they dictate how topics of race, racism, whiteness, and white privilege are addressed in our society. The ground rules are meant to stifle honest dialogues on race and to prevent those with power and privilege from listening and considering the legitimacy of counter-narratives coming from POC (Bell, 2003; Feagin, 2001). Honest racial dialogues threaten to unmask the dirty secrets of the mythical "fair and just society," reveal how those with power and privilege have benefited from their current hierarchical arrangements, and expose the complicity of white Americans in the perpetuation of racism. These ground rules of how race is addressed in our society shield perpetrators, allies, bystanders, and other white Americans from hearing about the pain, suffering, and humiliation of racism, or how they may be personally complicit in perpetuating bias and discrimination. In his research on racial dialogues, Sue (2015) identified three race-related ground rules that serve to discourage and stifle racial discussions (race talk) between white Americans and POC: (a) the politeness protocol, (b) the academic or intellectual protocol, and (c) the color-blind protocol.

The Politeness Protocol

Although authentic and honest racial dialogues have been advocated as a means to increase racial understanding and to decrease racism, it has been a difficult goal to achieve (President's Initiative on Race, 1998, 1999). This is especially problematic in the dance of racism when racist beliefs and actions need to be openly discussed among the parties involved. In our society, however, racial dialogues have been found to push hot emotional buttons among participants; they can become heated, filled with anger and defensiveness, and evoke personal attacks and fears of physical violence (Sue, 2013; Utsey et al., 2005). To avoid conflict, preserve harmony, and ensure smooth relationships, powerful norms regarding how one talks about racial topics are operative: limits are placed on how deeply the topic is explored and the manner in which people should talk about race. The politeness protocol dictates that people should be nice to one another, take care not to offend, and keep conversations noncontroversial, calm, light, and superficial.

As mentioned earlier, race talk between white Americans and POC represents a clash of racial realities between a master narrative and a counter narrative. For white Americans, it challenges their self-image of being a “good person” who would never behave in racist ways. Racial dialogues are uncomfortable and filled with anxiety because they threaten to replace innocence and naiveté with the horrible realization of personal racism and one's complicity in its perpetuation. Although POC are more likely to broach race and racism topics, they, too, are also ambivalent about raising them because of the potential negative consequences. POC have learned that raising such matters is often met with silence, avoidance, defensiveness, and denial by white Americans. Worse yet, POC are often accused of being overly sensitive, playing the “race card,” told that their perceptions are inaccurate, and blamed for creating disharmony and conflict. Thus, rather than increasing mutual respect and understanding, “race talk” can be very polarizing, create ruptures in relationships, and lead to greater disagreements.

The potentially explosive and polarizing nature of racial dialogues is mitigated through ground rules that allow participants to avoid, ignore, or remain silent; if discussed, however, it is done in a very superficial manner (Sue, 2013, 2015). In our society race talk is a taboo topic, to be avoided or

ignored. The politeness protocol prevents honest dialogues on race and racism from occurring. This overarching etiquette aids in preventing authentic self-disclosures, minimizing interpersonal conflicts, preserving interpersonal or group harmony, and alleviating discomfort and anxiety. In public forums, social gatherings, classrooms, boardrooms, and neighborhood events, deep racial dialogues are discouraged because they may prove offensive or uncomfortable to the parties involved (Zou & Dickter, 2013). In many ways, the dance of racism between perpetrators, targets, bystanders, and allies is allowed to continue uninterrupted when the politeness protocol is operating.

The Intellectual or Academic Protocol

In western ontology and epistemology, the intellectual or academic protocol considers emotions as antagonistic to reason. Western European approaches to knowing, learning, being, and finding "truth" elevate reason over emotion, objectivism over subjectivism, and empiricism over experientialism in resolving problems (Palmer, 2007). The intellectual or academic protocol operates from a belief that racial emotions block dialogue and understanding and that feelings need to be controlled to have a productive outcome. Indeed, the ground rule assumes that understanding race and racism are purely cognitive exercises devoid of feelings. Yet, racial dialogues almost always release formidable unpleasant feelings that run the gamut from fear, anger, frustration, blame, and defensiveness (Presidents Initiative on Race, 1998). In academia, teachers often perceive strong expressions of emotions between students to be polarizing and unruly and to break classroom decorum. Teachers, thus, set ground rules for how discussions are to take place: they must be discussed "calmly" (control, suppress, or deny feelings), "respectfully" (avoid attacks, anger, and blame), and "objectively" (detach and focus on facts, not personal feelings or experiences). The ultimate outcome imparted by the intellectual protocol is to dictate that racial dialogues should be conducted in a sterile and objective decorum devoid of emotions.

Such an approach becomes problematic because race talk is full of nested or embedded feelings; ignoring or denying them allows emotions to fester away untouched and ultimately defeats attempts to resolve personal racial issues (American Psychological Association, 2012; President's Initiative on

Race, 1999). Understanding the origins of these feelings has been found to provide clues to their psychological meaning and the ultimate development of a nonracist identity. For white Americans, these emotions are likely to be unpleasant, ranging from anxiety to fear, anger, sadness, and defensiveness (Catagnus et al., 2021). The feelings seem to come from three sources: (a) culturally conditioned fears of differentness associated with outsiders (Jones, 1997), (b) apprehension that they will unintentionally reveal their biases (Sue, 2015), and (c) anger/defensiveness over feeling "unjustly" accused of being racist (Bell, 2002). The major underlying menace, however, is that race talk threatens to decode the racist assumptions of the master narrative and lay bare the invisible tentacles of racism.

POC may also experience strong unpleasant reactions when their attempts to "tell their stories" are thwarted and when they encounter negative stereotypes in the form of microaggressions (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). They may become annoyed, angry, feel powerless, and pained over having their racial integrities assailed, realize how unaware whites are about their biases and privileges, and become "fed up" with what they see as white denial and a "conspiracy of silence." The need to work through these emotions is considered by many to lay the groundwork for mutual respect and understanding, and compassion and empathy (American Psychological Association, 2012; President's Initiative on Race, 1998; Sue, 2015).

In general, racial feelings are real, and when unacknowledged, they simmer away, counteracting attempts at racism reduction. Race and racism are comprised of not only attitudes, thoughts, and beliefs but are also in the conscious and unconscious emotions of people. Kim (2016) goes so far as to posit emotions as another dimension of race that needs to be recognized and researched, especially unpleasant ones. The ability to process disruptive racial feelings has been found to be beneficial to the well-being of people, to rid them of emotional roadblocks, and to increase compassion and understanding (Peluso & Freund, 2018; Sue, 2015). For white Americans, especially, *The* President's Initiative on Race (1998, 1999) has concluded that acknowledging and processing racial emotions lead to (a) less intimidation and fear of differences, (b) an increased compassion for others, (c) a broadening of their horizons, (d) appreciation of people of all colors and cultures, and (e) a greater sense of connectedness with all groups.

The Color-Blind Protocol

“Colorblindness refers to a set of beliefs that individuals' group membership or physical appearance is not and should not be influential in how we perceive, evaluate, make decisions about, or formulate public policy toward them” (American Psychological Association, 2012, p. 9). Like the politeness and academic protocols, color blindness may act to squelch honest dialogues about race and racism. Although intended to create a race-neutral society, research suggests it is nearly impossible not to notice major physical features of people, such as race and gender, even among infants (Ito & Urland, 2003; Montepare & Opeyo, 2002). This troublesome philosophy has been translated into practice, where many whites now avoid mentioning race or pretend not to notice it when interacting with POC. For many white Americans, overtly acknowledging race risks the possibility of being perceived by others as racist; thus, considerable energy is expended to not mention race in order to appear fair and nonprejudiced (Plaut et al., 2009; Sue, 2015). The failure to acknowledge race, even when it is a relevant factor, has been labeled “strategic colorblindness” (Apfelbaum et al., 2008), an adaptive tactic used by many majority group individuals to appear unbiased, fair-minded, and friendly to POC.

Ironically, attempts to appear unbiased by ignoring race may backfire and make white Americans appear “more prejudiced” (Tynes & Markoe, 2010; Vorauer & Turpie, 2004). The psychic energy expended toward being careful about “what to say and how to say it” depletes psychological resources and makes the person appear guarded, unfriendly, hesitant, and uncomfortable (Richeson & Shelton, 2007). To avoid directly addressing race, they may (a) “dance around the topic,” (b) their speech content and pattern may become ambiguous, obtuse, and nonsensical (“rhetorical incoherence”), (c) they stammer, stutter, and mispronounce race-related words, and (d) they communicate anxiety verbally and nonverbally (avoid eye contact, appear nervous and fidgety, etc.) (Apfelbaum et al., 2008; Sue, 2015; Utsey et al., 2005). POC are likely to interpret these behaviors as evasive, inauthentic, and biased; in other words, the individual has something to hide.

Being a color-blind nation, however, has a detrimental impact on both white Americans and POC (Neville et al., 2013; Plaut et al., 2009; Sue, 2015). Neville and associates (2013) have identified two distinct forms of color

blindness, which they call *color evasion* and *power evasion*. Both serve to protect white Americans from accepting personal responsibility for their roles in the perpetuation of racism and allow them to live in a world of false deception. As long as race and racism are not addressed, it perpetuates the status quo and provides an excuse for individual inaction. Color evasion facilitates the belief in sameness: "POC are no different than white Americans." Thus, discussion of differences is delegitimized, considered irrelevant or even divisive, and assimilation and acculturation are encouraged (Sue, 2015). Color evasion denies the racialized experiences of POC and considers racism an insignificant factor in their lives.

On the other hand, power evasion ignores the existence of power and privilege held by white Americans over POC. More importantly, it minimizes the harmful impact of cultural, institutional, and structural racism upon their psychological well-being and lower standard of living. Power evasion diminishes the existence of structural inequities, sustains the current social hierarchy, and avoids recognizing the advantages enjoyed by white Americans (white privilege). Power evasion and color evasion work hand in hand to uphold the myth of meritocracy and blame the victim for their lot in life. Being color-blind is to be color mute: it prevents white Americans from openly talking about race and racism and from hearing the counternarratives of POC.

CONCLUSION

This chapter highlights the powerful interpersonal dynamics, cultural narratives, scripts, and ground rules that reinforce, replicate, and contagiously spread bias and discrimination. The multidimensional and multilevel components of racism suggest that breaking its deadly dance cannot be undertaken simply at the individual level (i.e., changing the attitudes and behaviors of perpetrators, targets, bystanders, and allies), but must also focus on how racism is sustained through an interlocking system of individual, institutional, societal, and cultural hierarchies of power and privilege. This is not to diminish the importance of ending explicit and implicit biases in individuals, motivating people to take anti-bias actions, and arming them with the necessary skills to intervene when racism occurs.

These are all necessary, but not sufficient conditions to make the revolutionary changes required.

Disrupting the dance of racism requires a concerted effort to neutralize the forces of cultural racism by challenging its master narrative of white superiority and POC inferiority, by addressing the symbiotic interplay of individual and institutional racism, by developing critical consciousness of the racial scripts that dominate our lives, and by seriously challenging the ground rules for racial dialogues that prevent understanding, empathy, and compassion. In essence, it is *intentional culture change* that needs to be undertaken to break the deadly dance of racism at the individual, institutional, and cultural levels (Hamedani et al., 2024). We address the basic principles of intentional culture change in the next chapter.

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Note

1 A portion of this section was adapted from Sue (2015). John Wiley & Sons. Permission granted.

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CHAPTER SEVEN
Overcoming Cultural, Systemic, and Institutional Racism

In the last chapter, we noted how the deadly dance of racism is choreographed by biased cultural scripts containing stories, narratives, myths, proverbs, symbols, and beliefs that reinforce and dictate how we behave toward in-group and out-group individuals (Jones, 1997; Skinner-Dorkenoo et al., 2021). Cultural conditioning and socialization fortify well-rehearsed racist "dance steps" and make them appear normal, desirable, and not to be questioned or contested (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019). To prevent actors from deviating from the script (breaking the dance of racism), safeguards are placed to discourage or even punish those who dare stray from or resist participating. As we have seen, these ground rules protect the secrecy of racism by silencing the voices of POC and well-intentioned white allies (Bell, 2003; Feagin, 2001).

Michaels et al. (2023) use the term "personally mediated racism" to illustrate how the ugly tentacles of racism control the individual roles of actors and their subsequent racist manifestations. Like marionettes, people's actions are controlled, influenced, and manipulated by *the puppet master of cultural racism*. Whether perpetrator, target, ally, or bystander, all can feel the tug of the puppet strings emanating from cultural norms, standards, traditions, and ways of behaving. Cultural racism not only determines the racist outcomes of interpersonal interactions, but personally mediated racism facilitates and supports the biased structural and hierarchical arrangements in our society. In other words, the relationship between cultural racism and interpersonal bias reinforces one another; the former socializes racial bias and bigotry into individuals, but, at the same time, their biased individual expressions provide sustenance to systems of oppression.

Generally, the study of racism has focused primarily on personal expressions of racism (microaggressions, implicit bias, and stereotyping), and on institutional racism and how they create inequities in the standard of

living for POC (Feagin et al., 2020; Michaels et al., 2023). Less attention and analysis have been given to exploring the invisible role that cultural racism plays in fueling individual, systemic, structural, and institutional bias and bigotry toward POC. Indeed, even less focus is given to how these forms of racism are related to one another. We assert that cultural racism is both the foundation and root cause of individual and institutional racism. In this chapter, we (a) define the toxic omnipresence of cultural racism and its insidious relationship to white supremacy, (b) explore the roles that systemic, structural, and institutional inequities play in our daily lives, (c) provide a conceptual framework to understand the interrelated and symbiotic forces that contribute to the deadly dance of racism, and (d) offer solutions for cultural and institutional change that may disrupt the racism dance. In many respects, learning new anti-racist dance steps can only effectively occur when the umbrella of cultural racism is acknowledged, made visible, and diminished.

CULTURAL RACISM AND WHITE SUPREMACY

Cultural racism comprises the cumulative effects of a racialized worldview that perceives racial differences (biological, cultural, or lifestyle) as desirable/undesirable or superior/inferior and which is passed on to future generations through *institutional policies and structures (macroaggressions)* and through the *personal everyday actions of people (microaggressions)*. Children are socialized and educated through cultural racism, pass it on to future generations, and act in ways that oppress and silence POC, oftentimes unaware that they are doing so (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019; Bonilla-Silva, 2021; Ferguson et al., 2022). Cultural racism also infects the larger social, political, and economic arrangements, leading to systemic, structural, and institutional inequities that produce biased policies, programs, and practices. Cultural racism is, thus, comprised of individual and institutional racism, both expressing the superiority of *European American cultural heritage*, and are transmitted by a *white epistemology and ontology* (ways of knowing, thinking, behaving, and being) that is enforced on POC (Jones, 1997; Winston, 2020). In our society, cultural racism is intertwined with the ideology of white racial

supremacy. To understand the dynamics of cultural racism, it is important to understand how whiteness and white supremacy are insidious forces infecting all aspects of U.S. society.

Whiteness and White Racial Superiority

It is important to note that whiteness as a phenotype in itself is biologically insignificant except when it is anchored to a network of advantageous social, legal, and political structures that confer dominance to one group over all others (Marks, 2018). Sue (2006) describes the dynamic process of how whiteness is transformed to white racism and white supremacy. To understand the transformation, he identifies four processes that operate to create white racism. First are the phenotypical features of whiteness: "The constellation of physical features most characterized by fair or light skin color/tone. Other physical features may be considered ideal (associated with Western traits) such as blond hair, blue eyes, or elongated face. Whiteness, alone, conveys neither positive nor negative valence" (p. 17). Second, the tentacles of racism begin to emerge when whiteness is defined as desirable, natural, normal, and superior in nearly all aspects of life (biological, lifestyle, cultural values, beliefs, and traditions). This is generally accompanied by a belief in the inferiority of all other non-white groups. Third, these ethnocentric beliefs become a doctrine of racial superiority and are instilled in the worldview or the racial frame of the society. In this vein, there is a belief that whites are inherently superior in all ways to other races, and destined to dominate them (the natural order of things). In Chapter 3, for example, we showed how the concept of *manifest destiny* preordained white settlers with the right to take land away from Native Americans by force and without guilt and to dominate and subjugate them.

Although all nation groups may be ethnocentric and believe in their own desirability, it is the fourth component of white supremacy, "power to impose" that contributes to its oppressive and harmful impact toward POC. The power to impose is systemic in nature and is exercised not only in individual acts of oppression, but through institutional programs, policies, and practices that reward and uplift whites while punishing and denigrating POC. Education and schooling, the mass media, significant others, and organizations perpetuate the dominant/subordinate relationship between white and non-white groups (Ferguson et al., 2022; Michaels et al., 2023. In

other words, the cultural context of racism reflects the customs, tastes, expectations, beauty ideals, values, experiences, and history of white Americans to which all other groups are compared. Fifth, through socialization and equating the white racial frame as normal and "every day," racism is rendered invisible. Whiteness, as described by Harris (1993), becomes an invisible metaphor for power in that it represents "expectations of power and control that enshrine the status quo as a neutral baseline, while masking the maintenance of white privilege and domination" (p. 1715).

Sue (2006) suggests that cultural oppression and white supremacy are intertwined and the systemic outcome is manifested in white privilege —"unearned advantages and benefits that accrue to whites by virtue of a system normed on the experiences, values and perceptions of their group" (p. 17), and that it further justifies unequal and unfair treatment toward POC. The values that uphold white supremacy become part of the collective consciousness in that it rises above the minds of individuals to comprise a cultural "macropsychology" that is expressed in two racial frames that complement one another (Michaels et al., 2023): (a) the white racial frame and (b) the frame of color-blind racism. We have already made reference to the former in that it consists of beliefs in white superiority, perpetuates biases, stereotypes, and misinformation about POC, and legitimizes their inferior treatment. Color-blind racism, however, is a different animal altogether.

Neville et al. (2013) uses the term "color-blind racial ideology" in reference to denying the experiential reality of racism, obfuscating white racial identity, and socializing future generations to become oblivious to the existence of racial inequities. Color-blind racial ideology has two major components: (a) color denial and (b) power denial. The former denies racial/cultural differences by refusing or pretending not to see race and by asserting universality as evidenced by these common statements: "We are all human beings," "We are all the same under the skin," and "There is only one race, the human race." Apfelbaum et al. (2008) have labeled this phenomenon "strategic color-blindness," a behavioral pattern used by white people to minimize race or racial differences in order to appear unbiased. The approach indirectly communicates to POC that their lives as racial/cultural beings are no different than that of whites, that racial identity

is unimportant, and that success or failure in life applies equally to all groups.

While color denial functions to protect white Americans from acknowledging their own guilt and complicity in the expression of racism, power denial is a refusal to recognize the systemic nature of racism and how it advantages one group while disadvantaging another (Ferguson et al., 2022; Neville et al., 2013; Sue, 2015). Power denial is a repudiation and/or a minimization of structural inequities in institutions and society, prevents white people from admitting that organizational policies and practices advantage their group and disadvantage others, and operates from a false premise of equal access and opportunity (Yi et al., 2023). Such a narrative or premise places the blame for racial inequities on POC and, by extension, their biology, lack of motivation/intelligence, inferior culture, and primitive lifestyles (Michaels et al., 2023). This ideology uses the values of universalism and individualism and the beliefs in equal opportunity and meritocracy to blame POC for their lot in life.

From these race-related standards and norms, a racialized worldview emerges that creates a *false polarity* where (a) universalism is valued over relativism, (b) individualism over collectivism, (c) objectivism over subjectivism, and (d) empiricism over experientialism (Sue et al., 2024). When each of these four "foundational pillars" of western society and science are translated into how we ask and answer questions about the human condition (epistemology), and how we should think, behave, and feel (ontology), they may lead to cultural oppression and racism; *universalism* equates racial/cultural differences with pathology and promotes color/power blindness; *individualism* leads to the myth of meritocracy and victim-blaming; *objectivism* leads to objectification, dehumanization, and the othering of POC; and *empiricism* denies the lived experience of POC (Sue et al., 2024; Winston, 2020). (For a detailed analysis of how these pillars are executed and enforced to the detriment of POC and their communities, see Sue et al., 2024.)

SYSTEMIC, STRUCTURAL, AND INSTITUTIONAL RACISM

Just as cultural racism influences personally mediated racism, it is also the foundational base of systemic, structural, and institutional racism. All three terms are often used interchangeably, but *systemic racism* refers to the broad expanse of deeply embedded racism across nearly all aspects of society: education, employment, healthcare, housing, politics, and criminal justice (Braveman et al., 2022). *Structural racism* denotes the biased scaffolding of the different systems; the policies, formal and informal practices, written and unwritten rules and regulations, laws, entrenched norms, and standard operating procedures (SOPs). *Institutional racism* captures both qualities of systemic and structural racism, but is oftentimes used to deal with racism within a specific organization: schools, places of employment, hospitals, banks, etc. Table 7.1 lists examples of systemic racism in the United States that disadvantage, control, dominate, and harm POC. We also provide institutional and organizational examples by which racist policies and practices may operate. From the table, it should be quite obvious how cultural racism permeates nearly all aspects of life for POC.

These racial systems of oppression are populated by the many organizations and institutions that may carry out biased policies and practices that originate from cultural racism. Attempts to disrupt the dance of racism and to impact the individual performers must ultimately contend with the insidious and powerful source of bias emanating from both our institutions and from the cultural context. Thus, to have a lasting effect on breaking the dance of racism, change must be directed not only at the individual (micro) level, but at the systemic (macro) level as well.

Microaggressions and Macroaggressions: Distinctions and Focus

We have occasionally used the term “macroaggressions” with reference to systemic bias, but have not fully defined it. Sue et al. (2021) have coined the term “macroaggressions” to refer to the biased philosophy, policies, programs, or structures of our society and institutions. Macroaggressions may be codified into laws, customs, rules, and regulations that favor one group over another and create bias in employment practices (“first hired,

last fired”), economic disadvantage (redlining), discriminatory education (educational segregation), disempowered political representation (gerrymandering), unjust law enforcement policies (profiling), and inferior quality of healthcare. Although macroaggressions are synonymous with systemic racism, the focus of the former is on the active and dynamic manifestation of institutional racist bias, and especially how it differs from individual perpetrator behaviors such as microaggressions. Such a distinction is important, especially when we speak to the use of anti-bias strategies directed at either individual perpetrators or the bias emanating from institutions. The focus, goals, and impact are different from one another.

Table 7.1 Examples of Systemic and Structural Racism*

1. **Educational Bias and Inequities**
   Schools in Communities of Color are poorer; have fewer financial resources; more outdated textbooks; less qualified and fewer teachers; greater number of run-down classrooms and buildings; less likely to possess updated computers and digital-age equipment; and likely to contain biased curriculum that ignores or denigrates the heritage of POC. Students of Color are more likely to face greater disciplinary measures (suspensions and expulsions); less likely to be placed in gifted or advanced learning programs, given lower grades, and/or placed in slower learning groups or classes despite achieving equally to white students.
   Bias Manifestation: Nursery schools, preschools, childcare, primary-elementary schools, secondary-high schools, and universities.
2. **Employment Bias and Inequities**
   Black and Latinx employees are underrepresented in higher-paying jobs, less likely to be promoted when otherwise qualified, and paid less than their white counterparts doing the same job. Discrimination begins early in the hiring process: African Americans with "black-sounding names" were 50% less likely to receive interview callbacks than white applicants. Asian American managers need to be many times more qualified than their white counterparts in order to attain the same positions. Employees of Color were subjected to biased hiring, retention, and promotion criteria, were more likely to be fired, and were often segregated to lower-paying jobs.
   Bias Manifestation: The world of work and employment falls into many categories. For example, jobs or places of employment can come from the construction industry, agriculture, fashion, media, technology, financial services, healthcare, education, hospitality, and so on.
3. **Homeownership Bias and Inequities**
   Racism in housing has a long history dating back to the National Housing Act of 1934, when "redlining" was formalized. It restricted POC from living in newly established suburbs; to this day the practice continues to segregate POC to poorer neighborhoods; their homes are

significantly valued less. Just 44% of Black householders own their home compared with 73% of whites. Part of the segregation of African Americans is based on a common belief that if Blacks move into white neighborhoods, home prices will drop. It is also important to note that the lower value of Black homes means less ability to obtain loans; the loans are often lesser amounts (restricting capital accumulation and wealth) and come with exorbitantly higher interest costs when compared to that of whites.
Bias Manifestation: Homeownership bias is affected by many institutions in the political and financial sectors. In the financial world, they may include commercial banks, savings and loans, mortgage companies, insurance companies, and credit unions; and in the political world, it involves real estate appraisals and legislative actions.

4. **Criminal Justice Bias and Inequities**
Police violence is a leading cause of death for young Black men; POC represent 39% of the population but make up 60% of those incarcerated. Approximately 1 in every 1000 Black men is killed by police; those killed are more likely to be unarmed when compared to whites. Racial profiling is a reality in police work and results in 47% of wrongful convictions. Black drivers are 20% more likely to get stopped than white drivers. Facial recognition technology used in police work is 100 times more likely to misidentify Black and Asian faces; Native Americans had the highest false-positive rate. African Americans are given more severe sentences than their white counterparts for similar crimes. Police are more likely to be called to schools to deal with misbehaviors by Students of Color when compared to white students.
Bias Manifestation: The police and law enforcement, prosecution and trial courts, and detention and supervision by corrections agencies.

5. **Healthcare Bias and Inequities**
POC, especially African Americans, Latinx Americans, and Native Americans, face significant social and structural barriers trying to access quality healthcare. Communities of Color suffer from higher rates of illness, including diabetes, obesity, asthma, and heart disease;

Black Americans' life expectancy is 4 years lower than whites; and Native Americans have an even lower rate. In the practice of medicine, Black patients are significantly less likely to receive pain medication, and when provided, it is lower in dosage. There is a dominant historical belief that Blacks feel less pain. The type of medical care provided to Patients of Color is frequently transitory and superficial; less time is given by physicians to Patients of Color, and they are less likely to address the underlying medical issue.
Bias Manifestation: Hospitals, convalescent hospitals, health maintenance organizations, health clinics, nursing homes, extended care facilities, mental health or psychological services, and other institutions whose primary goal is the prevention and treatment of illness or mental disorders, hospice care, and the elderly.

6. **Political Bias and Inequities**
   Historically, overt laws segregating, oppressing, and disempowering POC are numerous (Jim Crow laws, the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882, laws forbidding Groups of Color owning land, not allowing them to testify in courts, forbidding them to marry, preventing them from voting, etc.). Current voter suppression laws mimic the historical disenfranchisement of POC through unfair voter ID laws, voter suppression, and gerrymandering strategies that state legislatures have chosen to restrict Communities of Color from political power. By deliberately redrawing electoral district boundaries to favor a political party, the votes of POC are made to count less. In August 29, 2025, for example, Texas Governor Greg Abbott signed into law a new congressional map that targeted Democratic seats in favor of Republicans.
   Bias Manifestation: The three branches of the federal government are (a) the executive branch—run by the President, (b) the legislative branch composed of the House of Representatives and the Senate, and (c) the judicial branch—the Supreme Court. It is important to note, however, that state, city, and local governmental institutions represent independently functioning entities in themselves.

7. **Immigration Policies and Inequities**
   Xenophobia, race, and racism have always been intertwined in immigration policies. From early on the question of who is worthy of

citizenship was always confined to “free white persons” of good character, and while millions of white immigrants (Irish, Italians, Germans, etc.) could lay claim to discrimination upon entering the country, they were eventually welcomed and could find employment. Immigrants from Africa, Asia, and Spanish-speaking countries, however, encountered stricter policies and mistreatment. The current political climate has raised the specter of racism through mass deportations, ending birthright citizenship, family separation, barring education and health services to migrants, and ending asylum policies. Cruelty, overt racism, and anti-immigrant demagoguery are encouraged through individual actions, political legislation, and discriminatory laws.

Bias Manifestation: The U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) under the auspices of Homeland Security provides benefits and services to immigrants—information, green cards, citizenship, etc., and the Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) enforces immigration laws. As the laws have become increasingly political, many institutions have formed to stop biased immigration policies and/or to aid immigrants in contrast to those devoted to strictly enforcing racist policies and actions.

8. **Other Systems of Bias and Inequities**
   The list of systemic racism is nearly endless: financial disparities, food insecurity, environmental racism, digital inequities, homeownership, and media portrayal and control all may represent biased systems of oppression that advantage white Americans over POC.

[*] Taken and adapted from: Braveman et al. (2022), Ten Examples of Systemic Racism in the USA (2024), and Key Examples of Systemic Racism in the U.S. (2024).

According to Sue et al. (2021), macroaggressions and microaggressions differ in three ways. First, the bias of microaggressions resides in individuals, such as their attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors, while macroaggressions originate from the biased programs, policies, and practices of institutions, communities, and society. Thus, the perpetrator may be either an individual or an organization. Second, microaggressions are usually directed toward a single individual or target, while

macroaggressions are group-focused and aimed at an entire marginalized class of people. A hospitalized white patient who questions the competence of a Black doctor, and refuses treatment affects an individual target. However, an organization's seniority policy, “last hired, first fired,” may unintentionally discriminate against a broad class of Employees of Color, because they are most likely to be the “last hired.” Third, to disarm or dismantle microaggressions means changing the individual bigotry of people, while dismantling macroaggressions requires changing institutional policies and practices that deny equal access and opportunity. The anti-bias strategies and goals used to combat individual or institutional racism are quite different from one another. In Chapters 8 and 9, we will directly deal with the use of anti-bias strategies (microinterventions) to disarm microaggressions and to dismantle macroaggressions.

Microaggressions and Macroaggressions: The Myth of Meritocracy

Although these distinctions are helpful, microaggressions and macroaggressions cannot be isolated from one another because they both originate from cultural racism and work in unison to perpetuate and reinforce the oppression of POC (Michaels et al., 2023; Skinner-Dorkenoo et al., 2021). As we have seen, the myth of meritocracy that arises from individualism is a deeply ingrained cultural narrative in our society. It's a belief that anyone, regardless of their race, ethnicity, or gender (color blindness) can succeed if they work hard enough (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). Meritocratic beliefs operate under an assumption of equal access and opportunity, that all individuals and groups function on a level playing field, and internal attributes ultimately determine one's status in life. It is a common belief that people who are highly successful have acquired their status in life through their own individual efforts, innate abilities, or motivations. On the flipside is the belief that those who are less successful or “fail” in life, possess fewer of these desired characteristics. Success or failure is, therefore, attributed to internal reasons (abilities, motivation, and ambition) rather than external ones (less opportunity, white privilege, poverty, and racism).

The myth of meritocracy is a common thread that not only runs through individual belief systems, but also through institutional assumptions and

policies. Biased performance appraisal systems used by business and industry serve gatekeeping functions determining who will be hired, retained, promoted, and fired. In business and industry, for example, hiring decisions are based upon the concept of “the most qualified candidate,” and in college admissions, test scores/grades are used to determine the highest-functioning student. The criteria used to evaluate qualifications are usually culture- and class-bound and based upon the concept of individual “merit.” The intersection of microaggressions and macroaggressions works together to advantage one group (White Americans) and to disadvantage others (Persons of Color). The belief that POC are inferior, less capable, less intelligent, and less motivated than their white counterparts (microaggressive messages) is supported by biased rules and regulations in the form of SOPs that appear race-neutral because they are applied equally to everyone.

Microaggressions and Macroaggressions: Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs)

Again, micro/macroaggressions are often expressed through SOPs of organizations. SOPs are written or unwritten rules or regulations in business, industry, education, or healthcare that spell out specifically how tasks are completed. These are often presented as flowcharts and bulleted steps and are hierarchical in nature. They are meant to improve efficiency and effectiveness and allow all employees to understand the process to be used in organizations. SOPs are believed to be unbiased and objective; they represent standardized procedures and are generally applied equally to the defined goals and/or the daily functioning of organizations. Because they are utilized uniformly for all employees, there is a common belief in organizations that equal treatment is fair treatment and, thus, cannot be discriminatory. However, SOPs infected by racism can be found in criteria used to hire or fire employees, are embedded in bank lending practices that disadvantage Borrowers of Color, and are in the judicial system exercising a color-blind policy (power denial). SOPs are oftentimes insidious in their day-to-day management of workspaces because they reflect an invisible white Western supremacy: dress codes (suits and not saris), “professional” and Western appearance (straight hair and not dreadlocks; beard bans),

speech and accent, restrained emotions (emotion is antagonistic to reason), Western-sounding names, communication styles, etc.

Among one of the most biased SOPs that impacts POC in the workforce, and oftentimes in determining their employability, is the concept of "cultural fit" (Bye et al., 2014). Although cultural fit has a positive impact on job performance, retention, and job satisfaction for employees who share the same values and background as other white employees, it can also be a euphemism for racial discrimination. Almost all organizations use some form of cultural fit in the hiring process, but it can also influence the retention and promotion process as well (Rivera, 2012). When encountering prospective job applicants, white hiring managers may personally relate better to white candidates than Applicants of Color, feel more comfortable with them, and describe them as "someone I'd go to lunch with." POC who may not share the majority group values, behaviors, interests, customs, communication styles, and even physical appearance/dress are considered less desirable (Bye et al., 2014). As indicated earlier, this is a prime example of how whiteness privileges some, but disadvantages others. Cultural fit, when used in an unenlightened manner, may be an expression of systemic and institutional racism.

In conclusion, the relationship between individual racial biases and actions, coupled with other systems of oppression, fortifies bias and discrimination (Skinner-Dorkenoo et al., 2021). White Americans frequently act out their entrenched biases that are supported by institutional customs and rules and, at the same time, reinforce and enforce them through applying SOPs to POC. In other words, the active manifestation of macroaggressions is still individually mediated; people act as agents of institutions by applying biased rules and regulations.

THE INTERLOCKING RELATIONSHIP OF RACISM

Figure 7.1 visually depicts the interrelationship of cultural, institutional, and individual racism and how they support, enforce, and reinforce the deadly dance of racism for individual performers. Note that the arrows linking the components of racism are bi-directional. Cultural, institutional, and

individual racism are not isolated from one another nor linear in their impact, but rather symbiotically interrelated to one another. When individuals express their racial biases, they are acting out not only their individual beliefs about race, but they are also supported and reinforced by prejudicial institutional norms. Likewise, when individuals carry out racially biased policies and practices of institutions and society, they, in turn, reaffirm and legitimize structural and systemic inequities. Cultural racism, from which these biases originate, becomes fortified, more ingrained, and unquestioned whenever individual and institutional racism function in harmony with one another (Skinner-Dorkenoo et al., 2021).

As we have repeatedly stressed, the overarching umbrella of cultural racism is imposed upon individuals through a painful process of socialization and cultural conditioning in the belief that white western values and traditions are superior to all other groups. These standards are executed and enforced through racist individual actions, and by the programs, policies, and practices of systemic, structural, and institutional racism. On an individual level, the dance of racism involves the dynamic and symbiotic interplay of multiple roles: perpetrator, target, ally, and bystander. These roles do not occur in a vacuum, but follow racist scripts and norms, social influence dynamics, and the relationships dancers have to one another. Breaking the deadly dance of racism may be ineffective if anti-bias strategies are only directed at the individual level. It is not enough to concentrate simply on individual change. Becoming white allies, for example, can be harshly punished by institutional rules and regulations that ostracize them, lower their performance ratings, withhold promotions, and even end their employment (institutional backlash). In other words, it does little good for white allies, targets, and bystanders to be nonracist (having broken the racism dance as individuals) when the very organizations that influence their lives are set to punish them for their newfound anti-bias identities and actions. In a symbiotic relationship between organizations and individuals, people depend on institutions to support, validate, and protect them; likewise, organizations depend upon individuals to carry out their racist systemic policies and to preserve the illusion of fairness. Breaking this symbiotic cycle is a monumental task.

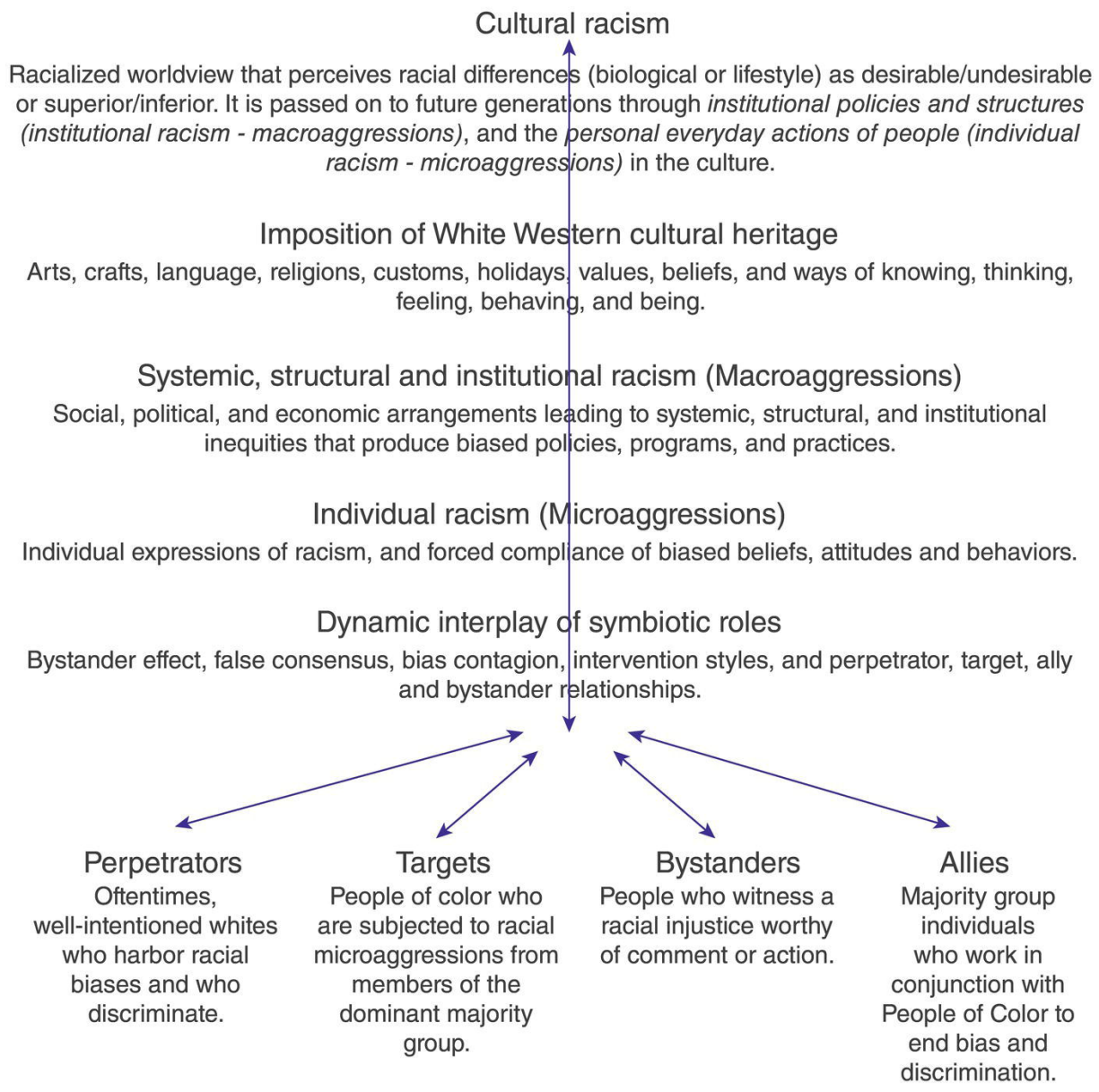

Figure 7.1 Deadly Dance of Racism

INSTITUTIONAL AND CULTURAL CHANGE

Our journey into an understanding of cultural and systemic racism may make anti-racist change appear overwhelming and hopelessly futile. You might be asking: “What can I, a single individual, do to change the biased nature of organizations? How can I convince business, industry and governmental entities to change their oppressive policies and practices? After all, I'm only one person!” The feelings of powerlessness and

hopelessness are legitimate feelings because systemic change is formidable when viewed against the actions of a single individual, and when expectations for immediate change are unrealistically high. Bleakness about future change, however, only provides an excuse for personal inaction and for maintaining the status quo (King et al., 2022). We need to realize that institutional change rarely, if ever, comes from the efforts of a solitary individual, but rather through collaborative group determination and struggle.

To address systemic change means social advocacy, working with other like-minded individuals, and forming collaborative partnerships or coalitions to address and change the inequities of society (Watson-Thompson et al., 2022). Intentional culture change, whether it be directed at an institution or to society at large, often involves conflict, power struggles, and, in the larger scheme of things, protest and persuasion, and even civil disobedience (Hamedani et al., 2024; Sue, 2008). Further, most institutional changes are incremental, long-term, and marked with successes and failures. Impatience and an unrealistic expectation of quick solutions will lead to disappointment and helplessness. Cultural and systemic change is "not a sprint, but a marathon," requires the effort of many committed individuals, and requires a multisystem approach (Affinity, 2023; Buchanan et al., 2021; Watson-Thompson et al., 2022). With respect to the latter point, organizations are composed of many systems, and a change in one inevitably impacts others; some may resist the changes unless they, too, share common goals of equity. In the next two sections, we focus on anti-racist change in particular institutions, and then turn our attention to more global cultural change in our society. Because organizations and societal traditions differ, it is impossible to suggest changes relevant to the uniqueness of these entities in this chapter. Systemic change in law enforcement, for example, is different than that in education or healthcare. Likewise, social change with regard to social policies, customs, and those codified in law requires a different focus and different strategies with regard to voter rights, environmental racism, and affirmative action. Since addressing all of these different institutional and societal issues is unfeasible, we have chosen to provide general principles for anti-racist organizational and cultural change.

Disarming Institutional Racism: General Guidelines

As we have repeatedly stressed, institutional racism may occur in the policies and practices of schools, hospitals, clinics, law firms, retail establishments, grocery stores, and many other places of employment. The goals of institutional change are (a) to create a workplace that allows for equal access and opportunity, (b) to eliminate racially biased rules, regulations, and customs, and/or (c) to create and enact new procedures and policies that discourage, prevent, and guard against prejudice and discrimination in the workplace (American Psychological Association, 2021; King et al., 2022; Pieterse et al., 2023). Depending on the specific organization and its identified racial barriers, actions may involve implementing microaggression training for all employees, changing culturally biased recruitment and hiring criteria to encourage diverse applicant pools, identifying and restructuring performance appraisal systems that are culturally unbiased, instituting formal and informal open communication from Employees of Color, creating mentoring systems that are culturally informed, identifying and eliminating hostile and invalidating work environments, designing work climates of openness, safety, and validation for diverse employees, and so forth (Sue, 2008; Sue et al., 2021). As Table 7.1 reveals, there is no dearth of biased policies and practices in organizations that need to be addressed.

The task of addressing institutional racism in business and industry, education, or healthcare is formidable. It is impossible to cover the wide range of organizations and situations that present themselves. Combatting systemic racism means starting at a place that directly affects you and your family, friends, and colleagues. As individual citizens, for example, we function in many institutions that may require anti-racist intervention and change. We may have children attending a school district whose curriculum is primarily white Western European in focus. It ignores the contributions of different racial groups, presents stereotypes of POC, and not only alienates Students of Color but also presents a false racial reality to their white counterparts. For Parents of Color and white parent allies, efforts can be directed at school leadership to make the curriculum relevant to all groups. Or, we may be employed in a business where the hiring, retention, and promotion criteria are biased against Employees of Color. Efforts to change the policies and practices of the institution means using strategies to bring

awareness to upper management and encourage change. In this section, we propose some general principles and guidelines to use in approaching institutional change. With specific organizations, intervention in programs and policies may differ, but some common guidelines can be identified.

Anti-Racist Organizations

An anti-racist organization or place of employment does not currently exist, but some are more open, unbiased, and fair than others (Sue et al., 1998). Like our own individual development, becoming an anti-racist institution is more a journey than an end point and more aspirational than actualized. Helping organizations move from their monocultural and biased identities means having a working definition of anti-racist organizations. We use the term "multicultural organizations" in this book synonymously with anti-racist organizations because equal access and opportunity apply to all socially devalued groups in society (Sue, 1995; Sue, 2008). We use an adapted aspirational working definition of a multicultural organization proposed by Barr and Strong (1988, p. 20) to make it current and relevant to anti-racist guidelines for institutional transformation. The key points in their definition are highlighted below.

A multicultural (anti-racist) organization is (a) genuinely committed (***action as well as words***) to diverse representation throughout its organization and at ***all*** levels, (b) sensitive to ***maintaining an open, supportive,*** and ***responsive*** environment, (c) working toward and ***purposefully*** including elements of diverse cultures in its ongoing operations (organizational policies and practices are carefully monitored to the goals of multiculturalism), and (e) ***authentic*** in responding to issues confronting it (commitment to changing policies and practices that block cultural diversity and creating new ones that enhance inclusion and equity). From this definition of anti-racist organizations, a number of institutional characteristics that facilitate diversity, equity, and inclusion can be listed (Sue et al., 1998).

1. ***Encourage Strong Commitment of Leadership to Anti-Racist Goals and Initiatives*.** Needless to say, those at the very top of organizations have the power and influence to change corporate culture, and to model allegiance to diversity goals (Affinity, 2023; Greene, 2020).

Workers are very tuned in, for example, to not only what the CEO or upper management professes, but to their actions in promoting equity in the workforce. Thus, employees are likely to take notice and to be swayed by the CEO and upper management in business and industry, by the president, provost, or board of trustees in higher education, by the superintendent or principal of elementary/secondary school districts, and so forth.

2. ***Develop a Written Anti-Racist Vision and Policy Statement that are Meaningfully Operationalized*.** With the murder of George Floyd and with the rise of the *Black Lives Matter* movement, companies and organizations rushed to issue anti-blackness statements regarding their institutions and their stand in society (Hamedani et al., 2024). These were often beautifully crafted, full of flowery language, and truly inspiring, but lacked specificity in how companies would change, and how they would implement anti-racist policies. Unless operationalized, such statements will remain cosmetic features more for public relations than actual implementation (Sue, 2008).
3. ***Implement an Anti-Racist and Diversity Action Plan with Clear Objectives and Timelines*.** When a company identifies biased policies and practices that discriminate against Employees of Color, inaction and delay seem to be the rule rather than the exception in executing change (Affinity, 2023). Organizations often spend an inordinate amount of time and energy in ascertaining problematic racist policies, discussing their detrimental impact, and recommending change. Unless clear objectives and specific timelines are established, these recommendations will languish in perpetuity (White, 2022).
4. ***Empower Superordinate Anti-Racist Oversight Monitoring, such as Specific Individuals, Teams, or Units*.** The ultimate measure of a company's actual commitment to anti-racist change is whether the individual or group has the power and authority to assess, develop, monitor, and enforce goals. Too often companies are well-intentioned in their multicultural goals, but place DEI leadership in an advisory capacity; power still resides in higher-level individuals or departments who often accept the report, but “sit on it” (Sue et al., 1998).

5. ***Develop an Open Feedback Mechanism to and from Underrepresented Groups to Upper-Level Management.*** Oftentimes, organizations will make inaccurate assumptions about the needs and/or satisfactions of Employees of Color. Some may even be averse to, or apprehensive about "opening up a can of worms" and choose to remain ignorant of problematic biased situations in the workforce. If an institution is sincere and willing to face unpleasantries about how it treats Employees of Color, then it must listen to the voices of those most marginalized and oppressed (Bohonos & Sisco, 2021). Employees of Color provide a rich source of information concerning the issues and concerns within an organization.
6. ***Ensure Accountability of Individuals and Department Units to Anti-Racist Operations and Goals.*** The easiest way to initiate movement is to make certain individuals (department heads, supervisors, and managers) responsible and accountable for measurable anti-racist outcomes. In higher education, for example, the Chair of the Department and recruitment/hiring committees are explicitly made responsible for, and evaluated on, their ability to recruit, retain, and hire Faculty of Color, and for making the curriculum multicultural (Affinity, 2023).
7. ***Make Multicultural Competence a Part of the Hiring and Promotion Criteria for Upper-Level Leadership (Executives, Managers, Supervisors, etc.) and for Employees and Stakeholders.*** Such a move may be met with considerable resistance because performance appraisal systems are usually defined in such a manner as to advantage certain groups and disadvantage other (Greene, 2020). Because POC have had to become bicultural to survive, they may possess an advantage in possessing qualities considered cultural competence (Sue et al., 1998). Likewise, white candidates that do not possess experience in working with POC and who lack sensitivity and understanding of race and racism would be considered less viable candidates.
8. ***Develop and Institutionalize Culturally Relevant Mentorship for POC.*** For many white Americans, formal and informal mentorship already exist in the "old boy's network." POC are often placed in the unenviable position of negotiating the corporate world (primarily white) on their own, or with assigned mentors who have little

understanding of race and racism (Bohonos & Sisco, 2021; Sue et al., 1998). Many nontraditional workers are unfamiliar with the corporate culture and the many hidden rules, regulations, and customs. Companies often simply assign mentors to Employees of Color who often operate from a color-blind frame. Culturally appropriate mentorship may differ from traditional white Western networks.

9. ***Encourage Coalition Building and Networking Between and Among POC.*** Employees of Color often experience the work culture as alienating, invalidating, and even hostile to their group identities and lived experiences (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). The sense of isolation and loneliness increases as they move up the corporate ladder because POC are concentrated primarily at the lower levels of employment. Coalition building and networking allow Employees of Color to affirm their identities, provide social support and advice to one another, let one another know that they are not alone, and grant them added strength and safety to bring issues to management, especially when the leadership is open and receptive.
10. ***Commit to Long-Term and Continuing Anti-Racist Education and Training for the Entire Workforce.*** Such training would include implicit bias training, especially the manifestation, dynamics, and impact of microaggressions in the world of work, but also issues of institutional racism (macroaggressive policies, practices, and programs that block equal access and opportunity). Such events may include in-service training, discussion groups among Employees of Color, focus groups, management training, etc. The main issue is that training must reach the entire workforce, including management and the upper echelons of organizational power and influence (Sue et al., 1998).

Persuading and convincing organizations to attune to diversity, equity, and inclusion are not individual ventures, but rooted in the efforts of many concerned people; targets, white allies, and well-intentioned bystanders. This is not to discourage individuals from “speaking up” when they note the unfairness of a policy, but once a racist institutional bias is identified, the voices of many are needed to institute macro-level changes. In Chapter 9, we will devote considerable attention to how individuals and groups can take anti-bias actions (microinterventions) against macroaggressions.

Cultural Racism and Societal Change: General Lessons

Implementing individual and institutional changes is challenging, but most of us believe they are possible with sustained expertise and effort. Cultural change, however, seems like a massive and impossible undertaking because culture occupies all aspects of our lives; it is in the air we breathe and in the water we drink. The form and meaning we derive about life come from our histories, narratives, mores, music, literature, symbols, language, and traditions; they provide us with what is "true," moral, good, right and wrong, and how life should be lived (Amenta & Polletta, 2019; Hamedani et al., 2024). This is especially so with respect to racial realities or how white Americans perceive issues of race or racism (Sue, 2015). Yet, the history of the United States is the history of cultural change, albeit slow, tedious, oftentimes painful, and full of conflict and resistance (Sue et al., 2021). Social or cultural change seems to occur through (a) external revolutions (technological advancement—industrial revolution, invention of the automobile, smartphone, Internet, artificial intelligence (AI), and social media) or exigencies (climate change, COVID pandemic, natural disasters, etc.), (b) evolutionary attitude change (decline in smoking, mandatory use of seatbelts, acceptability of divorce, single parenthood, churchgoing, etc.), and (c) intentional efforts (civil rights, LGBTQ+ rights, marriage equality, etc.) (Newport, 2021).

In a groundbreaking article entitled "We Built This Culture (So We Can Change It)," Hamedani et al. (2024) introduce the term *intentional culture change*. They note that calls for culture change are prominent because of widespread dissatisfaction with the status quo (governmental agencies, law enforcement, criminal justice, pornography, education, unfair workplaces, voter rights, gun control, and pollution), and the belief that culture has become dysfunctional, outdated, and even toxic in the lives of its citizens. Intentional culture change is defined as "actively and deliberately modifying the mutually reinforcing features of a culture. These features include collective narratives, representations, policies, practices, norms, products, attitudes, beliefs and behaviors" (p. 385). Dismantling cultural racism is a formidable task but seemingly achievable when we turn to lessons learned from social movements like women's suffrage, Me Too, Occupy Wall Street, LGBTQ+ rights, and legalization of same-sex marriage (Hamedani et al., 2024). But is it possible to impact cultural racism that is

so rooted in our society. Hope and optimism can be found in social revolutions like the abolition of slavery, civil rights, Brown vs. Board of Education, the Third World Movement, the Ethnic Studies Movement, and Black Lives Matter (BLM). Lessons that can be derived from social movements are plentiful, but we list only a few here.

Lesson One—Collective Action

One of the major lessons learned from social movements is that of *collective action*; the achievements of social change cannot be accomplished by a single individual, but by the efforts of many like-minded social advocates (DeLeon, 2010; Uchino, 2009). Demands to end systemic racism are likely to bring pushback and punitive actions from the status quo in an effort to preserve, protect, and perpetuate its hallowed customs and practices. One person engaging in anti-racism work has little influence or power to effect change, is vulnerable to retribution, prone to "burnout" and racial battle fatigue, and likely to become ineffective (Uchino, 2009; van Zomeren et al., 2008). Belonging to and collaborating with a group of like-minded individuals, sharing similar values and goals, affording aid, comfort, and knowledge to one another, diminishing power differentials, and providing greater safety and protection, but more importantly, validating the anti-racist cause is paramount to perseverance and continued struggle (Sue et al., 2021; van Zomeren et al., 2008).

Lesson Two—Monopolies of Power

Many assume that racial disparities are due to misunderstandings, miscommunication, inadequate information, and biased beliefs and attitudes. Racism, they believe, can be minimized or eliminated through simply educating others, by correcting misunderstandings, by providing accurate information about racial groups, and by increasing communication between the parties. Although these seem to play a significant role in overcoming racism at the individual level, the primary culprit or barrier to cultural change may be the monopolies of power and privilege embedded in the fabric of our culture (Michaels et al., 2023; Sue, 2008). In one of the basic principles of intentional culture change, Hamedani et al. (2024) state: "Culture change typically involves power struggles and identity threats. Resistance is a normal and expected part of the culture change process" (p.

394). As we have indicated in Chapter 1, the changing complexion of society has triggered a backlash against POC, where their increased presence threatens a way of life. Diversity initiatives are seen as threats, teaching race and racism in classrooms destabilizes the master narrative, and DEI programs in business and industry jeopardize those who hold power and privilege in our society.

Lesson Three—Conflict and Struggle

It is important to recognize that where race and racism are involved, conflict and struggle will naturally ensue from a white supremacist society that is averse to change. Studies on intentional culture change suggest that it is most likely to occur when "top-down" and "bottom-up" pressures are in alignment with one another (Hamedani et al., 2024). With respect to cultural racism, however, there is a misalignment between those at the "top" (whites who hold power and privilege, who benefit from the present status quo, and who have the ability to block change) and those at the "bottom" (POC who are marginalized, disadvantaged, and disempowered). Having less power and status in society means that collective action is even more important. In this case, targets, white allies, and socially conscious bystanders need to join other activists, community organizers, grassroots organizations, and human rights associations to minimize the power imbalance required for change (Sue et al., 2021). Social advocacy, persuasion, protests, and even civil disobedience have become the defining features of the civil rights movement. Demands for equal rights are often characterized by confrontation, antagonism, and refusing to obey biased laws; indeed, some social movements have even broken just laws in order to bring attention to the unjust ones. We will describe some of these strategies in the next chapter, but it is important to acknowledge that cultural change not only comes with conflict and struggle but often violence as well. Thus, those who are engaged in intentional culture change must be prepared to face the reality of their change efforts and the potential negative consequences that may ensue.

Lesson Four—Racial Socialization

"Prevention is better than remediation." This statement is particularly powerful when applied to cultural racism and the narratives that it instills in

all of us. Throughout this book, we have stressed how all of us are born, raised, and socialized into a white supremacist world, taught to believe in one group's superiority and another group's inferiority, have inherited the biases and prejudices of the society, and view our world through a white and color-blind lens. Almost all our intervention strategies to combat cultural racism are directed toward remediation efforts: initiatives on implicit bias training, passing laws that prevent institutional racism, changing existing biased narratives—removing harmful symbols of white racial superiority or denigration of group identities (Confederate flags, Native American mascots, etc.), and celebrating and amplifying contributions of POC.

In other words, we are attempting to remediate the aftereffects of racism, which are already present in all of us due to a biased and flawed socialization process. Were we able to prevent the formation of these biased worldviews through how we raise our children, how we teach them to value diversity, and how we instill in them anti-racist attitudes and behaviors, then remediation would be less important and pressing. Indeed, it is our position that one of the most potent means of combatting racism is through the racial socialization process. How do we raise race-conscious children as parents, caretakers, significant others, and teachers? In Chapter 10, we spend considerable time addressing the issue and importance of raising race-conscious but anti-racist children.

CONCLUSIONS—LOOKING AHEAD

Throughout the book, we have tried to provide suggestions of how targets, white allies, and well-intentioned bystanders can break the deadly dance of racism, what personal changes need to occur within them, and how they can move to being an anti-racist. In Chapter 1 we described three needed internal developments in anti-racism work: critical consciousness (the ability to make racism visible), self-reckoning (understanding yourself as a racial/cultural being), and becoming anti-racist (action, not just words). When all three become integrated into your identity, then learning the tools and strategies to combat racism is the next step to social advocacy.

In the next three chapters, we turn our attention to anti-racist intervention strategies that can be used to combat individual, institutional, and cultural

racism. One of the major findings from our work is that the motivation to combat racism is not enough without the awareness, knowledge, and skills needed to disarm or dismantle racism. In work with individuals who recognize microaggressions and macroaggressions, they often feel paralyzed about what to do. In other words, it is not that targets and well-intentioned allies are unwilling to intervene and confront racism; it is simply that they do not know how to intervene. That is the topic of the next two chapters, using microintervention, using microintervention tactics to address micro/macroaggressions.

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PART FOUR
Anti-Bias Strategies and Actions to Challenge Individual, Institutional, and Cultural Racism

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CHAPTER EIGHT
Microintervention Strategies to Disrupt, Diminish, and Dismantle Racism: Arming Targets, Bystanders, and White Allies

If you recall, in Chapter 1 we presented a dance metaphor of a racist joke being told by a perpetrator before an audience of onlookers. We used it as an example of how racist comments or actions are allowed to occur in everyday interactions. We suggested that when a racist expression goes unchallenged, it could be seen as a form of complicity on the part of those witnessing a racial transgression. In the scenario, we hypothesized four different roles played by the individuals involved: perpetrator, target, bystander, and white ally. The hypothetical scenario was the following:

> At a social event, a small group of people are gathered around a jokester, telling an offensive racist joke. As the punchline is delivered, some are obviously distressed by the joke, while others appear oblivious to the racist connotation. Those in the audience who disapproved of the story, however, remain silent, and some even feigned laughter.

We indicated how each role contributed to the racism dance through inaction, silence, or willful avoidance/ignorance, and that each character faced (a) personal inhibitions that allowed a racist event to go uncontested, (b) powerful social influence dynamics like the "bystander effect," social scripts, and ground rules that prevent racial dialogues, and (c) systemic and cultural racism that socializes and enforces individuals into their passive and racist social roles. The main focus of previous chapters was on the challenges facing targets, bystanders, and white allies that prevented them from taking anti-racist actions; what they needed to do to overcome inaction; and their personal development from a racist to a non-racist, and finally to an anti-racist identity.

Even when well-intentioned individuals feel the need to intervene and disrupt the dance of racism, many have indicated they become paralyzed and are at a loss of what to do (Alsaidi, 2021; Sue et al., 2019). Most have

very limited experience of how to intervene, lack anti-racist skills, and by the time they decide on an action, the problematic situation has ended. Exercising microintervention strategies and anti-racism actions are not necessarily complicated, but they need to be identified, practiced and rehearsed so they become part of an individual's repertoire of automatic responses (American Psychological Association, 2022; Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008, 2014; Jones & Rolon-Dow, 2018; Scully & Rowe, 2009; Sue et al., 2019). In most expressions of racist bias, the interventions to disarm them are not particularly complex (Awad & Connors, 2023; Byrd, 2018). Let us use the racist joke scenario as an example of how targets, white allies and well-intentioned bystanders might respond.

> ***Target Response***. "I know you meant that to be funny, but it really hurts and offends me."
>
> ***Bystander***. "Ouch!" "I don't find it funny at all." *Or* "What makes that funny?"
>
> ***White Ally Response***. "I don't appreciate racist jokes!" Or "Whoa, let's not go there!"

Although these microinterventions might seem like "small things," and you might wonder how impactful they can be, research on similar anti-bias responses suggests they have major macro-impact not only on the perpetrator, but on targets and bystanders as well (Egan-Kunicki & Saris-Baglama, 2024; Faller et al., 2023; Sue et al., 2021). Why such brief anti-racist actions are so effective and helpful in disarming racism will be discussed shortly.

In this chapter, we focus on the strategies, tactics, and skills that anyone (targets, white allies, and bystanders) may use to disarm, negate, or dismantle individual and institutional expressions of racism. First, we define the concepts and characteristics of microinterventions (anti-bias responses), their objectives and goals, and the ultimate impact they have on the parties involved. Second, we provide a microintervention framework of "best practices" with numerous strategies derived from the work of Sue et al. (2019, 2021) and from education and training programs, especially in medicine, on how best to intervene (Fu et al., 2024; Govindraj et al., 2024; Grass et al., 2024; Walker et al., 2022). Last, we provide specific examples

of tactics to use in the presence of microaggressions. These anti-racist responses, comebacks, and strategies can be used by anyone when confronting microaggressions.

MICROINTERVENTIONS: WHAT ARE THEY?

Many believe that combatting racial prejudice, stereotyping, and discrimination expressed by family, friends, neighbors, casual acquaintances, and strangers requires actions and skills beyond the purview of ordinary citizens. Work on anti-racism bias, however, suggests that almost any responsible individual in their everyday lives can take action to combat bias and bigotry with only minimal training and experience (Alsaidi, 2021; Ashburn-Nardo et al., 2008; Sue et al., 2021). Anti-bias actions frequently labeled *microinterventions* can be directed toward individual perpetrators (microaggressions) or biased institutional policies and practices (macroaggressions). Just as it is important to distinguish microaggressions from macroaggressions, so too is the distinction between microinterventions and *macrointerventions*.

Microinterventions are individual anti-bias actions aimed at perpetrators or institutional policies and practices; they are intended to neutralize or disarm microaggressions or to dismantle macroaggressions (Sue et al., 2021). Several examples of microintervention actions taken by a target, white ally, and bystander toward a perpetrator telling a racist joke have already been given. Note that these microinterventions are directed toward an individual's racist attitudes, beliefs, or behaviors. When individual actions, however, are directed toward an organization's biased policy or practice and *result in institutional change*, we refer to this as a *macrointervention*. Macrointerventions are the actual elimination of a biased policy or practice in organizations and society; it may also entail creating and implementing systemic change through a new policy, tradition, custom, or law aimed at ending discrimination and/or allowing for equal access and opportunity. Examples of macrointerventions vary from major legal rulings (abolition of slavery, Civil Rights Act of 1964, overturning the “separate but equal doctrine,” and so forth) to changes in societal norms and customs (NASCAR's banning of the flying of the Confederate flag at all racing events, removing demeaning mascots and racist monuments among sports

teams and municipalities, etc.) and to establishing workplace initiatives (implementing diversity training in organizations, mandating microaggression training for employees, creating affirmative hiring practices, and making educational curriculum multicultural).

The strategies and goals to address systemic change (macroaggressions) may differ from individual change (microaggressions), but they all require individual or collective action (microinterventions) on the part of many well-intentioned individuals to achieve (macrointerventions). In other words, microinterventions are the basic tools that bring about both individual and systemic changes. In the following sections, we rely heavily on the work of Sue et al. (2019, 2021; Alsaidi, 2021; Awad & Connors, 2023) in their taxonomy of microinterventions and the strategies and tactics used to address microaggressions and macroaggressions.

Microinterventions

Microinterventions are the "everyday anti-bias actions taken by targets, white allies, and bystanders to counteract, challenge, diminish, or neutralize individual (microaggressions) and institutional/societal (macroaggressions) expressions of prejudice, bigotry, and discrimination" (Sue et al., 2021, p. 30). The primary goals of microinterventions directed at microaggressions are to (a) make the perpetrator aware of what they have said or done, (b) indicate they have engaged in actions offensive to you or others, (c) force them to consider the racist meaning of their behaviors, and, finally, (d) stop or end such demeaning conduct.

What people seldom realize is that there are secondary benefits to those who engage in anti-racist actions as well (Alsaidi, 2021; Byrd, 2018; Ong et al., 2023; Scully & Rowe, 2009). First, they serve to enhance psychological well-being and provide targets, allies, and bystanders with a sense of control and self-efficacy. Second, they provide a repertoire of responses that can be used to directly disarm or counteract the effects of micro- and macroaggressions by challenging perpetrators and systems of oppression. Third, when others object to or challenge biased expressions, it models anti-racist behaviors and encourages onlookers to not remain passive during racist encounters. Last, although some may perceive microinterventions to be small and insignificant actions that potentially trivialize the power of racism, many scholars have suggested that the everyday interventions of

allies and well-intentioned bystanders have a profound positive effect in creating an inclusive and welcoming environment, discouraging negative behavior, challenging false consensus, and reinforcing a norm that values respectful interactions (Ashburn-Nardo, 2018; Scully & Rowe, 2009; Sue et al., 2021). In other words, microinterventions can have a *macro*-impact by creating a societal climate in public forums, employment settings, and educational institutions that encourage the positive and discourage the negative.

Sue et al. (2019, 2021; Alsaidi, 2021; Awad & Connors, 2023) have developed a conceptual framework identifying three types of microinterventions that individuals can use in microaggressive situations: (a) microaffirmations, (b) microchallenges, and (c) microprotections.

Microaffirmations

Chantel was attending an emergency managerial meeting called by her male CEO boss. She was only one of two managers of color, and the only African American in a group of a dozen men. The give and take of ideas expressed in the meeting was fast paced. As always, when Chantel voiced her ideas, she was often ignored, cut off in mid-sentence, or "talked over." One white male manager noticed the ready dismissal of her ideas and made the following comments: **"There are many good options here, but I'm interested in Chantel's idea."** Turning to Chantel, he said, "**Could you expand upon your solution?"** At that point, everyone turned to Chantel and listened to her ideas.

In this scenario, which occurs all too frequently to Women of Color, Chantel experienced a number of microaggressions from fellow white managers: her comments were ignored and not given much weight. To them, she was invisible! The microaggressive meta-communications being sent to her were: "Your ideas are not worthy of consideration." "You are not competent and capable." "Just sit there and be quiet." "Let us white men take the steering wheel." If Chantel were to object to how she was being treated, she might be told to "be more assertive" and to "speak up more" in presenting her ideas. More devastating would be the evaluation of peers that she is "overly sensitive" and "paranoid" about her treatment. In other words, victim-blaming and gaslighting are often the outcome for people of color (POC).

When the male colleague (white ally or bystander) intervened and made his observations, however, he was engaging in a microintervention that directly changed the outcome of the interactions. His actions deflected and ended the microaggressions, altered the flow of interactions, may have brought awareness to male colleagues that they have ignored Chantel's ideas, and indicated that at least one member of the team valued her input. In essence, his two-sentence statement not only stopped the microaggressive interactions, but sent a counter-communication to Chantel: “You have good ideas that are worthy of consideration. I value you as a colleague. I view you as a competent member of this team, so do not give up. I support you. I see and hear you.” Her male ally had engaged in a microaffirmation: “Small acts that validate and affirm a person's humanity, racial/cultural identity, experiential reality, and worth or value. They make a person feel welcomed, seen, heard, respected, valued, supported, and affirmed” (Sue et al., 2021, p. 30).

Microaffirmations can be delivered in the form of microcompliments (*That took courage to say. I admire what you just did*.), microsupports (*I'm here if you need me. I support you. You have my vote. You are not alone*.), or microvalidations (*Don't doubt yourself. You're not crazy! You are reading the situation correctly*.). The concept of microaffirmations was first posed by Mary Rowe as early as 1973 (Rowe, 2008). She found that these tiny acts of support, caring, listening, and generosity by others served to neutralize “microinequities” (microaggressions) from individuals and lessen the alienation from macroaggressions (especially from a hostile and invalidating organizational climate). Recently, a number of scholars have demonstrated how microaffirmations can be used effectively in a variety of situations (Boyce-Rosen & Macadon-Mann, 2023; Jones & Rolon-Dow, 2018; Koch et al., 2025). The research on “racial uplifts” or “simple acts of kindness,” for example, has found such behaviors to increase self-esteem, ethnic bonding, and subjective well-being, and they potentially immunize targets against microaggressions (Boothby & Bohns, 2021; Hui et al., 2020; Ong et al., 2023). These researchers concluded that “a little good goes a long way” and that most people underestimate the powerful and positive impact on recipients (Kumar & Epley, 2023).

Microchallenges

Hank, a no-nonsense supervisor who resented the company's affirmative action hiring initiative was recently informed that Ricardo, a new Latino worker was being assigned to his team. When informed in the presence of several co-workers, Hank appeared irritated at the news, rolled his eyes, sneered disapprovingly, and made the following statement: “Those people are so lazy that everyone will have to pick up the slack. Next thing we know, they'll be requesting to take their afternoon siestas!” One of the employees looked at Hank and said **“That's a racist statement! Those types of comments go against our company's code of conduct.”**

Microchallenges are direct action strategies aimed at disarming microaggressions through forceful and confrontational means. The primary goal is to stop or deflect the microaggression, force the perpetrator to consider what they have said or done, and communicate disapproval to the offender (Sue et al., 2019, 2021). In the above case, the microchallenge was clear and explicit and put the supervisor on notice that others did not agree with his statement, that it was against company policy, and that such language should stop. An important thing to note, however, is that the white ally never asserted that the supervisor was “racist,” but that his behavior was unacceptable. Although seemingly a small thing, this distinction is important to make because it lowers defensiveness. We will elaborate on this point shortly, but note that microchallenges directed at individual and interpersonal microaggressions can be used to contest or neutralize the biased behaviors of individuals, but that a different class of strategies is needed to confront macroaggressions or systemic bias.

When racially biased policies and practices are involved, microchallenges may still be directed at individuals, because the rules and regulations of organizations are still carried out by people, usually by those who occupy positions of power and authority. In other words, the application of racist policies and practices is mediated by people, so appealing to the benevolence and fairness of those in authority, the decision-makers, or those who create the policies, customs, and laws of organizations about ending systemic bias is still interpersonally focused. When fair-mindedness is an ineffective appeal, however, more forceful microchallenges may be required. Ending a biased policy means altering systems of oppression, privilege, and power that are immune to appeals of goodwill. As a result,

efforts to change may involve resistance, persuasion, cajoling, protest, and even rebellion by a collection of concerned individuals. Demonstrations, social advocacy, and even civil disobedience are meant to confront, provoke, defy, and even sabotage unjust rules and regulations. In the next chapter, we will describe these microchallenges in addressing systemic and institutional racism and specific actions that targets, allies, and bystanders can take to confront and/or disarm institutional racism.

Microprotections

Jamel, an 18-year-old African American asked for the keys to his parent's car to meet friends at the local shopping mall "to hang out." Before handing him the keys, however, the father asked Jamal to sit on the sofa for their frequent talks about "driving while Black (DWB)." The father emphasized to the teenager society's perception of Black men as dangerous, and how he could be stopped by police because of profiling. He stressed the importance of understanding the "mind of whites" and rehearsed with his son the need to be courteous and respectful, to obey their commands, not to make any sudden moves, and to keep his hands in plain sight. He ended the conversation by saying: "We know who we are son…no one will make us feel humiliated at being Black. We're Black and proud of it!" He hugged his son and told him he was loved.

Microprotections are the everyday actions by parents, caretakers, teachers, and significant others in the lives of young POC who teach them the reality of racism (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019; Byrd, 2018), send them messages that promote ethnic pride (Jones & Rolon-Dow, 2018), and equip them with the tools to survive and thrive in a racist society (James, 2016; Sue et al., 2019). In the above scenario, the father was engaging in microprotections by teaching his son how racism operates, using survival skills in a racist society, and countering messages that denigrate ethnic pride and identity. Microprotections are most central to racial socialization of Children of Color and in the parent's roles in raising race conscious children (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019). Microprotections have been found to be highly successful in protecting Children of Color against the ravages of racism, and to immunize them against demeaning messages that they are "lesser human beings, inferior and unintelligent, dangerous, untrustworthy, aliens in their own land, and outsiders" (Dotterer & James, 2018).

Microprotections are the strategies and skills used by Parents of Color and significant others to raise race-conscious children and to prepare them to combat racism on their own. First and foremost is helping Children of Color to develop racial literacy and critical consciousness; to understand demeaning meta-communications, to see beyond the obvious or to read between the lines, and not to doubt their own sanity. As we have seen, micro/macroaggressions are often hidden and invisible, and discerning their true meanings can be difficult. The ability to read "reality" correctly allows POC to maintain their sanity when everyone around them may invalidate their lived experience (Sue et al., 2019). Second, promoting ethnic pride is important to counter society's constant messaging that to be racially different is to be deviant, pathological, and lesser in nature. Research suggests that positive racial identities serve as buffers to the impact of discriminatory racial encounters and build resilience and hardiness (Dotterer & James, 2018). Third, preparation for racism involves allowing Children of Color to experience racism and to develop the coping and survival skills needed to maintain one's integrity and humanity. Contrary to the belief that microprotections are meant to protect children from "experiencing racism," they are designed to have parents and caretakers help youngsters navigate the racial biases that exist in the lived experience of Children of Color.

STRATEGIES AND TACTICS TO COMBAT INDIVIDUAL MICROAGGRESSIONS

In general, microaffirmations, microchallenges, and microprotections can overlap with one another and be equally applicable whether directed at an individual perpetrator, biased policy or practice, or preparing Children of Color to deal with racism. For example, teaching POC how to use microaffirmations and microchallenges can be forms of microprotection. Our focus in this section, however, is on microintervention actions needed to disarm microaggressions at the individual level. Because systems change often requires using microchallenges to forcefully confront racist policies and practices, we reserve Chapter 9 to cover microintervention actions needed to dismantle institutional racism. Likewise, we spend considerable time discussing microprotections in Chapter 10, especially as they relate to

the raising of race-conscious children for both whites and Youngsters of Color. It raises our belief that "prevention is better than remediation" when dealing with microaggressions.

In this section we ask the question: *How can targets*, bystanders and *white allies combat racism they experience or observe in their daily interactions with others?* In Chapter 4, we credited Latane and Darley (1970), Ashburn-Nardo et al. (2008, 2014), and Ashburn-Nardo and Karim (2019) with developing the first models on confronting prejudice in which they depict psychological processes whereby bystanders notice a discriminatory event that leads to action. They have become foundational in understanding what inhibits and facilitates anti-bias interventions. Where they fall short, however, is in providing readers with a repertoire of anti-racist actions that may be taken to combat individual expressions of racism (Sue et al., 2021).

Recent scholarly work on eliminating or responding to microaggressions has provided insights into the type of responses and training programs most effective in neutralizing their harmful impact. Some of the best practical approaches have been developed in medical and healthcare settings about how to handle microaggressions when they come from patients directed at staff, interns, residents, and other medical personnel of color (Ahmad et al., 2022; Sandoval et al., 2020; Sotto-Santiago et al., 2020). Although developed in medical situations, the anti-bias actions proposed seem to have broad generality across different settings (education, employment, healthcare, and most interpersonal interactions). A number of workshops developed to train targets and bystanders how to respond to microaggressions have been found not only to be effective (Grass et al., 2024; Sandoval et al., 2020; Sotto-Santiago et al., 2020), but have provided specific microintervention tools to use in different situations.

For those interested in setting up education and training workshops to teach microintervention tactics, we suggest the following models: ACTION (Macintosh et al., 2022), ERASE (Faller et al., 2023), IRANT (Grass et al., 2024), LIFT (Govindraj et al., 2024), OWTFD (Sotto-Santiago et al., 2020), STR (Sandoval et al., 2020), and VITALS (Walker et al., 2022). There are many commonalities in these workshops, and their acronyms represent various microintervention guidelines that can be taken to disarm and neutralize microaggressions. For example, the acronym represented by VITALS represents sequential steps to address a microaggression: *Validate*

your thoughts, perceptions, and feelings (don't doubt your observations), *Inquire* or obtain clarification and information (What do you mean by that statement?), *Take Time* to mirror/reflect what the person says, *Assume* good intent of the perpetrator, *Leave Opportunities* for follow up, and *Speak Up* and intervene (Walker et al., 2022).

From these workshops/studies we have been able to pull out best practices, advice, and suggestions and integrate them into the taxonomy presented by Sue et al. (2019, 2021; Alsaidi, 2021; Awad & Connors, 2023) on microinterventions. Before continuing, it is important to distinguish between strategies and tactics. A strategy is an action plan or a long-term vision that helps determine the direction or goal. Tactics are short-term individual actions or specific steps that can be taken to achieve the goal. In reviewing the vast literature on anti-bias and anti-racist actions, microinterventions seem to fall into four strategic goals: (a) making the "invisible" visible, (b) disarming the microaggression, (c) educating the perpetrator, and (d) seeking outside support and help (Sue et al., 2019, 2021). Under each specific strategic goal, a number of tactics that could be utilized to achieve these objectives are listed. Table 8.1 lists examples of microintervention tactics for each of the specific strategic goals.

It is important to note that the inventory of tactics is not exhaustive, and that the ploys outlined are only limited by the creativity or ingenuity of responders. Further, these microinterventions can be used by almost anyone whether target, bystander or white ally. Some may, however, be more appropriate for one group than another. These represent the repertoire of anti-racist skills that may begin breaking the deadly dance of racism.

Strategic Goal #1: Making the "Invisible" Visible

As indicated, microaggressions vary on a continuum from being intentional to unintentional and from being explicit to implicit (Sue & Spanierman, 2020). It is often said by POC that intentional and overt microaggressions are easier to deal with because there is no guesswork involved. Unintentional and subtle racism that is outside the level of awareness of perpetrators (and, at times, targets) poses a major challenge because it is invisible to offenders who believe they have behaved in an appropriate and non-biased manner (Dovidio et al., 2002). When racist behaviors are invisible to perpetrators, they are not motivated to change, as they are

allowed to continue their lives in complete obliviousness, naivete, and innocence (DiAngelo, 2018; Trepagnier, 2017).

With the murder of George Floyd, for example, the phrase "Black Lives Matter" was voiced by many African Americans, and it spawned a major social movement. It was met, however, with a microaggressive response from many well-intentioned white Americans who stated that "All Lives Matter." On the surface, it is true that all lives matter, but the microaggressive response tended to do three things. It dismissed and negated the message that Black lives are worth less than that of their white counterparts, that they are killed or murdered more often in our society, and that they are treated with disrespect and as lesser human beings. Second, the statement that "all lives matter" implies that the lives of African Americans are no different than that of white Americans and allows society to ignore the individual and systemic racism they experience daily. Third, it allowed perpetrators to cling to their beliefs that they are good moral citizens incapable of acting in a racist manner. When POC found the "all lives matter" comment to be a microaggression, it was difficult for white Americans to understand its racist hidden meanings (invalidating the racial reality of Black Americans).

Table 8.1 Microinterventions to Disarm and Neutralize Individual Expressions of Racism (Microaggressions)

Adapted with permission from Sue (2021).

Strategy I: Make the "Invisible" Visible
Objectives:
• Bring the microaggression to the forefront of the person's awareness • Indicate to the perpetrator that they have behaved or said something offensive to you or others • Force the perpetrator to consider the impact and meaning of what was said/done or, in the case of the bystander, what was not said/done
Rationale:
• Allows targets, allies, and bystanders to verbally describe what is happening in a nonthreatening manner • When allies and bystanders intervene, reassures targets that they are not "crazy" and that their experiences are valid • When those with power and privilege respond, they may have a greater impact on the perpetrator
Tactics:
1. Develop perspicacity 2. Disempower the innuendo by naming it 3. Undermine the meta-communication 4. Challenge the stereotype 5. Broaden the ascribed trait to a universal human experience 6. Ask for clarification of a statement or action 7. Make the communication explicit by restating/rephrasing the demeaning message

8. Reverse or mimic the microaggression and direct it toward the perpetrator
9. Depersonalize and make process observations

Strategy II: Disarm the Microaggression

Objectives:

- Stop or deflect the micro/macroaggression
- Force the perpetrator to consider what they have just said or done
- Communicate your disagreement or disapproval towards the perpetrators actions in the moment

Rationale:

- Provide targets, allies, and bystanders with a sense of control and self-efficacy to react to perpetrators in the here and now
- Preserves targets' well-being and prevents traumatization by or preoccupation with what transpired
- Allows perpetrator to think before they speak or behave in future encounters with similar individuals

Tactics:

1. Affirm, validate, and support the target
2. Express disagreement
3. State values and set limits
4. Describe what is happening
5. Use a brief exclamatory utterance
6. Express nonverbally your reactions
7. Interrupt and redirect

8. Remind them of the rules
9. Disengage from dialogue or remove yourself from the situation

Strategy III: Educate the Perpetrator

Objectives:

- Engage in a one-on-one dialogue with the perpetrator to indicate how and why their behavior is offensive to you and others
- Facilitate a possible more enlightening conversation and exploration of the perpetrator's biases
- Encourage perpetrators to explore the origins of their beliefs and attitudes toward targets

Rationale:

- Allow targets, allies, and bystanders the opportunity to express their experiences while maintaining a relationship with the offender
- Lowers the defense of the perpetrator and helps them recognize the harmful impact
- Perpetrator becomes keen to microaggressions committed by those within their social circle and educates others

Tactics:

1. Differentiate between intent and impact
2. Contradict the group-based stereotype with opposing evidence by personalizing it to specific individuals
3. Appeal to the offender's values and moral principles
4. Point out the commonalities
5. Promote empathy
6. Point out how they benefit

7. Reframe the meaning of the statement or action
8. Revisit the incident later

Strategy IV: Seek Outside Support and Authoritative Help

Objectives:

- Partake in regular self-care to maintain psychological and physical wellness
- Check in with self and others to ensure optimal levels of functioning
- Send a message to perpetrators at large that bigoted behavior will not be tolerated or accepted

Rationale:

- Mitigates impact of psychological and physiological harm associated with continual and cumulative exposure to microaggressions
- Reminds targets, allies, and bystanders that they are not alone in the battle
- Ensures situations of discrimination or bias do not go unnoticed

Tactics:

1. Find and join a support group
2. Establish a buddy system
3. Debrief and process event with mentor or senior ally
4. Fortify self through spirituality/religion/community
5. Seek formal psychological help
6. Alert leadership
7. Report the incident

Tactics

Nine different tactics to make the “invisible” visible have been identified (Grass et al., 2024; Sue et al., 2019, 2021). The overall goal of the tactics is to bring the microaggression to the forefront of offenders' awareness, to indicate they have behaved in an offensive manner, and to consider the meaning and impact on targets of what they have said or done. In general, the responses, comebacks, and ploys of increasing awareness have the best results when delivered in a non-threatening manner that minimizes defensiveness.

1. ***Develop Perspicacity***. Perspicacity is an aspect of critical consciousness, or a keen ability to discern the hidden meanings of events and situations, to see beyond the obvious, and to read between the lines (Sternberg, 2001). This quality is the basic foundation of microintervention effectiveness because without it, targets, allies, and bystanders will not be able to ascertain and call out microaggressions when they occur. What is wrong, for example, with saying “all lives matter” to a “Black lives matter” statement? What is wrong with complimenting a third-generation Chinese American for speaking good English? Microaggressions are often invisible and cloaked in the form of compliments or other non-racist meanings. Without an understanding of the offensive meta-communications being sent to targets, no action will be taken.

   Microinterventions in these cases are taken to make offenders aware of, or begin to explore, the hidden meanings of their actions. Most are relatively simple and brief:

   Do you realize what you just said?

   Can't you see what is happening here?

   Think about how you made Ricardo feel.

   What is making you so angry?

   Let's analyze why Mun Lee was offended.

2. ***Disempower the Innuendo by Naming It***. This tactic “names” the unspoken (biases and fears) that hold power over those in the racism dance. Addressing the “elephant in the room” demystifies it, names the

oppressive event, condition, or process, and is the first step to liberation and empowerment (Freire, 1970). Although perpetrators may still get defensive when using this tactic, note that every attempt is made to separate their actions from their identities. “That's a racist statement,” for example, separates the behavior (Your behavior is racist.”) from the person (“You are a racist.”)

That sounds like a racist statement.

That's a stereotype.

That's a microaggression.

Your biases are showing.

Relax, I'm not dangerous (Black man to white woman who appears anxious.)

You are discriminating.

You're acting in a biased and unfair manner.

3. ***Undermine the Meta-Communication***. Microaggressions contain hidden or disguised meanings or meta-communications that are derogatory or demeaning. Critical consciousness is the ability to distinguish between the conscious communication and those outside the level of awareness of the perpetrator. Once that is done, undercutting the insulting message and creating puzzlement with the perpetrator are effective strategies. For example, a Latino born and raised in the United States is complimented for speaking good English by an audience member after delivering a speech. (“You speak excellent English.”) The meta-communication here is that “You are a perpetual alien in your own country. You are not a true American. True Americans are light skinned, blue eyes and blond haired.”

The Latino speaker can respond with a microintervention: “Thank you. I hope so. I was born here.” The target thanks the conscious complimentary intent of the perpetrator (“thank you”), expresses a desire for it to be true (“I hope so.”), but then undermines the unflattering meta-communication (“I was born here.”). These three brief statements are powerful in their impact on perpetrators. When

used effectively, it produces puzzlement in the perpetrator by bringing to awareness their biased assumption.

I was born and raised here.

I'm sorry, I'm not very good at math. (From Asian-American target.)

Yeah, I'm fortunate to get into Harvard. Lucky, I graduated at the top of my high school class. (African American student being asked by a white student how they got into an Ivy League University while operating under the assumption that Black students could not have gotten in by merit, but only through athletics or an accommodated admissions program.)

4. ***Challenge the Stereotype***. This tactic is related to naming the microaggression, but is more forceful and goes further in challenging, unmasking, and confronting perpetrators with their biased actions. On crowded subways in Manhattan, African American students often observe that seats next to them are the last taken or remain empty during the duration of their ride. The meta-communications being sent to them are “You are dangerous or undesirable to sit next to. You and your kind are up to no good, violent and potentially a criminal.” Many Black students indicate they just let it slip by, and enjoy the extra space. Some, however, directly confront all the passengers to make them aware of their biases by loudly exclaiming, “There's an empty seat here, if any of you are tired of standing. I won't bite you, and I won't hurt you. You won't catch anything from me either.”

   That hasn't been my experience at all.

   Don't worry, I might be Black, but that doesn't make me dangerous.

   Robberies and crimes are committed by people of all races and background.

   Relax, no one will harm you.

   Wow, you must believe that all Asians are math nerds.

5. ***Broaden the Ascribed Trait to a Universal Human Experience***. The nature of stereotyping often involves selective perception; negative traits or bothersome behaviors that almost any group possesses are

attributed to only a marginalized one. Dead giveaways to this process are statements that begin with *"Those people are all…." or* "Why do they all behave like that?" Qualities like laziness, misbehaviors, anger, resistance and other negative traits are attributed only to POC. An effective microintervention involves broadening the trait to other groups: "I don't think that's only a Latino thing, white people do it too."

I think that applies to everyone.

Most people would do the same thing.

Haven't you done and reacted the same way?

6. ***Ask for Clarification of a Statement or Action***. One of the most powerful microinterventions is to simply ask for clarification of statements or actions from the perpetrators because the ploy throws the ball back into the court of the offender. Microaggressions are full of negative insinuations and hidden biased meanings directed toward targets. A request for an explanation often requires perpetrators to "repeat and listen" to what they have said and forces them to confront the disguised meaning. The result is often surprise, shock, and discomfort when they reflect on their statements or behaviors: "Did I really say that?"

   Jonathon, what exactly do you mean?

   Come again, did I hear you correctly?

   Do you realize what you just said?

   What made you behave that way?

   Why is that funny?

   Do you really believe that all Latinos are lazy?

   I can't believe what you just said. Can you tell me more?

7. ***Make the Communication Explicit by Rephrasing or Restating the Demeaning Message***. This tactic is more uncomfortable and a threatening ploy for perpetrators to experience. The technique is to paraphrase or restate not the conscious intent of the offender, but the meta-communication being sent. In a multinational corporation, a

white supervisor might state that his work team has too many Asian American employees and that it is holding the team back from being competitive. A microintervention might be "You're telling me that your team is handicapped because Asian employees are non-competitive, unassertive and too passive in their work roles." Note that this response goes to the heart of the possible meta-communication and brings to light the biases of the perpetrator. It may result in defensiveness and denial, but at least it opens the door for discussion and forces perpetrators to deal with their possible biases. You can begin the paraphrase by starting with these statements: "Let me see if I hear you correctly…" *or* "In other words, you believe or feel that…" This intervention allows the individual to maintain a relationship with the perpetrator by not appearing accusatory in that the restatement comes from what perpetrators have said or done.

> You're telling me that Malachi is not being promoted to supervisor, because the company workers are not ready for a Black boss.
>
> Are you telling me that Students of Color would not be admitted to Columbia University without an athletic scholarship? That they couldn't have gotten in by merit.
>
> In other words, you believe Muslims are prone to violence and can't be trusted.

8. ***Reverse or Mimic the Microaggression and Direct It Toward the Perpetrator***. This tactic is very effective because it contains humor and some sarcasm to drive home the microaggressive point. It is a form of verbal or behavior jujitsu that reverses the roles of perpetrator and target. For example, a 3rd-generation Chinese American student is complimented by a white classmate for speaking such good English: "You speak excellent English!" The Asian American student responds: "Thank you John, you do too!" This maneuver was suggested by Black teenage girls when discussing typical microaggressions they experienced. One of the most frequent ones from white female classmates was "You know, you're pretty for a dark girl." to which they would respond, "Thank you. You're pretty for a white girl." These microintervention counters usually stop perpetrators in their tracks, create confusion and conflict, make them sort out the reasons for their

discomfort, and hopefully lead to insight or realization. A Black and white student had recently become friends. During the course of a conversation, the white student says to his friend, “You're the least scary Black person I know!” The Black student says to his friend, “And you're the least scary white person I know.”

A Black shopper enters an elevator with a single white woman. *She tenses up, clutches her purse tightly, and immediately moves to the corner of the elevator*. The Black shopper *feigns fear and apprehension of the white rider, moves away, and quickly exits the elevator at an opportune time*.

9. ***Depersonalize and Make Process Observations***. When a microaggression occurs, there may be considerable tension among the perpetrator, target, and the audience, especially when some notice the demeaning aspects of the interaction. Calling it out directly may be ill-advised when it may lead to strong emotions, anger, and denial. Defensiveness on the part of the offender can be triggered easily, and increased sensitivity may make it difficult for the perpetrator to divorce themselves from becoming accused and blamed. Constriction and self-protection may be aroused, leading to an inability to listen and entertain feedback.

   In such a situation, it is best to depersonalize the situation for the actors involved by describing or making process observations. Such a technique allows interveners to speak to process observations that everyone can note and accept. It is often easier for perpetrators to address process (what is happening) than to deal with their biases directly. It is not meant, however, to avoid unpleasant topics and self-reckoning, but allows a measured step-by-step desensitizing approach to address the “real” issue.

I notice that not everyone has had a chance to speak.

It seems like every time race becomes a topic, everyone becomes quiet.

We always seem to focus on negatives rather than the positives about racial equity.

We are really getting emotional here, what seems to be pushing our buttons?

I seem to be getting anxious, and it looks like some of you are likewise.

When the topic of anti-Blackness was brought up by Juanita, I noticed that some of you rolled your eyes and no longer participated.

Strategic Goal #2: Disarm the Microaggression

Not all microaggressions are equal in impact or harm. Complimenting a 3rd-generation Asian American for speaking "good" English is qualitatively different than perceiving POC as suspicious suspects, which results in racial profiling. In the latter case, there is not only psychological harm, but also the possibility of instantaneous physical injury (shooting of unarmed African American motorist). Microinterventions under this category tend to be more direct, immediate, and forceful in stopping, deflecting, or challenging the microaggression. Although making the microaggression "visible" is an important goal, the primary objective is twofold: (a) to obstruct, neutralize, and end the insulting biased attack because of their injurious nature to targets, and (b) to support and preserve the well-being of targets and to help immunize them against future discriminatory encounters.

1. ***Affirm, Validate, and Support the Target***. Traumatization, self-doubt, pain, and confusion are often the outcome of microaggressions. For targets, we have provided studies and examples in Chapter 3 as to the psychological and physical harm that occurs. Microaffirmations that counteract the biased meta-communications are powerful medicine in affirming, validating, and supporting targets. Variations of the microintervention statements or actions below are easy enough for white allies, bystanders, and even other targets to perform.

That took courage.

Don't doubt yourself.

You're not crazy, it did happen.

I'm with you.

Count on me.

You have my support.

2. ***Express Disagreement***. Silence is not golden! It is very important to let the perpetrator know that you disagree with their microaggressive words or actions. As in nearly all the microinterventions, taking action works against false consensus and lets others know that such thoughts, beliefs, and actions are not shared by you (and possibly others). Unlike other expressed differences with the perpetrator that may be indirectly delivered, you are placing yourself in a position of personally opposing and owning the disagreement. Again, simple short comebacks are more effective than responses that turn into lectures.

   I don't agree with what you just said.

   That's not how I see the situation.

   What you see happening, is not what I see happening.

   That doesn't sound right to me at all.

   I don't think that's true.

   I think you are making an erroneous assumption.

3. ***State Values and Set Limits***. Similar to the previous microintervention tactic, this one also uses the intervener as the instrument or tool to combat racial microaggressions. It is especially effective with people you know or those who have some type of personal or working relationship with. Here, you use your own values, standards, and equitable beliefs about inclusion and anti-racism to serve as guardrails, and to corral the microaggression being expressed. It appeals to the offender's desire to be respectful to you.

> You know that respect and tolerance are important values in my life and while I understand that you have a right to say what you want, I'm asking you to show a little more respect for me by not making such offensive statements. (Sue et al., 2021, p. 130).

4. ***Describe What Is Happening***. This microintervention is similar to tactic #9 under the previous category, but goes deeper in describing what is occurring and the possible impact it has on perpetrator, target, ally, and bystander, and between them. It is a process observation that paints a larger picture primarily for the perpetrator, but also helps onlookers achieve clarity and enlightenment.

   > I notice that you always start off our meetings with a joke…and that's good because it seems to loosen everyone up. But, when you tell racist jokes, the Employees of Color on the team don't seem to like being the butt of them. They seem uncomfortable, offended, and hurt. Do you realize how they must perceive you?
   >
   > Jim, I wonder if you notice that most of our brainstorming sessions seem to produce ideas from our white managers, and that Managers of Color are relatively quiet and non-participative. At yesterday's meeting, I observed that we (white men) were more likely to cut them off or interrupt them in mid-sentence. Is it possible that we are discouraging them? Are we sending them a message that their ideas are not important?
   >
   > We seem to be having a difficult class dialogue on race right now. It seems like Aisha feels offended by Richard's comments. I notice also that most of the white students are quiet and not verbally participating. Does anyone have any idea of what's happening? (If group continues to remain silent, call on someone to get the ball rolling).

5. ***Use an Exclamatory Brief Utterance***. This tactic is one of the easiest and simplistic responses that can be made to a microaggression. But the impact is powerful and beyond the words. It is based on the observation that when someone accidentally steps on your toes, the most likely response is “Ouch” (Aguilar, 2006; Sunshower Learning, 2007). It quickly tells responsible parties that they have hurt you by their unintended actions, to stop, and to apologize. Exclamatory

utterances express pain, surprise, shock, disagreement, or discomfort with minimal responding and effort by the target or bystander.

> ‘If it wasn't for their athletic scholarships, students of color wouldn't be admitted to Harvard.’ Counter: ‘Ouch!’
>
> ‘Beware of Muslims carrying backpack.’ Counter: ‘Aww, C'mon!’
>
> ‘Don't sign up for that section of the math class, because there are too many Asian students.’ Counter: ‘Get Serious!’
>
> ‘Who knows what you can catch from them.’ Counter: ‘Yikes!’ or ‘Oh-dear.’

6. ***Express Non-Verbally Your Reactions***. Just as microaggressions can be expressed non-verbally (rolling your eyeballs to express annoyance, disbelief, or contempt), so too can microinterventions be used to communicate disapproval. Studies on communication indicate that some 60–70% of a message is communicated non-verbally, such as bodily gestures, use of personal space, silence, tone of voice, and so forth (Ramsey & Birk, 1983; Singelis, 1994). Returning to our earlier example of a jokester telling a racist joke, audience members can leave the scene before the punchline is delivered, shake their head in disapproval, or fail to laugh. The counter-communication from these actions sends a clear message of disapproval.

   > Rolling your eyeballs.
   >
   > Leaving the situation.
   >
   > Looking away.
   >
   > Covering your mouth with your hands.
   >
   > Shaking your head.

7. ***Interrupt and Redirect***. Oftentimes, it is possible to anticipate the microaggression, such as when a person begins to tell a racist joke, or the perpetrator goes into a long monologue (rant) about “those people.” The statement may be biased or misinformed, but a well-timed microintervention can interrupt, disrupt, and redirect the offending statement before the punchline or finale. Sue et al. (2021) provides an example of an angry white supervisor who goes into a

long racist rant because some Latinx workers failed to complete a work assignment on time. Expressing his anger to others, he calls the workers “lazy,” “stupid,” and other increasingly racist labels. One fellow supervisor interrupted the monologue and disarmed it: “Stop right there! I don't appreciate those sorts of comments. They are hurtful and vile. Now, if you really want to solve this issue, let's focus on the task at hand” (p. 129).

Maybe we should focus on the task at hand.

Whoa …let's not go there.

Danger, quicksand ahead.

Let's cut this crap and figure out what to do.

Forget the punchline… I don't appreciate that type of talk.

Please stop that type of talk (or behavior).

8. ***Remind Them of the Rules***. Most organizations have vision statements and strategic action plans that express the company's expressed values of respect and tolerance for differences. The organization's values and codes of conduct generally voice explicit value in creating a diverse workforce of inclusion, diversity, and equity in many forms. In tactic #3, the microintervention uses the intervener as the tool for limits. In this tactic, using the company's policies on the value of diversity and inclusion can be an effective counter to microaggressions.

What you just said (or did) is against our company's standard of behavior, and could really get you in trouble.

This company does not tolerate those demeaning behaviors by any employee. The company has rules and you need to be aware of them.

Do you realize that the company considers your actions to be creating a hostile and invalidating work climate?

I would be careful with those statements in this company. Respectful behavior is the standard.

9. ***Disengage from the Dialogue or Remove Yourself from the Situation***. At times, confronting microaggressions between the parties involved can become heated and filled with accusations and anger. When this occurs, dealing with the situation in the immediacy may prove to no avail, as the parties or individual(s) involved find it difficult to communicate or listen to one another. A pause or "time out" may make it easier to return later to the conflict when tempers or emotions are calmer.

    Time out! Let's return to this disagreement later when we are calmer.

    We are getting too hot and emotional. Let's talk about this later.

    Let's take a break.

    I can see we're both had our buttons pushed. Maybe now is not the best time to talk about it.

Strategic Goal #3: Educate the Perpetrator

There is always an educational component to nearly all microinterventions. The primary purpose, however, in this class of strategic goals is "education" in getting offenders to realize they are committing microaggressions and to take responsibility for the harm they inflict upon targets. Although education is a long-term process, and we would be naïve in believing that brief responses can complete the learning process, we see these tactics as planting seeds of enlightenment and change that may blossom.

1. ***Differentiate Between Intent and Impact***. This microintervention tactic is perhaps one of the most important and effective ploys that lead to insight and change among perpetrators and bystanders. When an offender is "called out," the most common reaction is defensiveness and feeling of being unjustly accused (especially at being called a racist). Perpetrators are likely to respond with statements such as "I didn't mean it that way." "I didn't intend it that way." "It was not my intent." Focusing on intent is a losing issue because it is very difficult to prove what was motivating the person, and the debate is sidetracked from talking about the detrimental impact. Worse yet, a discussion of intent often leads to victim-blaming or gaslighting whereby the target

is perceived to be “oversensitive” and even “paranoid.” In other words, calling out a microaggression may lead to the delivery of other microaggressions (invalidating the lived experience of targets). To control the process, the intervener may acknowledge the “good intent” but redirect the debate to “impact.”

> I know you meant that joke to be funny, but it was offensive to Jesus.
>
> Think how your words affect others.
>
> You obviously wanted to compliment Chang, but it also implied that he was unassertive (or passive).
>
> I know you kid around a lot, but that stereotype is no joke.
>
> I know you want Employees of Color to succeed on your team, but always assigning them menial tasks won't make them confident.

2. ***Contradict the Group-Based Stereotype with Opposing Evidence by Personalizing it to Specific Individuals***. Many microaggressions come from group-based stereotypes in that all members of a racial group are attributed the characteristics: *Asian Americans are good in math and science, but weak in social skills, and are verbally deficient and unassertive. As a result, they make “poor people managers,” supervisors and executives. African Americans and Latinx Americans are less intelligent, lazy, unmotivated, loud, and emotional. Thus, they lack conceptual reasoning and act irrationally*. Presenting data to counter stereotypic statements is one approach, but it risks taking the discussion to a cognitive and intellectual level, making it an abstract exercise. This tactic challenges the stereotype from a personalized rather than an academic level by making the situation concrete, specific, and relevant to the perpetrator. Once the offender is forced to personalize the microaggression to an individual, you can present experiences that counter it. For example, a statement that “Those people have a poor work ethic” can be countered with “Just who are you talking about?”

Are you talking about someone in particular?

I know Malachi well, and he is a decent and trustworthy worker.

I've met many immigrants who speak English well. It's not easy to learn a new language. Have you ever tried?

3. ***Appeal to Offender's Values and Moral Principles***. Most people view themselves as fair-minded, concerned with the well-being of others, and moral human beings who would never engage in racial discrimination. They have been raised to believe in honesty and equality and would consciously condemn racial bigotry. Thus, pointing out how their biased actions (microaggressions) are at odds with their own moral standards are strong motivators for change.

   I know you're not a biased person, but can you see how you behaved inappropriately toward Ricardo?

   The way you just behaved shouldn't sit well with who you are as a decent fair-minded individual.

   Janet, what you just said is not who you are.

   That's not like you. What is going on with you?

   I know you value diversity and inclusion, and will do the right thing.

4. ***Point Out Commonalities***. We have been emphasizing throughout that differences are a natural consequence of the human condition, that they are not negative, and that they should be valued. When identities are associated with negative stereotypes and racial fears, however, these attributes dominate the overall perception of White Americans, making them unable to relate to POC as fellow Americans. Although people may not share the same identities (race, culture, ethnicity, gender, sexual orientation, etc.), they do share many commonalities or similarities in life experiences, hopes, fears, and aspirations that are often submerged or made less salient because the association of differences with deviancy clouds the ability to see the person as one of them. At times, being able to get perpetrators to see targets as like them, with similar struggles, goals, desires, and concerns, can help break the cycle of viewing POC as other beings.

> I need you and Abdullah to work as a team and increase sales. Treating him disrespectfully won't help. In some ways he's very much like you. He takes pride in his work and wants to succeed in the company. You know, he is also a dedicated cyclist like you. He's also a football freak! Have you really ever talked to him?

5. ***Promote Empathy***. Related to sharing commonalities, empathy has a deeper meaning. It is said to be composed of cognitive understanding and emotional compassion that allows the person to understand the feelings and perspectives of another. Racism objectifies and dehumanizes others and causes people to become cold, callous, and insensitive to POC. In its extreme form, racism allows cruel treatment of POC, an insensitivity to their pain and suffering, an inability to identify or take the role of another, and allows perpetrators to engage in bias and discrimination without guilt. Promoting empathy means attempting to get prospective perpetrators to relate to targets, to identify with them as fellow human beings, to increase compassion for another's pain, sorrow, and misfortune, and to motivate helpful and supportive actions (words or deeds).

> Look, how do you think Winona feels when you ignore her suggestions? What if you were treated the same way? Every day she comes to work and she is treated like a pariah by others. She goes to the cafeteria for lunch, but no one sits next to her. She is teased by co-workers for being so quiet and when she speaks up at the team meeting, you cut her off. Can you place yourself in her shoes? How can we help her not feel like an outcast.

6. ***Point Out How They Benefit***. Pointing out the benefits of diversity can be accomplished through objectively garnering facts and statistics or through sharing personal experiences of positive changes related to roles shared with perpetrators in educational, work, or healthcare settings. We reserve the former tactic for macroaggressions (institutional), while the latter is for microaggressions (individual). Indeed, citing statistics and facts on an intellectual/academic level appears less effective than sharing positive benefits that are personally experienced with offenders.

In Chapter 1, we ended with a conclusion that potential benefits are many: improved interracial and interethnic interactions, broadening of their horizons, increased appreciation of people (all colors and cultures), less fear and intimidation of differences, ability to communicate more openly and clearly with their family, friends, and coworkers, and a greater spiritual connectedness with all groups. Equally important are the potential benefits to our institutions and to our society. Sharing these personal and work benefits may be used as potent microinterventions.

> I use to feel the same way about our Asian American employees. I resented them for not participating in our brain storming sessions and believed they were uninterested and passive. So, why promote them to managerial positions when they were not 'go-getters.' Then I went through diversity training and discovered that I operated on stereotypes. It liberated my outlook and I changed for the better. Several years ago, I took a chance and promoted Hao. I have not regretted it since. His team is the most productive one around. Yet, his leadership style was different than mine; it was quiet and low-keyed, unlike what I believe were qualities of being a good manager. I discovered that many Asians believe that working behind the scenes, gathering group consensus, and sharing the praises for a job 'well done' were more effective motivators. This realization changed me. I find myself wanting to understand the experiences of others. My tendency to quickly judge others went away. I've become friends with Employees of Color and find it so rewarding. Come with me to lunch, and I'll introduce you to Hao and his Asian co-workers. You will be surprised at how talkative they are when they get to know you.

7. ***Reframe the Meaning of the Statement or Action***. Oftentimes, those who deliver microaggressions view actions of POC from a narrow, biased perspective and are unable to broaden their viewpoint. They have tunnel vision, are trapped from considering alternative meanings, and impute faulty negative significance to an action, statement, or event. The reason why Rosa always sits alone in the cafeteria is that she is unfriendly and unsociable; Chen is quiet in meetings because he is shy, passive, unassertive, and uninterested; and Malachi is loud and

boisterous because he angers easily and is impulsive, emotional, and irrational. The reframing tactic attempts to help perpetrators consider other reasons or meanings for their observations. It is best if the perpetrator is able to construe other possible interpretations on their own, but if not, the intervener might need to actively do so and/or suggest other ways to verify the meanings.

Is there another way to look at the situation.

Can you think of other reasons for Chen's behaving that way.

Do you think his will make him a poor leader?

What would it mean if Rosa was not sitting alone by choice?

Suppose Malachi's speaking style isn't from anger, what would that mean?

8. ***Revisit the Incident Later***. Almost all microintervention strategies contain a tactic to deal with issues that are best handled at another time. The dialogue may become so heated that participants are unable to understand one another, it may become too divisive or dangerous to continue, there may not be sufficient time to deal with the issue, or any number of other reasons. The important point here is that educating the perpetrator and dealing with the microaggression must not be left alone to fester and grow. Revising the incident is a necessity, or else it falls by the wayside, only to be repeated over and over.

   Let's hold off and deal with this at the next class meeting.

   I want to continue, discuss or revisit what happened yesterday.

   It wasn't the right time for me to say something last week, but can we talk about it now?

Strategic Goal #4: Seeking Outside Support and Validation

The tactic of seeking outside support and help is not a sign of weakness, but a recognition of reality. There are many times when taking action on your own is contraindicated because of exhaustion, need for self-care, danger, and limited knowledge of appropriate and effective actions.

First, racial battle fatigue is a reality in the lives of POC that can lead to burnout, a lowered sense of well-being, and other negative psychological states (anxiety, rumination, depression, and self-blame). At some point in the lives of POC, it is important to rest, recuperate, and regain one's intestinal fortitude to continue the fight against racism. Thus, seeking social validation and affirmation from a support group, personal confidant, or family members may help provide the nutrients required to face racial obstacles in life. Getting formal psychological or psychiatric help is also a possibility when the going gets so tough it threatens your emotional well-being.

Second, “safety first” is the prime directive in situations that endanger the target or ally (Faller et al., 2023). Seeking outside help is often required in the face of threatening and intimidating situations that place the target or ally in not only psychological but also physical danger. Perpetrators with extreme racial bias and hatred, who make no attempt to disguise their racist beliefs, and who tend to act from anger may not be amenable to change. There is always the possibility of psychological and physical abuse. In this case, being able to read contextual cues about unsafe situations is important. Stepping away from the situation and having security intervene may be required.

Third, power differentials between perpetrators and those challenging microaggressions may make interventions risky. Calling out a microaggression from a white professor by a Student of Color may result in punitive actions such as being labeled a “troublemaker,” receiving lower class evaluations, and even getting a failing score; likewise, calling out a white manager by a Black employee may result in a lack of a promotion or raise, or even being fired. It may be wise to seek help from a sympathetic source with an equal or higher status relationship.

Last, seeking outside help and support is often required when other perspectives are needed to intervene effectively. All of us have limitations and often lack experience of how to deal with or disarm racist expressions. Enlisting the aid, advice, and suggestions from someone experienced and wiser is often helpful.

There are a number of tactics we suggest under this strategic goal, but it is by no means exhaustive. The first five share commonalities because they

are related to combating burnout, seeking validation and nurturance, immunization against the forces of racism, and obtaining advice and suggestions about how to deal with problematic situations. Note that these are not confined to targets alone, but are equally applicable to white allies and well-intentioned bystanders. The struggle against racism also takes a psychological and physical toll on them because they are swimming upstream against the forces of the status quo that may take punitive actions against them, leading to exhaustion. The last two tactics are more related to establishing, documenting, and seeking outside intervention that impacts the organization.

1. ***Find and Join a Support Group***. Social support has been found to be one of the most powerful means of validation and sustenance against the forces of racism. It diminishes the feeling of isolation and sense of alienation, provides targets, allies, and bystanders with a sounding board, helps them find their voices, rejuvenates them, and allows them to learn new strategies to disarm bias and discrimination. Finding a support group of like-minded individuals may be challenging, but if none can be found at your place of employment, seeking one on the outside may be called for, or forming one on your own may be an option.
2. ***Establish a Buddy System***. It is important that anti-racist players find someone (an intimate or close acquaintance) to share their personal thoughts and feelings with, to freely discuss discriminatory events, and to validate one's resolve and resilience. It has many of the same functions of a support group, but is more confidential, private, and personal. A “buddy” relationship is supportive, more informal, and available. It is a relationship in which the individual is willing to share their pain and suffering, anger and frustration, and self-doubts with a confidante.
3. ***Debrief and Process Event with Mentor or Senior Ally***. If in the course of your employment, you are fortunate enough to establish a good relationship with a senior mentor or meet a trusted high-ranking member of the organization, it may be possible to help debrief/process the problematic situation and request aid: “Can I talk to you about what just happened? Or “Can we take some time to process and

discuss my (your) reactions?" From such a trusted relationship, you can seek their advice and/or request their aid, especially if a power differential exists between you and the perpetrator. In almost all cases, bias incidents should always be debriefed; if not with someone in authority, it should be so with colleagues or friends (Faller et al., 2023).

4. ***Fortify Self Through Spirituality/Religion/Community***. In the face of constant racial invalidations, insults, and putdowns, depletion of psychic energies and strong feelings of depression, powerlessness, helplessness, and hopelessness may occur. Studies on how targets handle microaggression identify one survival tactic often used: turning to religion, spirituality, and community connections to find strength and meaning in the face of oppressive environments. The Black Church, for example, has always served as the backbone of Black communities, where African Americans find strength, hope, spiritual guidance, and social support. For many POC, community centers, spiritual spaces, religious organizations, and non-profit human rights organizations offer communal connections, friendships, guidance, and opportunities for social and political activism.
5. ***Seek Formal Psychological Help***. Although many POC find traditional counseling and psychotherapy to be antagonistic to their ways of life, culturally relevant psychological services offer an opportunity to process traumatic racial experiences, to unlearn negative thinking, to understand personal and systems of oppression, and to teach them anti-bias and survival skills. In most cases, help is directed at having them to achieve critical consciousness, to avoid self-blame and negative thinking, to overcome feelings of hopelessness and helplessness, and to empower them.
6. ***Alert Leadership***. Alerting leadership is undertaken when the discriminatory situation seems deeply embedded in the individual perpetrator, unresponsive to individual interventions, and produces imminent psychological damage and harm to POC. If you or others are the targets and possess minimal power to stop the biased behavior of the perpetrator, making sure leadership is aware of the situation is crucial for macro-level change. The supervisor, someone with authority on your team, a human resource officer at the company, or

the office of diversity at educational institutions must be alerted so that they become responsible for taking action.

7. ***Report the Incident***. Like alerting leadership, reporting the incident, establishing a record of disturbing incidents, and documenting incidents of racial harassment for future action. Sometimes, reporting an incident does not result in immediate action, so recording incidents is needed to collaborate and establish credibility. Formally recording such incidents makes the “powers to be” responsible and accountable to take action. In situations where you prefer to keep your identity secret, anonymous online portals or using social media to bring attention to the issue can be the preferred action.

CONCLUSION

Whether target, white ally, or bystander, everyone has a moral responsibility to “call out” racist actions when they occur in our everyday lives. Disrupting the deadly dance of racism is paramount to our nation's health. We have provided a number of microintervention strategies and tactics whereby anti-bias actions can effectively disarm, neutralize, and stop individual expressions of microaggressions. These individual actions or best practices may seem to be small and insignificant interventions; however, research shows that they have a macro-impact on perpetrators and on those witnessing their appearance (Sue et al., 2019, 2021). Because they appear inconsequential, simple, and minor, it means that anyone with sufficient motivation can engage in these anti-bias actions. They are not complicated but must be practiced and rehearsed to become effective automatic behaviors. We encourage microintervention training in institutions of higher education, places of employment, and healthcare.

We turn our attention in the next chapter to how to use microinterventions to dismantle macroaggressions, or systemic and institutional racism. Microinterventions to challenge macroaggressions become more complex and complicated because the strategies move into the realm of social and political advocacy.

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CHAPTER NINE
Microintervention Strategies to Disrupt, Diminish, and Dismantle Systemic Racism (Macroaggressions): Arming Targets, Bystanders, and White Allies

As we have indicated, dealing with cultural and systemic forms of racism requires collective rather than individual actions (Watson-Thompson et al., 2022). In this case, we are attempting to dismantle macroaggressions and systems of oppression manifested in the biased rules, regulations, policies, and structures in organizations and society. Attempts to institute changes by one person are often not as effective as when many combine their efforts toward a specific goal. We provided numerous examples of systemic racism in our society (see Table 7.1) that occur in education, employment, healthcare, housing, politics, and criminal justice (Braveman et al., 2022). In general, microinterventions directed at macroaggressions are inherently more difficult than changing microaggressions because they involve systems of power and privilege that have advantaged some groups (i.e., White Americans) while disadvantaging others (i.e., POC) (Michaels et al., 2023). Those who are advantaged, whether knowingly or unknowingly, resist changes that benefit them.

Many rules and regulations in institutions achieve a functional autonomy or "Godfather"-like status in organizations that resist change and often punish those who seek it. Macroaggressions can also be embedded in laws and legal precedents that require authoritative modification at the highest levels (local, state, and the federal government through executive, congressional, or court actions) and are outside the reach of any one individual. The ultimate aim of microinterventions (individual actions), however, is to institute ***macrointerventions***, usually through collective partnerships. Advocating for systemic change means (a) altering current policies and practices to make them more equitable, (b) eliminating oppressive and biased ones, and/or (c) creating new ones that allow for equal access and opportunity. Before we outline what targets, allies, and bystanders can do

with the collaboration of others, it is important for us to note the changing political climate occurring in society that makes our work especially difficult.

THE CURRENT POLITICAL CLIMATE AND THE RISE OF OVERT RACISM

In Chapter 1, we noted how the "Make America Great Again" (MAGA) political movement was rooted in a desire to return to the conservative "good old days" where power, privilege, and hierarchical social relationships favored primarily straight white males. With the re-election of Donald Trump to the Presidency, that threat is being actualized through executive orders that attempt to end birthright citizenship (American Bar Association [ABA], 2025), dismantle and outlaw Diversity, Equity and Inclusion (DEI) programs (Lusane, 2025), withhold research funds to institutions of higher education that deal with social justice (Rodriguez et al., 2025), list forbidden words used by the National Science Foundation (bias, discrimination, equity, diversity, racism, multicultural, etc.) to determine desirability of grants (Novak, 2025), subvert the rule of law governing equal rights (defying court orders) (ABA, 2025), banning the celebration of racial/ethnic observances in several federal agencies (Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Juneteenth, and ethnic holidays/celebrations, etc.), and declaring immigration at the border a "national emergency" in order to provide cover for ramping up punitive measures against immigrants and neighboring countries (Rosenberg et al., 2025). The Trump administration is undoing decades of civil rights legislation and weaponizing the federal government to bully, intimidate, and enforce actions that discriminate and oppress people because of their race, gender, sexual orientation, gender identity, and disability.

Systemic Racism and Macroaggressions: Threat, Intimidation, and Silencing of Dissent

The current administration's attempt to dismantle years of hard-won anti-discrimination laws and policies has had a chilling effect on federal agencies, higher education, business and industry, and ultimately all POC. The detrimental effects seem to be threefold. First, racist laws, policies, and

practices emanating from the highest levels of government and from top leadership have undermined federal anti-discrimination laws won during the civil rights era. These laws and edicts guaranteed legally protected status to socially devalued groups associated with race, gender, sexual orientation, disability, etc. (Moore, 2025). The changes abandon measures that dismantled race and sex segregation in the hiring of marginalized groups in high-paying industries and those that mandated equal race and gender consideration for federal contracts.

The Trump Administration's attack on DEI also threatens to undercut the foundation of university-based research as an attempt to end what they derisively label higher education “slush funds” (Saul, 2025a). In 2025, for example, the administration pulled $400 million from Columbia University as a punitive measure that has sent shock, consternation, and fear among many institutions of higher education, with the promise to target other non-compliant universities (Patel, 2025a). This punitive action was followed by cutting off $800 million from John Hopkins University research funding, which forced them to propose laying off some 2000 researchers and workers (Saul, 2025b). The administration has justified these moves by engaging in a “divide and conquer” strategy, claiming that these universities have not done enough to stem anti-Semitism on their campuses. They have also engaged in a “conceptual jiujitsu” by defining DEI initiatives and programs as “illegal discrimination” intended to advance unqualified POC and women over those more qualified (i.e., whites and males). They advocate a false return to “meritocracy” and the reversion to traditional hierarchical relationships in our society where white men enjoyed unquestioned power and privilege.

These broad racist governmental attacks have forced private companies that receive federal contracts to roll back, change, or eliminate DEI-related offices and positions and to terminate equity-action plans. Many universities are choosing to stay neutral on political or social issues, to avoid hot-button topics, to remain silent on matters of civil and human rights for fear of retaliation from governmental entities, or to capitulate and “go along, to get along” (Patel, 2025a). The University of California, for example, has stopped requiring the use of diversity statements in hiring, and Columbia University has acquiesced to many of President Trump's demands (Patel, 2025b). It has also been reported that companies like Goldman

Sachs, Bank of America, Coca-Cola and PepsiCo, Disney, Amazon, Google, Target, McDonald's, Walmart, Ford, John Deere, Harley-Davidson, Victoria's Secret, and many others have taken major steps to roll back their diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives and programs to comply with the edicts of the Trump Administration (Murray & Bohannon, 2025). For most of these companies, their actions go against previous long-term commitments to providing equal access and opportunity to all. Changing their postures in waves, these companies are a sad sight as they seem to be selling out their integrities rather than resisting and challenging racism.

Second, the MAGA movement makes it blatantly clear that punitive measures will reign down on those who dare go against an administration determined to restore a white supremacist racial hierarchy of the past. Its actions have intimidated and instilled fear and anxiety among POC and their allies. With anti-immigrant policies invoked by the Trump Administration, threats of mass deportations, racial profiling, ending of birthright citizenship, and family separations, nowhere is the fear greater than that felt by our immigrant brothers and sisters. Threats to invade schools, worksites, and housing to root out “illegal” immigrants and deport them have led to fear, paranoia, and chronic stress in their lives. Migrants are reluctant to return to their worksites, place their children in public schools, attend church services, seek medical assistance, and go about their daily lives for fear of raids conducted by Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) agents.

Other marginalized groups also share the apprehension as they see their employment opportunities shrink, civil rights diminished, voting rights restricted, mass firings of federal employees (often those whose work challenges the administration on their racial policies), and punitive actions against even high-ranking individuals who have dared to challenge the MAGA agenda (firing four-star general Charles Brown, Jr., only the second African American to hold the position of Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff). The racist climate has crept into almost all aspects of American life, from banning books on discriminatory equity in Pentagon schools and a decision by the National Football League to remove the slogan “End Racism” stenciled on the end zones since 2021 to using pickaxes to remove the slogan “Black Lives Matter” painted in bold yellow letters on two blocks of Black Lives Matter Plaza in Washington, DC. The painted mural

occurred in 2020 in response to the murder of George Floyd and had attained a spiritual meaning to many (McGrady & Arango, 2025).

Third, under the Trump Administration, overt racism and racist expressions have seemingly made a fashionable comeback. Microassaults and macroassaults such as pardoning incarcerated white supremacists, redefining diversity and equity as reverse racism, and engaging in undisguised racist acts and speech (Elon Musk's public Nazi salute), the usual guardrails that made such actions taboo in the past now seem in vogue among many white Americans. In Chapter 6, we reviewed a number of studies and surveys that indicated an increase in overt expressions of racism, sexism, and anti-immigrant sentiment in our society during and up to the first election of Donald Trump (Giani & Méon, 2021; Jardina & Piston, 2023). The spike in racist incidents and hate speech was attributed to the social contagion of ethnic hostility, sanctioning of racism by political leaders, shifting norms toward acceptance of racism, and increasing bias among the populace (Chen et al., 2023). Although it is too early to determine whether Trump's reelection is having a similar impact, it appears reasonable in light of the multitude of racist executive orders issued in his second term. Indeed, one early survey found that anti-Asian hate surged online with the November 2024 election victory of Trump; South Asian slurs increased 75% from November 2024 to January 2025; East Asian slurs increased 51% (Daniels, 2025).

For many decades going back to the Civil Rights Movement, open displays of blatant racism, racial epithets, and hate crimes were considered socially unacceptable and abhorrent by most white Americans who perceived themselves as good and decent human beings (DeVos & Banaji, 2005; Dovidio et al., 2017). Race scholars believed that explicit bias (racism) had morphed into implicit bias and was manifested in the form of symbolic racism (Sears, 1988), modern racism (McConahay, 1986), implicit bias (Banaji et al., 1993), color-blind racism (Bonilla-Silva, 2021; Neville et al., 2013), aversive racism (Dovidio et al., 2002), and microaggressions (Sue et al., 2019, 2021). All were seen as forms of implicit racism that resided in individuals who found overt and conscious expressions socially unacceptable. Such a psychological dynamic allowed many white Americans to lead their lives in naivete and free of guilt. With governmental sanctioning of bias and bigotry and changing norms that make public racist

expressions acceptable, racist acts are no longer prohibited, nor is it unthinkable to appear “racist” (or even to be called one)! Although implicit racism is still very problematic, overt expressions of racism have become more frequently expressed by many White Americans and deemed more acceptable in others. The MAGA movement has made blatant, deliberate, and conscious expressions of microassaults and macroassaults not only tolerable, but increasingly commonplace. Little doubt exists that we are in a period in our country where racism, oppression, and silencing directed toward POC are at an apex, and our ability to resist, speak out, and take action to dismantle the forces of bias, bigotry, and hate is urgent and needed.

Civil Courage: Resistance and Social Change

> There may be times when we are powerless to prevent injustice, but there must never be a time when we fail to protest it—Elie Wiesel.
>
> Washing one's hands of the conflict between the powerful and the powerless means to side with the powerful, not to be neutral—Paulo Freire.

These two quotes were voiced about times of extreme oppression, threats of harm and retaliation, and even genocide. These voices represent a call for civil courage, especially in the face of racial injustice. There has never been a more pressing time for citizens to evidence civil courage, to act on the basis of a moral imperative, and to stand against the tyrannical forces of the times. Civil courage is different from our earlier discussion of altruism, the bystander phenomenon, and the failure to help when emergency situations present themselves. Williams et al. (2023) define civil courage as acting on the basis of a moral imperative, advocating for social change to create equitable systems, and standing for freedom and against tyranny. The most important aspect of civil courage is persisting despite the recognition of psychological, social, and physical costs that may ensue against them in light of their actions. Civil courage is not only important for targets, but also racial justice allies and bystanders who must find the motivation to bravely face the punitive backlash that will be visited upon them when they challenge injustice (Spanierman & Smith, 2017).

We realize how overpowering, repressive, and dictatorial many of our political leaders have become. Now that they control the levers of power in government, they are trying to impose their racist views on our way of life. The campaign of terrorism being waged against POC is not new to our ancestors who refused to submit and capitulate to racist actions perpetrated against them (Jones, 1997). Vernon E. Jordon, Jr., an African American confidant to former President Bill Clinton, in a speech at Howard University, made an analogy between terrorism and the historical racism directed toward Black people (Sue, 2003):

> None of this is new to Black people. War, hunger, disease, unemployment, deprivation, dehumanization and terrorism define our existence. They are not new to us. Slavery was terrorism, segregation was terrorism, the bombing of the four little girls in Sunday school in Birmingham was terrorism. The violent deaths of Medgar, Martin, Malcolm, Vernon, Dahmer, Cheney, Schwerner, Goodman were terrorism. And the difference between September 11 and the terror visited upon Black people is that on September 11, the terrorists were foreigners. When we were terrorized, it was by our neighbors. The terrorists were American citizens.
>
> … it is Black people who remind America that we know terrorism well. And we know that the surest defense against terrorism is affirmation of America's basic values, the values we have learned in our churches, the values we have fought and died for in America's every war, even in segregated armies.

Jordon reminds POC and allies that it is natural to feel overpowered and disempowered and to remain neutral or to simply “give up” in the face of such overwhelming odds. Yet, social justice advocates cannot afford to allow hopelessness to overtake them, because it is the forerunner of surrender. So, when they begin to feel tired and discouraged, when hopelessness seems just around the corner, and when they wonder what good their actions are doing, POC need to remind themselves of the strengths and assets they possess, many of them taught to them by their ancestors. It is important for them to realize that despite these indignities and atrocities, they have persevered and become stronger (Angelo, 1969). For POC, survival and resistance are fueled through their collective strength, heightened perceptual wisdom, ability to read the contextualized

meanings of their oppressors, bicultural flexibility, families, communities and spirituality/religion, racial/ethnic identity and pride, and belief in the interconnectedness of the human condition (Sue, 2003).

STRATEGIES AND TACTICS TO COMBAT MACROAGGRESSIONS (SYSTEMIC RACISM)[1]

In previous chapters, we indicated how good intentions were not enough without actively confronting and challenging systems of oppression. Those with the intestinal fortitude and courage to do so must be armed with the knowledge, strategies, skills, and tactics that can effect change (Alsaidi, 2021; Awad & Connors, 2023). Furthermore, dismantling systemic racism is most effective through the action of groups, rather than singular individuals. Whether targets, bystanders or white allies, social justice work is likely to engender constant pushback, resistance, and punitive consequences from those controlling the levers of power. Racial battle fatigue and "burnout" are more likely to occur when people confront systems of power and privilege on their own, without the support and encouragement of others. Research reveals that forming allies and being in the company of like-minded individuals are two of the most effective means of increasing social support, warding off stressful life events, validating the importance of the struggle, and increasing the sense of efficacy (DeLeon, 2010; Feeney & Collins, 2015; Maton, 2017; Olle, 2018; Uchino, 2009). Because no single individual possesses all the knowledge and expertise to effect systemic change, pooling together the proficiencies and know-how of many may prove more effective.

The old adages that "there is safety in numbers" and "power in numbers" seem apropos. One large study, for example, found that people alone tended to perceive threat and danger at much higher levels than those in groups (Cesario & Navarrete, 2014). Other studies reveal the power of social support and integration: it buffers against stress and challenges (Cohen & Wills, 1985; Feeney & Collins, 2015), promotes human flourishing, resilience, and hardiness (Cohen, 2004; Ozbay et al., 2007; Uchino, 2009), increases subjective well-being and physical health (Balaji et al., 2007;

Cohen, 2004), and provides resources to overcome challenges (Feeney & Collins, 2015; Ozbay et al., 2007). Thus, it appears that with social support and allies, social justice advocates are better able to withstand the stresses of anti-bias work, are more likely to speak up and resist oppression, and are better equipped to confront systems of oppression.

Challenging macroaggressions is different from using microinterventions directed at individual perpetrators because the goal is to change biased policies and practices that reside in groups, organizations, and society. In this case, social advocacy strategies and tactics are required: specific actions and practices that are seldom taught or practiced, often time-consuming and labor-intensive, and for which there is a high cost to engaging in them. Yet, breaking the deadly dance of racism requires civil courage and being armed with a repertoire of social advocacy skills that range from education to persuasion and civil disobedience (Maton, 2017; Sue et al., 2021). We have already enumerated many individual actions (microinterventions) that targets, allies, and bystanders can utilize when confronted with individual expressions of racism. In this chapter, we focus upon microintervention actions that ordinary citizens can use to disarm and dismantle macroaggressions. We continue to use the four strategic goals outlined by Sue et al. (2019, 2021) but translate them in such a way as to make them applicable to individual actions required to confront ***systemic racism***: (a) making macroaggressions visible to the general public, (b) educating leaders, decision-makers, stakeholders, and the public about institutional racism, (c) garnering wide support to challenge and dismantle macroaggressions, and (d) seeking external support to fight systems of oppression. Specific individual and group tactics under each of the strategic goals involve actions that educate, persuade, protest, and advocate for change.

Table 9.1 lists examples of microintervention tactics for each of the specific strategic goals. It is important to note that the inventory of tactics is not exhaustive and that the ploys outlined are only limited by the creativity or ingenuity of responders. Furthermore, these microinterventions can be used by almost anyone, whether target, bystander or white ally,. Some may, however, be more appropriate for one group than another. These represent the repertoire of anti-racist skills that may begin breaking the deadly dance of racism.

Strategic Goal #1: Making Macroaggressions Visible

Unjust policies and practices can be blatantly apparent or hidden and embedded in standard operating procedures of organizations or in the customs, traditions, and practices of the society. Although this section may be more applicable to the invisible bias inherent in the rules and regulations of an organization, our previous discussion of executive orders emanating from the Trump Administration may also contain concealed agendas that need to be made visible. For example, the banning of books on race and racism, listing taboo words related to equity, no longer celebrating racial/ethnic holidays, purging DEI initiatives, wiping out the heroic contributions of the 442nd Regimental Combat Team (the most highly decorated combat unit composed of Japanese Americans) during World War II, and attempting to delete the Army history of Jackie Robinson from the Pentagon are attempts to rewrite history and to literally wipe out and make POC insignificant and invisible in American history and society.

Table 9.1 Microinterventions to Dismantle Systemic and Institutional Racism (Macroaggressions)

Adapted with permission from Sue (2021).

Strategy I: Make the "Invisible" Visible
Objectives:
*Bring the macroaggression to the forefront of people's awareness.
• Increase awareness of the unfairness of a policy, program, or practice. • Convince and motivate those in leadership positions, stakeholders, and the public that action is required. • Make stakeholders aware of the harmful impact of institutional and societal macroaggressions.
Rationale:
• Provides a method of demonstrating the existence of and need to address issues of inequities and disparities. • Removes the entire burden for change from individuals, assigns the responsibility to those in authority, and holds institutions accountable. • Encourages individuals to work together and combine their power and influence in a collective way.
Tactics:
1. Monitor and document. 2. Advocate for evaluation and accountability. 3. Leverage your power and privileged identities.
Strategic Goal # 2—Challenging Macroaggressions Through Education
Objectives:

- Help stakeholders and decision-makers develop critical consciousness about systemic inequities.
- Encourage community-level educational engagement.
- Illuminate the benefits, gains, or advantages.

Rationale:

- Creates opportunities for conversation and learning.
- Encourages institutions to look inward and address issues that typically go unnoticed.
- Engages stakeholders at various levels with the community.

Tactics:

1. Raise critical thinking.
2. Support anti-bias education and training.
3. Highlight benefits of diversity and equity.

Strategic Goal # 3—Challenging and Disarming Macroaggressions

Objectives:

- Provide a potent and effective means to confront biased institutional or societal policies.
- Apply pressure on key stakeholders to institute change through persuasion.
- Utilize coercion and disruption to cause embarrassment and/or inconvenience to motivate change.

Rationale:

- Raise public awareness through media.

• Persuade and demand change from stakeholders and decision-makers. • Make an impact through collective organizing that cannot be dismissed or ignored.
Tactics:
1. Protest and persuade. 2. Engage in civil disobedience. 3. Challenge the status quo through media. 4. Enhance collective action.
Strategic Goal # 4—Seeking External Support in Fighting Macroaggressions
Objectives:
• Call on human rights organizations to get involved. • Take legal action when necessary to hold systems, laws, and practices accountable. • Foster a sense of community support through mentoring, engagement, and alliance.
Rationale:
• Connect with institutions to call on their support and access to resources. • Provide a solution for when all else fails. • Instill confidence and hope by utilizing the legal justice system to hold laws, practices, and policies or other forms of inequities accountable.
Tactics:

1. Call on the support of human rights organizations.
2. Initiate governmental action.
3. Seek community support.

The overall objectives for the strategy of making the “invisible” visible are threefold. First is to bring awareness to the general public of the existence and manifestation of macroaggressions related to a particular organizational or societal policy, practice, structure, and custom that unfairly treat POC while advantaging their white counterparts. Second, decision-makers must become cognizant that a current rule or regulation has detrimental or prejudicial consequences to certain marginalized groups and thus be motivated to change. As long as unfairness and inequities are outside the level of awareness of individuals, no action will be taken. Third, becoming aware hopefully motivates those in leadership positions, stakeholders, and the public to take action.

In this section, we deal with strategies and tactics (best practices) to make the “invisible” visible. By demonstrating the existence of inequities and disparities in the rules and regulations of an organization, it philosophically removes the entire burden for change from individuals and makes those in authority responsible and accountable. Without awareness of unfair policies, programs, and SOPs in employment, healthcare, and education, many will assume that equitable practices are being implemented. Three main microintervention tactics appear important: (a) monitor and document, (b) encourage systems of evaluation and accountability, and (c) leverage personal power and privileged identities.

1. ***Monitor and Document***. Although personal experiences and anecdotal examples may be enough to persuade individuals, organizational change requires convincing facts and data (statistics, survey information, proof, and objective evidence) to support the call for terminating an unfair policy or implementing a new and fair one (Jones & Dovidio, 2018). Targets and white allies, for example, can informally or formally monitor and document trends and differential outcomes of policies within an organization. These tactics are most

effective through group collaboration and effort because no one person possesses all the capabilities to monitor and document all the complexities of an organization. Some examples are Sue et al. (2021):

> Monitor and keep a log of inequitable policies, programs, and practices; report them to decision-makers (i.e., document inequitable trends around recruitment, hiring, retention, promotion, and termination of employment).
>
> Create partnerships with institutions to analyze data related to disparities in education, healthcare, and employment.
>
> Ask questions and share data at meetings and evaluation periods. Speak up and inquire about decisions being made, the data and reasons supporting current and future actions.
>
> Solicit feedback from marginalized group members about how policies and practices impact them. For example, encourage the use of focus groups to actively solicit feedback from marginalized group members.
>
> Conduct cultural audits to determine inclusive and exclusionary workplace or campus climate issues. In this case, the credibility of findings is more likely to be accepted by organizational leaders when they are involved in the audit.

2. ***Advocate for Evaluation and Accountability***. In many cases, organizations possess inspiring vision statements on diversity and equity, but few possess the means of evaluating whether they are attaining diversity goals. Furthermore, many institutions are vague in terms of what programs, departments, or individuals are responsible or accountable for making sure that equity goals are being attained. Some sample actions and goals are:

Move beyond using equity statements as simply public relations or aspirational purposes.

Make the company aware that a system of evaluation and accountability is needed. Encourage them to implement criteria that is measurable and build a system with rewards to encourage and motivate employees and administrators.

Designate and make explicit who and how accountability can be measured among management, supervisors, staff and workers.

Hold peers and those with power accountable for potentially biased hiring trends, promotions, or questionable actions.

Engage in continual consultation and soliciting feedback for ongoing evaluations.

Create new systems of accountability that ensure equitable practices.

3. ***Leverage Personal Power and Privileged Identities***. White male allies and bystanders are attributed more power, privilege, and status in our society than POC. These individuals can use their voices to raise awareness, enlighten and educate, and make known inequities that surround policies and practices. However, it is important to note that we all possess multiple identities; some of them may be marginalized, but others are privileged and can be used in many situations. For example, I (Derald Wing Sue) have a number of identities, some marginalized, but others enjoy more privilege and power: Asian American (race), male (gender), straight (sexual orientation), physically able (ability), middle-class (socioeconomic status), older adult (age), highly educated (education), Protestant (religious orientation), and so forth (Ratts et al., 2016). The author may be disadvantaged by his racial identity in some situations, but being highly educated, straight, and male may afford him elevated status to influence others. Furthermore, the salience of identities may vary depending on the situation, making, for example, religious affiliation and socioeconomic status more or less significant and persuasive. Examples of personal actions might include:

Use your privileged identities and power to sit at tables that are off limits to POC, to voice their concerns and issues. POC frequently have their voices silenced and cannot access spaces of power where majority individuals make decisions.

Speak on behalf of, and with the consent of employees, students and others of color for their rights in worksites, boardrooms, classrooms, neighborhood gatherings, and family events. This can be simply sharing observations or information about disparities and inequities in a process or regulation.

Be deliberate in making sure that the voices of those most silenced and oppressed be heard. Creating focus groups, encouraging town halls, and intentionally asking for the input of POC at meetings, events and gathering allows "space" for input and feedback.

Strategic Goal # 2: Challenging Macroaggressions through Education

The strategic goals of *Making the "Invisible" Visible* and *Challenging Macroaggressions through Education* overlap considerably, but the latter goes far beyond awareness to critical consciousness and perspicacity (Anderson & Stevenson, 2019; Sternberg, 2003). In this case, the target groups are stakeholders that may vary depending upon whether change is being sought for an organization (business, industry, schools, etc.), communities, or governmental agencies. Thus, stakeholders are individuals, social groups, organizations, or the larger society that have a *stake* in how a particular business, institution, and local, state, and federal agency operate (Jones & Dovidio, 2018). Key decision-makers (CEOs, school superintendents, upper management, educators, Board of Trustees, etc.), elected officials, employees, consumers, and the general public may represent stakeholders in which educational efforts are directed. Educating stakeholders about macroaggressions is about attempts to engage in dialogue with leadership to raise awareness of policy bias, to have them consider possible solutions, and to convince those at the very top of the organization to help in this endeavor. Three tactics seem especially relevant here.

1. ***Raise Critical Thinking***. Critical consciousness is about more than the acquisition of knowledge and information. It represents an active rather than passive approach to data understanding and analysis, but one that interrogates the source, purpose, and use of knowledge and determines who does and does not benefit from the present arrangements (El-Amin et al., 2017). In previous chapters, we indicated how critical consciousness, or critical thinking, represents a higher level of cognitive processing that involves analyzing systems of oppression and inequality. For example, facts and statistics indicate that African Americans have high incarceration and recidivism rates. That knowledge alone, on a passive level, may lead to the conclusion that Blacks, as a group, are more likely to be criminals. But biased norms and macroaggressions (external structural inequities) skew the statistics: racial profiling, increased presence and vigilance of police in Black communities, and harsher mandatory sentences for Black men when compared to their white counterparts (Blair et al., 2004; Plant & Peruche, 2005). Once released, institutional racism keeps them out of mainstream society, leading to homelessness, unemployment, poverty, and limited healthcare (Jones, 1997). Thus, getting stakeholders to understand how power, privilege, and oppression are interwoven into structural inequities that may lead to policies and practices that create inequities in the lives of POC. Examples of actions for targets, allies, and bystanders include:

    Facilitate an open discussion of how race, culture and ethnicity affect POC in organizations and in our society. Get stakeholders to understand the racial reality of POC; how racism is a constant reality in their lives and what others can do to life this burden.

    Participate with local community centers and faith-based organization to support and facilitate open dialogues about race, racism, power, privilege and human rights.

    Raise consciousness and critical thinking of stakeholders in how to recognize systemic racism and discrimination in employment, education and health care.

2. ***Support Anti-Bias Education and Training***. Unfortunately, the Trump Administration has issued an executive order condemning and

discouraging companies from implementing such training. In the past, however, many companies and organizations instituted anti-bias training for their employees and/or constituents that was found to be very successful. Workshops or classroom curriculum in business, industry, and education focused on diversity training aimed at achieving all or a combination of the following goals: (a) increase awareness of their values, biases, and assumptions about human behavior; (b) acquire knowledge and understanding of the worldview of people who differ from them in terms of race, ethnicity, and culture; (c) understand differences in communication styles and interactions; and (d) become cognizant of how institutional policies, practices, and customs may differentially advantage or disadvantage certain groups. These goals are meant to identify how individual and organizational biases affect majority group members and POC. Education and training, however, can also be informal. Neighbors, social groups, friends, and family may all profit. Some actions that can be taken are listed below (Sue et al., 2021).

Suggest and support formal anti-bias, microaggression, and macroaggression training in all organizations.

Encourage educators to include discussions of race, bias and racism in lesson plans at all levels of education.

Organize reading and discussion groups around book written by authors of color.

Publicly support policies that allow for equal access and opportunity.

Conduct or go on field trips to historical places that embody the racial struggles and lessons of oppression and courage.

Encourage people to join civil rights organizations like the Southern Poverty Law Center, Anti-Defamation League, and American Civil Liberties Union.

Form a community task force on valuing diversity and hold town hall meetings on the topic.

3. ***Highlight Benefits of Diversity and Education***. An important philosophical approach to multiculturalism is to focus on the benefits, advantages, and positive outcomes of diversity in one's personal and organizational life. Most formal and informal educational approaches to topics of race and racism confine themselves to addressing the detrimental consequences and harm of bias and discrimination. Although important, it is often more motivating for organizations to realize that diversity and multicultural environments possess major opportunities and financial benefits to their bottom line (Jones & Dovidio, 2018; Martic, 2018). In the world of work, for example, lack of diversity has been shown to lower work productivity, diminish morale, create higher employee turnover, and lose profits (Hunt et al., 2015). But the flipside is that diversity is shown to increase innovation and creativity, faster problem-solving, better ideas, and better decision-making (Martic, 2018). It is also correlated with high employee morale, increased engagement with the company, and reduced employee turnover. Interestingly enough, companies in the top quartile of racial/ethnic diversity were 35% more likely to be above the national industry medium in having higher financial returns (Hunt et al., 2015). Given these findings, getting organizations aware of them is a major tactic.

    Approach companies with information on how lack of diversity and multicultural result in lower work productivity, low morale, high employee turnover and lost profits.

    Describe the benefits of workforce diversity on education, employment, healthcare, and all other aspects of society.

Strategic Goal # 3: Challenging and Disarming Macroaggressions

Challenging macroaggressions is especially germane to the current political times, where disarming systems of power and privilege or resisting their implementation are quite overt and blatant. Although the nefarious nature of macroaggressions and systemic racism remains hidden to many, some in positions of power and authority are deliberate in their efforts to oppress and disempower groups of color. Such seems to be the case for the Trump

administration. As a result, the relevance of this strategy and the tactics that may be employed are of utmost importance, and we spend more time discussing this class of microintervention in this chapter.

Earlier, we identified three types of microinterventions: microaffirmations, microprotections, and microchallenges. The latter is most applicable to disarming macroaggressions through exercising pressure and force on those in authority who have the ability and power to institute change. Confrontation and force are microintervention tactics used when awareness, education, and goodwill fail; when influential stakeholders refuse to relinquish or share power; when biased rules and regulations are codified into laws; and when the opposition believes cherished values are being attacked (Jason et al., 2015; Olle, 2018). This strategy is especially important to confronting institutional racism in organizations and in racist governmental actions, policies, and laws that are imposed on communities of color that affect their standard of living (employment, education, and healthcare). How to challenge, resist, and fight back against the forces of oppression are especially important now as the MAGA movement enacts its racist agenda. Before we continue, however, it is important to address the use of violence in opposing oppressive systems.

Nonviolent and Violent Actions

The strategic goal of challenging and disarming macroaggressions can take many forms, from collaborative guidance, letter-writing campaigns, and town hall meetings to rallies, demonstrations, protests, and forceful coercion (Banks et al., 2019; Toporek & Ahluwalia, 2012). Depending on the degree of resistance and the perceived harm that policies, practices, and laws are taking upon POC, increasing confrontation and force may be instituted by social justice advocates (Amenta & Polletta, 2019). Nonviolent actions involve using symbolic protests, noncooperation, and defiance and are distinguished from those of physical violence (Ayres, 2018; Chenoweth & Stephan, 2011). Usually, nonviolent microinterventions are more effective than the use of violence (throwing smoke bombs, destroying property, and advocating violence against authorities) (Chenoweth & Stephan, 2011). When violence occurs, as in the immediate aftermath of the murder of George Floyd, it is punctuated by violence (burning police cars, smashing windows, looting, and physical assaults). Organizers of the Black

Lives Matter (BLM) movement tried to quell the carnage because they realized such actions discredited the legitimacy of the protest, undermined the goal of attracting more people to their cause, and created a backlash against the BLM movement.

However, the question still remains, “Is violent protest ever justified?” There are those who argue that violence is never justified and does not have a place in a democratic process (Soares et al., 2018). Others argue, however, that the intentional infliction of harm against people or property is justifiable in resisting tyrannical governments and political injustices (Greenwood-Reeves, 2022). Certainly, our founding fathers used violent means to protest and win their freedom. Those who entertain the legitimacy of violence assert that such actions can be “rational” and grounded in moral principles, especially when the state becomes illegitimate, declines to stop its tyrannical ways, and refuses to relinquish their power freely (Gibson, 2023). The issue of violent protests is a complex one, and we believe that discourse, discussion, and nonviolent means should be the first and primary means of effecting change. Yet, if our history has taught us anything, social movements and liberatory actions that involve violent protests can be a justified response.

Two historical figures stand out as successful proponents of nonviolent protests: Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., and Cesar Chavez. Dr. King led the Montgomery bus boycott and many other civil rights causes, while Cesar Chavez led the United Farm Workers Movement in 1965 over the inhuman working conditions for Chicanos. The strategies, techniques, and tactics used by these two historical Leaders of Color were non-violent means of protest: (a) *acts of omission*, where protesters refused to perform acts they were expected to carry out through strikes, boycotts, work stoppages, and sit-ins and/or (b) *acts of commission*, such as engaging in forbidden actions like public disrobing, rude gestures, and blocking traffic (Albert Einstein Institution, 2019). There is, however, a fine line between the tactics of civil disobedience, breaking the law, and the use of violence to bring attention to unjust laws, rules, and regulations. Here, we focus on four nonviolent tactics in social justice advocacy.

1. ***Protest and Persuade***. Protest and persuade are microintervention actions that are generally lawful and considered expressions of free

speech. They are tactics with a threefold purpose: (a) bring attention to a cause by creating inconvenience to specific stakeholders and/or the general public, (b) induce shame, humiliation, embarrassment, and guilt for their complicity in the unfair policy or practice, and (c) persuade those in power to implement change. Targets, white allies, and bystanders are often unaware of the many microinterventions that can be used as part of their civilian rights and instead often feel helpless in the face of systemic racism. Gene Sharp (1973) outlines nearly 200 microintervention tactics under 10 categories of *Nonviolent Protest and Persuasion*.

1. Formal statements—public speeches, letters of support or opposition, petitions, organizational statements, and declarations of indictment and intention.
2. Communications with a wider audience—slogans, caricatures and symbols, banners and posters, leaflets, pamphlets and books, newspapers and journals, skywriting, records, radio and television, and social media.
3. Group Representations—deputations, mock awards, group lobbying, and picketing.
4. Symbolic public acts—displaying and wearing symbols, prayer and worship, protest disrobing, symbolic sounds, display of portraits, destruction of own property, and rude gestures.
5. Pressures on individuals—haunting officials, taunting officials, and vigils.
6. Drama and music—humorous skits and pranks, singing, performance, and plays and music.
7. Processions—marches, parades, motorcades, pilgrimages, and religious processions.
8. Honoring the dead—political mourning, mock funerals, and homage at burial places.
9. Public assemblies—assemblies of protest and support, protest meetings, teach-ins, and town halls.

10. Withdrawal and renunciation—walk-outs, silence, turning one's back and renouncing honors.

A category of protest and persuasion that represents an increased level of pressure, force, and intensity is the tactic of noncooperation. Work slowdowns or stoppages, boycotts, and strikes threaten the potential economic security of organizations and have proven to be one of the most effective means of producing change (Chenoweth & Stephan, 2011; Sharp, 1973).

2. ***Engage in Civil Disobedience***. The tactic of civil disobedience often overlaps with protest and persuasion, but it does not necessarily mean *lawful actions*. Civil disobedience means nonconformance to customs, practices, and frequently the law. These microinterventions are often used purposefully to violate or disobey laws, orders, or commands of an organization, including law enforcement, governmental, or societal authorities. The actions are manifested in two forms: (a) directly breaching the *unjust practice or law* or (b) indirectly breaching a *just practice or law* for the purpose of bringing attention to the unfair, racist, and discriminatory one (Brownlee, 2017). On-campus demonstrations, for example, protesting students may break into the President's office, occupy it, and spray slogans on the walls. From April to June 2024, pro-Palestinian protesters established a “Gaza Solidary Encampment” on Columbia University grounds and refused to leave. In addition to numerous other protests (walking out of class, holding rallies, and handing out literature), a group of students also forced their way into Hamilton Hall, a university building, and occupied it. They were subsequently arrested and removed from the building while being charged with breaking a number of laws. By definition, civil disobedience is nonviolent, yet it represents the outer limits of coercion, disruption, and breaking laws. While these actions can be condemned and severely criticized, civil disobedience has a long history in social movements; it has become part of the fabric and free principle of democratic action, embedded in the American way of life, and considered by social justice advocates a legitimate means of checks and balances against unfair policies and practices (Chenoweth & Stephan, 2011). The free speech movement, the Third World Strike, the Civil Rights Movement, and Vietnam War protests all used civil disobedience to attain their goals. Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. has

argued that the actions of protesters may break laws, but that people must answer to a higher moral law. Some examples of civil disobedience actions are listed below.

> *Boycotts, refusal taxes or rent, refusal to pay fees or dues, slowdown strikes, resignations, excommunication, social isolation, hunger strikes, overload facilities, nonviolent sabotage, reluctance or slow compliance, office invasions and blockages*.

3. ***Challenge the Status Quo via Media***. Civil rights leaders have always used the power of media to raise public awareness, educate stakeholders, influence decision-makers, and advocate for change. That is one of the primary reasons why the Trump Administration is attempting to exert control over traditional and social media to squelch the voices of dissent.

   There are three classes of media that may be used to challenge the status quo: (a) traditional media such as television, radio, and print—newspapers; (b) social media such as YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, and former Twitter (now X that no longer is considered a democratic space); and (c) other forms of protest such as sky and earth writing, displaying symbols, and use of slogans.

   - Traditional media are powerful to highlight injustices as they occur (i.e., television and press coverages of civil rights marches, boycotts, violence enacted against nonviolent protesters, the killing of George Floyd and other unarmed Black men, and police misconduct) to document images of pain, humiliation, and injustice directed toward POC. The strategy has been effective in making their grievances known and garnering sympathy and support from onlookers. It is important to note, however, that using media to confront large-scale societal macroaggressions can also be directed at unjust policy, practices, and customs in organizations, neighborhoods, and municipalities.

   Use TV, radio, Op-eds, letters to the editor, press releases, news conferences, newspaper and radio interviews, documentaries, leaflets, pamphlets, books, and podcasts to challenge the status quo.

- Social media platforms are also powerful tools because they are relatively free of control from traditional media in the form of censorship and/or one-sided perspectives. Its impact can be immense as it is able to livestream events (encampments, sit-ins, confrontations, arrests, and demonstrations) in real time, coordinate events publicly or in secrecy, mobilize protesters, network with allies and collaborators, enhance emotional appeals, heighten collective identity, and mobilize collective action. The #BlackLivesMatter hashtag is a prime example of the intersection of social media and protest, where the BLM movement had a huge impact in bringing attention to the reality of racism against Black Americans and sparking change.

Use social media such as Blue Sky, Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, WhatsApp, podcasts, webinars, and videos for protesting aims.

- Although not classified under the banner of media, other forms of communicating protests include tactics used to raise social issues, invoke empathy/sympathy, mock individuals, educate the populace, engage in satire, enhance camaraderie, and motivate action.

Communicate through skits, plays, and theater, movies and documentaries, skywriting, protest songs, banners and displayed communications, slogans, caricatures and symbols, and mock public events.

4. ***Enhance Collective Action***. The potency and strength of a movement are often based upon the number of protesters and stakeholders demanding action. An important tactic is to identify allies and collaborators, win them over to the cause, utilize their individual and unique competencies, and form an action plan. Working with allies and other like-minded individuals, they have found that successful battles against macroaggressions are almost always achieved through collective action (van Zomeren et al., 2008). One of the benefits of collective action that makes it so effective is the impact it has on its members. First, belonging to a group provides aid and comfort to its members, validates its cause, immunizes and buffers members against organizational pushback, and enhances motivation. Second, no one

individual possesses all the knowledge, skills, competence, and experience to challenge systems of oppression. In a collaborative group, some members may possess legal skills, public relations skills, and organizational knowledge that, when combined, will lead to more effective challenges and outcomes.

Serve on boards, attend town halls, work with others to revise and to vote on community policies.

Create or join existing coalitions that share your values and visions to create equal access and opportunity.

Create caucuses for targets and allies, join neighborhood or employee groups, and encourage the formation

Strategic Goal #4: Seeking External Support in Fighting Macroaggressions

Oftentimes, social justice advocates are unaware of powerful organizational entities that already exist that have a long track record in fighting for equal rights. Challenging systems of oppression is an enormous undertaking, and social justice advocates may lack the knowledge, expertise, and influence to bring pressure to bear on decision-makers. If macroaggressions, for example, are embedded in legal or constitutional doctrine, their complexities may require groups that understand the intricacies of governmental operations and change. Seeking help from institutional authorities, social advocacy organizations, and special interest groups are advantages for seeking special expertise, funds, and resources to enhance microinterventions. With respect to combatting racism, three actions are especially important: calling on human rights organizations, initiating governmental action, and seeking community collaboration are important microintervention tactics.

1. ***Call on the Support of Human Rights Organizations***. One of the most important resources that social justice advocates can tap into is the number of human rights organizations that exist in our society. Targets, white allies, and bystanders can join or collaborate with them to challenge macroaggressions. These groups often offer special talents, training and education, the existence of ongoing social justice

programs, guidance on strategies and tactics, community connections, and resources. Some organizations are national and international in influence; others are more local and community-based: Southern Poverty Law Center, National Association for the Advancement of Colored People, American Civil Liberties Union, Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch, United Nations Human Rights Council, and many others.

Report incidents to human rights organizations and communicate with leaders in the organization directly to learn more about how they can help.

Utilize resources, guides, and “how to” documents provided on websites as tools for social justice advocates.

Connect with other individuals who are in the organizing and mobilizing sphere to learn from them and share tools.

2. ***Initiate Governmental Action***. This microintervention tactic is especially relevant in light of the flurry of executive orders issued by the Trump administration that undermine civil rights and detrimentally impact the lives of POC. When governmental actions adversely impact POC, it is important for targets, white allies, and the general citizenry to exercise their constitutional and legal rights to end oppressive and discriminatory policies/laws or create new policies/laws that ensure equal access and opportunities. Theoretically, the executive, legislative, and judicial branches of our government represent our communities, and they make decisions that affect our daily lives. Each branch of government, however, can either be part of the problem or part of the solution to ending and dismantling racism. First, at the executive level, the President of the United States can issue directives or executive orders that manage the federal government that may either have a positive or negative impact on specific populations. In 1942, President Franklin D. Roosevelt issued Executive Order 9066, which interned 120,000 Japanese Americans, of which two-thirds were citizens by virtue of birth. The order was a travesty of justice, just like many of the executive orders arising from the current Trump administration. Executive orders can also counteract or end bias against vulnerable populations. In 2014, then-President Obama issued

an executive order intended to shield undocumented immigrants from deportation. It is clear that executive orders reflect the political and ideological views of presidents but are also amenable to change when social justice advocates make their voices heard.

Second, at the congressional level, Congress has the power to pass legislation that either promotes civil rights of citizens or detrimentally impacts their lives in devastating ways. The Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882, a racist law, banned the immigration of the Chinese to the United States because it led to a “race problem” and needed to maintain “racial purity.” In our history, Southern states passed numerous legislation supporting Jim Crow laws, forbidding POC to own land or to even testify in courts. On the other hand, Congress was also responsible for passing one of the most significant legislation ever passed, the Civil Rights Act of 1964, which prohibited discrimination on the basis of race, color, religion, sex, and national origin. Unfortunately, under the current political climate, these rights are being slowly eroded.

Third, the judicial branch of the government (state and federal courts and the Supreme Court) can impact policies, practices, and laws for decades. In 1954, for example, the Supreme Court in *Brown v. Board of Education*, declared unconstitutional the *separate but equal doctrine*, which overturned 60 years of discriminatory actions against African Americans. It can also be an instrument in perpetuating biased practices and laws that oppress and discriminate. On June 29, 2023, the US Supreme Court ruled against race-conscious admissions used in universities and colleges because the majority of the justices believed it violated the Equal Protection Clause of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 (Hlavac & Fegely, 2023).

Depending on the qualifications and expertise of targets, allies, and concerned citizens, a number of roles can be played, and it is obvious that influence and change must come from collaborative efforts. Governmental interventions require social advocates to inform and educate themselves about the legislative process, the identity of decision-makers at the executive, legislative, and judicial levels, and how best they can contribute to the task at hand (providing proof, data, and anecdotal examples; voicing concerns at town hall or city

council meetings; forming personal connections with lawmakers; making phone calls; and providing expert testimony before legislative panels. This is where the power of collaboration reveals itself. Not all of us have the expertise to write an amicus brief or possess knowledge of how the government operates. Having members with differing know-how or capabilities makes efforts toward change more impactful. Just because we do not possess such knowledge, however, does not mean we cannot add our voices against injustice nor make a contribution to the cause. For those of us who do not have a legal background, there are many ways to aid the challenge. People can provide hospitality services to other advocates—providing your home for a meeting, providing nourishment for the group, running errands, and providing transportation on the group's behalf. We list a few of the actions that targets, allies, and citizens may take, depending upon their expertise.

Communicate with members of Congress to educate and persuade them to take action. Call local representative and voice your concerns or institute face-to-face meetings with lawmakers or decision-makers.

Plan or create a Town Hall meeting for local representatives; in organizations invite decision-makers to hear the concerns and thoughts of employees.

Join groups with mutual goals and work toward systemic change.

Participate in commissions and task forces at local, state, and federal levels.

Help file amicus briefs and help provide expert testimony.

Join planning committees and organizations that aim to foster and support marginalized communities.

3. ***Seek Community Support***. One of the greatest resources available to social justice advocates lies within the community. Seeking social support and allies not only provides validation to the self but to the cause as well. There is nothing more empowering and liberating than being in the presence of many like-minded allies and nothing more immunizing against strong resistance and pushback. Community

support can be formal or informal, but collaboration and coalitions can be parents, teachers, community leaders, church leaders, and neighbors. When confronting macroaggressions, community support is essential to initiate and encourage engagement, mobilize actions for change, and maintain psychological well-being. The strength of social bonds and sense of community have been shown to enhance collective action (Feeney & Collins, 2015).

Join community groups with mutual goals.

Invite neighbors to home meetings to discuss issues of race, racism, power and privilege in schools and the community. If the meetings are successful, create a group of concerned citizens on racism issues.

Join planning committees and organizations that aim to foster and support marginalized communities.

Become active in your church and suggest programs on racial topics; invite community experts to share their knowledge with the group.

Create networking and mentoring opportunities for underrepresented employees in an organization.

Challenging macroaggressions means confronting systems of power, privilege, and hierarchy. It is a herculean task that may have major psychological, social, and physical costs to targets, white allies, and bystanders who choose to do so. Yet, not to do so will allow the deadly dance of racism to continue unabated, costing the lives of POC and confining them to a life of mistreatment, second-class status, restriction of life opportunities, and oppressive harm. Racism is a malignant force that ultimately harms everyone, and we are all responsible for disarming and dismantling its many manifestations. As we have indicated throughout, we are not powerless to end racism. Although any one single individual may have minimal impact against macroaggressions, taking action as a collaborative group of allies is certainly within our grasp. In the last two chapters, we have tried to offer microintervention strategies that can be used against microaggressions and macroaggressions. In the next and final chapter, we attack micro/macroaggressions through the lens of prevention

through advocating the raising of race-conscious children (white children and Children of Color) by parents, teachers, and caretakers.

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Note

1 Much of this section is adapted with permission from Sue et al. (2021).

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CHAPTER TEN
Racial Socialization and the Microprotections that Shape Antiracist Development

Across the previous chapters, we have examined how racism takes root through everyday behaviors, structural arrangements, and emotional habits, often long before individuals recognize their roles as perpetrators, bystanders, targets, or allies. These patterns do not arise spontaneously. They are taught, absorbed, and rehearsed in what we have called racism's deadly dance. In this final chapter, we turn our attention to the beginning of that dance, focusing on how children come to understand race and how that understanding can be shaped toward justice rather than racial hierarchy and oppression. As explored in Chapter 2, where we examined how ordinary people become unwitting perpetrators of racism, the dance is not choreographed solely in adulthood. It begins in childhood through the subtle and persistent ways children learn to internalize hierarchy and difference. Grounded in the belief that prevention is more powerful than remediation, this chapter focuses on racial socialization as a lifelong process. We offer concrete strategies for interrupting the intergenerational transmission of racism and for cultivating youth who are prepared to recognize, resist, and repair injustice.

Racial socialization, or the process through which children learn about race, racism, and racial identity, unfolds long before adolescence. Historically, this literature has focused on youth of color, illuminating how caregivers foster cultural pride and prepare children to navigate racial bias (Hughes et al., 2006). More recently, scholars have turned increasing attention to white racial socialization (WRS), documenting how white youth come to understand and, often, misunderstand race in environments shaped by silence or avoidance (Seaton et al., 2018; Spanierman, 2022). As Hazelbaker et al. (2022) suggested, these environments often reinforce dominant narratives, or cultural scripts, such as color-blind racial ideology and white supremacy. These narratives guide beliefs and behaviors to

uphold racial inequities. From school segregation and curriculum bias to housing discrimination and unequal disciplinary policies, structural racism shapes the settings in which children learn about race. These systemic realities must be made visible for racial socialization to serve as a tool of prevention and repair. Racial socialization is not a one-time conversation, but a lifelong process shaped by families, schools, media, and policy.

Racism is a white problem (DiAngelo, 2018; Katz, 2003), and intervening early in the racial socialization process offers a powerful opportunity to disrupt racial dominance. In this chapter, we argue that racial socialization across racial groups is a core developmental process. For white families in particular, disruption of dominant narratives must be purposeful and sustained. We consider racial socialization not only as a lifelong developmental process but also as a site of prevention and repair for white communities.

We draw from Heberle et al.'s (2020) developmental-ecological framework for cultivating critical consciousness and extend their model by incorporating recent empirical advances, caregiver-facing interventions, and systems-level strategies. Our goal is to equip families, educators, and communities with actionable approaches to racial socialization, especially for those raising white children, while advancing healing and justice for youth of color.

In a sociopolitical moment marked by disinformation campaigns, curriculum bans, and escalating attacks on racial equity, the stakes for antiracist socialization are especially high. The post-2020 racial reckoning sparked renewed public interest in race dialogue, but it also provoked intensified backlash. As efforts to suppress antiracist education intensify, the need for intentional, developmentally attuned racial socialization becomes even more urgent. Children must now be prepared not only to address racial bias but also to resist denial, distortion, and historical erasure. This requires that caregivers and educators be equipped to challenge the legacy and resurgence of white nationalist rhetoric that threatens youth's understanding of history and systemic injustice.

APPLYING RACIAL MICROPROTECTIONS: A FRAMEWORK FOR PREVENTION

Building on the discussion in Chapter 8, we apply *microprotections* as a foundational framework for prevention in racial socialization. In contrast to microaggressions, which convey everyday slights and invalidations that reinforce racism (Sue & Spanierman, 2020), microprotections are intentional acts that shield children from racial harm and guide them toward justice. We define racial microprotections as proactive, developmentally grounded strategies that buffer against racism while fostering resilience and critical consciousness. Coined by James (2016) and empirically developed by Dotterer and James (2018), microprotections originally referred to small, daily behaviors that Black parents use to affirm children's dignity and help them navigate the harms of racism. These include parental warmth, cultural pride messaging, and preparation for bias. In this chapter, we broaden the term's application across racial groups and developmental contexts, using it as a guiding framework not only to protect children from racism, but also to prevent the internalization of racial dominance and superiority among white youth. Each microprotection represents a deliberate step out of racism's deadly dance and a step toward racial justice.

In the sections that follow, we first outline how children learn about race and examine the science of racial socialization. We then introduce eight foundational practices for antiracist socialization, offering concrete strategies that function as racial microprotections in daily life. These practices are informed by Sue's (2015) foundational work on race talk, empirical research on WRS, and caregiver narratives. We also showcase systems-level applications that help bring these practices to scale. This includes extending microprotections beyond individual households into schools, media, and community settings.

LEARNING RACE: HOW CHILDREN ARE TAUGHT TO REPRODUCE SOCIAL HIERARCHIES

Children's understandings of race do not emerge in a vacuum. Rather, they are constructed through daily interactions, cultural messages, and societal structures. From an early age, children absorb cues about who holds power, who belongs, and whose lives are valued. Even before they have language to describe race, children learn its meanings and their place within its hierarchies through what they observe, hear, and experience. Decades of developmental research affirm that infants can perceive racial differences, and by preschool, children notice and assign meanings to racial groupings, often linking them with social status and showing preferences (Katz & Kofkin, 1997; Waxman, 2021). These early perceptions reflect racial ideologies embedded in peer dynamics, media portrayals, and AI-generated content.

Left unaddressed, such early impressions can harden into distorted beliefs about group worth. As discussed in Chapter 6, these impressions are not benign. They are early enactments of racial scripts and roles. The interplay between individual learning and structural messaging reinforces the very ground rules that sustain racism's choreography. While educators play a vital role in disrupting this trajectory, their efforts are increasingly constrained by political censorship and policy backlash. In this climate, parents, caregivers, mentors, and coaches are more essential than ever in scaffolding justice-oriented ways of making sense of race.

Developmental Pathways for Understanding Race

Children's understanding of race evolves alongside their cognitive, emotional, and social development. As Heberle et al. (2020) emphasized, racial socialization must be developmentally scaffolded to match children's readiness to understand complexity, ambiguity, and justice.

- ***Infants and Toddlers***. Children notice racial differences. At this stage, caregivers should focus on modeling inclusive behavior, offering racially diverse books and toys, and using affirming language.

- ***Preschoolers***. Children begin asking direct questions about race and fairness. Adults should respond with clear, age-appropriate language that normalizes race talk and names injustice.
- ***Elementary-Aged Children***. This stage is ideal for reinforcing cultural pride, teaching fairness framing, and helping children identify and challenge stereotypes and bias in media and peer interactions.
- ***Preteens and Teens***. Youth gain capacity for abstract thinking and moral reasoning. Conversations can address structural inequities, historical injustice, and opportunities for antiracist advocacy.

As these stages illustrate, racial socialization is not a one-size-fits-all process. It must be continuously attuned to children's evolving cognitive, emotional, and moral capacities. When approached with this nuance, racial socialization becomes more than a parenting strategy or academic concept. It is a vital developmental intervention with deep implications for children's identity, relationships, and sense of justice. However, even as racial socialization has gained traction in scholarly research, myths and misconceptions continue to shape how it is understood and practiced. In the next section, we challenge these myths and lay the groundwork for the eight foundational practices that follow.

THE MYTHS THAT UNDERMINE ANTIRACIST SOCIALIZATION

Despite burgeoning research on racial socialization, several pervasive myths undermine effective antiracist socialization. Rooted in fear, avoidance, or misunderstanding, these myths distort caregivers' instincts and stall conversations before they begin. Left unchecked, they leave children vulnerable to absorbing dominant racial narratives of white superiority by default.

The Myth of Racial Colorblindness

This myth suggests that ignoring race will lead to greater racial harmony. Caregivers may say, “We're all the same inside,” or discourage children from naming racial differences. While often well-intentioned, color-blind

racial messaging teaches children that race is something to be avoided rather than understood. It ultimately reinforces white dominance by denying the realities of racism and structural inequities (Apfelbaum et al., 2008; Hughes et al., 2006; Plaut et al., 2009). Color-blind messaging often reflects parental discomfort under the guise of egalitarianism (Hughes et al., 2006), which can impair children's ability to detect racism (Apfelbaum et al., 2008). Far from neutral, these messages cultivate white innocence and white fragility, emotional postures that shield white children from accountability and allow dominant racial narratives to go unchallenged. As noted in Chapter 4 on bystanders, this avoidance mirrors the defensive postures adults often adopt, such as minimization or moral credentialing. When confronted with racism, adults who reinforce a culture of silence among children deepen their disengagement from racial awareness and responsibility.

The Myth of Exposure as Enough

The myth of exposure assumes that placing children in diverse settings is sufficient to foster positive racial attitudes. However, mere exposure does not guarantee antiracist development. Even in diverse spaces, children may receive contradictory or harmful messages if adults fail to address racism directly (Perry et al., 2019). Allport's (1954) contact hypothesis suggests that intergroup exposure can reduce prejudice under certain conditions: equal status, shared goals, cooperation, and institutional support. Although contact can improve attitudes even when these conditions are not fully met (Pettigrew & Tropp, 2006), proximity is not enough. Without intentional conversations and adult guidance, bias may persist or even deepen. Moreover, reducing prejudice is not the same as building antiracist consciousness or commitment.

The Myth That Talking About Race Causes Bias

Some worry that naming race might “put ideas in children's heads” or make them more biased. However, the opposite is well-documented. Avoiding conversations about race leaves children vulnerable to internalizing dominant cultural messages about hierarchy and worth. Left unspoken, dominant narratives shape young minds through what they see, hear, and sense, especially in social media and peer interactions (Hazelbaker et al.,

2022). As Bigler et al. (2022) explained, even silence sends a message. When adults sidestep these topics, they may unintentionally teach that race is irrelevant, uncomfortable to discuss, or taboo.

Moving Beyond the Myths

Taken together, these myths obstruct the rhythm of antiracist socialization, keeping families locked in step with the default choreography of racism. They surface across racial and cultural contexts but are especially entrenched in white households and institutions, where silence is often mistaken for progress (Hazelbaker et al., 2022; Scott et al., 2024). When left unexamined, such myths leave children unprepared to make sense of the racial messages all around them, reinforcing inequity by default rather than disrupting it by design. To shift the dance, antiracist socialization must replace these narratives with practices grounded in truth, transparency, and accountability. In what follows, we explore how racial socialization can be reclaimed as a tool for preventionand and possibility.

THE SCIENCE OF RACIAL SOCIALIZATION

In this section, we turn to the science of racial socialization, examining how early racial messages are transmitted, comparing common strategies in families of color and white families, and identifying key opportunities for prevention and intervention. Racial socialization refers to the explicit and implicit ways children learn about race, racism, and group-based power and privilege. Such messages are conveyed through everyday interactions, institutional norms, and sociocultural cues that shape how children come to understand difference and hierarchy. Racial socialization unfolds across multiple ecological levels, including families, schools, media, peer groups, and broader institutional structures (Perry et al., 2025). Emerging technologies such as social media algorithms and generative AI now play an increasingly powerful role in shaping children's racial perceptions, often reinforcing stereotypes, misinformation, and dominant racial narratives through seemingly neutral platforms (Noble, 2018; Tynes et al., 2024).

While all children are exposed to racial messages, the content, timing, and interpretation of those messages vary across and within racial groups. Youth of color often receive direct and indirect cues about exclusion, vigilance,

and resilience. These messages reflect systemic realities while drawing from cultural strengths (Belizaire et al., 2024; Hughes et al., 2006). Such messages may come from caregivers, peers, mentors, coaches, community leaders, or elders and are often oriented toward survival, resistance, and pride. In contrast, white children are more likely to encounter racial silence or vague ideals of fairness, leaving them with limited tools to name injustice or reflect on their own positionality (Hazelbaker et al., 2022; Pahlke et al., 2021). Even within the same racial group, factors such as geographic region, social class, and caregiver orientation influence the nature of racial socialization (Perry et al., 2025). Understanding these nuances is key to identifying which messages function as racial microprotections and which allow dominant ideologies to take root.

Across racial groups, these socialization processes may include or omit racial microprotections. To understand how racial microprotections function across groups, we begin by examining the rich tradition of ethnic-racial socialization among youth of color.

Youth of Color: A Rich Tradition of Ethnic-Racial Socialization

Extensive research has documented the protective and developmental role of ethnic-racial socialization in the lives of youth of color. These practices, typically led by caregivers, help children make sense of race and racism while affirming cultural identity and resilience. Hughes et al. (2006) identified four core dimensions: (a) cultural socialization, which fosters racial pride and knowledge of cultural heritage; (b) preparation for bias, which prepares youth to anticipate and respond to discrimination; (c) promotion of mistrust, a form of racial vigilance, which encourages caution in cross-racial interactions; and (d) egalitarianism and silence about race, which emphasizes individual traits, such as hard work and virtue, over cultural group identity and often overlaps with color-blind racial messaging.

These practices are not merely protective. Rather, they are developmental necessities in a racially stratified society. From an early age, youth of color encounter messages about exclusion, devaluation, and marginalization. Ethnic-racial socialization equips them with interpretive tools to navigate these experiences and affirm their worth. When these practices incorporate cultural strengths and foster critical reflection, they have been linked to

positive outcomes, including strong racial and ethnic identity, psychological resilience, and adaptive coping (Neblett et al., 2012; Umaña-Taylor & Rivas-Drake, 2021).

Extending this foundation, researchers have emphasized how racial socialization can nurture racial literacy and antiracist agency (e.g., Burgess et al., 2021; Stevenson, 2014). Rather than shielding children from racism, these messages prepare them to recognize injustice, resist internalized oppression, and envision liberatory futures. As such, ethnic-racial socialization affirms identity while fostering critical consciousness and a sense of collective responsibility.

Importantly, this is not a call to place the responsibility for antiracist change on communities of color. As discussed earlier, racism is a white problem that is maintained through white systems and socialization. To truly disrupt its intergenerational transmission, we must examine how white children are explicitly and implicitly taught to understand race, power, and inequity. In the next section, we turn to the emerging science of WRS, a historically underexamined process that plays a pivotal role in both the perpetuation of racial injustice and the potential for its disruption.

White Racial Socialization: What We Know

Compared to the extensive literature on ethnic-racial socialization among youth of color, WRS remains vastly understudied and less intentionally practiced. Most research suggests that white caregivers tend to avoid conversations about race or default to color-blind racial messages, which emphasize sameness while sidestepping systemic realities (Pahlke et al., 2024; Perry et al., 2019; Seaton et al., 2018; Spanierman, 2022). This avoidance reflects a persistent assumption in both parenting practice and psychological theory that whiteness is raceless, neutral, and the norm. Abaied (2023) challenged this assumption, arguing that developmental science has historically treated white children as devoid of racial context, obscuring how WRS shapes their identity development.

Without intentional scaffolding, white children grow up without the racial microprotections introduced earlier. As a result, they are more vulnerable to internalizing white innocence, fragility, and superiority. In contrast to youth of color, who may receive messages of cultural pride and resilience, white

youth are rarely offered tools to reflect on their positionality or challenge racial injustice. Practitioners can help address this gap by providing caregivers with practical tools, including age-appropriate language and structured resources (Lingras, 2021; Rivas-Drake et al., 2025). As later sections will demonstrate, these protective messages can and must be deliberately cultivated in white families.

In practice, WRS often takes the form of silence or race-evasive messaging, unintentionally reinforcing dominant racial norms (Nieri et al., 2024). As Bigler et al. (2022) argued, the absence of race talk is itself a form of racial instruction. It teaches children that race is irrelevant, uncomfortable, or impolite. In white households, this silence allows children to derive meaning from unspoken cues about who is celebrated, who is feared, and who holds power. These patterns, reflected in media, schools, and peer interactions, instill early assumptions of white normativity, entitlement, and superiority (Seaton et al., 2018). As Moffitt and Rogers (2022) noted, white youth form racial identities within a cultural context saturated with white supremacy, where dominant narratives are normalized rather than interrogated. Left unexamined, WRS actively sustains injustice.

In today's sociopolitical context and rampant backlash against antiracist education, this gap becomes not only a developmental concern but a political imperative. Emerging research underscores that failing to engage white youth in antiracist racial socialization has real consequences, both for individual development and for broader equity efforts. Huft et al. (2025) found that lower levels of intentional WRS among white adolescents and young adults predicted greater vulnerability to racial resentment, far-right identification, and extremist recruitment. These findings demonstrate that the absence of meaningful WRS does not preserve innocence. Instead, it leaves white youth susceptible to grievance, radicalization, and racial retrenchment.

The Urgency of Intentional WRS

To disrupt these cycles of avoidance, deflection, and unexamined dominance, WRS must become intentional. This includes engaging self-reflexivity and structural critique in ways that align with children's developmental capacities. Hazelbaker et al. (2022) further called for justice-oriented WRS that centers truth-telling, emotional discomfort, humility, and

accountability. Racial socialization should be scaffolded across the lifespan, with families, educators, and mentors playing essential roles at each stage (Heberle et al., 2020). Without this scaffolding, white children remain vulnerable to dominant narratives that normalize entitlement and suppress systemic critique. With it, however, WRS can cultivate the empathy, insight, and clarity needed to challenge racism at its roots.

Recent research highlights the power of intentional, antiracist WRS. For example, Curran et al. (2023) found that white parents and adult children with greater awareness of white privilege reported lower racial bias and less anxiety in interracial contexts. Similarly, Belizaire et al. (2024) documented how white parents who intentionally engaged in conversations about race reported greater confidence, consistency, and alignment with antiracist parenting goals. Moffitt and Rogers (2022) also emphasized the importance of developmental context, showing that critical consciousness does not arise spontaneously among white youth. It must be nurtured through purposeful guidance. Collectively, these findings underscore the importance of intergenerational dialogue and structural self-reflection in shaping antiracist orientations.

We frame WRS as a developmental necessity. Just as ethnic-racial socialization offers microprotections that buffer children of color from harm and cultivate resistance, WRS must offer white youth the tools to recognize injustice, reject dominance, and develop antiracist identities. Without this shift, white children remain vulnerable to the very narratives that uphold racism's deadly dance. With it, however, new pathways open for responsibility and repair.

ENACTING RACIAL MICROPROTECTIONS: FOUNDATIONAL PRACTICES FOR ANTIRACIST SOCIALIZATION

Drawing from Sue (2015), we offer eight foundational practices for raising race-conscious children. These are actionable, research-informed strategies designed to help adults disrupt racial silence, model accountability, and cultivate antiracist commitments. Each practice functions as a racial microprotection: a daily act of prevention, preparation, and repair. These

microprotections interrupt racism's choreography by offering children alternative scripts for meaning-making, rooted in empathy and justice.

To support the enactment of racial microprotections, we introduce four bias strategies that guide adults in responding to racism across time: before, during, after, and beyond moments of bias. As shown in Table 10.1, these strategies (bias prevention, bias check, bias cleanse, and anti-bias action) offer a developmentally grounded framework for disrupting racial harm and modeling antiracist values in daily life.

- **Bias prevention** involves proactively shaping antiracist environments before harmful messages are absorbed.
- **Bias checks** prompt adults to pause and examine avoidant impulses or intervene in the moment, before bias takes root or escalates.

Table 10.1 Four Strategies to Address Bias Across Time and Context

BIAS STRATEGY	TIMING	FOCUS	EMOTIONAL TONE	CHILD TAKEAWAY
Bias Prevention	Before	Proactively shape environments	Anticipation, intention, foresight	“We talk about race openly and plan ahead”
Bias Check	During	Pause or interrupt bias in real time	Awareness, courage	“We notice and stop bias when it happens”
Bias Cleanse	After	Return to missed or mishandled moments	Humility, reengagement, repair	“It's okay to make mistakes. We come back to grow and try again”
Anti-Bias Action	Beyond the moment	Sustain values-based modeling of justice and allyship	Purposeful commitment	“Antiracism is part of how we live and act”

Note. These strategies apply across developmental stages and should be adapted using age-appropriate language, examples, and emotional scaffolding.

- **Bias cleanse** refers to returning to missed opportunities with humility and reflection to repair harm or confusion.
- **Anti-bias action** involves deliberate, values-based responses that model justice, empathy, and sustained commitment to equity.

Together, these four strategies clarify when and how to enact racial microprotections in everyday life. They also anchor the eight foundational practices that follow. In today's climate, marked by legislative efforts that dismantle DEI initiatives in educational settings, these tools are more essential than ever. Table 10.2 offers a snapshot of these foundational

practices, including core messages, real-world examples, and suggested actions to support antiracist parenting and education in daily life.

Foundational Practice 1: Be Purposeful—Commit to Your Own Racial Learning

Racial microprotections begin with adults' own racial self-awareness. Caregivers and educators of all racial backgrounds cannot guide children with clarity or consistency without reflecting on their own racial identity, socialization, and, for white adults, investment in whiteness. This mirrors the barriers to white ally development discussed in Chapter 5, where limited racial self-awareness impedes sustained engagement and effective advocacy. Without this internal work, race talk often reinforces the very dynamics it seeks to challenge by centering guilt, relying on platitudes, or defaulting to silence. Children, in turn, learn that race matters, but remains off-limits. This dissonance is not incidental. Adults who have not examined their racial development often bring unresolved defenses, such as guilt, fragility, denial, or survival-based avoidance, into interactions with children. These defenses become part of racial socialization, transmitted through what adults flinch at, deflect, or cannot name. Children interpret this discomfort as a cue that race is off-limits (Bigler et al., 2022).

Table 10.2 Eight Foundational Practices for Enacting Racial Microprotections in Daily Life

FOUNDATIONAL PRACTICE		CORE MESSAGE	REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE	SUGGESTED ACTIONS
1	Commit to Your Own Racial Learning	Engage in self-reflexivity about race and positionality to guide children with clarity and consistency	Adults bring emotional defenses (e.g., guilt and fear) into interactions with children	Use racial autobiography prompts; join affinity groups or guided workshops; share your growth with children (Bias Prevention)
2	Break the Silence	Lean in and name race and racism. Silence teaches children that race is taboo	Adult avoids child's question about skin color at the playground	Use children's questions or observations as entry points; model curiosity (Bias Check)
3	Make Race Talk Normative	Embed race talk into daily life, not just during moments of crisis	Race is discussed only during racial tensions or major events	Use meals, story time, or family rituals to name fairness; celebrate resistance and joy (Bias Prevention; Bias Check*)
4	Practice and Role-Play	Build racial literacy through low-stakes rehearsal and role-play	Child struggles to respond when a peer makes a racist joke	Role-play daily scenarios; use dolls, drawings, or storytelling to practice responses together (Bias Check; Bias Prevention*)

FOUNDATIONAL PRACTICE		CORE MESSAGE	REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE	SUGGESTED ACTIONS
5	Anticipate and Prepare	Prepare children in advance for how to respond to racial bias and exclusion	Child witnesses exclusion on the playground and freezes	Script age-appropriate, brief responses to bias; prepare for common situations in advance (Bias Prevention)
6	Take the Lead	Create intentional moments for racial learning through books, stories, and community events	Family visits a civil rights museum together and discusses racism	Curate antiracist booklists with children; honor resistance stories; make learning part of family culture (Anti-Bias Action; Bias Prevention*)
7	Recover from Mistakes	Model accountability by returning to missed opportunities with sincerity and humility	Adult shuts down a race question, later reopens it with reflection	Apologize, name the mistake, and reflect aloud, even when discomfort is high; model trying again (Bias Cleanse)
8	Validate and Reinforce	Affirm children's antiracist actions to build moral character and reinforce values	Child interrupts a stereotype in a cartoon; adult affirms the action	Name and praise the action; align it with core values, share it with others to strengthen norms (Anti-Bias Action; Bias Cleanse*)

* Asterisk indicates secondary bias strategy. Table 10.1 elaborates on bias strategies.

To break this cycle, adults must approach racial socialization not as a one-way transmission of values, but as a shared process of learning and growth. Purposeful engagement begins with turning inward and reflecting on one's own racial learning. Hazelbaker et al. (2022) found that white caregivers who had not explored their own racial stories were more likely to default to silence or vague messaging (e.g., “We're all human”). In contrast, those who had engaged in sustained reflection, through accountability groups or storytelling, reported greater emotional readiness to engage children in nuanced conversations about race and respond meaningfully to children's questions (see also Belizaire et al., 2024; Heberle et al., 2021). Beyond just talking about race, these caregivers modeled self-reflexivity, growth, and repair in real time.

Of course, not all caregivers have access to structured learning spaces. Many caregivers of color draw on lived experiences to model racial awareness, often without institutional scaffolding. For example, a Latina single mother navigating workplace discrimination may share those experiences with her child, using everyday reflection to foster dialogue about fairness and equity. Similarly, a Black single father might use a police stop or news story as a springboard for a conversation with his son to discuss safety, injustice, and collective resistance. These acts of informal, necessity-driven socialization reflect longstanding traditions of racial learning that coexist with structural adversity.

Committing to racial learning is not a solitary or performative act. As researchers have emphasized, white caregivers benefit most from expert-guided learning opportunities that are scaffolded across time and bolstered by community accountability (Heberle et al., 2024; Underhill & Clark, 2023). These settings allow caregivers to process discomfort and practice new scripts without placing the burden on children, partners, or friends of color. Structured learning also disrupts white cultural norms of individualism, replacing them with collective practices of accountability. While some white caregivers may signal awareness publicly, meaningful change is demonstrated through consistent, humble modeling of responsibility at home and in classrooms.

Self-reflexivity prepares adults to offer consistent, grounded messages about race rather than silence or confusion. This internal work enables adults to proactively shape antiracist environments before harmful

narratives take hold (Sue, 2015). When adults do their own internal work, they become better equipped to provide the racial microprotections their children need.

Strategies for Purposeful Self-Reflexivity:

- ***Reflect on Your Own Racial Socialization***. Use prompts such as, *When did I first learn I was white? What messages did I receive about people of color growing up?* Surfacing early internalizations helps identify patterns that still shape behavior.
- ***Join a White Accountability Group***. Growth is more sustainable in community. Structured groups offer honest feedback, shared reflection, and accountability.
- ***Center the Voices of People of Color***. Read and discuss books, articles, and podcasts authored by POC. These counter-narratives foster empathy, challenge assumptions, and offer language for antiracist conversations.
- ***Model Growth for Children***. Let kids see you learning. Say, “I used to think this, but I've learned more” or “Here's what I'm working on.” This shows racial learning is lifelong, mistakes are expected, and accountability is an act of care.

Once adults begin this lifelong self-reflection, they are better equipped to engage children in race talk. The next step is to move from internal awareness to outward engagement, thus breaking the silence that surrounds race, especially in white families.

Foundational Practice 2: Break the Silence—Don't Avoid Race Talk

Children receive racial messages from their environments whether adults acknowledge them or not. In white households especially, the absence of explicit conversations about race is not neutral. It is a form of racial socialization that teaches children that race is taboo, irrelevant, or too difficult to discuss, while simultaneously depriving them of the microprotections needed to navigate difference and recognize injustice. In

this way, silence serves as a bias incubator: without active interruption, bias calcifies.

Many adults avoid race talk out of fear of saying the wrong thing, causing harm, or revealing their own uncertainty, often because they have not yet engaged in the internal work described in Practice 1. Yet this avoidance itself becomes instructional. Children quickly learn that noticing race is impolite and that injustice is someone else's concern. In white families, emotional discomfort, neighborhood segregation, and color-blind racial ideology often converge to make race unspeakable. But research shows that this silence leaves children vulnerable to absorbing dominant racial narratives from peers, media, and broader cultural norms (Hazelbaker et al., 2022; Nieri et al., 2024; Scott et al., 2024). Breaking the silence often begins with what Sue (2015) describes as a bias check: recognizing one's own avoidant impulse in real time and choosing to engage instead. For example, when a child asks why someone's skin is darker, the adult might pause and ask, “What am I modeling right now? Am I signaling this question is inappropriate?” This strategy works best when paired with consistent, everyday opportunities to engage. As Belizaire et al. (2024) emphasized, early scaffolding through metaphor-rich and emotionally safe strategies can help children process racial experiences. Even mundane moments offer entry points. Open-ended prompts like “What did you notice?” or “How do you think that felt?” can turn books, television shows, or peer interactions into springboards. Such low-stakes rehearsal improves racial fluency and reduces avoidance over time (Fu et al., 2022). Similarly, Heberle et al. (2020) emphasized that race talk should be scaffolded in developmentally appropriate ways. What begins as naming differences and fairness in early childhood can grow into conversations about power, resistance, and justice.

Rather than striving for perfect responses, the goal is presence, persistence, and attunement in the moment. Conversations about race do not need to be scripted to be meaningful. Rather, they need to be responsive and ongoing. What matters is staying engaged, responding with care, and signaling that conversations about race are always welcome and worth continuing.

Strategies for Breaking the Silence:

- ***Start with What Children Observe***. Use books, media, or peer interactions as natural openings. Ask, “What did you notice?” or “How do you think that person felt?”
- ***Rehearse Simple Scripts***. Practice short responses like “That's called racism,” or “It's okay to notice differences,” to build confidence.
- ***Use a Bias Check in the Moment***. Pause and ask yourself, “Am I avoiding this? What am I modeling right now?”
- ***Normalize Presence, Not Perfection***. Focus less on having the right answer and more on staying engaged, even when the conversation is difficult.

Breaking the silence is only the beginning. To build racial literacy and resilience, children need consistent exposure to race talk across time, settings, and emotions. The next practice invites adults to embed race conversations into daily life, so they become expected, not exceptional.

Foundational Practice 3: Make Race Talk Normative—Incorporate It Naturally

Once the silence has been broken, the real work begins with building the habit. If race is only discussed during moments of crisis, children may associate it with conflict, shame, or discomfort and assume racism is rare rather than a daily undercurrent. To enact racial microprotections consistently, adults must make race talk part of the everyday rhythm by weaving it into daily routines, rather than reserving it for special occasions or teachable moments.

When race talk is framed as exceptional, children may internalize the idea that it is dangerous. For children of color, this may reinforce feelings of isolation or invalidation; for white children, it can activate early forms of fragility, thus fueling the avoidance loop described previously. By contrast, when discussions of race happen during mealtimes, bedtime stories, or walks to school, they become a natural part of moral and social development. As Hazelbaker et al. (2022) found, children whose caregivers regularly named race in ordinary contexts were more likely to ask questions, make connections, and speak up when witnessing bias.

Normalization also interrupts emotional and ideological barriers to sustained engagement. White caregivers often feel pressure to “say the right thing” or fear they lack knowledge, leading to paralysis. Making race talk routine lowers the emotional stakes. It shifts the emphasis from performance to presence. Even brief, imperfect exchanges can scaffold children's racial learning if they are consistent and authentic (Belizaire et al., 2024).

This practice also expands how race is discussed. Too often, race appears only in conversations about injustice or harm. While naming injustice is vital, so is celebrating resistance, solidarity, and cultural pride. When adults discuss race in joyful, curious, and affirming ways, they broaden the moral vocabulary available to children. Racial microprotections must include not only warnings and defenses, but also invitations to honor, connect, and imagine.

Researchers have documented examples of white caregivers using reading routines to foster racial dialogue. Botto and Kerr (2024) described parents who asked questions like, “What do you think about what happened?” and “What would you do in that situation?” to help children reflect on race and justice themes in books. These open-ended, values-based conversations promoted comfort, racial literacy, and empathy. Similarly, Vezaldenos et al. (2023) found that some children, after engaging in routine race talk at home, later recognized exclusion at school and asked caregivers for help. This illustrates how normalized race talk can support both awareness and action.

Making race talk normative is a form of bias prevention. It creates an environment where race is not off-limits or reactive, but expected and integrated. It also enables bias checks—helping adults notice when they are about to soften or skip a racial moment and instead lean in with curiosity. When children see that adults are willing to speak about race as part of daily life, and not just during a crisis, they internalize a message of consistency, responsibility, and care.

Strategies for Making Race Talk Normative:

- ***Use Media as a Springboard***. While watching TV or reading a book, ask: “What do you notice about who's included?” or “Why do you

think they were treated that way?" Let children lead with their observations and respond with open-ended curiosity.

- ***Create Regular Rituals***. Try "Friday fairness check-ins," "social justice book nights," or sharing one example of allyship each week. Routine deepens reflection.
- ***Celebrate Resistance and Joy***. Highlight solidarity, cultural contributions, family history, and community pride. Point out empowerment, not only harm.

Normalizing race talk builds the foundation, but fluency takes more than repetition. To prepare children (and ourselves) for real-world bias and injustice, we must move beyond conversation into active rehearsal and reinforcement. The next practice focuses on role-play and practice as tools for building racial confidence and strengthening responsiveness.

Foundational Practice 4: Practice and Role-Play—Build Racial Dialogue Fluency

Talking about race is not only a value, but a skill that requires practice. Many caregivers want to raise antiracist children, but uncertainty and fear of "getting it wrong" can lead to vague messages or silence. These responses tend to reinforce avoidance rather than build resilience. Practicing race talk in low-stakes moments helps caregivers find their footing. It builds the rhythm, responsiveness, and balance needed to engage with clarity and care.

Research consistently affirms the importance of rehearsal. Fu et al. (2022) found that when caregivers engage in guided practice, they become less likely to freeze or deflect during race-related moments and more likely to model effective responses. Without rehearsal, even well-intentioned caregivers may default to silence, redirection, or minimization. As seen in Chapter 9, such avoidance is not confined to childhood; it becomes institutionalized in settings like education and healthcare, where racism persists unchallenged without intentional interventions. These missed opportunities can reinforce the belief that race is too risky to discuss, calcifying patterns of white fragility.

Practice does not mean memorizing a perfect script. It means staying grounded even in uncertainty and cultivating the ability to draw on earlier practice when real-life moments arise. It is not about flawless delivery, but about fluency and the ability to stay present in the conversation without shutting down. Hazelbaker et al. (2022) reported that caregivers who practiced and modeled racial dialogue, even imperfectly, were more likely to follow through on antiracist commitments and less likely to reinforce avoidance in their children.

When children and adolescents are invited to rehearse responses to everyday bias, they gain both vocabulary and courage. Role-playing helps them anticipate how to respond if a friend makes a biased joke or if a teacher dismisses a concern. These rehearsals do not inoculate children from discomfort, but they do give them something to reach for when the moment comes. Researchers have documented cases where White caregivers used role-play to help children anticipate bias and practice responses (Fu et al., 2022; Vezaldenos et al., 2023). In some instances, children later applied these rehearsed scenarios in school settings, responding to exclusion or naming unfairness with greater confidence. These moments of readiness were not spontaneous. They resulted from prior reflection, practice, and parental support.

Practice is another powerful form of bias prevention. By rehearsing, adults can interrupt avoidant reflexes before they take hold. Bias check (i.e., pausing to reflect on one's response pattern in the moment) is easier to access when a caregiver has rehearsed how to stay present.

Strategies for Practicing Racial Fluency:

- ***Role-Play Everyday Scenarios with Children***. Ask, “What would you say if a friend made fun of a classmate's name?” or “What if someone said something racist?” Draw examples from media, school, or past experiences.
- ***Rehearse Adult Responses, Too***. Practice what you might say if a neighbor makes a biased remark or a relative commits a microaggression. Try different phrasings aloud.
- ***Use Play-Based Storytelling***. With younger kids, use dolls or drawings to explore fairness, exclusion, and courage in different settings.

- ***Name the Goal of Practice***: Remind children (and yourself) that the aim is not perfection but staying in the conversation and learning out loud.

Even with rehearsal, children will encounter real-world bias. This next foundational practice equips them to anticipate, name, and respond to those moments with confidence.

Foundational Practice 5: Anticipate and Prepare—Script Responses to Common Racial Incidents

Antiracist socialization is not only reactive, but also proactive. While the previous practice emphasized building fluency through rehearsal and role-play, this practice focuses on anticipation. Preparation equips children—and adults—for the kinds of everyday racial moments they are likely to encounter and helps them to respond with confidence. If rehearsal teaches the steps of racial dialogue, preparation ensures children stay in rhythm when the real dance begins.

Children frequently encounter racialized moments that go unaddressed, such as biased jokes on the playground, stereotyped characters in media, peer exclusion, or racially charged comments in class. Without preparation, children may freeze, deflect, or retreat into silence. This is not due to apathy, but to being overwhelmed. Proactive preparation enables children to name injustice and act in alignment with their values (Scott et al., 2024). It also counters the internalized scripts of passivity, fragility, or hypervigilance that children, particularly white youth or youth navigating racialized environments without support, may absorb when race is rarely discussed at home.

Preparation does not mean scripting an entire dialogue. Rather, it means offering children something to reach for in the moment. Phrases like “That's not okay,” “What makes you say that?” or “Let's not joke about that” can interrupt bias without escalating tension. Researchers found that caregivers who practiced brief, scenario-based responses with their children observed increased confidence in both children and themselves when responding to bias. Specifically, one parent in the *EmBARK* program reported that after practicing short responses at home, their child felt more confident speaking up during a peer interaction (Scott et al., 2024). These brief acts of

resistance matter. They disrupt bias before it becomes normalized and foster a sense of preparedness and trust that supports antiracist action (Fu et al., 2022; Vezaldenos et al., 2023).

Preparation is most effective when it is both developmentally attuned and practically applied. Belizaire et al. (2024) highlighted the importance of this kind of scaffolding in their *Routes to Effective Anti-racist Parenting* (REAP) model, which frames preparation not as fear-based scripting, but as agency-building. Children are encouraged to imagine how they might respond, supported by emotionally attuned caregivers.

Anticipation benefits adults as well. When caregivers and educators practice how they will respond to racially charged comments at school meetings, family gatherings, or in public spaces, they are less likely to fall into shock, minimize harm, or ruminate afterward. As with children, this preparation helps adults stay anchored in their values, even when discomfort is high. Whether modeled by adults or rehearsed with children, preparation lays the groundwork for action. It shows children they have agency, and that speaking up, even imperfectly, is a form of care. The goal is not flawless execution but readiness.

Strategies for Anticipating and Preparing:

- ***Identify Common Scenarios Your Child May Face***. These might include exclusion based on language or appearance, biased humor, racial stereotypes in media, or silence in response to injustice.
- ***Script Short, Empowering Responses***. Practice phrases like “That's not okay,” “That sounds racist,” or “We don't say that in our family.” For younger children, pair language with visual prompts or play.
- ***Rehearse During Calm Moments***. Don't wait for an incident. Use walks, car rides, and mealtimes to introduce scenarios and ask, “What could we say in that situation?”
- ***Normalize Imperfect Responses***. Remind children—and yourself—that what matters most is speaking up, staying engaged, and being willing to try again.

While preparation equips children to respond in the moment, they also need proactive exposure to the histories, voices, and communities too often left

out. The next practice invites adults to take the lead by creating intentional opportunities for racial learning.

Foundational Practice 6: Take the Lead—Instigate Everyday Race Lessons

Racial socialization should not be left to chance. Many adults wait for the “right moment,” such as a headline or a child's question, but those cues often come too late. By taking the lead, adults show that conversations about race are not a reaction to a crisis, but a regular part of daily life. Especially in a sociopolitical climate where race dialogue is censored or politicized, intentionality is not optional. An intentional stance is a protective act and a form of resistance.

While earlier practices focused on responding to children's cues or preparing them for common scenarios, this practice centers the adult's role as the instigator of antiracist learning. Rather than waiting for teachable moments, adults create them by embedding values of justice, empathy, and accountability through consistent modeling. This is bias prevention at the root, not reactive correction.

Studies based on interviews and survey data with white parents reveal wide variation in how race lessons are approached, ranging from an emphasis on kindness and diversity to efforts that promote privilege awareness and antiracist action (Gillen-O'Neel et al., 2022; Jennings, 2024; Pahlke et al., 2024). While the former may reflect good intentions, such superficial approaches can inadvertently uphold dominant racial norms by avoiding deeper conversations about power and systemic injustice. This variation highlights the need for adults to move beyond vague ideals and lead with accountability.

When adults regularly initiate race talk, during meals, morning routines, or bedtime stories, they signal that race is not taboo, but integral to moral development. For instance, Botto and Kerr (2024) described caregivers who used books and weekly reflection routines to encourage children to think critically about difference, and justice. One could imagine, for example, a Diné (Navajo) household, in which a grandmother draws on her community's efforts to protect water from uranium contamination to share stories with her grandchildren about land, survival, and the fight for

sovereignty. These moments may not be framed as formal lessons, but rather as part of everyday caregiving and cultural continuity.

This practice of instigating race lessons also broadens how race is emotionally experienced and buffers children against dominant racial narratives. It connects race not only to injustice, but also to resistance, celebration, and belonging. Rituals like reading about changemakers, celebrating cultural milestones, or reflecting on moments of collective care show children that race is not something to fear, but something to understand, honor, and engage with. By taking the lead, adults help children develop a counter-narrative grounded in truth, responsibility, and courage.

Instigating race lessons is a powerful form of bias prevention. It reduces the novelty of race talk and builds children's racial fluency over time. When conversations about power, fairness, and identity are woven into daily life, children are less likely to freeze or retreat when bias arises. Instead, they draw on a well of prior knowledge and practice. Each purposeful exchange becomes a racial microprotection that reinforces values and prepares children to meet injustice with clarity and skill.

Strategies for Instigating Lessons on Race:

- ***Initiate Race Talk Consistently***. Choose one or two recurring moments, such as bedtime stories, car rides, or weekend mornings, to discuss racial justice.
- ***Curate Antiracist Media***. Build a home library of books, cartoons, documentaries, and YouTube videos that center POC voices, movements, and histories.
- ***Honor Racial and Cultural Milestones***. Observe events like Juneteenth and Indigenous Peoples' Day to connect history with present-day pride.
- ***Use Metaphors with Young Children***. Say, “Justice is like a garden that grows when we take care of it,” or “We build fairness like a bridge, step by step.”

Even when adults lead with care and intention, missteps are inevitable. The next practice explores how caregivers and educators can model repair by turning those moments into opportunities for accountability and growth.

Foundational Practice 7: Recover from Mistakes—Model Imperfection and Growth

Antiracist socialization is not about perfection. It is about presence, persistence, and the willingness to repair. In every family, especially those just beginning to disrupt generations of racial silence or avoidance, mistakes will happen. A question gets brushed off. A biased comment slips by without response. An attempt to talk about race gets mired in defensiveness. Although discouraging, these moments also offer powerful opportunities for repair. How adults respond when they misstep shows children that growth is possible, discomfort is normal, and accountability is a form of care.

Children pay close attention not only to what adults teach, but to how they recover. When an adult pauses, reflects, and returns to a missed moment, they model courage, humility, and emotional resilience. As we discussed previously, perfectionism is the enemy of progress in racial learning. A clumsy or incomplete attempt is not failure; rather, it is a step forward in a new dance. The ability to return and try again may be one of the most impactful microprotections adults can offer. This pattern was evident in Heberle et al. (2021), where several White parents described initially shutting down race conversations out of fear, awkwardness, or uncertainty, but later revisited those moments with greater clarity and emotional presence. These returns, though imperfect, modeled accountability and sent a clear message that we can always try again.

This process reflects what Underhill and Clark (2023) observed in their study of accountability-based interventions. White caregivers who learned to reflect and repair, especially with community-based support, developed greater resilience. Rather than avoiding discomfort, they learned to name it and return to the conversation with renewed commitment. When adults reinforce this cycle of misstep, reflection, and reengagement, they offer children an invaluable emotional blueprint. They teach that racial justice work is not about getting it right the first time. Rather, it is about being willing to stay in the work even when it is messy. This is essential not only for adult growth, but for shaping young people's expectations of accountability in themselves and others.

Repair does not require a script; it requires sincerity. A caregiver might say, “Earlier I dismissed your question. I've been thinking about it, and I want to try again.” Or: “I said something that didn't reflect my values, and I want to talk about why that matters.” These statements, offered calmly and without defensiveness, model emotional agility and moral clarity. They tell children: “We don't give up on hard conversations. We learn and return.”

Recovering from mistakes is also a direct form of bias cleanse. This practice communicates that race talk does not end when something goes wrong. Instead, it deepens and becomes more honest through repair. These moments become racial microprotections when they show children that the adults around them are willing to be vulnerable and committed to growth.

Strategies for Modeling Recovery and Growth:

- ***Name the Misstep Clearly***. Use direct language like “I made a mistake earlier” or “I didn't handle that well.”
- ***Avoid Defensiveness***. Focus on the impact, not your intent. You might say, “What I said could have made someone feel unseen or dismissed.”
- ***Reflect Out Loud***. Say, “I've been thinking more about what happened. I want to do better.”
- ***Reopen the Conversation***. Invite the child back in with curiosity. “What were you wondering earlier?” or “Let's try again.”
- ***Model This as an Ongoing Process***. Normalize repair as part of your family culture, not a one-time exception.

Next, we describe the final practice, which explores how to validate children's antiracist actions and reinforce those behaviors over time.

Foundational Practice 8: Validate and Reinforce—Reward Antiracist Actions

Just as silence can shape complicity, affirmation can shape courage. When children take risks to name injustice, speak up in peer settings, or ask hard questions, they often do so with some social or emotional cost. Especially for white children raised in majority-white spaces, antiracist actions can feel awkward or isolating. Without caregiver validation, those moments of

courage may fade, or worse, give way to avoidance and self-protective silence. Caregivers play a vital role in reinforcing these early actions, transforming them from isolated behaviors into internalized commitments.

Validation is not merely praise. It is about naming the value behind the act, aligning it with the child's emerging identity, and affirming their agency. When adults say, “That was brave,” or “You care about fairness,” they are helping children connect behavior to moral development. When children receive consistent, values-based feedback after interrupting bias, they are more likely to repeat the behavior and see it as part of their moral identity (Belizaire et al., 2024; Heberle et al., 2020).

Belizaire et al. (2024), through the REAP model, emphasized that reinforcement must occur across multiple levels—not just within the home, but also in peer groups, schools, and broader community settings. Similarly, Heberle et al. (2020) found that consistent, emotionally attuned responses from multiple adults can serve as a relational scaffold, helping children stay aligned with justice over time. Together, these studies underscore that reinforcement is not just an individual act, but a social and relational process. When antiracist behaviors are recognized and supported across environments, they become part of a shared moral culture in which children learn, “This is what we do here.”

Children need more than tools and scripts; they need to feel emotionally backed when they use them. When adults respond to a child's antiracist actions with curiosity, affirmation, and shared pride, they help build the internal architecture for sustained moral courage. A simple example: A child notices a racially stereotyped character in a cartoon and says, “That's not okay.” A caregiver might respond: “I'm proud of you for noticing that. It shows that you care about fairness and want things to be better. That took courage, and that's leadership.” This framing affirms the action and helps shape identity: “I am someone who notices injustice. I speak up. That's who I am.”

Adults should be cautious of overpraising or turning the child into a “hero.” Children are highly attuned to adult cues, and exaggerated affirmation can unintentionally frame antiracism as a performance for approval rather than a value to uphold. As explored in Chapter 5, this distinction between performative allyship and sustained, values-driven action is critical. When

recognition centers the child's exceptionalism rather than the responsibility behind the act, it may inadvertently reinforce white saviorism. The goal is not to reward distinction but to cultivate consistency and moral clarity.

Validation is a core form of anti-bias action. When done thoughtfully, it helps children metabolize moments of action as meaningful and valued, rather than risky or isolating. This practice also supports bias cleansing. When children stumble or hesitate, adults can affirm the impulse to repair, creating emotional safety for trying again with care. Over time, validation builds identity and moral agency. When antiracist behavior is recognized and supported, it becomes part of the dance, a rhythm children can return to when facing injustice again.

Strategies for Validating and Reinforcing:

- ***Acknowledge Effort, Not Just Outcome***. Say, “I saw you try. That mattered,” even if the result was messy or incomplete.
- ***Name the Values Behind the Action***. “You stood up because you believe everyone deserves to feel safe.”
- ***Share and Amplify***. Tell teachers, grandparents, or trusted peers what your child did. Collective recognition reinforces commitment and builds shared values.
- ***Avoid Exceptionalism***. Emphasize consistency and responsibility rather than praise or reward. Be careful not to frame the child as a hero or savior.
- ***Validate Reflection and Repair***. If a child misses a moment or makes a mistake, affirm their willingness to circle back: “It's okay to take time. Trying again shows courage.”

By consistently naming, supporting, and affirming children's antiracist actions, adults help turn one-time acts into lifelong commitments.

Summary

Taken together, these eight foundational practices offer a roadmap for enacting racial microprotections in everyday life. They move from the internal to the interpersonal, beginning with adults' self-awareness and

culminating in intentional modeling, recovery, and reinforcement. Across these practices, antiracist socialization is framed not as a singular event or rigid script, but as a dynamic, relational process grounded in presence, rhythm, and repetition.

By embedding race talk into daily routines, anticipating and rehearsing, initiating lessons with intention, normalizing missteps, and affirming children's efforts, adults cultivate durable values and practical skills. These strategies equip children to respond to injustice with clarity and courage. Over time, each act of reflection, preparation, and reinforcement becomes a racial microprotection—a small but powerful move in disrupting bias.

Crucially, these practices also shift what is considered normal. When dialogue, accountability, and antiracist action become part of daily life, children learn these values are not exceptional but expected. In the next section, we turn to the broader systems that can sustain and amplify this work, ensuring that the dance of antiracist socialization that begins at home continues wherever children live and learn.

SYSTEMS-LEVEL OPPORTUNITIES: EXTENDING RACIAL MICROPROTECTIONS BEYOND THE HOME

While caregivers lay the foundation for racial socialization, children do not grow up in isolation. Their understandings of race are shaped by the messages they encounter in classrooms, media, generative AI, and peer networks. Systems can reinforce racism's default choreography or become sites of deliberate disruption. As the urgency of antiracist socialization grows, so does the need for evidence-based frameworks that can be implemented across these broader contexts. Such models show that racial socialization is not an abstract ideal but a teachable, assessable, and scalable practice. They offer concrete tools for embedding racial microprotections into daily life and equipping children to challenge injustice rather than replicate it by default.

Schools

Educators are among the most influential racial socializers in children's lives. Yet most receive little to no formal preparation in how to engage in race talk, interrupt bias, or support identity development. In many predominantly white districts, these gaps are compounded by discomfort and institutional resistance, often framed as concerns about politicizing the classroom. These dynamics have been dramatically escalated by the Trump administration's political playbook, which fueled disinformation, reframed antiracist education as ideological indoctrination, and mobilized legislative campaigns to suppress racial discourse in schools. The legacy of this strategy persists through ongoing attacks on DEI programs, curriculum bans, and criminalization of educators across states like Florida and Texas, as well as growing censorship pressures nationwide. In this climate, even educators committed to racial equity can face public pushback or institutional silencing. As discussed in Chapter 7, these patterns reflect the standard operating procedures through which predominantly white institutions maintain comfort and control by resisting racial dialogue under the guise of neutrality or procedural propriety.

Despite these challenges, promising systems-level strategies are emerging. While implementation is increasingly difficult in the current climate, educators and researchers continue to develop strategies for embedding racial microprotections, even in constrained environments. Stevenson (2014) argued that racial literacy should be taught explicitly, especially for educators navigating racial tension in schools. Tools like the *Multicultural Teaching Competency Scale* (Spanierman et al., 2011) offer a way to assess educators' multicultural knowledge and skills, helping determine whether they are prepared to scaffold race talk and implement antiracist practices. Evans and McDonald (2023) likewise called for integrating racial socialization competencies into teacher and clinician preparation pipelines.

In the face of mounting restrictions in schools, caregivers and educators alike must think creatively about how to reinforce racial socialization practices at home and through community partnerships, especially when classroom implementation is constrained. While some structured programs are school-based, others are designed for use by families and caregivers—both are needed in today's political climate. *The Identity Project*, for example, is typically implemented in schools and provides a scaffolded

framework for helping youth develop ethnic-racial identity and critical consciousness (Umaña-Taylor & Douglass, 2017). Although originally developed for students of color, it can be thoughtfully adapted to support white youth in cultivating antiracist commitments. *EmBARK* (Empowering Behaviors to Address Race with Kids; Scott et al., 2024) targets an earlier developmental period and equips white parents of 5–7-year-old children with scripted prompts, reflection activities, and practical tools. The program has been shown to increase caregiver concern and confidence around addressing early racial bias, reinforcing the school-home partnership in promoting antiracist learning. Beyond home and school, caregivers also have an advocacy role to play by pushing back on censorship policies and urging legislators to support antiracist education. These actions help ensure that schools remain sites of truth-telling and justice rather than silence and avoidance.

Community Institutions

Libraries, museums, and civic groups shape public narratives of belonging and difference. These spaces can normalize race talk outside of academic contexts. Events like the *Brooklyn Children's Museum's Anti-Racist Family Day* offer accessible, community-based opportunities for families to engage in racial dialogue and reflect on justice through hands-on activities and storytelling. Still, access remains uneven, with segregation and informal gatekeeping limiting awareness and participation for many families. These inequities reflect what Chapter 8 identified as institutional mechanisms of white supremacy: routines and omissions that maintain racial hierarchy not through overt exclusion, but through inequitable access, representation, and cultural gatekeeping.

The REAP Model (Routes to Effective Anti-racist Parenting), although designed for caregivers, offers a metaphor-rich, ecological framework built around gardening metaphors, like a pot, soil, seeds, and the environment (Belizaire et al., 2024). It emphasizes developmentally aligned practices that scaffold antiracist values over time. REAP's layered design, which addresses individual, relational, and systemic dimensions, translates well to public programming in libraries and museums. These institutions can draw on their structure to support intergenerational learning and foster community-wide microprotections.

Faith organizations, though varied in structure and commitment, can also play a formative role in shaping children's moral and racial understandings. When mobilized with intention, they can offer early opportunities for antiracist messaging, through curricula, rituals, or intergenerational dialogue, that reinforce justice-oriented values. For many immigrant families, faith-based institutions also serve as cultural anchors. A Korean church community, for instance, may provide not only spiritual guidance but also a trusted space for racial learning, cultural pride, and navigating systemic challenges. In this context, racial socialization might occur through sermons, youth programming, or conversations among congregants. These interactions are often shaped by shared experiences of racialization, discrimination, or migration.

Media and Technology

Media and digital platforms are among the most powerful and consistent racial socializers. From children's shows to TikTok feeds, young people absorb implicit and explicit messages about who matters, who belongs, and who holds power. Digital environments often perpetuate white-centric narratives and marginalize stories of resistance or complexity. Such dynamics are sustained by commercial algorithms that prioritize dominant norms and restrict diverse representation, especially among families with limited access to diverse sources of information (Noble, 2018).

In response, family-centered media literacy initiatives can help caregivers and educators deconstruct stereotypes and amplify counter-narratives. Resources from the American Psychological Association (n.d.), such as the *Reading and RES Guide*: Parent Tip Tool at this URL: https://www.apa.org/res/parent-resources/reading and *RESilience Tip Sheets*, offer actionable guidance for using books and digital content to spark conversations about race with children. These materials function as microintervention prompts (Sue et al., 2019), helping adults respond in real time to problematic media portrayals.

Other sectors offer adaptable tools that could be repurposed for media contexts. Although developed in healthcare, tools such as *I-RANT* (introduction, role naming, affirming the target, negating the microaggression, and transitioning within patient encounters; Grass et al., 2024) provide structured, mnemonic-based dialogue strategies and emotion-

regulation supports that could be adapted for use by caregivers and educators in digital or media-rich contexts. Relatedly, *Bias at the Bedside* (Faller et al., 2024) offers case-based role-play exercises and structured reflection tools that may inform bias-response training for educators and caregivers engaging with racialized content in virtual classrooms and other media-rich environments.

Peer Networks and Youth Spaces

Children and adolescents spend significant time in peer environments, such as on sports teams, in extracurricular groups, and in online communities. These settings shape how young people perceive social norms, respond to bias, and engage in solidarity. Justice-oriented programming in these spaces can cultivate diverse peer networks, build skills for disrupting racism, and promote youth-led advocacy. Vezaldenos et al. (2023) found that monoracial parents raising multiracial children often prepare their children to anticipate racial exclusion and navigate complex peer dynamics. These efforts reflect a broader desire to equip youth with the tools to recognize and resist bias, even in social settings where such responses may carry risk.

Emerging models within peer networks and youth spaces demonstrate that racial socialization is not limited to home or school. Such socialization can be actively cultivated through friendships, group dynamics, and youth-led initiatives. When young people are supported in building racial literacy together, they are more likely to challenge bias, foster solidarity, and carry antiracist values into the communities they shape. Programs like *Youth vs. Apocalypse*, *WE ARE (Working to Extend Anti-Racist Education)*, and *Youth Justice Coalition* exemplify how youth across racial backgrounds can lead transformative conversations, organize for justice, and model everyday antiracist action. These efforts help young people step out of racism's dominant choreography and co-create new forms of resistance and solidarity.

CONCLUSION: REIMAGINING THE FUTURE OF RACIAL SOCIALIZATION

Racial socialization is never a single conversation. It is a lifelong process of reflection, repetition, and repair. Every silence, comment, and gesture

transmits values, whether intentionally or by default. We have argued that racial socialization is both a site of harm and a site of possibility—a space where the deadly dance of racism is rehearsed, but also where new liberatory rhythms can begin to take shape.

While families of color have long cultivated practices to shield children from racism's harms, interrupting white racial socialization remains an urgent and still underdeveloped frontier. The concept of racial microprotections offers a meaningful path forward through small, developmentally grounded acts that help inoculate against racial dominance and nurture antiracist values. These practices begin at home and must also be reinforced across systems, including classrooms, media, communities, and peer networks.

Amid mounting political resistance and widespread fatigue, this work can feel daunting. Yet the antidote is daily, ordinary, and shared. Each act of antiracist socialization is a step away from the inherited scripts of dominance and toward new rhythms rooted in justice, accountability, and care.

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